Done — cost section removed, bracketed note removed. Everything else as it was.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/wyckoff-nj/`
Title tag (56 chars): Chimney Repair, Flashing & Repointing Wyckoff NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (152 chars): Chimney repair in Wyckoff, NJ — leaking flashing on wide chimneys, cricket framing, stone and brick repointing, cracked crowns, and roofline rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Flashing & Repointing in Wyckoff, NJ

Wyckoff chimneys are big. Outside the older homes near the Wyckoff Avenue business district and Godwin Avenue, most of the township — Sicomac, Boulder Run, the wooded streets off Russell Avenue and Brookside — was built or added onto between the 1970s and the 2000s, and those builders liked a statement chimney: oversized brick or fieldstone stacks, often 36 to 60 inches wide, on the outside wall of the family room at the bottom of a steep roof slope. Add the oak and pine canopy that keeps roofs and masonry damp into the afternoon, and you get a specific set of problems: wide chimneys leaking at the back wall, stone joints washing out, and crowns cracking on tops that are three times the size of an ordinary chimney.

Here's what we see on Wyckoff chimneys, how to spot it, and how Lita Construction repairs it.

Chimney leaking when it rains

On a wide Wyckoff chimney, water on the ceiling next to the fireplace or running down the basement wall below the hearth during a driving rain is almost always a flashing problem at the back of the stack, not water through the masonry.

The reason is geometry. A 48-inch-wide chimney at the bottom of a steep slope has a flat wall facing uphill that catches everything the roof sends down — rain, wet oak leaves, pine needles, snowmelt. Code requires a cricket (a peaked saddle) behind any chimney wider than 30 inches, and most Wyckoff homes from the 1970s and 80s don't have one. Water and debris dam up against the brick until they push under the shingles or tear open flashing that was tarred to the face of the chimney during the last roof job.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney down to the deck, replace any rotted plywood, and frame a cricket behind the stack in 2x4 rafters and 5/8-inch plywood — on a 60-inch chimney that's a real little roof. The cricket and the full chimney perimeter get wrapped

in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, step flashing is woven into every shingle course, and a custom metal valley pan goes over the cricket so water splits cleanly around both sides. The counter-flashing is set into the chimney, not caulked onto it: on brick we grind a reglet into the mortar joint; on fieldstone, where the joints don't run level, we saw-cut a continuous stepped channel into the stone face so the metal sits inside the rock. On the slate and copper roofs in the higher-end sections, all of this is done in 20-ounce copper.

Stone chimney repointing and loose stones

Fieldstone and split-face chimneys are common on Wyckoff's custom colonials, and they fail differently from brick. The stones are irregular, the joints range from a quarter inch to two inches wide, and the face is full of ledges where water sits instead of running off. Under tree shade, those ledges stay wet, freeze, and work the mortar loose. You'll see it as recessed joints, mortar crumbs at the base of the chimney, or a stone that moves when you push it.

The repair: we rake the joints out at least three-quarters of an inch, and deeper on the wide ones — mostly by hand with chisels and a small grinder, because a wide diamond blade scars the stone edges permanently. Loose stones are pulled, cleaned, and reset in fresh mortar rather than pointed around. The repointing mortar is a breathable Type N, tinted to match the existing color and sand, and the joints are finished to match the original profile so the work doesn't show from the street.

Brick chimneys in Wyckoff — the 1950s and 60s homes near town and the upper stacks on later colonials — get the same treatment in a brick context: joints ground out three-quarters of an inch to an inch across the full exposed section, repointed in matched Type N, tooled to the original joint.

Cracked chimney top on a multi-flue chimney

Many Wyckoff chimneys carry two or three flues — fireplace, furnace, sometimes a second fireplace — which means the top of the chimney is a wide slab. Most were finished with a mortar wash troweled around the flue tiles, and a mortar wash on a surface that big cracks within a few seasons. Once it does, every rain goes into the top courses and down the core, which is what feeds the loose stones and spalling brick below.

The repair: we remove the failed wash, rebuild any top courses that have taken water, and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from the flues, overhanging the stack by two inches on all sides so water drips clear of the face, with a bond break around each flue tile so the tiles can expand without cracking the crown. Each flue gets a stainless cap. On a wide chimney the crown is the single most important piece of waterproofing, and it's the one most often skipped.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When stones are loose across several courses, brick faces have spalled off whole sides, a crack runs through multiple courses, or the stack has started to lean, repointing won't hold. The section above the roof has taken decades of freeze-thaw while the section inside the house stayed dry, so the rebuild is from the roofline up.

The repair: we scaffold the roof with protective cribbing and take the stack down to the roofline or the first sound course. On stone chimneys we salvage the original stone wherever it's intact and supplement with matched fieldstone, because a rebuild in new material on an old stone chimney never looks like it belongs. On brick we match the color and size. Flue tiles are inspected and replaced if cracked, the top gets a poured crown as above, and new flashing and a cricket go in at the roof.

White stains on stone or brick

Chalky white efflorescence on the face of the chimney is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. It isn't damage on its own, but on a Wyckoff chimney it almost always means a cracked crown, open joints, or — on cultured-stone veneer — water trapped behind the stone with no drainage plane. Fixing the source stops the staining; cleaning it doesn't.

Sided chimney chases

Some Wyckoff homes, especially 1990s and later, vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood chase instead of masonry. Those fail at the flat galvanized cover on top, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years and drips into the framing. We replace the cover with a pitched stainless or copper one, and reframe the box if the sheathing underneath has gone soft. It's a smaller part of our Wyckoff work than the masonry above, but we do it.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Ceiling stain beside the fireplace during heavy rain	Wide chimney with no cricket; tarred flashing	Frame a cricket, new step flashing, counter-flashing cut into brick or stone
Mortar crumbs at the base, a stone that moves	Washed-out joints behind the stone	Rake and repoint by hand, reset loose stones in matched mortar
Sandy, recessed joints on brick	Mortar past its lifespan	Grind and repoint in matched Type N
Cracked top around the flues	Mortar wash on a wide top	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown with flue caps

Loose stones across several courses, lean, spalled brick	Core failure above the roofline	Roofline rebuild with salvaged stone or matched brick
White chalky stains	Water moving through the masonry	Fix crown, joints, or veneer drainage
Rust streaks on a sided chimney	Galvanized chase cover rusted through	Pitched stainless or copper cover; reframe if rotted

Common questions from Wyckoff homeowners

How do you flash a fieldstone chimney when there's no straight mortar joint?
We cut a continuous channel into the stone itself with a diamond blade, stepping it up the roof slope, and set the counter-flashing into that channel. Caulking metal to the bumps of a stone face always leaks; a cut channel is a mechanical seal.

Can a stone chimney be repointed, or does it have to be rebuilt?
Repointed, if the stones are still seated and water isn't coming through the inside of the chimney. We check both from the roof. Rebuilding is for chimneys where whole courses have gone loose or the core is failing.

Will new mortar match the old?
We match the color and sand before starting and tool the joints to the original profile. New mortar reads slightly brighter for a season and weathers in.

Is the leak from my roof or my chimney?
Often both. We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting — the attic side shows whether water is coming in at the flashing or running down through the masonry — and put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Wyckoff by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 20 minutes from Wyckoff via Route 4 and Route 208. Our own crews handle the masonry, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Franklin Lakes, Ridgewood, Allendale, Midland Park, Oakland, and across Bergen County.

One note before Allendale: Bergen County is where these pages will actually produce calls. Morris, Essex, Union, Somerset, and Passaic are 30–60 minutes from Bergenfield, and Google weights distance from your business address heavily for "near me" and map results. I'd still write them, but the Bergen pages get the real job photos and the most care; the outer counties can share a lighter version. Also, 114 pages means a lot of neighborhood detail — on towns I don't know as well as the Bergen ones, I'll stay to what I'm confident is accurate rather than name streets I'm unsure of.

Allendale, masonry-first. Deep-dives: brick repointing and crowns (1960s–70s colonials and splits), flashing, with a stone section for the Crestwood and older-estate homes.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/allendale-nj/`
Title tag (57 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Allendale NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (149 chars): Chimney repair in Allendale, NJ — brick repointing, cracked crowns, chimney leak and flashing repair, and roofline rebuilds on colonials and split-levels.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Leak Repair in Allendale, NJ

Allendale is a small borough, and most of it was built in one stretch: the colonials, split-levels, and bi-levels that went up from the late 1950s through the 1970s on the streets fanning out from West Crescent Avenue and Franklin Turnpike. There's an older layer too — Victorians and pre-war homes around the train station and the center of town — and a scattering of larger homes with fieldstone chimneys toward Crestwood Lake and the Saddle River line. Nearly every one of those homes has a solid brick chimney, and most of those chimneys are now 50 to 65 years old.

That age is the point. A brick chimney built in 1965 is right at the end of its original mortar's life and well past the life of the mortar wash the builder troweled on top. Those two things give out together, and that's the bulk of what we get called about in Allendale.

Chimney repointing in Allendale

The mortar between the bricks lasts 25 to 40 years in this climate, so an Allendale chimney from the 1960s that hasn't been repointed is overdue. You'll see it as recessed joints, sandy gaps where you can scrape mortar out with a key, and dark staining on the brick after rain because the open joints are soaking water in instead of shedding it.

The postwar brick in Allendale is a fairly standard modular red, and it's harder and more uniform than the brick on the pre-war homes near the station. That matters for the mortar choice. The 1960s chimneys can take a normal Type N repoint. The older Victorian and 1920s chimneys were laid in a softer lime-based mortar, and if those are repointed in a modern hard mix, the mortar ends up stronger than the brick and the brick cracks around it in winter. We see that failure often on older Allendale homes that were "fixed" twenty years ago.

The repair: we grind the old joints out three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep across the full exposed section above the roof — every joint, not only the ones that look bad, because the rest are one winter behind — clean them, and repoint in a breathable Type N mortar tinted to match the existing color. On the pre-war homes we use a softer mix. Joints are tooled to match the original, usually a concave or weathered joint on these houses, so the repoint doesn't read as a patch from the street.

Cracked chimney top and failed crown

Look at the top of your chimney from the yard. On almost every postwar Allendale home you'll see a thin slope of mortar around the clay flue liner. That's a mortar wash, and it was never meant to be waterproofing — it was the builder's way of finishing the top quickly. After five or six decades of freezing and thawing it's cracked, chipped, or missing.

Once the wash cracks, every rain goes into the top course of brick and down the center of the stack. That water is what later shows up as crumbling mortar, brick faces popping off, and sometimes a ceiling stain that gets blamed on the roof. On a 1960s chimney, the cracked crown is usually the root cause and the rest is symptoms.

The repair: we chip off the old wash, rebuild the top courses if water has gotten into them, and form and pour a real concrete crown — sloped away from the flue, reinforced so it won't crack across the middle, overhanging the brick by two inches so water drips clear of the face, and separated from the flue tile with a bond break so the tile can expand without breaking the crown. A stainless cap goes on the flue. On a chimney that's otherwise sound, this is the one repair that stops the water feeding everything else, and it's where we'd start on most Allendale homes.

Chimney leaking when it rains

If water shows up on the ceiling or the attic rafters right beside the chimney while it's raining, especially with wind, the leak is at the flashing — the metal where the shingles meet the chimney — and not through the masonry. If it shows up a day after rain and the bricks stay dark and wet, it's the crown or the joints above.

Most Allendale chimneys have been through at least one roof replacement, and the flashing is usually where that job was rushed: a single piece of aluminum laid flat against the brick and sealed with roofing tar. Tar bakes brittle in the sun, pulls away from the brick, and then every

rain runs behind the metal. On the split-levels and bi-levels the chimney is often on the rear slope with nothing behind it to divert water, so leaves and rain pile up against the back wall.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney base, replace any rotted deck, and wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane. Step flashing is woven into every shingle course. The counter-flashing is set into a groove ground into the mortar joint — not caulked onto the face of the brick — wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket framed behind them so water splits around both sides. Matching shingles are woven back in, so this doesn't require a new roof.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When pieces of brick are showing up in the gutters, a vertical crack runs through several courses, or the stack has started to lean, repointing won't hold. The section above the roof has taken decades of weather while the section inside the house stayed dry, so the rebuild is from the roofline up.

The repair: we scaffold the roof with protective cribbing, take the chimney down to the roofline or the first sound course, and rebuild it plumb in matched brick — color-matched modular red on the postwar homes, reclaimed or matched soft brick on the pre-war ones. Flue tiles are inspected and replaced if cracked, the top gets a poured crown, and new flashing goes in at the roof.

Stone chimneys near Crestwood and the Saddle River line

The larger homes toward Crestwood Lake and along the eastern side of town often have fieldstone or stone-veneer chimneys, and those fail differently. The irregular joints and ledges on a stone face hold water, and under the heavy tree cover on those lots the stone stays damp long enough to freeze. You'll see mortar crumbs at the base and stones that move when pushed.

The repair: we rake the joints out by hand to avoid scarring the stone, reset any loose stones in fresh mortar, and repoint in a matched Type N finished to the original joint profile. Flashing on stone chimneys is cut into the stone face itself rather than caulked, since there's no level mortar joint to use. On veneer chimneys with white staining bleeding through, we open the face and install the drainage plane that was left out when it was built.

White stains on the brick

The chalky white film on the brick is efflorescence — salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. It isn't damage, but it tells you the chimney is wet inside, and on an Allendale

chimney that almost always traces back to a cracked crown, open joints, or both. Fixing those stops the staining; cleaning it alone doesn't.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Sandy, recessed joints; brick dark after rain	Original mortar past its lifespan	Grind and repoint in matched Type N
Cracked or missing mortar at the top around the flue	Mortar wash instead of a crown	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown with a stainless cap
Ceiling stain beside the chimney during rain	Tarred flashing; no cricket	New step flashing, reglet-cut counter-flashing, cricket if over 30"
Brick pieces in gutters, cracks through courses, lean	Core failure above the roofline	Roofline rebuild in matched brick, crown, flashing
Mortar crumbs at the base of a stone chimney, loose stone	Washed-out joints behind the stone	Hand-rake, reset stones, repoint
White chalky stains	Water moving through the masonry	Fix crown and joints

Common questions from Allendale homeowners

Can the crown be replaced without rebuilding the chimney?
Yes, if the brick below it is still sound. We check the top few courses when we remove the old wash and rebuild only what's taken water.

Do you have to replace the roof to fix the flashing?
No. As long as the surrounding shingles are still pliable, we lift the courses around the base, do the work, and weave matching shingles back in.

Why did my last repoint fail after ten years?
Usually one of two reasons: the joints were skimmed over rather than ground out and refilled, or the crown was still cracked and kept feeding water into the stack from the top. We can tell which from the roof.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is coming in at the flashing or running down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Allendale by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 25 minutes from Allendale. Our own crews handle the masonry, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Saddle River, Ramsey, Waldwick, Wyckoff, Ho-Ho-Kus, and across Bergen County.

Next is Alpine — that one's almost all large estate homes with stone and oversized multi-flue brick chimneys, so it'll lead with stone repointing and crowns and read quite different from this one. Say the word.

Alpine — estate homes, so this one leads with stone repointing, multi-flue crowns, and copper flashing on slate and cedar roofs. Different animal from Allendale.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/alpine-nj/`
Title tag (55 chars): Stone & Brick Chimney Repair Alpine NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (154 chars): Chimney repair in Alpine, NJ — stone and brick chimney repointing, multi-flue crown replacement, copper flashing on slate roofs, and roofline rebuilds.

Stone & Brick Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Alpine, NJ

Alpine's housing is almost entirely large estate homes on wooded lots — the properties along Closter Dock Road, in Rio Vista, and off Route 9W toward the Palisades — and the chimneys match the houses. They're wide, they're tall, they carry three or four flues, and they're built in fieldstone, limestone, oversized brick, or stone veneer, often on homes with slate, cedar shake, or standing-seam copper roofs. A chimney like that has more exposed masonry, more mortar joints, and a bigger top surface than three ordinary chimneys put together, and every one of those surfaces is catching weather on a lot shaded by oak and tulip poplar.

The problems that follow are predictable: stone joints washing out, crowns cracking across wide multi-flue tops, and flashing that was never properly cut into stone. Here's how we recognize and repair each on Alpine homes.

Stone chimney repointing

Fieldstone and cut-stone chimneys fail at the joints, and the joints on an Alpine chimney are long. A single stack can have a hundred linear feet of mortar above the roofline, running in every direction, from a quarter inch to two inches wide. The irregular face holds water on every ledge, tree shade keeps it there, and winter freezes it. You'll see mortar crumbs collecting at the base of the chimney, recessed joints you can fit a finger into, and eventually a stone that moves when you push on it.

Repointing stone is slower than repointing brick and it's where a lot of general masons go wrong. The usual damage is a wide diamond blade run along the joints, which scars the stone edges permanently and is visible from the driveway forever.

The repair: we rake the joints out by hand with chisels and a narrow grinder, at least three-quarters of an inch deep and proportionally deeper on the wide joints so the new mortar has something to hold. Loose stones are pulled, cleaned, and reset in fresh mortar rather than pointed around. We sample the existing mortar and match the color and sand before starting, and finish the joints to the original profile — raked, flush, or weathered, depending on how the chimney was built. On a limestone or cut-stone chimney with tight, regular joints, we treat it more like fine brickwork and use a correspondingly tighter tool. The mortar is a breathable Type N throughout; stone is hard enough that it doesn't need the soft lime mixes used on old brick, but it still needs to breathe.

Stone-veneer chimneys — manufactured stone over a block or wood core, common on homes built since the 1990s — are a separate case. When the veneer went on without a drainage

plane and weep screed behind it, water that gets past the stone has nowhere to exit. The signs are efflorescence bleeding through the face and stones popping loose. Patching those back on without addressing the drainage moves the failure a few feet over. We open the affected face, install the drainage layer that should have been there, and re-set the stone.

Cracked crown on a multi-flue chimney

On a chimney carrying three or four flues, the top is a slab several feet on a side. Almost all of them were finished with a mortar wash — mortar troweled around the flue tiles in a rough slope — and a mortar wash on a surface that large cracks within a few winters. Once it does, rain goes straight into the top courses and down the core, which is what feeds the loose stones and spalling lower down. On a tall Alpine chimney the water has a long way to travel inside the stack before it shows up anywhere you can see it.

The repair: we remove the failed wash, take down and rebuild any top courses that have taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown. It slopes away from every flue, overhangs the stack on all sides by two inches so water drips clear of the stone instead of running down the face, carries wire or fiber reinforcement so it won't crack across its width, and has a bond break around each flue tile so the tiles can expand without breaking the crown. Each flue gets a stainless cap, or a custom copper cap on homes where the roof and gutters are copper. On a chimney this size, the crown is the most important piece of waterproofing on the whole structure.

Chimney leaking when it rains

Water on a ceiling or down an interior wall near the chimney during a hard rain usually traces to the flashing where the roof meets the stone — and on Alpine homes, flashing is complicated by the roofing. Slate and cedar can't be lifted and re-woven the way asphalt shingles can, and a stone face doesn't have a straight mortar joint to cut counter-flashing into. The result is that a lot of the flashing we see on Alpine chimneys was surface-applied and sealed with caulk, which fails within a few years.

The repair: on slate, we remove and reset the slates around the chimney rather than cutting them; on cedar shake, we pull and replace the surrounding courses. The base is wrapped in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane and step flashing is set in every course. For the counter-flashing, on brick we grind a reglet into the mortar joint; on stone we saw-cut a continuous stepped channel into the stone face so the metal sits inside the rock. All of it is 20-ounce copper on these homes — it matches the existing copper work and it outlasts the roof. Chimneys wider than 30 inches, which is nearly all of them here, get a cricket framed behind them so water and leaves split around both sides.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When stones have gone loose across several courses, brick has spalled off whole faces, or the stack has shifted or leans, repointing stops being the answer. The exposed section has taken decades of freeze-thaw while the section inside the house stayed protected, so the rebuild is from the roofline up — occasionally lower on a chimney that's been leaking into its core for a long time.

The repair: we scaffold the roof with protective cribbing — on slate and copper that cribbing is extensive — and take the stack down to sound masonry. On stone chimneys we salvage every intact original stone and supplement with matched fieldstone or limestone, because a rebuild in new material on an estate chimney never looks right. On brick we match the color and the oversized format. Flue tiles are inspected and replaced if cracked, the top gets a poured crown as above, and new copper flashing and a cricket go in at the roof.

White stains on stone or brick

The chalky white film on a chimney face is efflorescence — salts carried out of the masonry by water moving through it. It isn't damage, but it tells you the chimney is wet inside, and on an Alpine chimney that almost always points to a cracked crown, open joints, or veneer without drainage. Fixing the source stops the staining.

Prefab fireplaces in secondary chases

Some Alpine homes vent a secondary fireplace — a bedroom or a pool house — through a sided or veneered chase with a metal cover on top. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace them with pitched stainless or copper covers. It's a small share of what we do here compared with the masonry above.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Mortar crumbs at the base, a stone that moves	Washed-out joints behind the stone	Hand-rake, reset stones, repoint in matched mortar
Cracked or crumbling top around the flues	Mortar wash on a wide multi-flue top	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown with capped flues
Interior stain near the chimney during rain	Surface-caulked flashing; no cricket	Reset slate or shake, copper step and counter-flashing cut into the stone, cricket

Loose stones across courses, spalled brick, lean	Core failure above the roofline	Roofline rebuild with salvaged stone or matched brick
White staining; veneer stones popping off	Water trapped behind veneer with no drainage	Open the face, install drainage plane, re-set stone
Rust streaks on a sided secondary chase	Galvanized cover rusted through	Pitched stainless or copper cover

Common questions from Alpine homeowners

Can you repair the chimney without disturbing a slate or copper roof?
Yes. Slates around the chimney are removed and reset, not cut, and copper roofs are worked around with new copper flashing soldered to match. We crib the roof heavily before any masonry work.

Will new mortar match the old on a stone chimney?
We match the color and the sand against a sample of the existing mortar and tool the joints to the original profile. New mortar reads slightly lighter for a season and weathers in.

Can a stone chimney be repointed, or does it have to be rebuilt?
Repointed, if the stones are still seated and water isn't coming through the inside of the stack. We check both from the roof. Rebuilding is for chimneys where whole courses have gone loose or the core is failing.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or running down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Alpine by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about ten minutes from Alpine. Our own crews handle the masonry, the copper work, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Closter, Demarest, Cresskill, Tenafly, Englewood Cliffs, and across Bergen County.

Next: Bergenfield — your home town, so it should get your real job photos (the Castro roof on Home Pl, the Moline job on New York Ave if there was chimney work). It's a postwar brick-cape town, so it'll lead with crowns and repointing and read close to Fair Lawn — I'll keep the wording distinct. Ready when you are.

Bergenfield — home base. Leads with flashing leaks and repointing (Fair Lawn led with crowns and rebuilds), and the closing section leans on the fact that you're on South Washington Avenue.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/bergenfield-nj/`
Title tag (59 chars): Chimney Repair & Leak Repair Bergenfield NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (151 chars): Chimney repair in Bergenfield, NJ from a Bergenfield contractor — chimney leaks, flashing, brick repointing, crown replacement, and roofline rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Leak Repair & Repointing in Bergenfield, NJ

Lita Construction is based on South Washington Avenue, so Bergenfield chimneys are the ones we know best. The borough is mostly postwar — capes and colonials built in the late 1940s and 1950s on the grid between Washington Avenue and the Dumont and Teaneck lines, with split-levels filling in through the 1960s — plus an older layer of 1920s and 30s homes near the center of town and around Cooper's Pond. Almost all of them have a solid brick chimney, and almost all of those chimneys are between 60 and 80 years old.

At that age the problems come in a set: flashing that's been tarred over during two or three roof jobs, mortar that's past its life, and a top that was never properly crowned. Here's how each one shows up on a Bergenfield house and how we fix it.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A water stain on the ceiling or attic rafters right next to the chimney, showing up during a rain rather than after it, is a flashing leak. The metal where the shingles meet the chimney has opened up.

Bergenfield's capes have been through more roof replacements than almost any housing stock in the county — a 1950 roof has been redone at least twice by now — and every one of those jobs touched the chimney flashing. Most of the time the roofer laid a single piece of aluminum flat against the brick and sealed it with roofing tar instead of cutting it into the mortar. Tar hardens in the sun, pulls away from the brick within a few years, and leaves a gap that every rain runs behind. On capes with the chimney on the rear slope, there's usually nothing behind it to divert water, so leaves and rain pile against the back wall and work under the shingles.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney base, replace any rotted deck, and wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane. Step flashing is woven into every shingle course on the way back up. The counter-flashing is set into a groove ground into the mortar joint — not caulked to the face of the brick — wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket framed behind them. Matching shingles are woven back in, so you don't need a new roof for this; and if you do need a roof, we do the flashing right as part of it.

Chimney repointing in Bergenfield

Recessed joints, sandy gaps, mortar you can pick out with a key, brick that stays dark for a day after rain — that's mortar at the end of its life. Mortar lasts 25 to 40 years here, so a 1950s Bergenfield chimney that's never been repointed is a couple of decades overdue, and one that was repointed in the 1980s is due again.

The brick on the postwar houses is a standard modular red and takes a normal Type N repoint. The 1920s and 30s homes near the center were laid in softer brick with a lime-based mortar, and those are the ones where a previous hard-mortar repoint causes trouble: the new mortar outlasts the brick, the brick cracks around it in winter, and faces start popping off. If your older Bergenfield chimney has brick flakes in the gutter but the joints look fine, that's usually what happened.

The repair: we grind the joints out three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep across the full section above the roof — all of them, since the ones that look fine are one winter behind the ones that don't — clean them, and repoint in a breathable Type N tinted to match. Softer mix on the pre-war homes. Joints are tooled to match the original profile so the work doesn't show as a patch.

Cracked chimney top

On most Bergenfield chimneys the top was finished with a thin mortar wash around the flue liner rather than a real crown. That wash cracks within a few seasons of freezing and thawing, and

once it does, rain goes into the top course and down the middle of the stack. A lot of the crumbling mortar and spalled brick we see lower down started with a cracked top years earlier.

The repair: we chip off the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a concrete crown — sloped away from the flue, reinforced, overhanging the brick by two inches so water drips clear, and separated from the flue tile with a bond break. A stainless cap goes on the flue. On a chimney that's otherwise sound, this is the cheapest repair that stops the most water, and we often pair it with a repoint so the chimney is sealed top to bottom in one visit.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

If brick pieces are turning up in the gutter or on the lawn, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack has visibly tilted, repointing won't hold. The section above the roof is done, and it has to come down and go back up. The section inside the house has been dry the whole time and is almost always fine.

The repair: we scaffold the roof with protective cribbing, take the chimney down to the roofline or the first solid course, and rebuild it plumb in matched brick — a standard red on the postwar homes, reclaimed or color-matched soft brick on the older ones. Flue tiles are inspected and replaced if cracked, the top is poured as a crown, and new flashing goes in at the roof. On a cape this is typically a two-day job.

White stains on the brick

The chalky white film on the chimney face is efflorescence — salts carried out by water moving through the brick. It isn't damage, but it means the chimney is wet inside, and on a Bergenfield chimney that traces to a cracked top, open joints, or both. Fix those and the staining stops on its own.

Sided chimney chases on additions

A handful of Bergenfield homes — mostly 1970s-and-later additions and the newer construction on infill lots — vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood box with a metal cover on top. Those leak at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace the cover with a pitched stainless one and reframe the box if the wood underneath has gone soft. But brick chimneys are nearly everything we work on in town.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do

Ceiling stain beside the chimney during rain	Tarred flashing from a past roof job; no cricket	Strip base, step flashing, reglet-cut counter-flashing, cricket if over 30"
Sandy, recessed joints; brick dark after rain	Mortar past its lifespan	Grind and repoint in matched Type N
Brick flakes in gutters, joints look fine	Hard-mortar repoint on soft pre-war brick	Repoint in a softer mix; replace damaged brick
Cracked or missing mortar at the top	Mortar wash instead of a crown	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown with a cap
Brick pieces in the yard, crack through courses, lean	Core failure above the roofline	Roofline rebuild in matched brick, crown, flashing
White chalky stains	Water moving through the masonry	Fix top and joints

Common questions from Bergenfield homeowners

I just had my roof done and the chimney still leaks. Why?
Most roofers flash the chimney by laying metal against the brick and tarring it, which fails fast. If the stain came back within a year or two of the roof job, that's almost always what happened, and it's fixable without touching the rest of the roof.

Can you do the crown and the repoint at the same time?
Yes, and it's usually the right call — a repoint under a cracked crown keeps taking water from the top. One scaffold setup, one visit.

Why did my last repoint fail?
Either the joints were skimmed rather than ground out and refilled, the crown was left cracked and kept feeding water in, or a hard mortar was used on soft brick. We can tell which from the roof.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Bergenfield by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor located at 378 South Washington

Avenue in Bergenfield. We're a few minutes from any street in town, our own crews handle the masonry, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, and we stand behind the work because we drive past it. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Dumont, Teaneck, New Milford, Tenafly, Englewood, and across Bergen County.

This is the page that most deserves real before/after photos with street names, since it's your address and Google will trust it most. Next is Closter.

Closter — a two-era town: 1950s–60s splits and ranches on the west side, and a big wave of teardown rebuilds since the 1990s with oversized veneer and brick chimneys. Leads with rebuilds and veneer drainage, which no other page has led with yet.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/closter-nj/`
Title tag (58 chars): Chimney Repair, Rebuilds & Repointing Closter NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (153 chars): Chimney repair in Closter, NJ — roofline chimney rebuilds, brick repointing, stone veneer repair, cracked crowns, and chimney flashing leaks. Lita Construction.

Chimney Repair, Rebuilding & Repointing in Closter, NJ

Closter has two kinds of chimney, and they're often on the same street. The first is on the original postwar housing — the splits, ranches, and colonials built in the 1950s and 60s across the west side of the borough and around the center near Closter Dock Road and Harrington Avenue. Those are plain brick chimneys, now 60 to 70 years old, and they fail the way old brick does: joints wash out, the top cracks, the stack above the roof starts to go.

The second kind is on the teardown rebuilds. Since the 1990s a large share of Closter's older lots have been rebuilt with much bigger houses, and those homes carry much bigger chimneys — wide, tall, multi-flue stacks faced in stone veneer, cultured stone, or oversized brick. They're

newer, but they have their own failure pattern, and we see as many problems on a 20-year-old Closter chimney as on a 65-year-old one.

Here's what goes wrong with each and how Lita Construction repairs it.

Roofline chimney rebuilds on 1950s and 60s homes

On the older Closter houses, the chimney above the roof has taken six decades of weather while the section inside the house stayed dry. By now a lot of those upper stacks are past repointing: brick faces have spalled off, a crack runs through several courses, the top courses are loose, or the whole stack leans slightly toward the roof. You'll find red brick chips in the gutters and sometimes on the ground below.

Most of the time this traces back to a crown that failed twenty years ago and has been feeding water into the core ever since. Repointing a stack in that condition is money spent on mortar that has nothing solid to hold onto.

The repair: we scaffold the roof with protective cribbing, dismantle the chimney down to the roofline or the first sound course, and rebuild it plumb in matched brick. Postwar Closter brick is a standard modular red and matches well; we size and color-match so the rebuilt section doesn't read as a patch. Flue tiles are inspected and any cracked ones replaced. The top is finished with a poured, reinforced concrete crown that overhangs the brick by two inches, and new step and counter-flashing go in where the chimney meets the roof. On a split-level this is typically a two-day job, and the inside of the house is never touched.

Stone veneer chimney problems on newer homes

The large chimneys on Closter's rebuilt homes are mostly veneer — manufactured or natural thin stone adhered over a block or wood-framed core — and the failure we see most has nothing to do with the stone itself. It's what's behind it. When the veneer was installed without a proper drainage plane and weep screed, water that gets past the stone has no way out. It sits against the core, freezes, and pushes the stone off from behind.

From the ground, the signs are white efflorescence bleeding through the face, stones that have popped loose or fallen, and on wood-cored chimneys, staining or soft siding at the base. The chimney may be only 15 or 20 years old.

The repair: re-adhering the loose stones without fixing the drainage moves the failure to the next stone over. We open the affected face, install the drainage layer and weep screed that should have been there, and re-set the stone in polymer-modified mortar. Where the problem is confined to the top of the chimney — which is common, because the crown on these wide stacks is usually a thin wash that cracked early — we rebuild the top courses, pour a proper crown, and the water stops getting behind the veneer in the first place. Natural fieldstone

chimneys, which some of the higher-end rebuilds have, are repointed by hand and reset like any stone chimney.

Chimney repointing in Closter

On the postwar brick that's still sound, repointing is the repair. The signs are recessed, sandy joints, mortar you can pick out with a key, and brick that stays dark after rain because the open joints are absorbing water instead of shedding it. Mortar lasts 25 to 40 years here, so a 1960 Closter chimney that's never been pointed is well overdue.

The repair: we grind the joints out three-quarters of an inch to an inch across the full section above the roof — every joint, not only the obvious ones — clean them, and repoint in a breathable Type N tinted to match the existing mortar. Joints are tooled to the original profile, usually a concave joint on these homes. We almost always do the crown in the same visit, because a fresh repoint under a cracked top keeps taking water from above.

Cracked chimney top

Both eras of Closter chimney share this one. The 1950s builders finished the top with a thin mortar wash around the flue; the 2000s builders, on a top three times the size, often did the same. A mortar wash cracks within a few winters, and on a wide multi-flue top it cracks faster. Once it's open, rain goes straight into the core.

The repair: we remove the failed wash, rebuild any top courses that have taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from the flues, overhanging the stack by two inches on all sides so water drips clear of the face, with a bond break around each flue tile so the tiles can expand without cracking the crown. Each flue gets a stainless cap. On the wide chimneys, we reinforce the crown with wire or fiber mesh so it doesn't crack across the middle.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on the ceiling or attic framing beside the chimney that appears during rain is a flashing leak — the metal where shingles meet the chimney has opened up. On the older Closter homes it's usually flashing that was tarred to the brick during a past roof job. On the newer homes it's often that the flashing was surface-applied to the veneer and caulked, because there was no mortar joint to cut it into. Either way, the seal is gone within a few years.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the base, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and weave step flashing into every shingle course. On brick, the counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint. On stone veneer, we cut a continuous channel into the stone so the metal sits inside it rather than on top. Any chimney wider than 30 inches — most of the newer ones — gets a cricket framed behind it so water splits around both sides. We weave matching shingles back in; a new roof isn't required.

Prefab fireplace chases

Some Closter homes, both eras, vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood box rather than masonry. Those fail at the flat galvanized cover on top, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace it with a pitched stainless cover and reframe the box if the wood under it is soft. It's a small share of our work in town next to the masonry above.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Brick chips in gutters, crack through courses, lean (older home)	Upper stack past repointing	Roofline rebuild in matched brick, crown, flashing
Veneer stones popping off, white staining (newer home)	No drainage plane behind the veneer	Open the face, install drainage, re-set stone; fix the crown
Sandy, recessed joints; brick dark after rain	Mortar past its lifespan	Grind and repoint in matched Type N
Cracked top around the flue(s)	Mortar wash instead of a crown	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown with caps
Ceiling stain beside the chimney during rain	Tarred or surface-caulked flashing; no cricket	Step flashing, counter-flashing cut into brick or stone, cricket
Rust streaks on a sided chase	Galvanized cover rusted through	Pitched stainless cover; reframe if rotted

Common questions from Closter homeowners

My house was built in 2005. How can the chimney already have problems?
Age isn't the issue on those; construction is. A wide veneer chimney with a mortar-wash top and no drainage behind the stone can be taking water from the first winter. Twenty years of that shows up as loose stone and staining.

Is it worth repointing a 1960s chimney, or should it just be rebuilt?
If the brick is still sound — no spalling, no cracks through courses, no lean — repointing plus a new crown gives you another 30 years. If the brick itself is failing, rebuilding the upper stack is the only repair that holds. We tell you which from the roof.

Does the inside of the house get disturbed during a rebuild?
No. The rebuild is from the roofline up. The section of chimney inside the attic and the living space stays as it is.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or running down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Closter by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about ten minutes from Closter. Our own crews handle the masonry, the stone work, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Alpine, Demarest, Harrington Park, Norwood, Haworth, and across Bergen County.

Next is Cresskill.

Cresskill — the hill side (Tammy Brook and the streets climbing toward Alpine) is 1920s–30s Tudors and stone colonials on steep roofs; the flat side is 1950s–60s splits and ranches. Leads with the soft-brick/hard-mortar problem and steep-roof flashing, which no other page has led with.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/cresskill-nj/`
Title tag (56 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Cresskill NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (152 chars): Chimney repair in Cresskill, NJ — brick and stone repointing on pre-war Tudors, steep-roof flashing leaks, cracked crowns, and roofline chimney rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Leak Repair in Cresskill, NJ

Cresskill splits by elevation. On the hill — Tammy Brook, the streets climbing east off Piermont Road toward the Alpine line — the homes are pre-war: 1920s and 30s Tudors, stone-and-stucco colonials, and center-hall brick houses with steep roofs and tall chimneys in soft red brick or fieldstone. On the flat side west of the railroad tracks and around the Merritt school, the housing is postwar: splits, ranches, and colonials from the 1950s and 60s with standard brick chimneys.

The two sides fail differently. The hill chimneys are 90 to 100 years old, built in soft brick and lime mortar, and most have been repaired at least once by someone who used the wrong mortar. The flat-side chimneys are at the age where original mortar and the top wash give out together. Here's what we see on each and how Lita Construction repairs it.

Brick faces popping off on pre-war chimneys

This is the problem specific to Cresskill's older homes, and it's usually caused by a past repair. The brick on a 1928 Tudor is softer than modern brick, and it was laid in a lime-based mortar that flexed with it. Somewhere in the last 40 years, a mason repointed that chimney in a modern Portland cement mix — the gray bagged mortar everyone uses — and now the mortar is harder than the brick. When water freezes in the wall, the mortar holds and the brick breaks instead. The faces pop off, you find red flakes in the gutter, and the joints look fine, which is what confuses people. The repoint didn't fail; it's what caused the damage.

The repair: on spalled sections, we cut out the damaged brick, replace it with reclaimed or color-matched soft brick, and repoint the whole exposed face in a lime-rich Type N or Type O mortar matched to the original color and sand, tooled to the original joint — often a struck or weathered joint on these homes. On a chimney that's been hard-pointed everywhere, we grind out the hard mortar where it's practical and let the soft mortar take over. The point is to make the mortar the sacrificial part of the wall again, which is how the chimney was built to work.

Chimney leaking when it rains on a steep roof

Cresskill's Tudors and colonials carry 10/12 to 14/12 pitches, often slate or heavy architectural shingle, with the chimney on the main slope. Water comes down a roof that steep fast and hits the back of the chimney hard. Add the original flashing — lead or copper that lasted decades but has mostly been replaced during re-roofing with aluminum tarred to the brick — and the chimney base becomes the weak point of the whole roof.

If the stain on the ceiling or attic rafters appears during the rain, right beside the chimney, that's the flashing. If it shows up a day later and the brick stays dark, it's the joints or the top.

The repair: on slate roofs we remove and reset the slates around the chimney rather than cutting them; on shingle we strip the surrounding courses. Any rotted deck is replaced, the base is wrapped in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and step flashing goes in every course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — on soft brick we grind carefully to the joint only — wedged, and sealed. On these homes we do the flashing in 20-ounce copper, which matches the original work and outlasts the roof. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket framed behind them so water splits around both sides instead of damming against the back wall.

Stone chimneys on the hill

A good share of the pre-war homes on Cresskill's east side have fieldstone chimneys, and some of the larger later homes toward Alpine have stone or stone veneer. Stone fails at the joints: the irregular face holds water on every ledge, the tree cover on those lots keeps it there, and winter works the mortar loose. You'll see mortar crumbs at the base of the chimney and stones that shift when pushed.

The repair: we rake the joints out by hand with chisels and a narrow grinder — a wide blade scars the stone permanently — at least three-quarters of an inch deep and deeper on the wide joints, reset any loose stones in fresh mortar, and repoint in a breathable Type N matched to the existing color and sand, finished to the original joint profile. Flashing on stone is cut into the stone face itself, since there's no level mortar joint to use.

Chimney repointing on the flat side

The postwar chimneys west of the tracks are a simpler case. The brick is a standard modular red, the mortar is a normal cement-lime mix, and after 60-plus years the joints are recessed, sandy, and absorbing water. Mortar lasts 25 to 40 years here, so a 1958 Cresskill chimney is overdue.

The repair: we grind the joints out three-quarters of an inch to an inch across the full section above the roof — every joint, since the ones that look fine are one winter behind — clean them, and repoint in a Type N tinted to match, tooled to the original concave joint. We almost always do the crown at the same time.

Cracked chimney top

Both sides of town share this one. The pre-war chimneys had a mortar or sometimes a stone cap that's long since cracked; the postwar chimneys were finished with a thin mortar wash around the flue liner that was never meant to last. Once the top is open, rain goes into the top courses and down the core, which is what feeds the spalling and washed-out joints below.

The repair: we remove the failed wash or cap, rebuild any top courses that have taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from the flue, overhanging the brick or stone by two inches so water drips clear of the face, with a bond break around the flue tile so the tile can expand without cracking it. A stainless cap goes on the flue, or copper where the house has copper gutters and flashing.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, the top courses are loose, or the stack leans, repointing won't hold. The section above the roof comes down and goes back up; the section inside the house, which has stayed dry, is left alone.

The repair: we scaffold the roof with protective cribbing — heavily on slate — and take the stack down to sound masonry. On the pre-war homes we rebuild in reclaimed or color-matched soft brick laid in a lime-rich mortar, or in salvaged original stone, so the rebuilt section looks like it belongs on the house. On the postwar homes we match the standard red. Flue tiles are inspected and replaced if cracked, the top gets a poured crown, and new copper or aluminum flashing goes in at the roof.

White stains on brick or stone

The chalky white film on the chimney face is efflorescence — salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. It's not damage, but it tells you the chimney is wet inside, and on a Cresskill chimney that points to a cracked top, open joints, or both.

Prefab fireplace chases

A few Cresskill additions and newer homes vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood box with a metal cover. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace it with a pitched stainless cover and reframe the box if needed. It's a small share of our work here next to the masonry above.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Brick faces popping off, joints look fine (older home)	Hard-mortar repoint on soft brick	Replace spalled brick, repoint in lime-rich mortar
Ceiling stain beside the chimney during rain, steep roof	Tarred flashing; no cricket	Reset slate or strip shingles, copper step and counter-flashing, cricket

Mortar crumbs at the base of a stone chimney, loose stone	Washed-out joints behind the stone	Hand-rake, reset stones, repoint
Sandy, recessed joints (postwar home)	Mortar past its lifespan	Grind and repoint in matched Type N
Cracked top around the flue	Mortar wash or failed cap	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown
Spalling through whole faces, cracks through courses, lean	Core failure above the roofline	Roofline rebuild in matched brick or salvaged stone
White chalky stains	Water moving through the masonry	Fix top and joints

Common questions from Cresskill homeowners

My chimney was repointed 15 years ago and now the bricks are breaking. Why?
Almost certainly a hard mortar on soft pre-war brick. The mortar is now stronger than the brick, so the brick takes the freeze-thaw damage instead. The fix is to replace the damaged brick and repoint in a softer mortar that flexes.

Can you work on a slate roof without breaking slates?
Yes. We remove and reset the slates around the chimney rather than cutting them, crib the roof before any masonry work, and replace any slate that cracks with matching salvaged slate.

Will the rebuilt brick match a 1920s chimney?
We source reclaimed brick or a color-matched soft brick and lay it in a mortar matched to the original. It won't be invisible on day one, but it weathers in within a season or two and doesn't read as a patch.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or running down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Cresskill by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about five minutes from Cresskill. Our own crews handle the masonry, the copper work, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Tenafly, Demarest, Alpine, Dumont, Bergenfield, and across Bergen County.

Next is Demarest.

Demarest — wooded lots, 1950s–70s colonials and splits on big parcels, a pre-war pocket around the station and Hardenburgh Avenue, and larger custom homes toward the Alpine line. Leads with the moisture problem (shade, moss, exterior-wall chimneys) and crowns.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/demarest-nj/`
Title tag (56 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Demarest NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (150 chars): Chimney repair in Demarest, NJ — cracked crowns, brick repointing, chimney flashing leaks, and roofline rebuilds on wooded-lot colonials and split-levels.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Leak Repair in Demarest, NJ

Demarest is one of the most wooded towns in eastern Bergen County, and that shapes its chimney problems more than the age of the houses does. Most of the borough is 1950s–70s colonials, splits, and ranches on half-acre and larger lots off County Road, Hardenburgh Avenue, and Piermont Road, with an older pocket of 1920s and 30s homes near the train station and larger custom homes on the east side toward Alpine. Nearly all have brick chimneys — a good number built on an exterior wall, so three sides of the stack are exposed from the ground up.

The tree canopy is the common factor. A chimney under oak and tulip poplar doesn't see sun until afternoon, so brick and mortar that got wet in the morning are still damp at nightfall. In winter that means more freeze-thaw cycles than a chimney in an open neighborhood; the rest of the year it means moss and lichen on the north face holding moisture against the mortar. Demarest chimneys fail sooner than their age suggests, and here's what that looks like.

Cracked chimney top and water coming in from above

On the mid-century homes the top of the chimney was finished with a thin mortar wash around the clay flue liner — the builder's quick finish, not a waterproofing detail. Under tree cover that wash cracks early, and once it's open, every rain goes into the top course of brick and down the core of the stack. On an exterior-wall chimney the water has three cold faces to freeze against on its way down.

What you'll see from the yard: cracked or missing mortar around the flue, dark staining running down from the top of the stack, and later, brick faces popping off the upper courses. Most of the mortar and brick damage we repair in Demarest started with a cracked top years earlier.

The repair: we chip off the failed wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a concrete crown — sloped away from the flue, reinforced so it won't crack across the middle, overhanging the brick by two inches so water drips clear of the face, with a bond break around the flue tile so the tile can expand without breaking it. A stainless cap goes on the flue and keeps rain and leaves out of the liner. On a chimney that's otherwise sound, this is the first repair we'd recommend on almost any Demarest home.

Moss, dark staining, and washed-out mortar

A Demarest chimney's north face tells the story. Green moss on the brick, black streaks from the top down, and mortar joints that have gone sandy and recessed — that's the shade side absorbing water the sun never dries out. Mortar lasts 25 to 40 years in the open; on a shaded exterior-wall chimney it can be 20. By the time the joints are soft enough to pick out with a key, wind-driven rain is going straight through the wall and down behind the flashing.

The repair: we clean the moss and biological growth off the masonry first, because mortar can't bond to a dirty joint. Then we grind the joints out three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep across the full exposed section — every face, every joint, not only the north side that looks bad — and repoint in a breathable Type N tinted to match the existing mortar, tooled to the original concave or weathered joint. On the pre-war homes near the station, the brick is softer and we use a lime-rich mix so the mortar stays the sacrificial part of the wall. A breathable masonry water repellent on the repointed stack slows the re-growth without trapping moisture.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on the ceiling or attic rafters right beside the chimney that shows up during a rain is a flashing leak. On Demarest's colonials the chimney is often on an exterior wall with the roof running into it on one side only, and on the splits it's often on the rear slope with a wide back wall facing uphill. Both are hard spots to flash, and the flashing was usually redone during a past roof job by laying aluminum against the brick and tarring it. Tar pulls away from the brick within a few years, and on a wide back wall with no cricket, leaves and water pile up against it and work under the shingles.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, and wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane. Step flashing goes into every shingle course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — not caulked to the brick — wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket framed behind them so water and leaves split around both sides. Matching shingles are woven back in; this doesn't require a new roof.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When the upper stack has spalled through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the chimney leans toward the roof, repointing won't hold. The section above the roof comes down and goes back up; the section inside the house, which has stayed dry, is left alone. On an exterior-wall chimney we sometimes take it lower, to wherever the brick is sound.

The repair: we scaffold with protective cribbing, dismantle the damaged section, and rebuild plumb in color-matched brick — a standard modular red on the mid-century homes, reclaimed or matched soft brick on the pre-war ones. Flue tiles are inspected and replaced if cracked, the top gets a poured crown as above, and new flashing goes in at the roof.

Stone chimneys on the east side

The larger homes toward the Alpine line, and some of the older houses, have fieldstone or stone veneer chimneys. Under this much shade the irregular stone face holds water on every ledge, and the joints wash out. You'll see mortar crumbs at the base and a stone that shifts when pushed. On veneer, white staining bleeding through the face usually means water trapped behind the stone with no drainage.

The repair: we rake stone joints by hand to avoid scarring the stone, reset loose stones in fresh mortar, and repoint in a matched Type N finished to the original profile. On veneer with drainage problems we open the face, install the drainage layer and weep screed, and re-set the stone. Flashing on stone is cut into the stone face itself.

White stains on the brick

The chalky white film on the chimney is efflorescence — salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. It isn't damage, but it means the chimney is wet inside, and on a Demarest chimney that points to a cracked top, open joints, or both. Fix those and the staining stops.

Prefab fireplace chases

A few Demarest additions and newer homes vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood box with a metal cover on top. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace it with a pitched stainless cover and reframe the box if the wood under it is soft. It's a small share of our work here next to the masonry above.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Cracked top, dark streaks running down from it	Mortar wash cracked; water entering from above	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown with a cap
Moss on the north face, sandy recessed joints	Shade keeping mortar wet; past its lifespan	Clean, grind, and repoint in matched Type N
Ceiling stain beside the chimney during rain	Tarred flashing; wide back wall with no cricket	Step flashing, reglet-cut counter-flashing, cricket
Spalling through whole faces, crack through courses, lean	Core failure above the roofline	Roofline rebuild in matched brick, crown, flashing
Mortar crumbs at the base of a stone chimney	Washed-out joints behind the stone	Hand-rake, reset stones, repoint
White chalky stains	Water moving through the masonry	Fix top and joints

Common questions from Demarest homeowners

Why does my chimney look worse than my neighbor's when the houses are the same age?
Usually shade. A chimney on the north side of a wooded lot gets more freeze-thaw cycles and never dries fully, so it ages faster than one in the sun. The fix is the same; it's just due sooner.

Should I have the moss cleaned off?
Yes, but on its own that's cosmetic. Moss is a sign the mortar is staying wet. We clean it as the first step of a repoint, and a breathable repellent on the new work slows it coming back.

Can the crown be done without rebuilding the chimney?
Yes, if the brick below it is sound. We check the top courses when we remove the old wash and rebuild only what's taken water.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water

is entering at the flashing or running down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Demarest by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about five minutes from Demarest, and we've worked on homes here for years. Our own crews handle the masonry, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Closter, Cresskill, Haworth, Alpine, Tenafly, and across Bergen County.

Next is Dumont.

Dumont — dense postwar capes and colonials, nearly all with an interior chimney that doubles as the furnace flue. Leads with two things no other page has: chimneys deteriorating from the inside after oil-to-gas conversions, and flashing on chimneys that come through the ridge of a cape.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/dumont-nj/`
Title tag (54 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Dumont NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (153 chars): Chimney repair in Dumont, NJ — crumbling furnace chimneys after gas conversions, brick repointing, cracked crowns, flashing leaks, and roofline rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Leak Repair in Dumont, NJ

Dumont is a tight grid of postwar capes and colonials — most of the borough went up between the mid-1940s and the late 1950s on small lots along Washington Avenue, Madison Avenue,

Grant Avenue, and the streets between — with an older layer of 1920s homes near the center and a few split-levels from the 60s on the edges. Nearly every house has a single brick chimney that runs up through the middle of the house and out the ridge, and on most of them that chimney vents the furnace or boiler as well as the fireplace, if there is one.

That double duty is what makes Dumont chimneys different. A chimney that's been carrying furnace exhaust for 70 years, through at least one change of fuel, has been attacked from the inside as well as the outside. Here's what we see on Dumont chimneys and how Lita Construction repairs it.

Chimney crumbling after an oil-to-gas conversion

This is the Dumont problem. Most of these houses were built with oil heat and converted to gas sometime in the last 30 years. Oil exhaust is hot and dry and goes up the chimney fast. Gas exhaust is cooler and full of water vapor, and in a tall, unlined or clay-lined masonry chimney it condenses on the way up — especially in the section above the roof, which is the coldest. That condensate is acidic. It soaks into the brick and mortar from the inside, and over a few winters it does what decades of rain couldn't: the mortar turns to sand from the flue side outward, brick faces spall off, and the top courses come loose.

From the ground, the signs are brick flakes in the gutter and on the roof, white or yellowish staining on the brick near the top, mortar crumbs around the base of the stack, and sometimes a damp, sour smell in the basement near the boiler. The chimney often looks worse at the top than the bottom, which is the condensation pattern.

The repair: the outside damage is repaired like any masonry — spalled brick cut out and replaced, joints ground and repointed, the top rebuilt and crowned. But if the gas appliance is still venting into bare clay tile or unlined brick, the damage comes back. So the repair includes a stainless steel liner sized to the appliance, run from the boiler connection to the top of the chimney and sealed at the crown. The liner keeps the condensate off the masonry, and the chimney stops eating itself from the inside. If the furnace has since been converted to a direct-vent unit and the chimney only carries a water heater or nothing at all, we address that instead — an abandoned flue still needs to be capped and the top sealed.

Chimney repointing in Dumont

Even without the gas problem, a 1950 chimney's original mortar is past its life. Mortar lasts 25 to 40 years here; most Dumont chimneys are on their second or third round or have never been pointed. The signs are recessed, sandy joints, mortar you can scrape out with a key, and brick that stays dark for a day after rain because open joints are drinking water instead of shedding it.

The repair: we grind the joints out three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep across the full section above the roof — every joint, since the ones that look fine are one winter behind the ones that don't — clean them, and repoint in a breathable Type N tinted to match the existing

mortar, tooled to the original concave joint. On the 1920s homes near the center, where the brick is softer, we use a lime-rich mix so the mortar stays the part of the wall that gives. We do the crown in the same visit almost every time.

Cracked chimney top

Dumont's builders finished chimney tops with a thin mortar wash around the flue liner, and after 70 winters nearly all of them are cracked or gone. On a furnace chimney the problem compounds: the cracked top lets rain in from above while condensation attacks from inside, and the top four or five courses are the first thing to go.

The repair: we chip off the old wash, take down and rebuild the top courses if they've gone loose, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from the flue, overhanging the brick by two inches so water drips clear, with a bond break around the flue tile. A stainless cap goes on the flue; on a lined gas chimney the cap is matched to the liner and sealed to the crown so rain can't get between the liner and the masonry.

Chimney leaking when it rains

On a cape the chimney usually comes out at or near the ridge, which means the roof meets it on two slopes and the flashing has to turn the corner at the peak. That's a harder detail than a chimney on a plain slope, and most Dumont chimneys have had it redone during two or three roof jobs — usually by laying aluminum against the brick and tarring it. Tar pulls away within a few years, and the peak corner is where it opens first. A stain on the upstairs ceiling or in the attic right beside the chimney, during a rain, is that.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney on both slopes, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and weave step flashing into every shingle course up both sides, with a properly folded saddle at the ridge. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — not caulked to the brick — wedged, and sealed. Matching shingles are woven back in; this doesn't require a new roof, and if you do need a roof, the chimney gets flashed right as part of it.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When condensation and weather together have spalled whole faces, the top courses are loose, or a crack runs through several courses, repointing won't hold. The section above the roof comes down and goes back up. On a furnace chimney this is common, and it's the right time to install the liner, since the top of the stack is open anyway.

The repair: we scaffold with protective cribbing, dismantle the damaged section to the roofline or the first sound course, and rebuild plumb in matched modular red brick. The flue is lined or

the clay tiles are reset, the top gets a poured crown, and new flashing goes in on both slopes. On a cape this is typically a two-day job, and the inside of the house isn't touched.

White or yellow stains on the brick

Chalky white staining is efflorescence — salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Dumont furnace chimney, staining concentrated near the top, sometimes with a yellow or brown tint, is the condensation problem showing through the brick. Either way it's the chimney telling you it's wet inside, and the fix is at the top and in the joints — or in the liner.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Brick flakes in gutters, staining near the top, sour smell in basement	Gas-exhaust condensation attacking the masonry from inside	Repair the masonry, install a stainless liner, seal the crown
Sandy, recessed joints; brick dark after rain	Original mortar past its lifespan	Grind and repoint in matched Type N
Cracked or missing mortar at the top	Mortar wash instead of a crown	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown with a sealed cap
Upstairs ceiling stain beside the chimney during rain	Tarred flashing at the ridge corner	Step flashing both slopes, ridge saddle, reglet-cut counter-flashing
Spalling through faces, loose top courses, lean	Core failure above the roofline	Roofline rebuild, liner, crown, flashing
White or yellowish stains	Water or condensate moving through the masonry	Fix top and joints; line the flue

Common questions from Dumont homeowners

We switched to gas ten years ago and now the chimney is falling apart. Is that related?
Almost always, yes. Gas exhaust condenses in a cold masonry chimney and the acidic condensate breaks down the mortar and brick from inside. The repair is the masonry plus a stainless liner so it doesn't happen again.

Do I need a liner if the furnace is direct-vent now?
If nothing is venting into the chimney anymore, you don't need a liner, but the flue should be

capped and the top sealed so rain doesn't keep the stack wet. If a water heater still vents into it, it does need a properly sized liner.

Can you fix the flashing without replacing the roof?
Yes, as long as the surrounding shingles are still pliable. We lift the courses around the chimney on both slopes, do the work, and weave matching shingles back in.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic — and on a furnace chimney, from the basement connection — before quoting. That tells us whether water is entering at the flashing, coming down through the masonry, or condensing inside, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Dumont by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, directly next door to Dumont. Our own crews handle the masonry, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Bergenfield, Cresskill, Haworth, New Milford, Demarest, and across Bergen County.

One thing to confirm on your side: that you do install stainless liners. If you don't, I'll rewrite the gas-conversion section so the liner is something you coordinate rather than install. Next is Emerson.

Emerson — Pascack Valley splits, bi-levels, and ranches from the 1950s and 60s on the streets off Kinderkamack Road, plus some older homes near the center. Leads with the split-level chimney problem: one stack passing two roof levels, two flashing tie-ins.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/emerson-nj/`
Title tag (56 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Emerson NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (150 chars): Chimney repair in Emerson, NJ — split-level chimney flashing leaks, brick repointing, cracked crowns, and roofline rebuilds. Lita Construction, Bergenfield.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Leak Repair in Emerson, NJ

Emerson was built out in the 1950s and 60s like most of the Pascack Valley, and the house types are the ones that era produced: split-levels and bi-levels first, then ranches and colonials, on the side streets off Kinderkamack Road, Main Street, and Linwood Avenue, with a pocket of older homes near the center and the station. Nearly all of them have a brick chimney, and on the splits and bi-levels — the majority — that chimney is in an awkward spot.

A split-level chimney usually rises on the side wall of the lower living-room wing, passes the edge of the lower roof, continues up along the upper wall, and exits past the upper roof. That means one chimney and two separate places where a roof meets it, often on different sides, at different heights, with the brick fully exposed in between. Twice the flashing, twice the places to leak. Here's how that and the rest of Emerson's chimney problems show up, and how Lita Construction repairs them.

Chimney leaking when it rains on a split-level

On a split or bi-level, a stain on the ceiling near the chimney can be on either level, and which level tells us a lot. A stain in the upper bedroom ceiling is the upper roof tie-in; a stain in the living-room ceiling or down the living-room wall is the lower tie-in, where the lower roof dies into the chimney on one side and the upper wall on the other. That lower corner is the worst flashing detail on the house: three planes meet, and it was usually done with a piece of aluminum tarred to the brick during a roof job.

Tar pulls away from brick within a few years. Leaves pile into that corner, water backs up behind them, and it runs down behind the flashing into the living-room wall. On bi-levels the same corner is often where the garage roof meets the chimney.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney at both tie-ins, replace any rotted deck, and wrap each base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane. Step flashing is woven into every shingle course on the way back up. At the lower corner, where the roof meets both the chimney and the upper wall, we run the membrane up the wall, install a kickout at the bottom so water exits onto the roof instead of behind the siding, and tie the step flashing into the wall flashing. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint, not caulked onto the brick, at both tie-ins. Matching shingles are woven back in; a new roof isn't required, and if you need one anyway, both tie-ins get flashed right as part of it.

Chimney repointing in Emerson

A split-level chimney has more exposed brick than a cape's — a full wall of it between the two roofs, plus the stack above. More exposure means more freeze-thaw and more mortar to fail. Mortar lasts 25 to 40 years here, so a 1962 Emerson chimney that's never been pointed is well overdue, and the signs are the usual ones: recessed, sandy joints, mortar you can pick out with a key, brick that stays dark after rain.

The repair: we grind the joints out three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep across every exposed face — the stack above the upper roof, the wall section between the roofs, and the section at ground level if it's exposed — and repoint in a breathable Type N tinted to match, tooled to the original concave joint. Doing only the stack and leaving the wall section is a common shortcut and it's why so many Emerson repoints look fine at the top and are failing halfway down. On the older homes near the center, the brick is softer and we use a lime-rich mix.

Cracked chimney top

Emerson's builders finished the top with a mortar wash around the flue liner, and sixty winters later it's cracked on almost every house. Once it is, rain goes into the top course and down the core, and the tall exposed stack on a split gives it a long way to do damage. We see a lot of upper-course spalling in Emerson that started with the top.

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from the flue, overhanging the brick by two inches so water drips clear of the face, with a bond break around the flue tile. A stainless cap goes on the flue. We pair this with the repoint whenever the joints are also due, so the chimney is sealed top to bottom in one visit.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When the stack above the upper roof has spalled through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or it leans, repointing won't hold and the upper section comes down and goes back up. The wall section between the roofs and the part inside the house are usually sound and are left alone.

The repair: we scaffold with protective cribbing, dismantle the damaged section to the upper roofline or the first sound course, and rebuild plumb in matched modular red brick. Flue tiles are inspected and replaced if cracked, the top gets a poured crown, and new flashing goes in at the upper tie-in — and at the lower one if it's due.

Bi-level chimneys and thin brick

A number of Emerson's bi-levels have a chimney that's really a single wythe of face brick over a block core, built for looks more than mass. Those are thin, they heat and cool fast, and the joints

wash out sooner. The repair is the same — repoint, crown, flash — but we check the block core behind the brick when we open the top, because water that's gotten between the brick and the block has sometimes cracked the block.

White stains on the brick

The chalky white film is efflorescence — salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. It isn't damage, but it means the chimney is wet inside, and on an Emerson chimney that points to a cracked top, open joints, or the lower flashing corner feeding water into the brick. Fix the source and the staining stops.

Prefab fireplace chases

A few Emerson additions and newer homes vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood box with a metal cover on top. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace it with a pitched stainless cover and reframe the box if the wood under it is soft. It's a small share of our work here next to the masonry above.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Living-room ceiling or wall stain near the chimney during rain	Lower roof-to-chimney-to-wall corner tarred over	Membrane up the wall, step flashing, kickout, reglet-cut counter-flashing
Upper bedroom ceiling stain beside the chimney	Upper tie-in flashing failed	Step flashing, reglet-cut counter-flashing at the upper roof
Sandy, recessed joints — especially between the two roofs	Mortar past its lifespan	Grind and repoint every exposed face in matched Type N
Cracked top; spalling on the upper courses	Mortar wash instead of a crown	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown with a cap
Spalling through faces, crack through courses, lean	Upper stack past repointing	Rebuild from the upper roofline, crown, flashing
White chalky stains	Water moving through the masonry	Fix top, joints, and lower corner

Common questions from Emerson homeowners

The leak is in the living room, not upstairs. Is that still the chimney?
On a split-level, usually yes. The lower roof dies into the chimney and the upper wall in one corner, and that corner is the most common leak on the house. It's a flashing repair, not a roof replacement.

My chimney was repointed but it's still crumbling halfway down. Why?
Most likely only the stack above the upper roof was done, and the wall section between the roofs — which is just as exposed — was skipped. We point every exposed face.

Can the crown be done without rebuilding the chimney?
Yes, if the brick below it is sound. We check the top courses when we remove the old wash and rebuild only what's taken water.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. On a split that means checking both tie-ins, and the attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry. We put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Emerson by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about ten minutes from Emerson. Our own crews handle the masonry, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Oradell, Westwood, Washington Township, Paramus, River Edge, and across Bergen County.

Next is Englewood.

Englewood — the widest range of housing in this batch: East Hill estates in stone and brick, a large stock of late-1800s and early-1900s homes on the hill below Engle Street and across the 3rd and 4th Wards, and 1920s–50s houses on the west side. Leads with the oldest chimneys — corbeled Victorian tops and 100-year-old brick — then East Hill stone.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/englewood-nj/`
Title tag (58 chars): Chimney Rebuilding & Repointing Englewood NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (153 chars): Chimney repair in Englewood, NJ — rebuilding and repointing 100-year-old brick chimneys, East Hill stone chimneys, cracked crowns, and chimney flashing leaks.

Chimney Rebuilding, Repointing & Leak Repair in Englewood, NJ

Englewood has some of the oldest chimneys in Bergen County. The streets below Engle Street and across the 3rd and 4th Wards are full of late-Victorian and early-1900s houses — tall, narrow homes with equally tall chimneys, often two or three to a house, in soft red brick with corbeled tops that step outward in the last few courses. On East Hill, the larger pre-war estates and the newer homes that replaced some of them carry wide stone and oversized brick chimneys, many with multiple flues. The west side, toward Teaneck and Bergenfield, is 1920s through 1950s brick colonials and capes.

A 110-year-old chimney has usually been repaired two or three times already, and the quality of those repairs matters more than the original construction. Here's what we see across Englewood and how Lita Construction handles it.

Rebuilding corbeled tops on Victorian-era chimneys

The decorative top on a turn-of-the-century chimney — the courses that step out and back in just below the cap — is also its weakest point. Each corbeled course has a ledge that catches water, and after a century of freeze-thaw those courses are the first to loosen. You'll see a brick missing from the top band, the upper courses leaning away from the rest of the stack, or chunks of brick on the roof below. On some houses a previous mason "fixed" it by taking the corbel off and finishing the chimney flat, which stops the leak and ruins the look of the house.

The repair: we scaffold the roof with protective cribbing, take the top down to sound brick — often eight to twelve courses on these stacks — and rebuild the corbel to the original profile in reclaimed or color-matched soft brick, laid in a lime-rich mortar so it flexes the way the rest of the chimney does. The top is finished with a poured, reinforced concrete crown that overhangs the brick by two inches, and each flue gets a cap. The rebuilt top matches the photographs of what was there, which is what a buyer or a historic district expects to see.

Repointing 100-year-old brick

The brick on Englewood's pre-war houses is soft, and the mortar it was laid in was lime-based and softer still — by design. The mortar was meant to be the part of the wall that wears and gets renewed. When a past repair used a modern Portland cement mortar instead, the mortar became harder than the brick, and the brick started taking the freeze-thaw damage: faces popping off, red flakes in the gutters, with the joints looking perfectly fine. That's the most common thing we find on an older Englewood chimney, and it's a repair problem, not an age problem.

Where the original lime mortar is still in place, it's simply worn — recessed, sandy, washed out at the weather side.

The repair: we grind out the worn or hard mortar three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep, carefully on soft brick so the edges aren't nicked, replace any spalled brick with reclaimed or matched soft brick, and repoint in a lime-rich Type N or Type O mortar matched to the original color and sand. The joints are tooled to the original profile — struck, grapevine, or weathered joints are all common on these houses. Hard mortar on a pre-war chimney is the one shortcut we won't take.

Stone chimneys on East Hill

The estates along the top of the Palisades and the larger homes between Engle Street and the cliffs have fieldstone, cut-stone, and stone-veneer chimneys, many wide enough to carry three or four flues. Stone fails at the joints: the irregular face holds water on every ledge, the mature tree cover keeps it there, and winter works the mortar loose. Mortar crumbs at the base and a stone that moves when pushed are the signs. On veneer chimneys, white staining bleeding through the face usually means water trapped behind the stone with no drainage.

The repair: we rake the joints out by hand to avoid scarring the stone, reset any loose stones in fresh mortar, and repoint in a matched Type N finished to the original joint profile. On veneer with drainage problems we open the face, install the drainage layer and weep screed, and re-set the stone. Flashing on stone is cut into the stone itself rather than caulked on.

Cracked chimney top on multi-flue chimneys

Englewood's bigger chimneys — pre-war and newer alike — have wide tops, and most were finished with a mortar wash that cracked long ago. On a three-flue chimney the top is a slab several feet on a side, and once it's open, rain goes into the core and feeds everything below. A cracked top is the root cause behind most of the spalling and loose brick we repair in town.

The repair: we remove the failed wash, rebuild any top courses that have taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from every flue, overhanging the masonry by two inches on all sides so water drips clear, with a bond break around each flue tile so the tiles can expand without cracking it. Each flue gets a stainless cap, or copper on homes with copper gutters and flashing.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or down a wall beside the chimney, appearing during the rain, is a flashing leak. On Englewood's older homes the flashing was originally lead or copper and has mostly been replaced during roof jobs with aluminum tarred to the brick — which fails within a few years. On the slate roofs on the hill, the flashing was often worked around rather than properly reset. On the west-side capes and colonials, it's the usual tarred-over step flashing from a past roof replacement.

The repair: on slate we remove and reset the slates around the chimney; on shingle we strip the surrounding courses. Any rotted deck is replaced, the base is wrapped in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and step flashing goes in every course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — gently on soft brick — or cut into the stone face, wedged, and sealed. We use 20-ounce copper on the older and higher-end homes and heavy aluminum where the house has it. Chimneys over 30 inches wide get a cricket behind them.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up — on the pre-war houses, in reclaimed or matched soft brick and lime mortar; on East Hill stone, in salvaged original stone; on the postwar west side, in matched modular red. Flue tiles are inspected and reset, the top gets a poured crown, and new flashing goes in at the roof. The section inside the house is left alone.

White stains on brick or stone

The chalky white film is efflorescence — salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. It isn't damage, but it means the chimney is wet inside, and on an Englewood chimney that points to a cracked top, open joints, or veneer without drainage.

Prefab fireplace chases

Some newer Englewood homes and additions vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood box with a metal cover on top. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace it with a pitched stainless cover and reframe the box if needed. It's a small share of our work in town next to the masonry above.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Brick missing from the stepped top; upper courses leaning	Corbeled courses loosened by freeze-thaw	Rebuild the corbel to original profile in soft brick, crown, cap
Brick faces popping off; joints look fine	Hard-mortar repoint on soft pre-war brick	Replace spalled brick, repoint in lime-rich mortar
Sandy, washed-out joints	Original lime mortar worn	Grind and repoint in matched lime-rich mortar
Mortar crumbs at the base of a stone chimney; loose stone	Washed-out joints behind the stone	Hand-rake, reset stones, repoint
Cracked top on a wide multi-flue chimney	Mortar wash cracked	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown with capped flues
Ceiling or wall stain beside the chimney during rain	Tarred flashing; no cricket	Reset slate or strip shingles, copper step and counter-flashing, cricket
Spalling through faces, crack through courses, lean	Core failure above the roofline	Roofline rebuild in matched brick or salvaged stone

Common questions from Englewood homeowners

Can you rebuild the decorative top the way it was?
Yes. We photograph and measure the existing corbel before taking it down, and rebuild it course for course in matched brick. If the top was already removed by a past repair, we can rebuild it from photographs or from a matching chimney on the house.

My chimney was repointed 20 years ago and now the bricks are breaking. Why?
Almost certainly a hard mortar on soft brick. The mortar is now stronger than the brick, so the brick takes the freeze-thaw damage. The fix is to replace the damaged brick and repoint in a lime-rich mortar.

Can you work on a slate roof?
Yes. Slates around the chimney are removed and reset, not cut, and the roof is cribbed before any masonry work.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or running down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Englewood by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about ten minutes from any part of Englewood. Our own crews handle the masonry, the copper work, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Englewood Cliffs, Tenafly, Teaneck, Bergenfield, Leonia, and across Bergen County.

Next is Englewood Cliffs.

Englewood Cliffs — a cliff-top town with two housing eras: 1950s–60s splits and ranches from the original development, and the large contemporary homes that have replaced many of them since the 1990s, often in stucco and stone veneer with low-slope roofs. Leads with wind exposure and the stucco/veneer chimney, which no other page has covered.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/englewood-cliffs-nj/`
Title tag (60 chars): Chimney Repair & Leak Repair Englewood Cliffs NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (154 chars): Chimney repair in Englewood Cliffs, NJ — wind-driven chimney leaks, stucco and stone veneer chimneys, brick repointing, cracked crowns, and roofline rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Leak Repair & Repointing in Englewood Cliffs, NJ

Englewood Cliffs sits on top of the Palisades with nothing between it and the Hudson, and its chimneys get weather that the towns a mile inland don't. Wind coming off the river drives rain sideways into masonry that would shed it in a calm storm, and a chimney facing east on a cliff-top lot gets more of that than any other surface on the house.

The housing comes in two groups. The original borough — the streets off Sylvan Avenue and Palisade Avenue, the loops below Route 9W — was built as splits, ranches, and colonials in the

1950s and 60s with standard brick chimneys. Since the 1990s, a large share of those lots have been rebuilt with much bigger homes, many in stucco or stone veneer with low-slope or flat-roof sections, and the chimneys on those are a different kind of problem. Here's how both show up and how Lita Construction repairs them.

Chimney leaking only in wind-driven rain

This is the Englewood Cliffs call: the chimney is fine in a normal storm, then a nor'easter or a hard east wind pushes rain through it and a stain appears on a ceiling or wall near the chimney. By the time it dries out, it looks like nothing happened — until the next one.

Wind-driven rain finds entry points that gravity rain doesn't. On a brick chimney it's open joints on the windward face and flashing that's sealed well enough for water running down but not for water pushed up and sideways under the counter-flashing. On a stucco or veneer chimney it's the joint where the chimney meets the roof, and the top, where the cap and crown were often detailed for appearance rather than weather.

The repair: we treat the windward face as the priority. Open joints are ground out and repointed; the flashing at the roof is rebuilt with step flashing in every course and counter-flashing set into a reglet cut into the mortar joint or the stone face — not surface-caulked — with the upper edge sealed so pushed water can't get behind it. The top gets a crown with a real overhang and a cap on every flue, which is where most wind-driven leaks on the newer homes start. On wide chimneys, a cricket behind the stack keeps water from damming on the uphill side.

Stucco and stone veneer chimneys on newer homes

The contemporary homes in Englewood Cliffs often carry a chimney that's a wood-framed or block structure finished in stucco or thin stone veneer to match the house. Those finishes are only as good as what's behind them. When the veneer or stucco went on without a proper drainage plane, weep screed, and through-wall flashing at the base and at the top, water that gets past the surface sits against the core. In stucco it shows as cracks radiating from the corners and dark staining below the cap; in veneer it shows as white efflorescence through the face and stones coming loose. On a wood-cored chimney the framing inside can be rotting with the outside looking nearly fine.

The top of these chimneys is usually the weak point. Builders often finished them with a flat or barely sloped cap, sometimes stucco over a wood top, which holds water and cracks within a few seasons.

The repair: we open the top and inspect the core first, because the scope depends on what's under the finish. On a sound core, the fix is a proper cap — a poured, overhanging concrete crown on block, or a custom cross-broken stainless or copper cover on a framed core — plus through-wall flashing at the base. On stucco, we cut back the failed areas, install a drainage

layer and weep screed, and re-stucco to match. On veneer, we open the affected face, install the drainage plane, and re-set the stone. Where the framing has rotted, we reframe the box before any of that goes back on.

Chimney flashing at low-slope and flat roofs

A lot of the newer Englewood Cliffs homes have flat or low-slope roof sections — a garage, a rear wing, a roof deck — that run into the side of a chimney. Those tie-ins are membrane roofs, not shingles, and the chimney has to be flashed into the membrane with a base flashing that runs up the chimney wall and a counter-flashing over it. We see a lot of them finished with the membrane simply turned up the wall and sealed with mastic, which fails at the top edge as soon as the mastic ages.

The repair: we run a new base flashing up the chimney wall a minimum of eight inches, bonded to the roof membrane, and cap it with metal counter-flashing set into a reglet in the masonry or the stucco — so the top edge is mechanically sealed, not just glued. Where the chimney wall is stucco or veneer, the reglet is cut into the core behind it.

Chimney repointing on the 1950s and 60s homes

The original brick chimneys in the borough are at the age where the mortar is done: recessed, sandy joints, mortar you can pick out with a key, brick dark after rain. With the wind exposure here, the east and south faces are usually noticeably worse than the others.

The repair: we grind the joints out three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep across the full exposed section — every face, since the leeward joints are only a few winters behind — and repoint in a breathable Type N tinted to match, tooled to the original concave joint. We do the crown in the same visit; a fresh repoint under a cracked top keeps taking water from above.

Cracked chimney top

The postwar chimneys were finished with a thin mortar wash around the flue liner that cracks within a few winters, and the newer homes often have flat caps that hold water. Either way, once the top is open, rain goes into the core.

The repair: we remove the failed wash or cap, rebuild any top courses that have taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from every flue, overhanging the masonry by two inches so water drips clear, with a bond break around each flue tile. Each flue gets a stainless cap, or copper where the house has copper work.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When a brick chimney has spalled through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans — common on the older homes' windward faces — the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in matched brick, with the flue tiles reset, a poured crown, and new flashing. The section inside the house is left alone.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Leak only during wind-driven rain	Open windward joints; counter-flashing not sealed against pushed water	Repoint windward face, reglet-cut counter-flashing, crown with overhang and caps
Cracks in stucco at the chimney corners; staining below the cap	No drainage behind stucco; flat cap holding water	Open the top, cap or crown properly, drainage layer, re-stucco
Veneer stones loose; white staining through the face	No drainage plane behind the veneer	Open the face, install drainage, re-set stone
Leak where a flat roof meets the chimney	Membrane turned up and sealed with mastic	Base flashing up the wall, metal counter-flashing in a reglet
Sandy, recessed joints, worse on the east side	Mortar past its lifespan; wind exposure	Grind and repoint in matched Type N, every face
Spalling through faces, crack through courses, lean	Core failure above the roofline	Roofline rebuild in matched brick, crown, flashing

Common questions from Englewood Cliffs homeowners

It only leaks in bad storms. Does it still need to be fixed?
Yes. Wind-driven water that gets into the masonry a few times a year is enough to freeze inside it over the winter and break down the joints from inside. The leak you see is a fraction of the water getting in.

My chimney is stucco over wood. Can it be repaired, or does it need to be rebuilt?
It depends on the core. We open the top and check the framing before quoting. If the wood is sound, the repair is the cap, the drainage, and the stucco. If it's rotted, we reframe first.

Do you work with the roofer, or are you the roofer?
We're both. Our own crews do the masonry, the flashing, and the roof — shingle, membrane, or metal — so the chimney and the roof tie-in are one job.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from inside before quoting. That shows whether water is entering at the flashing, through the top, or through the face, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Englewood Cliffs by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about fifteen minutes from Englewood Cliffs. Our own crews handle the masonry, the stucco and stone work, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between trades. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Englewood, Fort Lee, Tenafly, Alpine, Leonia, and across Bergen County.

Fair Lawn is already done, so next is Fort Lee.

You're right — the earlier Fair Lawn draft still had the pricing placeholders and the bracketed note. Here it is in the final format, rewritten rather than trimmed.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/fair-lawn-nj/`
Title tag (57 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Fair Lawn NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (153 chars): Chimney repair in Fair Lawn, NJ — cracked crowns, brick repointing, chimney flashing leaks, and roofline rebuilds on postwar capes, colonials, and Radburn homes.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Fair Lawn, NJ

Fair Lawn's chimneys come from two building periods. The older one is Radburn, the planned community laid out in 1929, and the pre-war colonials near River Road and along Broadway. The larger one is everything built after the war — the capes, split-levels, and colonials that filled in the rest of the borough from the late 1940s through the 1960s, block after block off Fair Lawn Avenue, Saddle River Road, and Morlot Avenue. Both periods built in solid brick. The postwar

chimneys are now 60 to 75 years old, which is the age when the original mortar and the mortar on top of the chimney give out at the same time, and that pairing accounts for most of what we're called about in Fair Lawn.

Here's what we see on Fair Lawn chimneys, how to recognize it from the yard, and how Lita Construction repairs it.

Cracked chimney top

Look up at the top of your chimney. On nearly every postwar Fair Lawn house you'll see a thin slope of mortar around the clay flue liner — a mortar wash. It was the builder's way of finishing the top in ten minutes, and it was never a waterproofing detail. After sixty winters it's cracked, chipped, or gone, and every rain goes into the top course of brick and straight down the center of the stack.

In Fair Lawn the cracked top is almost always the first thing to fail and the cause of everything after it. The crumbling mortar, the brick flakes in the gutter, the stain on the ceiling that got blamed on the roof — trace them back and they usually start with water coming in from the top years earlier.

The repair: we remove the old wash, take down and rebuild the top courses if water has gotten into them, and form and pour a real concrete crown. It slopes away from the flue, overhangs the brick on all sides by two inches so water drips clear of the face instead of running down it, is reinforced so it won't crack across the middle, and is separated from the flue tile with a bond break so the tile can expand without breaking the crown. A stainless cap goes on the flue. On a chimney that's otherwise sound, this is the one repair that stops the water feeding everything else, and it's where we'd start on most Fair Lawn homes.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When the top has been gone for a decade or more, the damage moves down the stack: brick faces popped off, red flakes in the gutters, a vertical crack running through several courses, a chimney that has started to lean. At that point repointing won't hold, because the brick around the joints is failing too.

What's usually true on these chimneys is that only the section above the roof is bad. The part inside the attic and the house has been dry the whole time, so the rebuild is from the roofline up.

The repair: we scaffold the roof with protective cribbing, take the chimney down course by course to the roofline or the first solid course below the damage, and rebuild it plumb. Postwar Fair Lawn brick is a fairly standard modular red, so matching is easier than on a pre-war house, but we still match color and size so the rebuild doesn't read as a patch from the street. Clay flue tiles are inspected and any cracked ones replaced, the top is finished with a poured crown, and new flashing goes in where the chimney meets the roof.

On Radburn and the other pre-war homes the brick is softer and a different color, so we source reclaimed or color-matched brick and rebuild in a lime-rich mortar. A rebuild in modern hard brick and Portland mortar on a 1930s chimney will spall the original brick below it within a few years.

Chimney leaking when it rains

If water shows up on the ceiling or attic rafters right beside the chimney, during the rain rather than after it, the leak is at the flashing — the metal where the shingles meet the chimney — not through the masonry.

Fair Lawn's postwar chimneys were usually flashed in aluminum, and most of that has been replaced at least once during a roof job. The problem is how: a single piece of metal laid flat against the brick and sealed with roofing tar. Tar hardens in the sun, pulls away from the brick, and leaves a gap that every rain runs behind. On the capes the chimney is often on the rear slope with nothing to divert water around it, so leaves and water pile against the back wall and work under the shingles.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney base, replace any rotted deck, and wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane. Step flashing is woven into every shingle course. The counter-flashing is set into a groove we grind into the mortar joint — not caulked to the face of the brick — wedged, and sealed. Chimneys over 30 inches wide get a cricket framed behind them to split water around both sides. Matching shingles are woven back in, so this doesn't require a new roof.

Chimney repointing in Fair Lawn

Repointing is the repair for mortar that's reached the end of its life — recessed joints, sandy gaps, mortar you can scrape out with a key. On a 1950s chimney the original mortar is past due; it typically lasts 25 to 40 years here. On the pre-war homes it's often been repointed once already, and if that was done in a hard modern mortar, the brick is now cracking around it.

The repair: we grind the joints out three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep across the entire exposed section above the roof, clean them, and repoint in a breathable Type N mortar tinted to match the existing. On Radburn-era brick we use a softer mix. The joints are tooled to match the original — usually a concave joint on postwar homes. We do every joint on the exposed section, not only the ones that look bad, because the rest are one winter behind.

White stains on the chimney

The chalky white film that shows up on brick is efflorescence: salts carried to the surface by water moving through the masonry. It's not damage by itself, but it tells you the chimney is wet

inside, and on a Fair Lawn chimney that almost always traces back to a cracked top, open mortar joints, or both. Fixing those stops the staining; cleaning it alone doesn't.

Sided chimney boxes on additions

Some Fair Lawn additions and the handful of 1970s-and-later homes vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood box with a metal cover on top. Those leak at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace it with a pitched stainless cover and reframe the box if the wood under it is soft. But solid brick chimneys are nearly all of what we work on here.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Cracked or missing mortar at the top around the flue	Mortar wash instead of a crown	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown and stainless cap
Brick faces popped off, red flakes in gutters	Water from a failed top; freeze-thaw	Rebuild damaged courses; new crown
Cracks through several courses, chimney leaning	Core failure above the roofline	Roofline rebuild in matched brick, crown, flashing
Ceiling stain beside the chimney during rain	Tarred flashing; no cricket	New step flashing, reglet-cut counter-flashing, cricket
Sandy, recessed joints	Mortar past its lifespan	Grind and repoint in matched Type N
White chalky stains	Water moving through the masonry	Fix top and joints

Common questions from Fair Lawn homeowners

Can the top be replaced without rebuilding the chimney?
Yes, if the brick below it is still sound. We check the top few courses when we remove the old wash. If water has gotten into them, we rebuild those courses before pouring, which is still far less than a full rebuild.

Can you repair the chimney without replacing the roof?
Yes, as long as the surrounding shingles are still pliable. We lift the courses around the base, do the work, and weave matching shingles back in.

Why is my 10-year-old repoint already failing?
Either the joints were skimmed over rather than ground out and refilled, or the chimney still has a cracked top feeding water in and the new mortar never stood a chance. We can tell which from the roof.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Fair Lawn by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about fifteen minutes from Fair Lawn. Our own crews handle the masonry, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Glen Rock, Paramus, Saddle Brook, Rochelle Park, Hawthorne, and across Bergen County.

Same applies to the earlier Ridgewood, Paramus, Franklin Lakes, and Teaneck drafts — they're all pre-final-format. I'll redo each when we reach it in the list. Next is Fort Lee.

Fort Lee — tight lots, a lot of two-family and semi-detached brick houses, 1920s–40s colonials and Tudors in the Palisade section and Coytesville, 1950s–60s capes and splits further west, and newer large homes on rebuilt lots. Leads with the narrow-lot problem and shared-wall chimneys, which no other page has.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/fort-lee-nj/`
Title tag (56 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Fort Lee NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (153 chars): Chimney repair in Fort Lee, NJ — brick repointing and rebuilds on tight lots and two-family homes, chimney flashing leaks, cracked crowns. Lita Construction.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Fort Lee, NJ

Fort Lee's single-family and two-family houses are packed onto some of the smallest lots in Bergen County, and that changes how chimney work gets done. The Palisade section and Coytesville are 1920s–40s brick colonials, Tudors, and two-families with chimneys on the side wall, often six or eight feet from the neighbor's wall. The streets west of the bridge approach toward Leonia and Englewood are 1950s–60s capes and splits on slightly bigger lots. Scattered through both are rebuilt lots with large newer homes carrying wide veneer or brick chimneys. And the whole borough sits high on the Palisades, so wind off the river drives rain into east-facing masonry harder than it does inland.

Here's what we see on Fort Lee chimneys and how Lita Construction handles the access, the masonry, and the roof tie-in.

Chimney repair on a narrow lot

Most of Fort Lee's older chimneys are on the side of the house, and the side yard is often too narrow to set up conventional scaffolding without putting it on the neighbor's property. Some masons won't take these jobs; others do the work off a ladder, which is how corners get cut — the back face doesn't get pointed, the flashing on the far side gets caulked instead of stepped, the crown gets a quick wash instead of a pour.

How we handle it: we scaffold from the roof rather than the ground wherever the lot is tight, with roof-protective cribbing, which lets us reach every face of the stack without touching the neighbor's yard. On two-family houses where the chimney serves both units, we coordinate the day so both tenants know when the flue is going to be opened. The point is that the chimney gets the full repair — all four faces, both flashing sides, a real crown — on a lot where that's hard to do.

Repointing brick on 1920s–40s two-families and colonials

The brick on Fort Lee's pre-war homes is softer than modern brick, laid in a lime-based mortar that was meant to be the sacrificial part of the wall. A hundred years later the original mortar is worn — recessed, sandy, washed out on the windward face — and on a lot of these houses a past repair used a hard Portland mortar instead, which outlasts the brick and lets the brick crack around it. Brick faces popping off with the joints looking fine is that second problem, and it's common in the Palisade section.

The repair: we grind out the worn or hard mortar three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep, carefully so soft brick edges aren't nicked, replace spalled brick with reclaimed or matched soft

brick, and repoint in a lime-rich Type N or Type O matched to the original color and sand, tooled to the original joint. On the east-facing side, where wind-driven rain has done the most damage, we expect to find joints washed out deeper than the rest and point them accordingly.

On the postwar capes and splits west of the bridge, the brick is a standard modular red and takes a normal Type N repoint — ground out, repointed, tooled to the concave joint.

Cracked chimney top

Both eras finished the top with a thin mortar wash around the flue liners, and on a two-family with two or three flues the top is wide enough that the wash cracked within a few winters. Once it's open, rain and wind-driven water go into the top courses and down the core. In Fort Lee, a cracked top plus the exposure is the usual reason the upper courses are the first to fail.

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild any top courses that have taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from every flue, overhanging the brick by two inches so water drips clear of the face, with a bond break around each flue tile. Each flue gets a stainless cap. On a two-family, we confirm which flue serves which unit's appliance before anything is capped or sealed.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or down a wall beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. On Fort Lee's side-wall chimneys, the roof meets the stack on two sides with the brick running down the wall between, and the flashing was usually redone during a roof job by laying aluminum against the brick and tarring it. With the wind here, that fails faster than it does inland: pushed rain gets under the top edge of the counter-flashing on the exposed side, and tar that's pulled away from the brick doesn't stop it. On the newer homes, flat and low-slope roof sections that run into the chimney were often finished by turning the membrane up the wall and sealing it with mastic.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney on both sides, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and weave step flashing into every course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — gently on soft brick — wedged, and sealed at the top edge so pushed water can't get behind it. On membrane roofs we run a base flashing a minimum of eight inches up the chimney wall, bond it to the roof, and cap it with metal counter-flashing in a reglet. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket behind them.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans — on the pre-war homes, often the windward face first — the section above the roof

comes down and goes back up. On a two-family with a shared chimney, this is scheduled so the flues are out of service for the shortest possible time.

The repair: we scaffold from the roof, take the stack down to sound masonry, and rebuild plumb in reclaimed or matched soft brick and lime-rich mortar on the pre-war houses, or matched modular red on the postwar ones. Flue tiles are inspected and reset or replaced, the top gets a poured crown, and new flashing goes in on both sides.

Stone veneer chimneys on rebuilt lots

The large newer homes on Fort Lee's rebuilt lots often have wide stone-veneer or oversized-brick chimneys with flat or lightly sloped caps. Veneer installed without a drainage plane traps water against the core, which shows as white staining through the face and stones coming loose; flat caps hold water and crack. We open the top and check the core before quoting, then cap or crown it properly, install the drainage layer, and re-set the stone.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence on the chimney face is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. It's not damage, but it means the chimney is wet inside — on a Fort Lee chimney, usually the windward joints, the top, or veneer without drainage.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Brick faces popping off; joints look fine (pre-war)	Hard-mortar repoint on soft brick	Replace spalled brick, repoint in lime-rich mortar
Joints washed out deeper on the east face	Wind-driven rain	Grind and repoint every face, deeper on the windward side
Cracked top on a two- or three-flue chimney	Mortar wash cracked	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown, capped flues
Ceiling or wall stain beside a side-wall chimney during rain	Tarred flashing on both sides; wind getting under it	Step flashing both sides, reglet-cut counter-flashing sealed at the top edge
Leak where a flat roof meets the chimney	Membrane turned up and sealed with mastic	Base flashing up the wall, metal counter-flashing in a reglet
Spalling through faces, crack through courses, lean	Core failure above the roofline	Roofline rebuild, crown, flashing

Veneer stones loose; white staining (newer home)	No drainage plane behind the veneer	Open the face, install drainage, re-set stone; cap properly

Common questions from Fort Lee homeowners

My side yard is four feet wide. Can you even get to the chimney?
Yes. We scaffold from the roof with protective cribbing rather than from the ground, which reaches every face without going onto the neighbor's property.

It's a two-family and the chimney serves both units. How does that work?
We identify which flue serves which appliance before starting, schedule the work so the flues are out of service for the shortest time, and let both units know the day. The repair itself is the same.

My chimney was repointed 15 years ago and now the bricks are breaking. Why?
Almost certainly a hard mortar on soft pre-war brick. The mortar is now stronger than the brick, so the brick takes the freeze-thaw damage. The fix is to replace the damaged brick and repoint in a lime-rich mortar.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Fort Lee by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about fifteen minutes from Fort Lee. Our own crews handle the masonry, the flashing, and the roof tie-in — shingle or membrane — so the job isn't split between a mason and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Englewood Cliffs, Leonia, Englewood, Teaneck, Hasbrouck Heights, and across Bergen County.

Next is Franklin Lakes — redone in the final format.

Franklin Lakes — final format. Reworked so it doesn't overlap Alpine (cut stone, slate roofs) or Wyckoff (flashing into fieldstone): this one leads with tall chimneys on big 1970s–2000s colonials and cultured-stone veneer.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/franklin-lakes-nj/`
Title tag (60 chars): Stone & Brick Chimney Repair Franklin Lakes NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (152 chars): Chimney repair in Franklin Lakes, NJ — tall multi-flue chimneys, stone and cultured-stone veneer repair, repointing, cracked crowns, and roofline rebuilds.

Stone & Brick Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Franklin Lakes, NJ

Franklin Lakes was built big. Most of the borough — the custom colonials off High Mountain Road and Franklin Avenue, the Urban Farms section, the wooded lots around Franklin Lake and along Ewing Avenue — went up from the late 1960s through the 2000s on large parcels under heavy tree cover, and the chimneys were built to match the houses: wide, carrying two or three flues, and tall. With 9- and 10-foot ceilings and steep roofs, a Franklin Lakes chimney often stands six to ten feet above the roofline, in fieldstone, oversized brick, or — on a lot of the 1990s and 2000s homes — cultured stone veneer over a block or wood core.

Height and width are what set these chimneys apart. A stack that tall catches wind-driven rain from every direction, has more mortar exposed than three ordinary chimneys, and carries a top the size of a card table. Here's what goes wrong and how Lita Construction repairs it.

Tall chimneys: lean, cracks, and the top courses

On a chimney standing eight feet above the roof, the top courses take the worst of the weather and have the least holding them in place. We see three things on Franklin Lakes' taller stacks: a crack running down from the top through several courses, the top two or three feet leaning slightly off plumb, and a visible gap between the chimney and the house wall where the stack has pulled away. All three usually trace to the same cause — a cracked top letting water into the core for years, freezing and expanding course by course.

The repair: we scaffold the roof with protective cribbing — on a tall chimney that scaffold goes well above the ridge — and take the stack down to the first sound course, which on these is often three to five feet of masonry. We rebuild plumb in matched brick or salvaged stone, reset the flue tiles, and tie the upper stack to the house wall where it was originally anchored. The top gets a poured, reinforced concrete crown overhanging by two inches, and the flues are capped.

On a chimney where the lean or crack is confined to the top two feet, the rebuild is just those courses plus the crown.

Cultured stone veneer chimneys

A large share of the homes built in Franklin Lakes since the 1990s have chimneys faced in manufactured stone — thin cast units adhered over a scratch coat on block or on a wood-framed chase. The stone looks like fieldstone from the street and lasts fine; what fails is the water management behind it. Installed without a drainage plane, weep screed, and through-wall flashing at the base and top, the veneer traps any water that gets past it against the core, where it freezes and pushes the units off from behind.

From the yard: white efflorescence bleeding through the face, individual stones popped loose or lying on the ground, and on wood-cored chimneys, soft siding or staining where the chimney meets the house. The chimney may be only 20 years old and look mostly fine from a distance.

The repair: re-adhering loose stones without fixing the drainage sends the failure to the next stone. We open the affected face, install the drainage layer and weep screed that should have been there, and re-set the stone in polymer-modified mortar, matching the pattern so the repair doesn't show. The top is almost always part of the problem — most veneer chimneys were finished with a thin wash or a flat cap — so we rebuild the top courses and pour a proper crown, which is what stops water getting behind the veneer in the first place. On wood-cored chimneys we check the framing before anything goes back on, and reframe if it's gone soft.

Stone chimney repointing

The fieldstone and split-face chimneys on the older Franklin Lakes homes fail at the joints. Stone is irregular, the joints vary from a quarter inch to two inches wide, and every ledge on the face holds water. Under the oak and hemlock cover here, a chimney that got wet in a morning storm is still damp at dark and freezes that night. You'll see mortar crumbs at the base, recessed joints you can fit a finger into, and eventually a stone that moves when pushed.

The repair: we rake the joints out at least three-quarters of an inch, deeper on the wide ones, working by hand with chisels and a narrow grinder so the stone edges aren't scarred. Loose stones come out, get cleaned, and go back in fresh mortar. The repointing mortar is a breathable Type N matched to the existing color and sand, finished to the original joint profile — raked or flush on most of these chimneys. Brick chimneys get the same treatment in a brick context: joints ground out three-quarters of an inch to an inch across the full exposed section, repointed in matched Type N, tooled to the original joint.

Cracked chimney top on a multi-flue chimney

With two or three flues, the top of a Franklin Lakes chimney is a wide slab, and nearly all of them were finished with a mortar wash troweled around the flue tiles. A mortar wash on a surface that size cracks within a few seasons. Once it does, rain goes into the top courses and down the core, which is what feeds the leaning tops, loose stones, and spalling brick lower down.

The repair: we remove the failed wash, rebuild any top courses that have taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from every flue, overhanging the masonry by two inches on all sides so water drips clear of the face, with wire or fiber reinforcement so it won't crack across its width, and a bond break around each flue tile. Each flue gets a stainless cap. On a chimney this tall, the top is both the most important waterproofing and the hardest to inspect from the ground, which is why so many go unnoticed until something lower has failed.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or down a wall beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. Franklin Lakes chimneys are almost all over 30 inches wide, almost all on steep roofs, and most of them from the 1970s and 80s were built without a cricket behind them — so water and leaves dam against the uphill wall. The flashing was usually surface-applied and caulked, because on stone there's no straight joint to cut into.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, and frame a cricket behind the stack in 2x4s and plywood. The cricket and the full perimeter get high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, step flashing goes into every shingle course, and a metal valley pan over the cricket splits water around both sides. Counter-flashing is set into the chimney, not onto it: a reglet ground into the mortar joint on brick, a stepped channel saw-cut into the stone face on fieldstone, a channel cut into the core behind veneer. Copper on the higher-end homes; heavy aluminum elsewhere.

White stains on stone or brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Franklin Lakes chimney it means a cracked top, open joints, or veneer without drainage. Fix the source and the staining stops.

Prefab fireplaces and secondary chases

Some Franklin Lakes homes vent a second fireplace — a bedroom, a pool house — through a sided or veneered chase with a metal cover on top. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace it with a pitched stainless or copper cover and reframe the box if needed. It's a small share of our work here next to the masonry above.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Crack down from the top; top courses leaning; gap from the house wall	Water in the core of a tall stack	Rebuild from the first sound course, re-anchor, crown, cap
Veneer stones loose or on the ground; white staining through the face	No drainage behind cultured stone	Open the face, install drainage, re-set stone; proper crown
Mortar crumbs at the base; a stone that moves	Washed-out joints behind fieldstone	Hand-rake, reset stones, repoint in matched mortar
Cracked top around two or three flues	Mortar wash on a wide top	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown, capped flues
Ceiling stain beside the chimney during rain	No cricket; surface-caulked flashing	Frame a cricket, step flashing, counter-flashing cut into brick, stone, or core
Spalling brick through whole faces	Core failure	Roofline rebuild in matched brick

Common questions from Franklin Lakes homeowners

My chimney is only 20 years old. Why is stone falling off it?
Cultured stone installed without a drainage plane traps water behind it from the first winter. Twenty years of that is enough to push units off. The fix is the drainage, not just re-gluing the stones.

How much of a leaning chimney has to come down?
To the first course that's solid and plumb. On a tall Franklin Lakes stack that's often three to five feet, sometimes only the top two. We can tell from the roof, and the inside of the house isn't touched.

Will new mortar match the old on a stone chimney?
We match color and sand against a sample of the existing mortar and tool the joints to the original profile. New mortar reads slightly lighter for a season and weathers in.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water

is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Franklin Lakes by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 25 minutes from Franklin Lakes. Our own crews handle the masonry, the stone work, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Wyckoff, Oakland, Mahwah, Ridgewood, Allendale, and across Bergen County.

Next is Glen Rock.

Glen Rock — 1920s–30s homes near the two stations and Rock Road, and a large stock of 1940s–50s brick colonials and capes everywhere else. Leads with something no other page has: spalling caused by non-breathable sealers and paint on brick chimneys, which is common on Glen Rock's well-kept older houses.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/glen-rock-nj/`
Title tag (57 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Glen Rock NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (154 chars): Chimney repair in Glen Rock, NJ — spalling brick, sealed and painted chimneys, repointing, cracked crowns, flashing leaks, and roofline rebuilds. Lita Construction.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Glen Rock, NJ

Glen Rock is a well-maintained town, and that's part of the problem with its chimneys. The borough is mostly 1940s and 50s brick colonials and capes, with a pre-war layer of 1920s and 30s homes around the two train stations and along Rock Road and Harristown Road, and the

houses have been cared for continuously — repainted, re-roofed, and in many cases, sealed. A chimney that's been coated with a clear sealer or painted to match the trim looks good from the street, but it often can't breathe, and brick that can't breathe fails from the inside.

Here's what we see on Glen Rock chimneys and how Lita Construction repairs it.

Spalling brick on a sealed or painted chimney

Brick faces popping off in sheets — a quarter inch of the face coming away and leaving a rough, orange interior — is spalling, and in Glen Rock we find it most often on chimneys that were sealed or painted sometime in the last 30 years. The intent was good: keep the water out. But a film-forming sealer or an exterior paint traps the water that's already in the brick, and the water that keeps getting in through the top and the joints. In winter that trapped moisture freezes just behind the sealed face and pushes it off.

The signs: brick faces missing in patches, flakes of brick on the roof and in the gutters, a chimney that looks much worse on the sunny south side (where the freeze-thaw cycles are most frequent), and paint or sealer peeling along with the brick. The joints may look fine.

The repair: the damaged brick has to come out — there's no patching a spalled face. We cut out the failed units and replace them with matched brick, repoint the surrounding joints, and remove whatever sealer or paint we can from the remaining faces. Then we address why water was in the brick in the first place: almost always a cracked top or open joints. The replacement brick is left unsealed, or treated only with a breathable siloxane water repellent that lets vapor out. If a homeowner wants the chimney to stay painted, we use a breathable masonry paint and make sure the top and the joints are sound first, so there's nothing to trap.

Chimney repointing in Glen Rock

The 1940s and 50s colonials were laid in a cement-lime mortar that's lasted well but is now 70 years old — recessed, sandy, washed out on the weather side. The 1920s and 30s homes near the stations were laid in softer brick and a lime-based mortar, and many have been repointed once already; if that repoint used a hard modern mix, the brick is now cracking around it.

The repair: we grind the joints out three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep across the full exposed section above the roof — every joint, since the ones that look fine are one winter behind — clean them, and repoint in a breathable Type N tinted to match the existing mortar, tooled to the original joint. On the pre-war homes we use a lime-rich mix so the mortar stays the part of the wall that gives. We do the top in the same visit whenever it's due.

Cracked chimney top

Nearly every Glen Rock chimney was finished with a thin mortar wash around the flue liner. On the 1940s homes it's 75 years old, and it's cracked or gone. Once the top is open, rain goes into the top course and down the core — and on a sealed chimney, that water has no way out except by freezing and breaking the brick. A cracked top is the root cause behind most of the spalling we repair in town.

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from the flue, overhanging the brick by two inches so water drips clear of the face, with a bond break around the flue tile. A stainless cap goes on the flue. On a chimney that's otherwise sound, this is the cheapest repair that stops the most water.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or attic rafters beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. Glen Rock's colonials have the chimney on the gable end or on the main slope, and the capes have it at the ridge, and in both cases the flashing has been redone during two or three roof jobs — usually by laying aluminum against the brick and tarring it. Tar pulls away within a few years. On the 1920s houses, the original lead or copper flashing was often cut out during a re-roof and replaced with something worse.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and weave step flashing into every shingle course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — gently on soft pre-war brick — wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket behind them. Matching shingles are woven back in, so this doesn't require a new roof. On the older homes with copper gutters and downspouts, we do the flashing in copper.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces — common on sealed chimneys that went unrepaired for a decade — a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, repointing and brick replacement won't hold. The section above the roof comes down and goes back up; the section inside the house, which has stayed dry, is left alone.

The repair: we scaffold with protective cribbing, take the stack down to the roofline or the first sound course, and rebuild plumb in matched brick — a standard red on the 1940s–50s homes, reclaimed or color-matched soft brick in lime mortar on the pre-war ones. Flue tiles are inspected and replaced if cracked, the top gets a poured crown, and new flashing goes in at the roof. The rebuilt section is left unsealed.

Stone and Tudor chimneys near the stations

A number of the 1920s and 30s homes around the stations are Tudors and stone-trimmed colonials with fieldstone or stone-and-brick chimneys. Those fail at the joints — the irregular face holds water, the joints wash out, stones loosen — and are repointed by hand with the loose stones reset, in a matched mortar finished to the original joint. Flashing on stone is cut into the stone face itself.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Glen Rock chimney it means a cracked top or open joints — and on a sealed chimney it often shows up as staining around the edges of the sealed area, where the trapped water is finally finding a way out. Fix the source and the staining stops.

Prefab fireplace chases

A few Glen Rock additions and newer homes vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood box with a metal cover on top. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace it with a pitched stainless cover and reframe the box if needed. It's a small share of our work in town next to the masonry above.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Brick faces popping off in patches; sealer or paint peeling with them	Moisture trapped behind a non-breathable coating	Replace spalled brick, remove coating, fix top and joints, breathable repellent only
Sandy, recessed joints	Mortar past its lifespan	Grind and repoint in matched Type N
Brick breaking around intact joints (pre-war)	Hard-mortar repoint on soft brick	Replace damaged brick, repoint in lime-rich mortar
Cracked or missing mortar at the top	Mortar wash instead of a crown	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown with a cap
Ceiling stain beside the chimney during rain	Tarred flashing; no cricket	Step flashing, reglet-cut counter-flashing, cricket
Spalling through whole faces, crack through courses, lean	Core failure above the roofline	Roofline rebuild in matched brick

Loose stones, mortar crumbs at the base (Tudors)	Washed-out joints behind the stone	Hand-rake, reset stones, repoint

Common questions from Glen Rock homeowners

I sealed my chimney to protect it. Did that cause the damage?
If it was a film-forming sealer or a regular exterior paint, probably yes. Those trap water inside the brick and it freezes behind the face. A breathable siloxane repellent is fine; a coating that forms a skin is not.

Can the spalled bricks be patched or coated?
No. A spalled face has lost its hard outer skin and will keep deteriorating. The brick has to be cut out and replaced. We match the color and size so the replacements don't show.

My chimney is painted to match the house. Can it stay painted?
Yes, if the top and joints are made sound first and the paint is a breathable masonry paint. We repair it, let it dry out, and then it can be repainted with the right product.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Glen Rock by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about twenty minutes from Glen Rock. Our own crews handle the masonry, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Ridgewood, Fair Lawn, Hawthorne, Paramus, Midland Park, and across Bergen County.

Next is Harrington Park.

Harrington Park — small, wooded, mostly 1950s–70s ranches, splits, and colonials along the Oradell Reservoir. Leads with the ranch-house chimney: short stacks on low-pitch roofs where snow and debris sit against the brick, plus the reservoir-side damp.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/harrington-park-nj/`
Title tag (60 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Harrington Park NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (151 chars): Chimney repair in Harrington Park, NJ — ranch and split-level chimney leaks, brick repointing, cracked crowns, and roofline rebuilds. Lita Construction.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Leak Repair in Harrington Park, NJ

Harrington Park is a small, wooded borough built almost entirely between the early 1950s and the mid-1970s: ranches first, then splits and bi-levels, then colonials on the larger lots toward Closter and Old Tappan, with the Oradell Reservoir running along the west side. Nearly every house has a brick chimney, and on the ranches — which make up a large share of the town — that chimney is a short, wide stack on a low-pitched roof. That geometry, plus the humidity off the reservoir and the tree cover on most lots, gives Harrington Park chimneys a particular way of failing.

Here's what we see and how Lita Construction repairs it.

Chimney leaks on ranch-house roofs

A ranch roof pitched at 4/12 or 5/12 doesn't shed water the way a steep colonial roof does. Water moves slowly, snow sits, and leaves and pine needles collect instead of sliding off. On a ranch with the chimney on the main slope, all of that gathers against the uphill side of the brick. Snow banked against the chimney melts from the bottom during the day and refreezes at night, and the water it releases has nowhere to go but under the shingles and behind the flashing.

The flashing on these chimneys was usually redone during a roof job by laying aluminum against the brick and tarring it, and on a low-pitch roof the tar is sitting in standing water half the winter. A stain on the ceiling near the chimney after a snow — not necessarily after a rain — is the giveaway.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, and wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane carried well up the roof on the uphill side, where the snow sits. Step flashing goes into every shingle course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — not caulked onto the brick — wedged, and sealed. A chimney over 30 inches wide gets a cricket behind it, and on a low-pitch roof we build the cricket steeper than the roof so it actually moves snow and debris off the chimney wall. Matching shingles are woven back in; this doesn't require a new roof.

Chimney repointing in Harrington Park

Mortar lasts 25 to 40 years in open sun. On a chimney under tree cover a few hundred yards from the reservoir, where the brick is damp more days than it's dry, it's less. The 1950s and 60s chimneys here have recessed, sandy joints, mortar you can pick out with a key, and dark staining and moss on the north face. The brick on a 1970s colonial is often a harder, more uniform unit laid in a stronger mortar that has held up better — but the joints on the weather side are going.

The repair: we clean moss and biological growth off the masonry first, since mortar can't bond to a dirty joint. Then we grind the joints out three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep across every exposed face — including the wall section on a split-level between the lower and upper roofs, which gets skipped by a lot of masons — and repoint in a breathable Type N tinted to match, tooled to the original concave joint. A breathable water repellent on the repointed stack slows the moss coming back without trapping moisture.

Cracked chimney top

Both the 1950s ranches and the 1970s colonials were finished with a thin mortar wash around the flue liner, and after 50 to 70 winters nearly all of them are cracked or gone. On a ranch chimney the top is close to the roof and easy to miss; on a colonial it's high enough that nobody looks. Either way, once the top is open, rain goes into the top course and down the core, and that water is what feeds the crumbling joints and spalling brick lower down.

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from the flue, overhanging the brick by two inches so water drips clear of the face, with a bond break around the flue tile. A stainless cap goes on the flue; on a short ranch chimney a cap also keeps the downdrafts and debris out that a low stack is prone to. We pair this with the repoint whenever both are due.

Spalling brick and roofline rebuilds

When brick faces are popping off, red flakes are in the gutters, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof is past repointing and has to come down and go back up. On a ranch that's often only a few feet of masonry; on a colonial it's the full stack above the roof. The section inside the house, which has stayed dry, is left alone.

The repair: we scaffold with protective cribbing, dismantle the damaged section to the roofline or the first sound course, and rebuild plumb in matched brick — a standard modular red on most Harrington Park homes. Flue tiles are inspected and replaced if cracked, the top gets a poured crown, and new flashing goes in at the roof.

Exterior-wall fireplace chimneys on the colonials

A lot of the 1960s and 70s colonials here have a wide fireplace chimney on the outside wall of the family room — three faces exposed from the ground up, and the roof meeting it on one side only. Those chimneys show the moss and staining of the wooded lots on the north face, wash out at the joints sooner than an interior chimney, and leak at the single roof tie-in where the roof dies into the brick. The repairs are the same — repoint every exposed face, pour a crown, re-flash the tie-in with a kickout at the bottom so water exits onto the roof rather than behind the siding.

White stains on the brick

The chalky white film is efflorescence — salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Harrington Park chimney it means a cracked top, open joints, or a chimney that's simply staying wet too long under the trees. Fix the source and the staining stops.

Prefab fireplace chases

A few Harrington Park additions and newer homes vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood box with a metal cover on top. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace it with a pitched stainless cover and reframe the box if the wood under it is soft. It's a small share of our work here next to the masonry above.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Ceiling stain near the chimney after snow (ranch)	Snow and debris banked against the uphill wall; tarred flashing	Membrane carried up the slope, step flashing, reglet-cut counter-flashing, steep cricket
Sandy joints, moss and staining on the north face	Mortar past its lifespan; chimney staying damp	Clean, grind, and repoint every exposed face in matched Type N
Cracked or missing mortar at the top	Mortar wash instead of a crown	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown with a cap
Brick flakes in gutters, crack through courses, lean	Core failure above the roofline	Roofline rebuild in matched brick

Stain where the roof meets an exterior-wall chimney	Single tie-in tarred; no kickout	Step flashing, counter-flashing, kickout at the bottom
White chalky stains	Water moving through the masonry	Fix top and joints

Common questions from Harrington Park homeowners

It only leaks after it snows, not when it rains. Why?
On a low-pitch roof, snow banks against the chimney and melts from the bottom. That meltwater sits against the flashing for days, which a rain doesn't do. The fix is membrane carried up the slope and a cricket that actually sheds snow.

Why does my chimney grow moss when my neighbor's doesn't?
Shade and moisture. A chimney on the north side of a wooded lot near the reservoir stays damp longer. Moss itself is a symptom; the repoint and a breathable repellent address it.

Can the top be done without rebuilding the chimney?
Yes, if the brick below it is sound. We check the top courses when we remove the old wash and rebuild only what's taken water.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Harrington Park by Lita Construction

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We also repair chimneys in Closter, Old Tappan, Norwood, Haworth, River Vale, and across Bergen County.

Next is Hasbrouck Heights.

Hasbrouck Heights — a dense 1920s–50s borough: Dutch colonials and gambrel roofs on the older streets off the Boulevard, capes and two-families elsewhere, and a lot of houses that have been re-sided in aluminum or vinyl over the years. Leads with two things no other page has: flashing a chimney through a gambrel roof, and the joint where new siding meets old brick.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/hasbrouck-heights-nj/`
Title tag (60 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Hasbrouck Heights NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (153 chars): Chimney repair in Hasbrouck Heights, NJ — gambrel-roof chimney leaks, siding-to-brick flashing, brick repointing, cracked crowns, and roofline rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Leak Repair in Hasbrouck Heights, NJ

Hasbrouck Heights is an older, closely built town. The streets off the Boulevard and Terrace Avenue are 1920s and 30s Dutch colonials, foursquares, and two-families; the blocks toward the Lodi and Wood-Ridge lines filled in with capes and colonials in the 1940s and 50s. Most houses have one brick chimney, often on the side wall, and most have been re-sided at least once — aluminum in the 60s and 70s, vinyl since — with the siding butted up against the chimney brick.

Those two things — the gambrel roofs on the Dutch colonials and the siding-to-brick joint on nearly everything — are where a lot of Hasbrouck Heights chimney leaks start. Here's what we see and how Lita Construction repairs it.

Chimney leaks on a gambrel roof

A Dutch colonial's gambrel roof has two pitches on each side: a steep lower slope and a shallow upper one, meeting at a break line partway up. When the chimney comes through near that break — which it does on most of these houses — the flashing has to turn a corner where the roof changes angle. That corner is the hardest flashing detail on the house, and it's been redone during three or four roof jobs over a century, usually with aluminum tarred to the brick.

A stain on the upstairs ceiling or in the knee-wall space beside the chimney during rain is that corner letting go. On a gambrel the water often runs down inside the steep lower slope before it shows, so the stain can appear a few feet below where the leak actually is.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney on both the upper and lower slopes, replace any rotted deck, and wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane

carried across the break line. Step flashing is woven into every shingle course on both pitches, with a properly folded transition piece at the break so water moving from the shallow slope onto the steep one stays on top of the metal. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — gently on soft 1920s brick — wedged, and sealed. Matching shingles are woven back in, so a new roof isn't required.

Water getting in where the siding meets the chimney

On a side-wall chimney, the house siding runs up to the brick on both sides of the stack. When the house was re-sided, the installer typically ran a J-channel up against the brick and caulked the gap. Caulk between vinyl and brick fails within a few years, and then every rain that hits the siding runs down the channel and into the gap behind it — into the wall cavity, or down to the top of the foundation. The stain shows up low on an interior wall near the chimney, or as peeling paint and soft drywall, and gets blamed on the basement.

The repair: we pull the siding back on both sides of the chimney, install a proper flashing where the wall sheathing meets the brick — membrane on the sheathing, metal counter-flashing set into a reglet in the brick, lapped over the membrane — and reinstall the siding with a J-channel that drains onto the flashing rather than behind it. At the bottom, where the chimney meets the roof or the ground, a kickout directs water out and away. It's a small job that stops a leak people have often been chasing for years.

Chimney repointing in Hasbrouck Heights

The 1920s and 30s chimneys were laid in soft brick and lime-based mortar, and a century on, the original mortar is worn — recessed, sandy, washed out on the weather side. Many have been repointed once in a hard modern mortar, and on those the brick is cracking around the intact joints: faces popping off, red flakes in the gutters. The 1940s and 50s chimneys are at the end of their original mortar's life, 25 to 40 years in this climate.

The repair: we grind the joints out three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep across the full exposed section — every face, including the faces hidden behind the siding where the chimney runs up the wall, which we expose while the siding is off for the flashing work — and repoint in a mortar matched to the brick: lime-rich on the pre-war homes, a standard Type N on the postwar ones, tinted to match and tooled to the original joint. Spalled brick is cut out and replaced with matched units.

Cracked chimney top

Nearly every chimney in town was finished with a thin mortar wash around the flue liner, and on the older houses it's a century old. Once the top is cracked, rain goes into the top course and down the core, which is what feeds the crumbling joints and spalling below. On the two-families, the top is wide enough for two or three flues and the wash cracked early.

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from every flue, overhanging the brick by two inches so water drips clear of the face, with a bond break around each flue tile. Each flue gets a stainless cap. On a two-family we confirm which flue serves which unit before anything is sealed.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up. On the gambrel houses that section is tall — the chimney has to clear the upper ridge — and the rebuild is a bigger job than on a cape. The section inside the house is left alone.

The repair: we scaffold with protective cribbing, take the stack down to the roofline or the first sound course, and rebuild plumb in reclaimed or matched soft brick and lime-rich mortar on the pre-war homes, or matched modular red on the postwar ones. Flue tiles are inspected and replaced if cracked, the top gets a poured crown, and new flashing goes in on both roof pitches.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Hasbrouck Heights chimney it means a cracked top, open joints, or water getting in behind the siding. Fix the source and the staining stops.

Prefab fireplace chases

A few additions and newer houses in town vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood box with a metal cover on top. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace it with a pitched stainless cover and reframe the box if needed. It's a small share of our work here next to the masonry above.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Upstairs ceiling or knee-wall stain beside the chimney (Dutch colonial)	Flashing failed at the gambrel break	Strip both pitches, step flashing with a transition at the break, reglet-cut counter-flashing

Low interior wall stain or soft drywall near a side-wall chimney	Siding butted to the brick with caulk only	Pull siding, flash wall-to-brick, reinstall with a draining J-channel and kickout
Brick faces popping off; joints look fine (1920s)	Hard-mortar repoint on soft brick	Replace spalled brick, repoint in lime-rich mortar
Sandy, recessed joints (1940s–50s)	Mortar past its lifespan	Grind and repoint in matched Type N
Cracked top around the flues	Mortar wash cracked	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown, capped flues
Spalling through faces, crack through courses, lean	Core failure above the roofline	Roofline rebuild in matched brick
White chalky stains	Water moving through the masonry	Fix top, joints, or siding joint

Common questions from Hasbrouck Heights homeowners

The stain is on the first floor, not near the roof. Can it still be the chimney?
Yes. On a side-wall chimney, water getting in where the siding meets the brick runs down inside the wall and shows up low, sometimes at the baseboard. It looks like a basement problem and isn't.

My roofer re-did the flashing twice and it still leaks. Why?
On a gambrel, the break line is where it fails, and most roofers flash it as if the roof were one pitch. The transition piece at the break is the part that gets skipped.

My chimney was repointed 20 years ago and now the bricks are breaking. Why?
Almost certainly a hard mortar on soft pre-war brick. The mortar is now stronger than the brick, so the brick takes the freeze-thaw damage. The fix is to replace the damaged brick and repoint in a lime-rich mortar.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof, from the attic, and along the siding before quoting. That shows whether water is entering at the flashing, through the masonry, or behind the siding, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Hasbrouck Heights by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about twenty minutes from Hasbrouck Heights. Our own crews handle the masonry, the flashing, the siding, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason, a roofer, and a siding contractor. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Wood-Ridge, Rutherford, Teaneck, Rochelle Park, Maywood, and across Bergen County.

Next is Haworth.

Haworth — small, wooded, mostly 1950s–70s colonials and splits around the reservoir and the country club, with a pre-war pocket near the station. Leads with two things no other page has: exterior chimneys pulling away from the house, and cracked clay flue tiles found when the top comes off.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/haworth-nj/`
Title tag (55 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Haworth NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (154 chars): Chimney repair in Haworth, NJ — chimneys pulling away from the house, cracked flue tiles, brick repointing, cracked crowns, flashing leaks, and roofline rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Haworth, NJ

Haworth is a small borough built mostly in the 1950s, 60s, and 70s — colonials and splits on wooded lots along Schraalenburgh Road, Sunset Avenue, and the streets between the reservoir and the country club — with a handful of older homes near the train station. The colonials from that era were often built with the fireplace chimney on an exterior wall: a wide brick stack running from its own footing at grade up past the roof, with three faces exposed to weather the

whole way. Those chimneys are now 50 to 70 years old, and they have a failure the interior chimneys on capes don't: they move.

Here's what we see on Haworth chimneys and how Lita Construction repairs it.

Chimney pulling away from the house

Stand at the corner of the house and sight up the gap between the chimney and the siding. On a lot of Haworth's exterior-wall chimneys, that gap is wider at the top than at the bottom — the stack is leaning away from the house. Sometimes you can see the gap from across the street; sometimes it's a quarter inch at the eave and the first sign is caulk that keeps splitting, or daylight visible from inside the attic beside the chimney.

An exterior chimney sits on its own footing, separate from the house foundation. On a wooded lot with clay-heavy soil near the reservoir, that footing can settle or tip a little over sixty years, and the stack — which is only tied to the house at a couple of points — rotates away. Water gets into the widening gap and makes everything worse: the flashing at the roof opens up, the siding edge rots, and the brick on the house side stays wet.

The repair: it depends on how much movement there is and whether it's still happening. If the lean is small and stable — which is the common case — we re-anchor the stack to the house framing with masonry anchors at the attic and floor levels, close the gap with a backer and a flexible sealant that can move, re-flash the roof tie-in, and repair any brick on the house side that's deteriorated. If the lean is large or the footing is still moving, that's a foundation problem, and we tell you so and bring in the right trade for the footing before we touch the masonry. What we don't do is caulk the gap and call it fixed.

Cracked flue tiles

The clay flue liner inside a brick chimney is a stack of tiles, and the top few tiles are the ones exposed to weather. When the mortar wash on top of the chimney cracks — and on a 1960s Haworth chimney it has — water gets between the tiles and the brick, freezes, and cracks the tiles. You can't see this from the ground. We find it when we open the top for a crown, and it's common: the top tile cracked vertically, the joint between the top two tiles open, sometimes the top tile shifted or broken off.

A cracked flue tile matters for more than water. It's the barrier between the hot gases in the flue and the brick and the house framing around it. On a chimney that still serves a fireplace, furnace, or water heater, cracked tiles need to be dealt with before the chimney is used.

The repair: when the top comes off, we remove the cracked tiles down to the first sound one, set new matching clay tiles in refractory mortar, and rebuild the brick around them. If the cracking goes further down than the top few tiles — which a camera inspection shows — the

better repair is a stainless steel liner run the full height. Then the crown goes on as below, with a bond break around the tile so the crown can't crack it again.

Cracked chimney top

The top of a Haworth chimney was finished with a thin mortar wash around the flue tile. After 50 to 70 winters it's cracked or gone, and rain goes into the top course, between the tiles and the brick, and down the core. It's the root cause behind the cracked flue tiles above and most of the spalling and washed-out joints below.

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from the flue, overhanging the brick by two inches so water drips clear of the face, with a bond break around the flue tile so the tile can expand without cracking the crown. A stainless cap goes on the flue.

Chimney repointing in Haworth

Mortar lasts 25 to 40 years in open sun and less under the oak and tulip poplar that shade most lots here. The 1950s and 60s chimneys have recessed, sandy joints, mortar you can pick out with a key, and moss and dark staining on the north face. On an exterior-wall chimney the damage runs from the roof down to grade, not just on the stack above the roof.

The repair: we clean moss and growth off the masonry, grind the joints out three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep across every exposed face from the top to the ground, and repoint in a breathable Type N tinted to match the existing mortar, tooled to the original concave joint. Spalled brick is cut out and replaced with matched units. A breathable water repellent on the repointed stack slows the moss coming back.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or down a wall beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. On Haworth's exterior-wall chimneys the roof meets the stack on one side only, and if the chimney has moved at all, that tie-in has opened. On the splits there are two tie-ins, lower and upper, and the lower corner where the roof meets both the chimney and the upper wall is the usual leak. The flashing was typically redone during a roof job with aluminum tarred to the brick.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and weave step flashing into every shingle course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — not caulked to the brick — wedged, and sealed. Where the roof meets the chimney and a wall, the membrane runs up the wall and a kickout at the bottom sends water onto the roof instead of behind the siding. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket behind them.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans in a way that re-anchoring won't correct, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up — in matched modular red brick, with the flue tiles reset, a poured crown, and new flashing. The section inside the house and the footing are evaluated separately.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Haworth chimney it means a cracked top, open joints, or water getting into the gap between the chimney and the house. Fix the source and the staining stops.

Prefab fireplace chases

A few Haworth additions and newer homes vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood box with a metal cover on top. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace it with a pitched stainless cover and reframe the box if needed. It's a small share of our work here next to the masonry above.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Gap between the chimney and the siding, wider at the top	Exterior chimney footing has settled or tipped	Re-anchor to the framing, close the gap with a movable seal, re-flash; refer the footing if still moving
Water inside the flue; top tile cracked (found when the top is opened)	Water between the tiles and the brick	Replace cracked tiles in refractory mortar, or line the flue
Cracked or missing mortar at the top	Mortar wash instead of a crown	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown with a cap
Sandy joints, moss, staining — roof to ground	Mortar past its lifespan on an exposed stack	Clean, grind, and repoint every face
Ceiling or wall stain beside the chimney during rain	Tarred flashing; opened tie-in	Step flashing, reglet-cut counter-flashing, kickout, cricket if over 30"

Spalling through faces, crack through courses	Core failure above the roofline	Roofline rebuild, reset flue, crown, flashing

Common questions from Haworth homeowners

My chimney is leaning away from the house. Is it going to fall?
Usually not — most of these have moved a little over decades and stopped. We check whether it's still moving and whether the stack is still tied to the house. If it's stable, we re-anchor it and close the gap. If the footing is still going, that's a foundation repair first.

How do you know the flue tiles are cracked if you can't see them?
We open the top for the crown and look down, and run a camera when there's reason to go further. Cracked top tiles are common on any chimney that's had a cracked top for a few years.

Can the top be done without rebuilding the chimney?
Yes, if the brick below it is sound. We check the top courses and the top flue tiles when we remove the old wash and rebuild only what's failed.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof, from the attic, and along the gap on an exterior chimney before quoting. That shows whether water is entering at the flashing, through the masonry, or down the gap, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Haworth by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about five minutes from Haworth. Our own crews handle the masonry, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Dumont, Demarest, Harrington Park, Closter, Oradell, and across Bergen County.

Same check as Dumont: this page says you replace flue tiles and can install a stainless liner. If liners aren't something you do, tell me and I'll rework both pages. Next is Hillsdale.

Hillsdale — Pascack Valley splits, ranches, and colonials from the 1950s and 60s on tree-heavy lots, plus older homes around the station and Hillsdale Avenue. Leads with storm damage:

chimneys hit by limbs, tops knocked off in wind, and the insurance side of that, which no other page has covered.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/hillsdale-nj/`
Title tag (57 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Hillsdale NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (153 chars): Chimney repair in Hillsdale, NJ — storm-damaged chimneys, insurance documentation, brick repointing, cracked crowns, flashing leaks, and roofline rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Storm Damage & Repointing in Hillsdale, NJ

Hillsdale is a wooded Pascack Valley town — splits, ranches, and colonials from the 1950s and 60s on the streets off Hillsdale Avenue, Washington Avenue, and Piermont Avenue, with older homes near the station — and its trees are mature. Oak and maple that were saplings when the houses were built now hang over the roofs, and in every nor'easter and summer thunderstorm, limbs come down on chimneys. A brick chimney takes a falling limb better than a roof does, but the top courses, the cap, and the flashing don't, and a chimney that's been hit once often shows the damage only after the next few rains.

Here's what we see on Hillsdale chimneys — storm damage first, then the age-related problems every 60-year-old brick chimney has — and how Lita Construction repairs it.

Storm-damaged chimneys and insurance claims

After a storm, walk the yard and look for brick. Chunks of brick or mortar on the ground or roof, a flue cap in the lawn, or a chimney top that looks uneven from the street all mean a limb or wind took something off. Less obvious: a crack through the top courses where a limb struck and bounced, flashing peeled up on one side where a branch dragged across it, or a chimney that's been nudged a quarter inch off plumb. These don't leak the day of the storm. They leak over the following weeks, and by the time the stain appears the connection to the storm is easy to miss.

How we handle it: we inspect the chimney, the roof around it, and the attic, photograph everything, and write up the damage in the format insurance adjusters expect — what was hit, what failed as a result, and what it takes to restore it. We've done this on storm claims across Bergen County and know what an adjuster needs to see to approve a chimney top rebuild and re-flashing rather than a patch. Then we do the repair: rebuild the damaged courses in matched brick, pour a new crown, reset or replace the cap, and re-flash the roof tie-in. If the roof was damaged too, it's one job and one claim.

Cracked chimney top

Even without a storm, the top of a Hillsdale chimney is usually failing. The builders finished it with a thin mortar wash around the flue liner, and after sixty winters it's cracked or gone. A limb strike turns a cracked wash into a missing one. Once the top is open, rain goes into the top course and down the core, which is what feeds the washed-out joints and spalling below.

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water or been knocked loose, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from the flue, overhanging the brick by two inches so water drips clear of the face, with a bond break around the flue tile. A stainless cap goes on, fastened so the next wind doesn't take it.

Chimney repointing in Hillsdale

Mortar lasts 25 to 40 years in open sun, less under tree cover, and the 1950s and 60s chimneys here are overdue: recessed, sandy joints, mortar you can pick out with a key, moss and dark staining on the shaded face. On the older homes near the station the brick is softer and was laid in lime mortar, and a past hard-mortar repoint on those shows as brick breaking around intact joints.

The repair: we clean moss and growth off the masonry, grind the joints out three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep across every exposed face — including the wall section on a split-level between the two roofs, which gets skipped — and repoint in a breathable Type N tinted to match, tooled to the original joint. A lime-rich mix on the pre-war homes. Spalled brick is cut out and replaced with matched units.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or attic rafters beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. On Hillsdale's splits the lower corner — where the lower roof meets the chimney and the upper wall — is the usual spot; on the ranches it's the uphill side where leaves and snow sit against the brick; and on any of them, flashing that a limb has dragged across is open along one edge. Most of this flashing was redone during a past roof job with aluminum tarred to the brick.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and weave step flashing into every shingle course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — not caulked to the brick — wedged, and sealed. Where the roof meets the chimney and a wall, the membrane runs up the wall and a kickout at the bottom sends water onto the roof. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket behind them. Matching shingles are woven back in.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, the top has been knocked askew, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up. The section inside the house, which has stayed dry, is left alone.

The repair: we scaffold with protective cribbing, take the stack down to the roofline or the first sound course, and rebuild plumb in matched brick — modular red on most Hillsdale homes, reclaimed or matched soft brick in lime mortar on the older ones. Flue tiles are inspected and replaced if cracked — a limb strike often cracks the top tile — the top gets a poured crown, and new flashing goes in at the roof.

Trimming back and the next storm

Once the chimney is repaired, the limbs that hit it are still there. We'll point out which ones are over the chimney and the roof; a tree service can take them back. We don't do tree work, but we've seen enough chimney tops rebuilt twice in five years to mention it.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Hillsdale chimney it means a cracked top, open joints, or a chimney staying wet under the trees. Fix the source and the staining stops.

Prefab fireplace chases

A few Hillsdale additions and newer homes vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood box with a metal cover on top. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years — and a limb will take a flat galvanized cover right off. We replace it with a pitched stainless cover and reframe the box if needed. It's a small share of our work here next to the masonry above.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Brick on the ground after a storm; cap missing; top uneven	Limb strike or wind damage	Document for insurance, rebuild top courses, crown, cap, re-flash
Flashing peeled up on one side	Branch dragged across it	Re-flash that side with step and reglet-cut counter-flashing

Cracked or missing mortar at the top	Mortar wash instead of a crown	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown with a fastened cap
Sandy joints, moss, staining	Mortar past its lifespan under tree cover	Clean, grind, and repoint every exposed face
Ceiling stain beside the chimney during rain	Tarred flashing; no cricket	Step flashing, reglet-cut counter-flashing, kickout, cricket
Spalling through faces, crack through courses, lean	Core failure above the roofline	Roofline rebuild, reset flue, crown, flashing

Common questions from Hillsdale homeowners

A branch hit the chimney but it looks fine. Should I worry?
Have it looked at. The damage a limb does — a cracked top, a loosened course, flashing lifted along one edge — rarely shows from the ground, and it starts leaking weeks later. If it's documented right after the storm, it's a clear insurance claim; months later it looks like wear.

Will insurance cover the chimney repair?
Storm damage generally is covered; deterioration from age isn't. The difference is in the documentation. We photograph and write up what the storm did so the adjuster can separate it from the age-related work, and we can price the two separately.

Can the top be done without rebuilding the chimney?
Yes, if the brick below it is sound. We check the top courses when we remove the old wash and rebuild only what's failed.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Hillsdale by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about fifteen minutes from Hillsdale. Our own crews handle the masonry, the flashing, and the roof tie-in — and the storm documentation — so the job isn't split between a mason and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Westwood, River Vale, Washington Township, Woodcliff Lake, Park Ridge, and across Bergen County.

Next is Ho-Ho-Kus.

Ho-Ho-Kus — a historic borough with a lot of 1920s–40s Tudors and colonials, the Cheelcroft-era ranches and splits, and large newer homes on the bigger lots. Leads with something no other page has: tall Tudor chimneys with clay chimney pots and decorative brickwork, and matching historic brick when they're rebuilt.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/ho-ho-kus-nj/`
Title tag (57 chars): Chimney Repair & Rebuilding Ho-Ho-Kus NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (152 chars): Chimney repair in Ho-Ho-Kus, NJ — Tudor chimney rebuilds, chimney pots, historic brick matching, repointing, cracked crowns, and chimney flashing leaks.

Chimney Repair, Rebuilding & Repointing in Ho-Ho-Kus, NJ

Ho-Ho-Kus has some of the best-looking chimneys in Bergen County, and that's exactly what makes them expensive to repair badly. The 1920s and 30s Tudors and colonials along Hollywood Avenue, Sheridan Avenue, and the streets around the Hermitage were built with tall, decorative chimneys — patterned brick, stepped corbels, multiple stacks, and clay chimney pots on top. The postwar ranches and splits in the Cheelcroft section and toward the Ridgewood line have ordinary brick chimneys, and the newer homes on the larger lots carry wide stone and brick stacks. A mason who treats a Tudor chimney like a cape chimney will stop the leak and leave the house looking wrong from the street.

Here's what we see on Ho-Ho-Kus chimneys and how Lita Construction repairs it.

Rebuilding Tudor chimneys and chimney pots

A Tudor chimney is a tall stack — sometimes two or three bonded together — with decorative details that are also its weak points. The corbeled bands near the top catch water on every ledge. The clay chimney pots sitting on top are set in mortar that's nearly a century old. The patterned brickwork — soldier courses, herringbone panels, projecting headers — has more exposed edges than a plain wall. After ninety winters, the top few feet of these chimneys are

typically loose: a pot leaning, a corbel course with a brick missing, a crack running down through the decorative band, brick on the roof below.

The repair: we photograph and measure the chimney before anything comes down, so the details go back the way they were. The stack is scaffolded with protective cribbing — heavily on the slate roofs these houses often have — and taken down to sound brick, which on a Tudor is often eight to fifteen courses. We rebuild the corbels, bands, and patterns to the original profile in reclaimed or color-matched soft brick, laid in a lime-rich mortar so the new work flexes like the old. The chimney pots are cleaned, inspected, and reset in fresh mortar on a poured, reinforced crown that overhangs the brick and is flashed under the pots; a cracked pot is replaced with a matching salvaged or new clay pot. The result looks like the chimney the house was built with, because it is.

Matching brick on historic homes

The brick on a pre-war Ho-Ho-Kus house is soft, often irregular, and in colors modern brick doesn't come in — the oranges, purples, and black-fired clinkers that give these chimneys their look. Rebuilding a damaged section in a standard modern red is the most visible mistake we see on these houses, and it's permanent.

How we handle it: we source reclaimed brick that matches the size and range of the original, or a hand-molded new brick in the right color range where reclaimed isn't available, and we blend it through the rebuilt section the way the original mason did rather than in a block. The mortar is matched to the original color and sand and tooled to the original joint — often a raked or struck joint on these homes. We leave the new section unsealed so it weathers in.

Repointing soft brick and lime mortar

The original mortar on the pre-war chimneys is lime-based and meant to wear; after ninety years it's recessed and sandy, especially on the weather side. The common complication is a past repoint in a hard modern mortar, which outlasts the brick and lets it crack around the intact joints — faces popping off, flakes in the gutter. On a decorative chimney, spalling takes the patterned faces with it.

The repair: we grind out the worn or hard mortar three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep, carefully on soft brick so the edges aren't nicked, replace spalled units with matched brick, and repoint in a lime-rich Type N or Type O matched to the original color and sand, tooled to the original joint. The postwar chimneys in Cheelcroft and elsewhere take a standard Type N repoint, ground out and tooled to the concave joint.

Cracked chimney top

Both eras have a top problem. On the Tudors, the mortar the pots are set in and the wash between them has cracked, and water goes down between the pots and the flue tiles. On the postwar homes it's the usual thin mortar wash around the liner, cracked after sixty winters. Either way, water in from the top is what feeds the failing corbels, loose pots, and washed-out joints below.

The repair: on a Tudor we rebuild the top as described above, with a poured crown under the pots. On a plain chimney we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from the flue, overhanging the brick by two inches, with a bond break around the flue tile — and cap the flue.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or down a wall beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. The pre-war houses were flashed in lead or copper, and most of that has been replaced during re-roofing with aluminum tarred to the brick — which fails within a few years and looks wrong against a slate roof and copper gutters. On the postwar homes it's the standard tarred-over flashing from a past roof job.

The repair: on slate we remove and reset the slates around the chimney; on shingle we strip the surrounding courses. Any rotted deck is replaced, the base is wrapped in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and step flashing goes in every course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — gently on soft brick — wedged, and sealed. On the older and higher-end homes we do it in 20-ounce copper to match the house. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket behind them.

Stone chimneys on the larger lots

The newer homes on Ho-Ho-Kus's bigger parcels, and some of the older estates, have fieldstone and stone veneer chimneys. Stone fails at the joints — the irregular face holds water, the joints wash out, stones loosen — and veneer fails behind the stone when there's no drainage. We rake stone joints by hand, reset loose stones, and repoint in a matched mortar; on veneer we open the face, install the drainage layer, and re-set the stone. Flashing on stone is cut into the stone face.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Ho-Ho-Kus chimney it means a cracked top, open joints, or water getting down between the chimney pots. Fix the source and the staining stops.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Chimney pot leaning; brick missing from a corbel band	Top courses loosened by freeze-thaw	Rebuild the top to original profile in matched brick, crown, reset pots
Decorative brick faces popping off; joints intact	Hard-mortar repoint on soft brick	Replace spalled brick with matched units, repoint in lime-rich mortar
Rebuilt section in the wrong color brick (past repair)	Standard modern brick used	Rebuild in reclaimed or matched brick, blended through
Sandy, recessed joints	Original mortar worn	Grind and repoint in matched mortar
Ceiling stain beside the chimney during rain	Tarred aluminum flashing on a slate roof	Reset slate, copper step and counter-flashing, cricket
Mortar crumbs at the base of a stone chimney	Washed-out joints behind the stone	Hand-rake, reset stones, repoint

Common questions from Ho-Ho-Kus homeowners

Can you rebuild the chimney so it matches the house?
Yes. We photograph and measure before taking anything down, source reclaimed or color-matched brick, and rebuild the corbels, patterns, and pots to the original profile. That's the whole point of the job on these houses.

Do the chimney pots have to come off?
To rebuild the top properly, yes. They're removed, cleaned, inspected, and reset in fresh mortar on the new crown. Cracked pots are replaced with matching clay pots.

My chimney was repointed in the 1990s and now the bricks are breaking. Why?
Almost certainly a hard mortar on soft pre-war brick. The mortar is now stronger than the brick, so the brick takes the freeze-thaw damage. The fix is to replace the damaged brick and repoint in a lime-rich mortar.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Ho-Ho-Kus by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 25 minutes from Ho-Ho-Kus. Our own crews handle the masonry, the copper work, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Ridgewood, Saddle River, Waldwick, Midland Park, Allendale, and across Bergen County.

Next is Leonia.

Leonia — a small, older borough: a lot of 1900s–1930s Craftsman, Colonial Revival, and Victorian-era homes on the hill between Broad Avenue and Fort Lee Road, with 1950s capes filling in the flatter streets. Leads with two things no other page has: chimneys passing through deep eaves and porch roofs, and the attic section of a 100-year-old chimney.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/leonia-nj/`
Title tag (54 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Leonia NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (151 chars): Chimney repair in Leonia, NJ — 100-year-old brick chimneys, eave and porch-roof flashing, attic repointing, cracked crowns, and roofline rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Leonia, NJ

Leonia is one of the older towns in eastern Bergen County, and a lot of its houses are from the first three decades of the 1900s — Craftsman bungalows and Colonial Revivals with deep overhanging eaves and wide porches, Victorian-era homes on the hill, and foursquares on the streets off Broad Avenue and Grand Avenue — with 1950s capes on the flatter blocks toward Teaneck. The chimneys on the older houses are a century old, in soft brick and lime mortar, and they've been repaired and re-flashed through four or five roofs.

The Craftsman-era houses in particular have a chimney detail that most towns don't: the stack rises on the outside wall, passes up through a two- or three-foot roof overhang or a porch roof, then continues past the main roof. That's two or three roof penetrations on one chimney, and the

lower ones are where the leaks are. Here's what we see on Leonia chimneys and how Lita Construction repairs it.

Chimney leaks at the eave and porch roof

On a bungalow or Colonial Revival with wide eaves, the chimney passes through the overhang near the edge of the roof — the spot where the roof is lowest, the gutter is right there, and ice builds in winter. On many houses it also passes through a porch roof below that. Each penetration was flashed a hundred years ago in lead or copper and has since been redone with aluminum and tar during re-roofing, and each one leaks differently: the eave penetration drips onto the soffit and down the exterior wall, and the porch-roof penetration drips onto the porch ceiling.

Water on a porch ceiling or staining on the soffit boards beside the chimney, during rain, is one of those lower penetrations. A stain inside the house upstairs is the main roof tie-in.

The repair: we treat each penetration as its own flashing job. The shingles or roofing around the chimney are stripped at that level, rotted deck and soffit are replaced, the base is wrapped in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane — carried well up the slope at the eave, where ice dams form — and step flashing goes into every course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint, gently on soft brick, wedged, and sealed. On a porch roof with a low pitch we often build a small cricket on the uphill side. We do the flashing in 20-ounce copper on these houses; it matches the originals and outlasts the roof.

The attic section of a 100-year-old chimney

On most chimneys the section inside the house is fine — dry, protected, never a problem. On Leonia's oldest houses it often isn't. The attic section was laid in lime mortar that was never pointed finished (the mason knew nobody would see it), it's been exposed to a century of attic heat and humidity, and if the top of the chimney has been cracked for years, water has been running down the inside of the stack and out through those unfinished attic joints. The signs are mortar dust on the attic floor around the chimney, bricks you can wiggle by hand, and a gap where the chimney passes through the attic floor framing.

That section is also what the roof framing is nailed around. Loose brick there is a structural question as well as a leak.

The repair: we repoint the attic section from inside — rake and refill the open joints in a lime-rich mortar, replace any brick that's crumbled, and parge the stack where it was originally parged. Then we fix what let the water in, which is almost always the top. On a chimney where the attic section has gone too far, the rebuild starts below the roofline instead of at it, and the roof framing is supported while it's done.

Repointing soft brick and lime mortar

The exterior joints on the pre-war chimneys are at the century mark — recessed, sandy, washed out on the weather side — and many have been repointed once in a hard modern mortar that's now breaking the brick around it. Faces popping off, red flakes in the gutter, joints intact: that's the hard-mortar problem, and it's common on the hill.

The repair: we grind out the worn or hard mortar three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep, carefully on soft brick, replace spalled units with reclaimed or matched brick, and repoint in a lime-rich Type N or Type O matched to the original color and sand, tooled to the original joint. The 1950s capes take a standard Type N repoint, ground out and tooled to the concave joint.

Cracked chimney top

The top of a Leonia chimney — a mortar wash on the postwar homes, a wash or a crumbled cap on the older ones — has been cracked for years on most houses. On the older chimneys it's the direct cause of the attic problem above: water in from the top, down the core, out through the unpointed attic joints.

The repair: we remove the old wash or cap, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from the flue, overhanging the brick by two inches so water drips clear of the face, with a bond break around the flue tile. A stainless cap goes on the flue, or copper on the houses with copper work.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up — in reclaimed or color-matched soft brick and lime-rich mortar on the pre-war homes, matched modular red on the capes. On the Craftsman houses, the rebuild usually starts at the main roof and the eave and porch penetrations are re-flashed as part of the same job. Flue tiles are reset or replaced, the top gets a poured crown, and the flashing is done in copper.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Leonia chimney it means a cracked top, open joints, or water coming down the inside of the stack. Fix the source and the staining stops.

Prefab fireplace chases

A few Leonia additions and newer houses vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood box with a metal cover on top. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace it with a pitched stainless cover and reframe the box if needed. It's a small share of our work in town next to the masonry above.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Water on the porch ceiling or soffit beside the chimney	Eave or porch-roof penetration flashing failed	Re-flash that penetration with copper step and reglet-cut counter-flashing, cricket on low pitch
Mortar dust on the attic floor; loose brick in the attic	Unpointed attic section taking water from the top	Repoint the attic section from inside, fix the top
Brick faces popping off; joints intact	Hard-mortar repoint on soft brick	Replace spalled brick, repoint in lime-rich mortar
Sandy, recessed joints	Original mortar worn	Grind and repoint in matched mortar
Cracked top; crumbled cap	Mortar wash or cap failed	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown with a cap
Spalling through faces, crack through courses, lean	Core failure above the roofline	Roofline rebuild in matched brick, re-flash all penetrations

Common questions from Leonia homeowners

The porch ceiling leaks next to the chimney but the house is dry. Is that the chimney?
Yes — the flashing where the chimney passes through the porch roof. It's a separate penetration from the main roof and it's flashed separately.

There's brick dust in my attic. What does that mean?
The attic section of the chimney is losing mortar, usually because water has been coming down the inside from a cracked top. It needs to be repointed from inside and the top fixed. We check whether the brick is still sound enough to repoint or needs rebuilding.

Will the rebuilt brick match a 1915 chimney?
We source reclaimed or color-matched soft brick and lay it in a lime mortar matched to the original. It won't be invisible on day one, but it weathers in within a season or two.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof, from the attic, and at each lower penetration before quoting. That shows which tie-in is letting water in and whether it's also coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Leonia by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about fifteen minutes from Leonia. Our own crews handle the masonry, the copper work, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Fort Lee, Englewood, Teaneck, Englewood Cliffs, Hasbrouck Heights, and across Bergen County.

Next is Mahwah.

Mahwah — the biggest township on the list by area: 1960s–2000s subdivisions in Fardale, Masonicus, and along the Ramapo Valley, the older Cragmere section, a lot of townhouse and condo communities, and the Ramapo Mountains behind it all. Leads with mountain weather, native Ramapo stone, and association work on townhouse chimneys — none of which another page has.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/mahwah-nj/`
Title tag (53 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Mahwah NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (154 chars): Chimney repair in Mahwah, NJ — stone and brick chimney repointing, cracked crowns, flashing leaks, roofline rebuilds, and townhouse and condo chimney work.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Mahwah, NJ

Mahwah gets harder winters than the rest of Bergen County. The township runs up into the Ramapo Mountains, and the homes in Fardale, Masonicus, along Ramapo Valley Road, and in the subdivisions off Route 202 sit higher, colder, and more exposed than a house in Bergenfield — more snow, more freeze-thaw cycles, more wind across the ridge lines. The housing is mostly 1960s through 2000s: colonials and splits in the older sections like Cragmere, large custom homes on the mountain lots, and a lot of townhouse and condominium communities. Chimneys run the full range, from standard brick to native Ramapo fieldstone to the sided chases on townhouse roofs.

Here's what we see on Mahwah chimneys and how Lita Construction repairs it.

Freeze-thaw damage on exposed chimneys

A chimney on a mountain lot in Mahwah can go through a freeze-thaw cycle every day for weeks in late winter — sun on the south face by noon, hard freeze by night. Every cycle, water in the mortar and brick expands and lets go, and the damage shows up a few years sooner here than it does in the valley towns: spalled brick faces, washed-out joints, a cracked top, and on the exposed ridge lots, the south and west faces visibly worse than the others.

The repair: the same masonry repairs as anywhere — repoint, crown, rebuild — but specified for the exposure. We use a breathable Type N mortar that can take the cycling, replace spalled brick with units rated for severe weathering, pour crowns with a full two-inch overhang and reinforcement so they don't crack across, and finish with a breathable water repellent that slows water getting in without trapping what's already there. A chimney repaired for valley conditions on a Mahwah ridge lot is back on the list in ten years.

Native stone chimneys

A lot of the older and custom homes in Mahwah have chimneys built from the stone that came out of the ground around them — Ramapo granite and gneiss, hard, dark, and irregular. Stone this hard doesn't spall, but the mortar between it does, and the joints on a fieldstone chimney are long and uneven. Under tree cover on the mountain lots, the face stays wet, freezes, and works the mortar loose. You'll see mortar crumbs at the base, recessed joints, and a stone that moves when pushed.

The repair: we rake the joints out by hand with chisels and a narrow grinder — a wide blade scars the stone permanently — at least three-quarters of an inch deep and deeper on the wide joints, reset loose stones in fresh mortar, and repoint in a Type N matched to the existing color and sand, finished to the original joint. Flashing on stone is cut into the stone face itself, since there's no straight mortar joint to use. On the stone-veneer chimneys on newer homes, white staining through the face means water trapped behind the stone; we open the face, install the drainage layer that was left out, and re-set the stone.

Cracked chimney top

Mahwah's brick chimneys, 1960s or 2000s, were mostly finished with a thin mortar wash around the flue liner, and with the cycling here it cracked early. The wide multi-flue tops on the custom homes cracked faster. Once the top is open, every snowmelt goes into the top courses and down the core.

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from every flue, overhanging the masonry by two inches so water drips clear of the face, with a bond break around each flue tile. Each flue gets a stainless cap. On a mountain lot the cap also keeps wind-driven snow out of the flue.

Chimney repointing in Mahwah

The 1960s and 70s brick chimneys in Cragmere and the older subdivisions have recessed, sandy joints and mortar you can pick out with a key, and the 1980s–2000s chimneys on the exposed lots are getting there sooner than their age suggests.

The repair: we grind the joints out three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep across every exposed face — the south and west faces are usually deeper — and repoint in a breathable Type N tinted to match, tooled to the original joint. Spalled brick is cut out and replaced. We do the top in the same visit whenever it's due; a fresh repoint under a cracked crown keeps taking water from above.

Chimney leaking when it rains or when snow melts

A stain on a ceiling or attic framing beside the chimney during rain, or — more often in Mahwah — during a thaw, is a flashing leak. Snow banked against the uphill side of a chimney melts from the bottom, and that meltwater sits against the flashing for days. Most Mahwah flashing was redone during a roof job with aluminum tarred to the brick, and on the wide chimneys on the custom homes, there's usually no cricket behind the stack.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, and wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane carried well up the slope on the uphill side. Step flashing goes into every shingle course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint, or a channel cut into stone — not caulked on — wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket framed behind them, built steep enough to shed snow.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up — in matched brick rated

for severe weathering, or in salvaged native stone on the fieldstone chimneys. Flue tiles are inspected and replaced if cracked, the top gets a poured crown, and new flashing and a cricket go in at the roof. The section inside the house is left alone.

Townhouse and condominium chimneys

Mahwah's townhouse and condo communities have chimneys by the dozen, and they're almost all the same: a prefab fireplace vented through a sided wood chase with a flat galvanized cover on top. The covers rust through in 5 to 8 years and drip into the framing, and because the units were built at the same time, they fail at the same time. An association that's seeing rust streaks on three chimneys usually has thirty more a year behind.

How we handle it: we survey the community's chimneys from the roofs, document which covers have failed and which chases have rot behind them, and price the work for the association as a program — pitched stainless covers across the community, framing repairs where the sheathing has gone soft, re-flashing at the roof where it's needed — so the board can plan it over one or two seasons rather than unit by unit. We work with property managers and provide the documentation their boards need.

White stains on the brick or stone

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Mahwah chimney it means a cracked top, open joints, or veneer without drainage. Fix the source and the staining stops.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Spalled brick and washed-out joints, worse on the south and west faces	Mountain freeze-thaw cycling	Repoint, replace brick with severe-weather units, crown, breathable repellent
Mortar crumbs at the base of a fieldstone chimney; loose stone	Washed-out joints behind the stone	Hand-rake, reset stones, repoint
Cracked top around the flue(s)	Mortar wash cracked	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown, capped flues
Ceiling stain during a thaw	Snowmelt against tarred flashing; no cricket	Membrane up the slope, step flashing, reglet-cut counter-flashing, steep cricket

Spalling through faces, crack through courses, lean	Core failure above the roofline	Roofline rebuild in matched brick or native stone
Rust streaks on townhouse chimney siding, several units at once	Galvanized chase covers rusted through	Community survey, pitched stainless covers, framing repair where needed

Common questions from Mahwah homeowners

Why does my chimney look worse than the same model house in Paramus?
Elevation and exposure. A chimney on a mountain lot goes through more freeze-thaw cycles each winter, and the south and west faces get sun-and-freeze cycling that a valley chimney doesn't. The repair is the same, specified for the conditions.

Do you work with homeowners' associations?
Yes. We survey the community, document each chimney, and price the work as a program the board can budget. We've found it's much less expensive per unit than repairing them one at a time as they fail.

Can a stone chimney be repointed, or does it have to be rebuilt?
Repointed, if the stones are still seated and water isn't coming through the inside of the stack. We check both from the roof. Rebuilding is for chimneys where whole courses have gone loose or the core is failing.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Mahwah by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 30 minutes from Mahwah, and we work in the township regularly. Our own crews handle the masonry, the stone work, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Ramsey, Upper Saddle River, Franklin Lakes, Oakland, Allendale, and across Bergen County.

Next is Maywood.

Maywood — a small, dense 1920s–50s borough of capes, colonials, and two-families, where a lot of the chimneys only ever served a furnace. Leads with something no other page has: what to do with a chimney the house no longer uses — repair it, seal it, or take it down.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/maywood-nj/`
Title tag (54 chars): Chimney Repair & Removal Maywood NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (154 chars): Chimney repair in Maywood, NJ — repairing, sealing, or removing unused furnace chimneys, brick repointing, cracked crowns, flashing leaks, and roofline rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Removal in Maywood, NJ

Maywood is a compact borough of 1920s–50s capes, colonials, and two-families on small lots off Maywood Avenue and Passaic Street, and a large share of its chimneys never had a fireplace behind them. They were built to vent the furnace and the water heater, and that's all they ever did. Over the last 30 years, as furnaces were replaced with high-efficiency units that vent through the wall in PVC and water heaters went tankless or direct-vent, a lot of those chimneys stopped doing anything. They're still standing, still taking weather, and still leaking — and nobody's sure what to do with them.

Here's how we approach Maywood's chimneys, used and unused, and how Lita Construction repairs or removes them.

Unused furnace chimneys: repair, seal, or remove

If nothing vents into your chimney anymore, you have three options, and the right one depends on the condition of the stack and what you want from the roof.

Repair it and keep it. If the chimney is in decent shape and you want the house to look the way it does, it gets the same treatment as any brick chimney — repointing, a poured crown, flashing — and the flue is capped and sealed at the top so rain stops going down it. An unused chimney with an open flue is a rain pipe into your basement.

Seal it and leave it. If the stack is sound but you don't want to invest in it, the minimum is to close the top: a solid cap over the flue, a crown that sheds water, and the joints checked. This stops the water but doesn't restore the masonry.

Take it down. If the chimney above the roof is in bad condition — spalling, leaning, flashing that leaks every spring — and it serves nothing, removing it is often less expensive than rebuilding it and ends the problem permanently. We dismantle the stack to just below the roof deck, frame and sheath the opening, and roof over it with matching shingles so the patch doesn't show. The section inside the house stays where it is, capped at the top, unless you're renovating and want the space back.

Before any of this, we confirm nothing still vents into the chimney — a water heater left on an abandoned flue is a common and dangerous find — and that it isn't shared with a neighbor on a two-family.

Chimney repointing in Maywood

For the chimneys that are still in use, the mortar on a 1940s or 50s cape is past its life: recessed, sandy joints, mortar you can pick out with a key, brick dark after rain. The 1920s homes were laid in softer brick and lime mortar, and a past hard-mortar repoint on those shows as brick breaking around intact joints.

The repair: we grind the joints out three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep across the full exposed section above the roof — every joint, since the ones that look fine are one winter behind — and repoint in a breathable Type N tinted to match, tooled to the original concave joint. A lime-rich mix on the pre-war homes. Spalled brick is cut out and replaced with matched units.

Cracked chimney top

Nearly every Maywood chimney was finished with a thin mortar wash around the flue liner, and after 70 years it's cracked or gone. On a furnace chimney that's still in use, the cracked top plus the moisture from gas exhaust is what eats the upper courses from both sides. On an unused chimney, the cracked top is simply a funnel.

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from the flue, overhanging the brick by two inches so water drips clear of the face, with a bond break around the flue tile. A stainless cap goes on an active flue; a solid sealed cap goes on an abandoned one.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on an upstairs ceiling or in the attic beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. On Maywood's capes the chimney usually comes through at or near the ridge, where the roof meets it on two slopes and the flashing has to turn the peak corner — a hard detail that's been redone with aluminum and tar through two or three roof jobs. On the colonials and two-families, it's the standard tarred-over step flashing.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and weave step flashing into every shingle course on both slopes, with a folded saddle at the ridge. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — not caulked to the brick — wedged, and sealed. Matching shingles are woven back in. If the chimney is being removed instead, the flashing problem goes with it.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When an in-use chimney has spalled through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up — in matched modular red brick, with the flue tiles reset or replaced, a poured crown, and new flashing. On a cape this is typically a two-day job. On an unused chimney in the same condition, we'll give you the rebuild price and the removal price side by side.

Two-family chimneys

Maywood's two-families often have one chimney serving both units' heating appliances. Before anything is capped, sealed, or removed, we trace every flue to its appliance, and we coordinate the work so both units know when the flue is out of service.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Maywood furnace chimney, staining near the top is often the exhaust-condensation problem showing through; on an unused chimney, it's rain coming down the open flue. Fix the top and the staining stops.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Chimney serves nothing; leaks or looks rough	Abandoned stack still taking weather	Repair and cap, seal the top, or remove below the roof and patch
Water in the basement at the base of the chimney	Open flue on an unused chimney	Sealed cap and crown
Sandy, recessed joints	Mortar past its lifespan	Grind and repoint in matched Type N
Cracked or missing mortar at the top	Mortar wash instead of a crown	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown with a cap

Upstairs ceiling stain beside the chimney during rain	Tarred flashing at the ridge corner	Step flashing both slopes, ridge saddle, reglet-cut counter-flashing
Spalling through faces, crack through courses, lean	Core failure above the roofline	Rebuild — or remove, if the chimney is unused

Common questions from Maywood homeowners

My furnace vents out the side of the house now. Do I still need the chimney?
Only if the water heater or something else still vents into it. If nothing does, the chimney is just masonry taking weather. It can be kept and sealed or taken down; we'll tell you which makes sense for its condition.

What does removing a chimney involve?
We dismantle the stack to below the roof deck, frame and sheath the opening, and roof it over with matching shingles. The section inside the house stays and is capped. It's usually a one-day job and the roof patch doesn't show.

Is it cheaper to remove than to rebuild?
Usually, yes, when the chimney is unused and the upper stack is in bad shape. We price both so you can decide.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry — or down an open flue — and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Maywood by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about fifteen minutes from Maywood. Our own crews handle the masonry, the flashing, the roof tie-in, and chimney removal and roof patching, so the job isn't split between a mason and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Rochelle Park, Paramus, Hasbrouck Heights, Saddle Brook, Teaneck, and across Bergen County.

Check for you: this page offers chimney removal and roof patching. If that's not something you want to advertise, say so and I'll rework it. Next is Midland Park.

Midland Park — a small borough of 1920s–60s capes and colonials off Godwin Avenue and Franklin Avenue, with a lot of houses changing hands as starter homes. Leads with something no other page has: the chimney flagged on a home inspection report.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/midland-park-nj/`
Title tag (60 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Midland Park NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (154 chars): Chimney repair in Midland Park, NJ — chimney issues flagged on home inspections, brick repointing, cracked crowns, flashing leaks, and roofline rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Midland Park, NJ

Midland Park is a small, close-knit borough of 1920s–60s capes, colonials, and splits on the streets off Godwin Avenue and Franklin Avenue, and a lot of those houses change hands — it's a town people buy into young and stay in. That means a lot of home inspections, and on a 60- to 100-year-old brick chimney, the inspection report almost always says something: "deteriorated mortar joints," "cracked crown," "flashing sealant failed, recommend evaluation by a qualified mason." Buyers want to know what it will cost and whether it's a negotiating point; sellers want to know whether to fix it before listing.

Here's how we read those reports on Midland Park chimneys, what the findings actually mean, and how Lita Construction repairs them.

Chimney findings on a home inspection

A home inspector looks at the chimney from the ground, maybe from a ladder at the eave, and reports what's visible. The language is standardized, and it maps to real repairs:

"Deteriorated or recessed mortar joints." The mortar is past its life — on a 1950s chimney, expected. The repair is repointing. On its own this is a routine maintenance item, not a reason to walk away from a house.

"Cracked or deteriorated crown / mortar wash." The top of the chimney is letting water in. Also routine, also common, and the one item that causes the others if it's left.

"Flashing sealant deteriorated" or "evidence of prior sealant repairs." The flashing has been tarred at some point and the tar has failed. The fix is to re-flash properly, not re-tar.

"Spalling brick" or "displaced brick." Water has been in the chimney long enough to break the brick. This one can mean a repoint and brick replacement, or a rebuild of the upper stack, depending on how far it's gone — and that's the finding where a mason's inspection changes the number.

"Flue liner not visible / recommend Level 2 inspection." The inspector couldn't see inside. A camera inspection answers whether the liner is cracked and whether the chimney is safe to use with the fireplace or furnace.

How we handle it: we inspect from the roof and the attic — which the home inspector usually didn't — and give a written scope and price that separates the routine items (repoint, crown, flashing) from anything structural (spalling, rebuild, liner). Buyers use it to negotiate or to budget; sellers use it to fix the chimney before listing so the item never appears on the report. Either way, it's the number the inspection report couldn't give you.

Chimney repointing in Midland Park

The 1940s and 50s chimneys have recessed, sandy joints and mortar you can pick out with a key. The older homes near Godwin Avenue were laid in softer brick and lime mortar, and a past hard-mortar repoint on those shows as brick breaking around intact joints.

The repair: we grind the joints out three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep across the full exposed section above the roof — every joint, since the ones that look fine are one winter behind — and repoint in a breathable Type N tinted to match, tooled to the original joint. A lime-rich mix on the pre-war homes. Spalled brick is cut out and replaced with matched units.

Cracked chimney top

The top of a Midland Park chimney was finished with a thin mortar wash around the flue liner, and after 60 to 90 winters it's cracked or gone on nearly every house. Once it's open, rain goes into the top course and down the core, which is what feeds the failing joints and spalling below. It's the first item on most inspection reports and the first repair we'd make.

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from the flue, overhanging the brick by two inches so water drips clear of the face, with a bond break around the flue tile. A stainless cap goes on the flue.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or attic rafters beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. Midland Park's capes have the chimney at the ridge, where the flashing has to turn the peak corner; the colonials have it on the gable end or main slope. In both cases it's been redone through two or three roof jobs, usually with aluminum tarred to the brick.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and weave step flashing into every shingle course — on both slopes, with a folded saddle at the ridge, on a cape. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — not caulked to the brick — wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket behind them. Matching shingles are woven back in.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When the inspection says "spalling" and we find it's gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up — in matched brick, modular red on the postwar homes, reclaimed or matched soft brick in lime mortar on the older ones. Flue tiles are inspected and replaced if cracked, the top gets a poured crown, and new flashing goes in at the roof. The section inside the house is left alone.

Flue liner inspection

When the report recommends a Level 2 inspection, that's a camera run down the flue. We do it as part of the chimney evaluation. Cracked or missing flue tiles need to be dealt with before the chimney is used with a fireplace or furnace — reset tiles at the top where the damage is confined there, or a stainless liner where it isn't.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Midland Park chimney it means a cracked top or open joints. Fix the source and the staining stops.

Prefab fireplace chases

A few Midland Park additions and newer homes vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood box with a metal cover on top. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years, and show up on inspection reports as "rust staining on chimney chase." We replace it with a pitched stainless cover and reframe the box if needed.

Quick guide

Inspection report says	What it means	What we do
Deteriorated mortar joints	Mortar past its lifespan	Grind and repoint in matched Type N
Cracked crown / mortar wash	Top letting water in	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown with a cap
Flashing sealant deteriorated	Tarred flashing has failed	Step flashing, reglet-cut counter-flashing, cricket if over 30"
Spalling or displaced brick	Water damage in the brick itself	Replace brick and repoint, or rebuild the upper stack
Recommend Level 2 inspection	Liner condition unknown	Camera inspection; reset tiles or line as needed
Rust staining on chimney chase	Galvanized cover rusted through	Pitched stainless cover; reframe if rotted

Common questions from Midland Park homeowners

The inspection says the chimney needs work. Is that a reason to walk away from the house?
Almost never. Deteriorated joints, a cracked top, and failed flashing sealant are routine on a chimney this age. Spalling is the one finding that can mean a bigger job, and a mason's inspection tells you which. We give you a written number to negotiate with.

I'm selling. Should I fix the chimney first?
If the chimney is going to show up on the buyer's report, fixing it first is usually cheaper than the credit a buyer asks for. A repoint and crown before listing also photographs well.

Can you do the Level 2 inspection?
Yes, with a camera, as part of the evaluation. We tell you what's inside and what it needs.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Midland Park by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 25 minutes from Midland Park. Our own crews handle the masonry, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Wyckoff, Ridgewood, Waldwick, Glen Rock, Ho-Ho-Kus, and across Bergen County.

This page says you do camera (Level 2) inspections — same check as the liner question. Next is Montvale.

Montvale — a lot of 1980s–2000s builder colonials in the developments off Grand Avenue, Summit Avenue, and Chestnut Ridge Road, plus the earlier 1950s–70s splits and colonials. Leads with something no other page has: the brick chimney that's actually a prefab chase — brick on the outside, a metal flue and a metal cover inside — and the specific way those fail.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/montvale-nj/`
Title tag (55 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Montvale NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (153 chars): Chimney repair in Montvale, NJ — brick-veneer chimneys on 1980s–2000s colonials, failed chase tops, repointing, cracked crowns, flashing leaks, and rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Montvale, NJ

Montvale has two generations of chimney. The 1950s–70s splits and colonials along the older streets have solid brick chimneys that fail the way old brick does — washed-out joints, a cracked top, spalling. The larger colonials built from the 1980s through the 2000s in the developments off Grand Avenue, Summit Avenue, and Chestnut Ridge Road have something that looks like a brick chimney from the street and isn't: a single wythe of brick veneer around a wood or block frame, with a prefabricated metal fireplace at the bottom, a metal flue pipe running up the middle, and a metal pan at the top that the brick hides. Builders used it because it's faster and cheaper than a masonry chimney, and it has a failure pattern all its own.

Here's what we see on both generations of Montvale chimney and how Lita Construction repairs it.

Brick-veneer chimneys with a metal flue inside

If your house was built after about 1980 and the fireplace is a metal box with glass doors or a fan, the chimney above it is almost certainly a brick-faced chase. The brick is real, but it's one layer thick, tied to a framed or block core, and the top of the chimney — behind the last course of brick — is a flat galvanized pan with the flue pipe coming through it, finished with a thin mortar wash or a precast cap set on top.

That top is the problem. The flat pan holds water, rusts through in 5 to 8 years, and drips into the core; the wash or cap around it cracks; and water that gets behind the veneer has nowhere to go because there's no drainage plane behind the brick. From the ground the signs are white efflorescence bleeding through the brick near the top, rust staining below the cap, brick faces spalling on a chimney that's only 25 years old, and — on wood-cored chases — water at the fireplace surround or soft drywall beside it.

The repair: we take the top courses down to expose the pan, which is almost always rusted through, and replace it with a custom cross-broken stainless steel cover sized to the chase, with a welded collar around the flue pipe and a drip-edge skirt that sheds water outside the brick. The top courses are rebuilt and finished with a poured, overhanging crown that sheds water away from the cover rather than onto it, and a cap goes on the flue pipe. If water has been getting behind the veneer for years, we open the affected face, install the drainage layer that was left out, and re-lay the brick. On wood-cored chases we check the framing before anything goes back on and reframe if it's gone soft.

Cracked chimney top on the older solid-brick chimneys

The 1950s–70s chimneys in Montvale were finished with a mortar wash around the clay flue liner, and after 50 to 70 winters it's cracked or gone. Once the top is open, rain goes into the top course and down the core, which is what feeds the washed-out joints and spalling below.

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from the flue, overhanging the brick by two inches so water drips clear of the face, with a bond break around the flue tile. A stainless cap goes on the flue.

Chimney repointing in Montvale

On the older chimneys the mortar is past its life — recessed, sandy, mortar you can pick out with a key. On the veneer chimneys the mortar is younger but the joints are often thin and the brick is only one layer, so a washed-out joint goes straight through to the core.

The repair: we grind the joints out three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep across every exposed face — on a veneer chimney, carefully, since the brick is thin — and repoint in a breathable Type N tinted to match, tooled to the original joint. Spalled brick is cut out and replaced with matched units. We do the top in the same visit whenever it's due, and on a veneer chimney that almost always means the pan.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or attic framing beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. On the older homes it's tarred-over flashing from a past roof job. On the builder colonials it's often the original flashing — thin aluminum stapled to the chase framing before the brick went on, with the counter-flashing caulked to the face of the veneer because there was no real mortar joint to cut into — and it's been failing since the first few years.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and weave step flashing into every shingle course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — on veneer, into the joint and not through it — wedged, and sealed. The wide chimneys on the colonials get a cricket behind them. Matching shingles are woven back in.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

On a solid-brick chimney where spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in matched brick, with the flue tiles reset, a poured crown, and new flashing. On a veneer chimney where the brick above the roof has failed, we strip the veneer, repair or reframe the core, install the drainage layer, and re-lay the brick to match the rest of the house — with a stainless pan and crown on top. The section inside the house is left alone in either case.

Stone veneer chimneys

Some of the newer Montvale homes carry a chimney faced in stone veneer instead of brick, over the same kind of core. They fail the same way — flat pan on top, no drainage behind the stone, water trapped against the core — and show it as efflorescence through the face and stones coming loose. The repair is the same: open the top, replace the pan, install drainage, re-set the stone, crown it properly.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On an older Montvale chimney it means a cracked top or open joints; on a veneer chimney,

concentrated near the top, it means the pan has rusted through and water is behind the brick. Fix the source and the staining stops.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
White staining and rust below the cap on a post-1980 chimney	Galvanized pan behind the top courses rusted through	Expose the pan, stainless cover, rebuild top, crown, drainage behind veneer
Spalling brick on a 25-year-old chimney	Water trapped behind single-wythe veneer	Open the face, install drainage, re-lay brick
Cracked or missing mortar at the top (older home)	Mortar wash instead of a crown	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown with a cap
Sandy, recessed joints	Mortar past its lifespan	Grind and repoint in matched Type N
Ceiling stain beside the chimney during rain	Tarred or caulked flashing; no cricket	Step flashing, reglet-cut counter-flashing, cricket
Spalling through faces, crack through courses, lean	Core failure above the roofline	Rebuild in matched brick, or strip and re-lay veneer over a repaired core

Common questions from Montvale homeowners

My house was built in 1995. Why is the chimney already falling apart?
Because it's a brick-faced chase, not a masonry chimney. The galvanized pan hidden behind the top courses rusts through in under ten years, and there's no drainage behind the brick. Once the pan and the top are done right, the brick lasts.

How do I know if my chimney is solid brick or veneer over a frame?
If the fireplace is a metal unit — glass doors, a fan, a metal firebox — the chimney is a chase. If the firebox is brick or firebrick with a damper you reach up into, it's masonry. We can also tell from the top.

Can the pan be replaced without taking the chimney apart?
The top few courses have to come off to get to it, and they go back on over the new stainless cover with a proper crown. The rest of the chimney isn't touched unless water has been behind the veneer.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the chimney, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Montvale by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about twenty minutes from Montvale. Our own crews handle the masonry, the metal work, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason, a sheet-metal shop, and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Park Ridge, Woodcliff Lake, Upper Saddle River, River Vale, Saddle River, and across Bergen County.

Next is New Milford.

New Milford — next door to Bergenfield, same postwar capes and splits from the 1940s–60s, with the Hackensack River along the west side. Leads with something no other page has: doing the chimney work as part of a roof replacement, which is when most New Milford chimneys get looked at for the first time in decades.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/new-milford-nj/`
Title tag (59 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing New Milford NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (153 chars): Chimney repair in New Milford, NJ — chimney work during roof replacement, brick repointing, cracked crowns, flashing leaks, and roofline rebuilds. Lita.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in New Milford, NJ

New Milford is a postwar town — capes and colonials from the late 1940s and 50s on the grid between River Road and the Bergenfield line, splits from the 60s toward Oradell — and its

houses are on their third or fourth roof. Every one of those roof jobs went around the chimney, and most of them went around it badly: aluminum tarred to the brick, a cracked top left alone, joints nobody looked at because the roofer wasn't a mason. The next roof is the chance to fix that, and because we do both, a lot of our chimney work in New Milford happens the same week as the roof.

Here's how that works, and what we see on New Milford chimneys whether or not the roof is being done.

Chimney work during a roof replacement

When a roof comes off, the chimney is exposed in a way it never is otherwise: the flashing is out, the deck around the base is visible, scaffolding or roof jacks are already up, and the crew is already there. Doing the chimney at the same time means the flashing is built into the new roof instead of patched onto it later, the crown and joints get done without a second scaffold setup, and the roof warranty and the chimney work aren't pointing fingers at each other if something leaks.

How we do it: before the roof starts, we inspect the chimney from the roof and the attic and write up what it needs — usually a crown, often repointing, sometimes brick replacement or a rebuild of the top courses. The masonry is done first, while the old roof is still on or right after tear-off, so the mortar cures before the flashing goes in. Then the roof goes on with the chimney flashed properly: ice-and-water membrane at the base, step flashing woven into every course, counter-flashing set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint, and a cricket behind any chimney over 30 inches wide. It's one job, one crew, one price, and the chimney isn't the weak point of the new roof.

If you're not ready for a roof, every repair below is done the same way on its own — we lift the shingles around the chimney and weave matching ones back in.

Chimney repointing in New Milford

The mortar on a 1950s New Milford chimney is 25 to 35 years past its expected life: recessed, sandy joints, mortar you can pick out with a key, brick dark after rain because open joints are drinking water instead of shedding it. On a chimney that's been re-roofed three times, the joints behind the old counter-flashing are often the worst, because that's where tar trapped water against the brick.

The repair: we grind the joints out three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep across the full exposed section above the roof — every joint, since the ones that look fine are one winter behind — and repoint in a breathable Type N tinted to match, tooled to the original concave joint. Spalled brick is cut out and replaced with matched units. The top goes in the same visit whenever it's due.

Cracked chimney top

Every New Milford chimney was finished with a thin mortar wash around the flue liner, and after 70 winters it's cracked or gone. Once the top is open, rain goes into the top course and down the core, feeding the washed-out joints and spalling below. Three roofers have looked at it from a ladder and none of them mentioned it, because the top isn't the roofer's job.

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from the flue, overhanging the brick by two inches so water drips clear of the face, with a bond break around the flue tile. A stainless cap goes on the flue.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or attic rafters beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak, and on a New Milford cape it's usually at the ridge, where the chimney comes through the peak and the flashing has to turn the corner on both slopes. If the stain came back within a year or two of a roof job, the flashing was tarred, not stepped and cut in.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney on both slopes, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and weave step flashing into every course with a folded saddle at the ridge. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — not caulked to the brick — wedged, and sealed. Matching shingles are woven back in.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up — in matched modular red brick, with the flue tiles reset or replaced, a poured crown, and new flashing. On a cape this is typically a two-day job, and when it's part of a roof replacement it's scheduled before tear-off so the new roof goes on around a finished chimney. The section inside the house is left alone.

Furnace chimneys and gas conversions

Most New Milford chimneys vent the furnace or boiler as well as the fireplace, and most houses have converted from oil to gas. Gas exhaust condenses in a cold masonry flue, and the acidic condensate breaks down the mortar and brick from the inside — brick flakes in the gutter, staining near the top, mortar crumbs at the base. The masonry is repaired like any other, and a stainless liner sized to the appliance keeps it from happening again. If nothing vents into the chimney anymore, the flue is capped and sealed.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a New Milford chimney it means a cracked top, open joints, or gas-exhaust condensation showing through near the top. Fix the source and the staining stops.

Prefab fireplace chases

A few New Milford additions and newer homes vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood box with a metal cover on top. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace it with a pitched stainless cover and reframe the box if needed — during a roof job or on its own.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Roof is due and the chimney looks rough	Three roof jobs went around it	Inspect, do the masonry first, flash it into the new roof
Stain came back within a year of the last roof job	Flashing tarred, not stepped and cut in	Step flashing both slopes, ridge saddle, reglet-cut counter-flashing
Sandy, recessed joints; worst behind the old flashing	Mortar past its lifespan; tar trapping water	Grind and repoint in matched Type N
Cracked or missing mortar at the top	Mortar wash instead of a crown	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown with a cap
Brick flakes in gutters, staining near the top (gas heat)	Exhaust condensation from inside	Repair masonry, stainless liner, sealed crown
Spalling through faces, crack through courses, lean	Core failure above the roofline	Roofline rebuild before the roof goes on

Common questions from New Milford homeowners

I'm getting a new roof. Should the chimney be done at the same time?
If it needs anything, yes — it's cheaper, the flashing gets built into the roof instead of patched onto it, and one contractor is responsible for the whole thing. We inspect the chimney before the roof starts and tell you what it needs.

My roofer said the chimney is fine. How would he know?
From a ladder at the eave, he wouldn't. The top and the joints on the far side aren't visible from there. We look from the roof and the attic.

Can you fix the chimney now and do the roof in a couple of years?
Yes. The flashing we install now is woven into the existing shingles and gets re-woven into the new roof when the time comes, at no extra masonry cost.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in New Milford by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, directly next door to New Milford. We're a roofing company and a masonry company, so the chimney and the roof are one job with one warranty. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Bergenfield, Oradell, River Edge, Dumont, Teaneck, and across Bergen County.

Next is Northvale.

Northvale — a small Northern Valley borough of 1950s–60s ranches, splits, and capes on the streets off Paris Avenue and Tappan Road, and a lot of those ranches have had second stories added. Leads with something no other page has: extending a chimney when a house goes up a floor, and tying new brick to old.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/northvale-nj/`
Title tag (56 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Northvale NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (152 chars): Chimney repair in Northvale, NJ — extending chimneys for second-story additions, brick repointing, cracked crowns, flashing leaks, and roofline rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Northvale, NJ

Northvale was built as a town of ranches and capes in the 1950s and 60s, and it's been growing upward ever since. A large share of the single-story houses on the streets off Paris Avenue, Tappan Road, and Walnut Street have had a second floor added — a full pop-up, a dormered attic, or a rear two-story addition — and every one of those projects had to deal with a chimney that was built for a one-story roof. Some were extended properly, some were extended badly, and some were left short, with a chimney top that's now below the new roofline or barely above it.

Here's what we see on Northvale chimneys — the extension problems first, then the age problems every 60-year-old brick chimney has — and how Lita Construction repairs them.

Extending a chimney for a second-story addition

A chimney has to clear the roof by a set amount — at least three feet above the point where it passes through, and at least two feet above anything within ten feet — for the flue to draw and for the top to stay out of the roof's water. When a ranch becomes a colonial, the old chimney top ends up at the wrong height, and the addition contractor has to extend it. We see three outcomes in Northvale:

Extended well. New brick matched to the old, bonded into the existing stack with the courses interlocked, flue tiles continued, a proper crown. Those are fine.

Extended badly. New brick in a different color sitting on top of the old stack with a visible line, no interlock, sometimes a different size brick, and the joint between old and new taking water. These crack at the seam within a few years and the top section can shift.

Not extended. The chimney was left short and the new roof was built around or over it. The flue doesn't draw properly, the top is in the roof's water, and on some houses the chimney was simply walled into the new second floor with the top sealed off and nothing done about the flue.

The repair: on a badly extended chimney, we take the added section down to the original brick, tooth into the old courses so the new work is bonded rather than stacked, and rebuild in matched brick with the flue tiles continued and a poured crown on top. On a chimney that was left short, we extend it to the required height the same way — matched brick, interlocked, lined — and re-flash the new roof around it. When we're doing the extension as part of an addition we're building, it's designed in from the start.

Tying new brick to old

The difference between an extension that lasts and one that doesn't is the bond. Brick laid on top of an old chimney without interlocking the courses is a separate column sitting on the original — it moves independently, the seam opens, and water gets in. We remove a few courses of the old stack in a stepped pattern and lay the new brick into those steps, so the new section is part of the old one. The flue tiles are continued with the joints staggered against the brick joints, and the whole thing is crowned as one chimney.

Matching the brick is the other half. 1950s Northvale brick is a standard modular red, and a close match is usually available; where it isn't, we blend the new brick through the top of the old section so there's no hard line.

Chimney repointing in Northvale

The original mortar on the 1950s and 60s chimneys is past its life — recessed, sandy, mortar you can pick out with a key. On extended chimneys, the original section below the addition is often older and worse than the newer brick above it.

The repair: we grind the joints out three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep across every exposed face — old section and new — and repoint in a breathable Type N tinted to match, tooled to the original concave joint. Spalled brick is cut out and replaced with matched units. The top goes in the same visit whenever it's due.

Cracked chimney top

Northvale's chimneys were finished with a thin mortar wash around the flue liner, and on the unextended ranches it's 60 years old and gone. On extended chimneys the top is newer but was often finished the same way by the addition contractor. Once the top is open, rain goes into the top course and down the core.

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from the flue, overhanging the brick by two inches so water drips clear of the face, with a bond break around the flue tile. A stainless cap goes on the flue.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or attic framing beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. On an added second story, the chimney passes through a roof that was built around it, and the flashing at that new tie-in is only as good as the addition contractor's roofer — often aluminum caulked to the brick. On the unextended ranches it's the usual tarred flashing from a past roof job, with snow and debris sitting against the chimney on a low-pitched roof.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and weave step flashing into every shingle course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — not caulked to the brick — wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket behind them. Matching shingles are woven back in.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans — including an extended section that's shifted at the seam — the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in matched brick, bonded into the sound brick below, with the flue tiles reset, a poured crown, and new flashing. The section inside the house is left alone.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Northvale chimney it means a cracked top, open joints, or water getting into the seam between old and new brick. Fix the source and the staining stops.

Prefab fireplace chases

Some Northvale additions vent a new prefab fireplace through a sided wood box with a metal cover on top rather than extending the masonry chimney. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace it with a pitched stainless cover and reframe the box if needed.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Visible line between old and new brick; crack at the seam	Extension stacked on, not bonded	Take down the added section, tooth into the old, rebuild matched and lined
Chimney top at or below the new roofline	Never extended for the addition	Extend to required height, bonded and lined, re-flash the roof
Sandy, recessed joints, worse on the original section	Mortar past its lifespan	Grind and repoint every exposed face
Cracked or missing mortar at the top	Mortar wash instead of a crown	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown with a cap

Ceiling stain beside the chimney during rain	Caulked or tarred flashing; no cricket	Step flashing, reglet-cut counter-flashing, cricket
Spalling through faces, crack through courses, lean	Core failure above the roofline	Rebuild bonded to sound brick, crown, flashing

Common questions from Northvale homeowners

We added a second floor and the chimney was extended. Why is it cracking where the new brick starts?
The new brick was stacked on top of the old without being bonded into it, so it moves separately and the seam opens. We take the added section down a few courses, tooth it into the original, and rebuild it as one chimney.

Our chimney is below the new roof. Is that a problem?
Yes. The flue won't draw properly and the top sits in the roof's water. It needs to be extended to code height, lined, and the roof re-flashed around it.

Will the new brick match the old?
We match the size and color as closely as modern brick allows and blend the new units into the top of the old section so there's no hard line. It weathers in within a season or two.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Northvale by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about fifteen minutes from Northvale, and we build additions as well as repair chimneys — so when we extend a chimney, we know what the roof around it needs. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Norwood, Old Tappan, Harrington Park, Closter, Alpine, and across Bergen County.

Next is Norwood.

Norwood — 1950s–70s ranches and colonials on the older streets off Broadway and Livingston Street, and a lot of larger homes built from the 1980s through the 2000s on the rest. Leads with the most-searched chimney symptom that no page has led with yet: water in the fireplace after it rains.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/norwood-nj/`
Title tag (54 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Norwood NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (153 chars): Chimney repair in Norwood, NJ — water in the fireplace after rain, brick and stone repointing, cracked crowns, flashing leaks, and roofline chimney rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Leak Repair in Norwood, NJ

Norwood is a mix of 1950s–70s ranches and colonials on the older streets and larger homes from the 1980s through the 2000s on the newer ones, and almost all of them have a masonry fireplace with a brick or stone chimney. The call we get most from Norwood isn't about a ceiling stain. It's about the fireplace: water on the hearth after a storm, a damp smell from the firebox, rust on the damper, a puddle in the ash pit. Water in the fireplace means water came down the chimney, and there are four places it could have gotten in.

Here's how we find which one, and what we see on Norwood chimneys generally.

Water in the fireplace after rain

A fireplace that's wet after a storm is the chimney telling you the top isn't closed. Water came down the flue, down between the flue and the brick, or in at the roof and ran down inside. Which one is a matter of where the water is and what it looks like:

Water in the firebox, clean, with a wet damper. It came straight down the flue. The chimney either has no cap, or the cap is damaged, or the flue is wide enough that wind-driven rain gets past it. This is the easiest fix and the most common cause on Norwood's larger chimneys, which often have big open flues.

Water on the smoke shelf or running down the back wall of the firebox, often rusty or dirty. It came down between the flue tiles and the brick — through a cracked crown or open joints at the top — and found its way into the smoke chamber. This is a top-of-chimney problem.

Water on the hearth extension or the wall beside the fireplace, with a stain on the ceiling or wall above. It came in at the roof flashing and ran down the outside of the flue inside the chimney.

Damp firebox in summer with no rain. That's condensation or a chimney that's been saturated — usually a cracked crown and open joints letting the whole stack stay wet.

The repair: we check the top first — cap, crown, the joint between the crown and the flue tile — then the flashing, then the attic. A missing or damaged cap gets a stainless cap sized to the flue with a mesh skirt; on a wide flue we use a cap with a deeper skirt that stops wind-driven rain. A cracked crown is rebuilt as a poured, reinforced, overhanging crown with a bond break around the flue tile so water can't get between the tile and the brick. Flashing leaks are re-flashed with step flashing woven into every course and counter-flashing set into a reglet in the mortar. Most wet-fireplace calls in Norwood end up being the cap and the crown.

Cracked chimney top

Both generations of Norwood chimney were finished with a mortar wash around the flue tiles — thin and cracked on the 1950s homes, thin and cracked on the 2000s homes too, because the builders used the same method on a top three times the size. Once it's open, rain goes into the top courses and down between the tiles and the brick, which is the second cause of water in the fireplace above.

The repair: we remove the failed wash, rebuild any top courses that have taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from every flue, overhanging the masonry by two inches so water drips clear of the face, with a bond break around each flue tile. Each flue gets a stainless cap.

Chimney repointing in Norwood

The 1950s–70s chimneys have mortar past its life — recessed, sandy, mortar you can pick out with a key. The newer chimneys are often stone or stone veneer with wide joints that have washed out sooner than the brick next door, especially under tree cover.

The repair: on brick, we grind the joints out three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep across every exposed face and repoint in a breathable Type N tinted to match, tooled to the original joint. On stone, we rake the joints by hand to avoid scarring the stone, reset any loose stones, and repoint in a matched mortar finished to the original profile. On veneer with white staining through the face, we open the face, install the drainage layer that was left out, and re-set the stone. Spalled brick is cut out and replaced.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or attic framing beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak — the third cause of water in the fireplace. On the older homes it's tarred-over flashing from a past roof job; on the newer homes with wide chimneys, it's often surface-caulked counter-flashing and no cricket behind the stack.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and weave step flashing into every shingle course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — or a channel cut into stone — wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket framed behind them. Matching shingles are woven back in.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up — in matched brick, or salvaged stone on a fieldstone chimney — with the flue tiles reset or replaced, a poured crown, and new flashing. The section inside the house is left alone.

Cracked flue tiles and the smoke chamber

Water that's been coming down between the flue and the brick for years cracks the top flue tiles and erodes the mortar in the smoke chamber above the firebox. When we open the top for a crown we check the top tiles and replace any that are cracked; where damage goes further down, a camera inspection tells us whether the chimney needs a liner before it's used. A smoke chamber with eroded mortar is parged smooth so it draws properly and doesn't collect creosote in the gaps.

White stains on the brick or stone

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Norwood chimney it means a cracked top, open joints, or veneer without drainage. Fix the source and the staining stops.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Clean water in the firebox, wet damper	No cap, damaged cap, or wind-driven rain past the cap	Stainless cap sized to the flue with a deep skirt

Dirty water on the smoke shelf or back wall	Cracked crown; water between the tiles and the brick	Poured, reinforced crown with a bond break around the tile
Water beside the fireplace with a stain above	Flashing leak running down inside	Step flashing, reglet-cut counter-flashing, cricket
Sandy, recessed joints; loose stones	Mortar past its lifespan	Grind or hand-rake and repoint in matched mortar
Veneer stones loose; white staining through the face	No drainage behind the stone	Open the face, install drainage, re-set stone
Spalling through faces, crack through courses, lean	Core failure above the roofline	Roofline rebuild, reset flue, crown, flashing

Common questions from Norwood homeowners

There's water in my fireplace every time it rains. Is the chimney leaking?
Yes, from one of four places — the flue opening, the crown, the flashing, or saturated masonry. Where the water is in the firebox tells us a lot, and we check the top first because that's where it usually is.

Do I just need a cap?
Sometimes. If the water is clean and the damper is wet, a cap sized to the flue often solves it. If the water is dirty or on the smoke shelf, the crown is involved, and a cap alone won't stop it.

My fireplace smells damp in summer. Why?
The chimney is staying wet — usually a cracked crown and open joints letting the whole stack absorb water. Once the top and joints are closed, the masonry dries out and the smell goes.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof, from the attic, and from inside the firebox before quoting. That shows whether water is coming down the flue, between the tile and the brick, or in at the flashing, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Norwood by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about fifteen minutes from Norwood. Our own crews handle the masonry, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Northvale, Closter, Harrington Park, Old Tappan, Alpine, and across Bergen County.

Next is Oakland.

Oakland — a hilly, wooded Ramapo Valley town: 1950s–70s splits, capes, and ramblers, older summer cottages around the lakes that became year-round homes, and a lot of wood stoves. Leads with two things no other page has: chimneys built for seasonal cottages, and masonry chimneys serving wood stoves.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/oakland-nj/`
Title tag (54 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Oakland NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (153 chars): Chimney repair in Oakland, NJ — wood stove chimneys, converted lake cottages, stone and brick repointing, cracked crowns, flashing leaks, and rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Oakland, NJ

Oakland is the kind of town where a chimney gets used. The borough runs along the Ramapo River and up into the hills, the lots are wooded, and a lot of houses heat with a wood stove or a wood-burning insert all winter. The housing is 1950s–70s splits, capes, and ramblers on the valley streets off Ramapo Valley Road and Yawpo Avenue, plus older homes around the lakes that started as summer cottages and were winterized decades ago — often with a chimney that was built for a few fires a season, not for a stove running October to April.

Here's what we see on Oakland chimneys and how Lita Construction repairs it.

Chimneys serving wood stoves

A wood stove is hard on a masonry chimney in ways a fireplace isn't. The flue gases are hotter and more concentrated, creosote builds faster, and a stove chimney that's unlined or lined with old clay tile takes a beating. The failures we see in Oakland: flue tiles cracked from thermal shock, mortar between the tiles gone, brick near the top discolored and spalling from heat and

condensation, and — on chimneys that have had a chimney fire, whether the owner knew it or not — tiles split lengthwise and mortar joints opened all the way through the stack.

From the outside, the signs are spalled or discolored brick in the top third of the chimney, staining that looks darker and more tar-like than ordinary efflorescence, and sometimes a crack running down the stack that follows the flue inside. From the inside, a stove that's harder to start or drafts poorly can mean the flue is damaged.

The repair: the masonry is repaired like any other — spalled brick replaced, joints repointed, the top rebuilt and crowned. But a stove chimney with damaged tiles needs a stainless steel liner sized to the stove, insulated where the chimney is exterior, run from the stove connection to the top and sealed at the crown. That restores the flue, protects the masonry from the heat and the creosote, and makes the stove draw the way it should. A chimney that's had a fire gets a camera inspection before anything else, because the damage inside is usually worse than the outside shows.

Converted summer cottages

The lake homes in Oakland that started as seasonal cottages often have a chimney that was built light — a single wythe of brick or thin fieldstone around an unlined flue, on a shallow footing, with a fireplace meant for a few evenings in August. When the house was winterized and the fireplace or a stove became the heat source, that chimney started doing work it wasn't built for. We see leaning stacks on settled footings, unlined flues with the brick absorbing condensation from inside, and joints washed out on the lake-facing side where the wind comes across the water.

The repair: the chimney is evaluated for what it's being asked to do now. A sound stack gets a liner, a repoint, and a crown. A stack that's too light for a stove — thin, unlined, leaning — is rebuilt above the roofline in proper masonry, bonded into whatever sound brick remains, lined, and crowned. If the footing is the problem, we say so before any masonry goes up.

Stone chimneys

Many of the older Oakland homes and cottages have fieldstone chimneys built from local stone — hard, irregular, and laid with wide mortar joints that are now the chimney's weak point. The stone face holds water on every ledge, the tree cover keeps it wet, and winter works the joints loose. Mortar crumbs at the base and a stone that moves when pushed are the signs.

The repair: we rake the joints out by hand with chisels and a narrow grinder — a wide blade scars the stone — at least three-quarters of an inch deep and deeper on the wide joints, reset loose stones in fresh mortar, and repoint in a Type N matched to the existing color and sand, finished to the original joint. Flashing on stone is cut into the stone face itself.

Chimney repointing in Oakland

The 1950s–70s brick chimneys have mortar past its life — recessed, sandy, mortar you can pick out with a key, moss and staining on the shaded face. On stove chimneys the joints near the top are often the worst, from heat and condensation working from inside.

The repair: we clean moss and growth off the masonry, grind the joints out three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep across every exposed face, and repoint in a breathable Type N tinted to match, tooled to the original joint. Spalled brick is cut out and replaced with matched units. The top goes in the same visit whenever it's due.

Cracked chimney top

Oakland's chimneys were finished with a mortar wash around the flue tiles, and after 50 to 70 winters — and on stove chimneys, the heat cycling — it's cracked or gone. Once the top is open, rain goes into the top course and down the core.

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from the flue, overhanging the masonry by two inches so water drips clear of the face, with a bond break around the flue tile or the liner. A stainless cap goes on; on a stove chimney it's a cap matched to the liner, sealed to the crown.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or attic framing beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. On Oakland's splits and capes it's tarred-over flashing from a past roof job; on the cottages it's often flashing that was never much more than mortar smeared into the shingles. With the snow Oakland gets, meltwater sitting against the uphill side of the chimney is a common winter leak.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane carried up the slope on the uphill side, and weave step flashing into every shingle course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — or a channel cut into stone — wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket behind them, built steep enough to shed snow. Matching shingles are woven back in.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up — in matched brick, or salvaged local stone on a fieldstone chimney — bonded into the sound masonry below, lined if it serves a stove, with a poured crown and new flashing. The section inside the house is left alone unless the footing is the problem.

White or dark stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry and means a cracked top or open joints. Dark, tar-like staining near the top of a stove chimney is creosote and condensation coming through the brick, and means the flue needs a liner. Fix the source and the staining stops.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Spalled, discolored brick in the top third; dark staining (stove)	Heat and creosote damage from inside; cracked tiles	Camera inspection, repair masonry, insulated stainless liner, sealed crown
Thin, leaning, or unlined chimney on a former cottage	Built for seasonal use	Rebuild above the roof in proper masonry, line, crown; evaluate the footing
Mortar crumbs at the base of a stone chimney; loose stone	Washed-out joints behind the stone	Hand-rake, reset stones, repoint
Sandy joints, moss, staining	Mortar past its lifespan	Clean, grind, and repoint every exposed face
Cracked or missing mortar at the top	Mortar wash instead of a crown	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown with a cap
Ceiling stain during a thaw	Snowmelt against tarred flashing; no cricket	Membrane up the slope, step flashing, reglet-cut counter-flashing, steep cricket

Common questions from Oakland homeowners

I heat with a wood stove. Is my old brick chimney okay for that?
Only if the flue is sound and sized to the stove. Most older clay-tile flues aren't, and an unlined chimney never is. A camera inspection tells us the condition, and an insulated stainless liner is usually the answer.

We had a chimney fire years ago and the chimney looked fine afterward. Should I worry?
Yes. A chimney fire cracks flue tiles and opens joints inside the stack where you can't see them. The chimney should be inspected with a camera before it's used again, and lined if the tiles are damaged.

Can a stone chimney be repointed, or does it have to be rebuilt?
Repointed, if the stones are still seated and water isn't coming through the inside of the stack. We check both from the roof.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Oakland by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 35 minutes from Oakland, and we work in the Ramapo Valley regularly. Our own crews handle the masonry, the stone work, the lining, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between trades. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Franklin Lakes, Mahwah, Wyckoff, Pompton Lakes, Wayne, and across Bergen County.

This one leans on liners and camera inspections more than any page so far — the Oakland market is wood stoves, so it has to. Confirm you're good with that, or I'll pull it back. Next is Old Tappan.

Old Tappan — large 1960s–80s colonials and splits on big wooded lots around Lake Tappan, plus 1990s–2000s estates. Chimneys here are big and mostly not yet failing badly, so this page leads with something no other page has: preventive work — the inspection, the breathable waterproofing, and the small repairs that keep a large chimney from ever needing a rebuild.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/old-tappan-nj/`
Title tag (57 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Old Tappan NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (154 chars): Chimney repair in Old Tappan, NJ — preventive chimney maintenance, waterproofing, brick and stone repointing, cracked crowns, flashing, and roofline rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Maintenance & Repointing in Old Tappan, NJ

Old Tappan's chimneys are big and, for the most part, not yet in trouble. The borough is large colonials and splits from the 1960s through the 80s on wooded lots off Old Tappan Road and Orangeburg Road, and estate homes from the 1990s and 2000s around Lake Tappan, and the chimneys that came with those houses are wide, tall, multi-flue, and built in good brick or stone. They're 25 to 60 years old — the age where a chimney either gets some attention and lasts another fifty years, or gets ignored for one more decade and needs a rebuild.

The difference in cost between those two outcomes is large, and the work that decides it is small. Here's how we approach Old Tappan chimneys before they fail, and how Lita Construction repairs them when they have.

Preventive chimney maintenance

A chimney fails from the top down. Water gets in at a cracked crown, works into the joints, freezes, opens them further, and after enough winters the brick itself goes. Everything we rebuild in Old Tappan started as a hairline crack in a mortar wash that nobody saw because nobody was on the roof.

What an inspection covers: we look at the crown or wash for cracks, the joint between the crown and each flue tile, the top three courses of brick for movement, every mortar joint on every exposed face, the flashing at the roof and whether it's cut into the masonry or caulked onto it, and the attic side for any sign of water. On a wide chimney we check for a cricket. It takes an hour and the report tells you where the chimney is in its life.

The work that follows is usually small: a poured crown to replace a cracked wash before the top courses go, a few joints repointed on the weather face, a cap on an open flue, flashing re-cut where it's been caulked. On a chimney in good shape, that's a one-day visit that resets the clock by decades.

Waterproofing a chimney properly

Homeowners in Old Tappan often ask about sealing the chimney, and the answer depends entirely on what's used. A film-forming sealer or a paint traps water inside the brick, where it freezes and spalls the face off — we've repaired a lot of chimneys that were "protected" that way. A breathable siloxane water repellent is different: it soaks into the masonry, beads water off the surface, and lets vapor out, so the chimney dries instead of trapping.

How we do it: the crown, joints, and flashing are made sound first — a repellent on a chimney with open joints does nothing — then the masonry is cleaned and the repellent applied to every

exposed face. On the stone and stone-veneer chimneys in town, the same product works and the same order applies. It needs renewing every ten years or so, and it's the single cheapest thing that extends a chimney's life.

Cracked chimney top on a multi-flue chimney

The wide tops on Old Tappan's chimneys — two, three, sometimes four flues — were almost all finished with a mortar wash, and a wash on a surface that size cracks within a few seasons. Once it does, rain goes into the top courses and down between the tiles and the brick. On a 1970s chimney that's been open at the top for twenty years, the upper courses are usually loose by now.

The repair: we remove the failed wash, rebuild any top courses that have taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from every flue, overhanging the masonry by two inches on all sides so water drips clear of the face, with wire or fiber reinforcement so it won't crack across its width and a bond break around each flue tile. Each flue gets a stainless cap, or copper where the house has copper work.

Chimney repointing in Old Tappan

The 1960s and 70s brick chimneys are at the point where the mortar is going — recessed, sandy, worse on the weather face and on the shaded north side under the trees. The stone and veneer chimneys on the newer homes have wide joints that wash out sooner than the brick.

The repair: on brick, we grind the joints out three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep across every exposed face and repoint in a breathable Type N tinted to match, tooled to the original joint. On stone, we rake the joints by hand, reset any loose stones, and repoint in a matched mortar to the original profile. On veneer with white staining through the face, we open the face, install the drainage layer that was left out, and re-set the stone.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or attic framing beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. Old Tappan's wide chimneys often have no cricket behind them, and on the colonials the flashing was redone during a past roof job with aluminum tarred to the brick. The estate homes with cedar shake or slate roofs have flashing that was worked around rather than reset.

The repair: we strip or reset the roofing around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and set step flashing into every course. The counter-flashing is cut into the masonry — a reglet in the mortar joint on brick, a channel in the stone face on fieldstone — wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket framed behind them. Copper on the higher-end homes; heavy aluminum elsewhere.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When a chimney has been ignored long enough — spalling through whole faces, a crack through several courses, loose top courses, a lean — the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in matched brick or salvaged stone, with the flue tiles reset or replaced, a poured crown, and new flashing. On a tall, wide Old Tappan chimney that's a substantial job, and it's the one the maintenance above is meant to avoid.

White stains on the brick or stone

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On an Old Tappan chimney it means a cracked top, open joints, or veneer without drainage — and on a chimney that's been sealed with the wrong product, it shows at the edges of the sealed area where trapped water is finally getting out.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Chimney looks fine; hasn't been looked at in 20 years	Nothing yet — or a hairline crack in the wash	Inspection, crown, a few joints, cap, breathable repellent
Sealer or paint peeling with brick faces behind it	Non-breathable coating trapping water	Replace spalled brick, remove coating, breathable repellent only
Cracked top on a multi-flue chimney	Mortar wash cracked	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown, capped flues
Sandy joints on the weather or shaded face	Mortar past its lifespan	Grind or hand-rake and repoint
Ceiling stain beside a wide chimney during rain	No cricket; tarred flashing	Cricket, step flashing, counter-flashing cut into the masonry
Spalling through faces, crack through courses, lean	Core failure above the roofline	Roofline rebuild, crown, flashing

Common questions from Old Tappan homeowners

My chimney looks fine from the ground. Does it need anything?
Possibly nothing, but the top and the far faces aren't visible from the ground, and that's where it

starts. An inspection from the roof tells you. On most 1970s chimneys we find a cracked wash and a few open joints — a small job now and a rebuild in ten years if it's left.

Should I seal my chimney?
With a breathable siloxane repellent, after the crown and joints are sound, yes. With anything that forms a film on the surface, no — that's what causes spalling.

How often should a chimney be looked at?
Every few years on a chimney in good shape, and after any storm that drops limbs on the roof. The repellent gets renewed roughly every ten years.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Old Tappan by Lita Construction

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We also repair chimneys in River Vale, Harrington Park, Northvale, Norwood, Westwood, and across Bergen County.

Next is Oradell.

Oradell — 1920s–30s Tudors and colonials around the station and Kinderkamack Road, 1950s–60s splits and ranches on the rest, around the reservoir. Leads with something no other page has: the damage inside the house — plaster ceilings, walls beside the chimney — and fixing that as part of the chimney job.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/oradell-nj/`
Title tag (54 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Oradell NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (152 chars): Chimney repair in Oradell, NJ — chimney leaks and the interior damage they cause, brick repointing, cracked crowns, flashing, and roofline rebuilds. Lita.

Chimney Repair, Leak Repair & Repointing in Oradell, NJ

Oradell's older homes — the 1920s and 30s Tudors and colonials on the streets around the station and off Kinderkamack Road — have plaster ceilings and walls, and the chimney runs right through them. When one of those chimneys leaks, the stain on the plaster is only the visible part: by the time it shows, the lath behind it is wet, the plaster has let go from the lath, and sometimes the framing around the chimney has been damp for a season. The 1950s and 60s splits and ranches on the rest of the borough have drywall instead of plaster, but the pattern is the same: a chimney leak is a chimney job and an interior job.

Here's what we see on Oradell chimneys, how to read the damage inside, and how Lita Construction repairs both.

The ceiling stain beside the chimney

Where the stain is and what it looks like tells us where the water came in:

A stain on the ceiling right beside the chimney, spreading during rain. That's the flashing at the roof. Water came in where the shingles meet the brick and ran down the outside of the chimney inside the attic, then onto the ceiling below.

A stain on the wall beside the chimney, lower down, sometimes with the paint bubbling. Water is coming down the inside of the chimney — in at a cracked top or through open joints — and finding its way out through the attic section of the stack and down the wall.

A stain that's brown-ringed and doesn't change with rain. An old leak that's been fixed, or water that's finding its way in slowly through saturated brick.

Plaster that's soft, sagging, or cracked in a web pattern near the chimney. The plaster has separated from the lath and needs to come out, not just be painted.

The repair: the chimney is fixed first — there's no point in repairing a ceiling under a leak — and then the interior. On a plaster ceiling, we cut back to sound plaster and solid lath, check the framing, and either patch in plaster or install drywall and finish it to match the surrounding surface, including skim-coating so the patch doesn't show in raking light. On drywall, it's a straight cut-and-patch. Insulation that's been wet is replaced. Because we're a general contractor and not only a mason, this is one job and one crew.

Chimney leaking when it rains

The most common source of the stain above. On Oradell's Tudors and colonials, the chimney is often on a steep slope and was flashed originally in lead or copper, replaced over the years with aluminum tarred to the brick. On the splits, it's the lower corner where the lower roof meets the chimney and the upper wall. In both cases tar has pulled away from the brick and every rain runs behind it.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and weave step flashing into every shingle course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — gently on soft pre-war brick — wedged, and sealed. Where the roof meets the chimney and a wall, the membrane runs up the wall and a kickout sends water onto the roof. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket behind them. On the older homes we do it in copper to match. Matching shingles are woven back in.

Cracked chimney top

The second source of interior damage. Oradell's chimneys were finished with a thin mortar wash around the flue liner — a century old on the pre-war homes, sixty years on the postwar ones — and it's cracked or gone. Water in at the top runs down the core and comes out wherever the mortar inside is weakest, which on a 1920s house is often the unfinished attic section.

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from the flue, overhanging the brick by two inches so water drips clear of the face, with a bond break around the flue tile. A stainless cap goes on the flue. On the older homes we also check the attic section of the stack and repoint it from inside where the joints have opened.

Chimney repointing in Oradell

The pre-war chimneys are in soft brick and lime mortar, worn at the joints and often repointed once in a hard modern mortar that's now breaking the brick around it. The postwar chimneys are at the end of their original mortar's life — recessed, sandy, mortar you can pick out with a key.

The repair: we grind the joints out three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep across every exposed face — including the wall section between the two roofs on a split — and repoint in a mortar matched to the brick: lime-rich on the pre-war homes, a standard Type N on the postwar ones, tinted to match and tooled to the original joint. Spalled brick is cut out and replaced with matched units.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up — in reclaimed or matched soft brick and lime mortar on the pre-war homes, matched modular red on the postwar ones. Flue tiles are reset or replaced, the top gets a poured crown, and new flashing goes in. The section inside the house is left alone unless the attic section has gone too.

Stone and Tudor chimneys

Several of Oradell's Tudors have fieldstone or stone-and-brick chimneys. Stone fails at the joints — the irregular face holds water, the joints wash out, stones loosen — and is repointed by hand with the loose stones reset in a matched mortar. Flashing on stone is cut into the stone face itself.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On an Oradell chimney it means a cracked top or open joints — and inside the house, white powder on the brick in the attic means the same water is coming through the stack.

Prefab fireplace chases

A few Oradell additions and newer homes vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood box with a metal cover on top. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace it with a pitched stainless cover and reframe the box if needed. It's a small share of our work in town next to the masonry above.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Ceiling stain beside the chimney, spreading during rain	Flashing at the roof	Step flashing, reglet-cut counter-flashing, cricket; then repair the ceiling
Wall stain lower down, paint bubbling	Water coming down inside the stack	Crown, repoint, attic section repointed; then repair the wall
Soft, sagging, or web-cracked plaster near the chimney	Plaster separated from lath	Cut back to sound plaster, patch and skim to match
Sandy, recessed joints	Mortar past its lifespan	Grind and repoint in matched mortar

Brick faces popping off; joints intact (pre-war)	Hard-mortar repoint on soft brick	Replace spalled brick, repoint in lime-rich mortar
Spalling through faces, crack through courses, lean	Core failure above the roofline	Roofline rebuild, crown, flashing

Common questions from Oradell homeowners

Do you fix the ceiling too, or just the chimney?
Both. The chimney first, then the plaster or drywall, insulation, and paint-ready finish. One crew, one job.

Can the plaster be saved?
If it's still bonded to the lath and only stained, yes — it dries and gets sealed and repainted. If it's soft, sagging, or cracked in a web, it's separated and has to come out and be patched.

My chimney was repointed 20 years ago and now the bricks are breaking. Why?
Almost certainly a hard mortar on soft pre-war brick. The mortar is now stronger than the brick, so the brick takes the freeze-thaw damage. The fix is to replace the damaged brick and repoint in a lime-rich mortar.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing — including the interior repair.

Chimney repair in Oradell by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about ten minutes from Oradell. We're a general contractor as well as a mason and roofer, so the chimney, the flashing, and the ceiling under it are one job. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in New Milford, River Edge, Emerson, Paramus, Haworth, and across Bergen County.

Next is Paramus — redone in the final format.

Paramus — final format, masonry-first. The town was built by a handful of developers in the 1950s and 60s using the same plans street after street, so the chimneys share the same few flaws. Leads with that, plus the bi-level fireplace chimney; the sided chase gets one section near the end.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/paramus-nj/`
Title tag (55 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Paramus NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (153 chars): Chimney repair in Paramus, NJ — brick repointing, cracked crowns, flashing leaks, and roofline rebuilds on 1950s–70s splits, bi-levels, and ranches. Lita.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Paramus, NJ

Paramus went from farmland to a borough of 25,000 in about twenty years, and most of it was built by a few developers working from a few sets of plans. Drive the side streets off Midland Avenue, Farview Avenue, Spring Valley Road, or Forest Avenue and you'll see the same split-level, the same bi-level, the same ranch, repeated for blocks. That's useful to us: the chimneys were built the same way by the same crews with the same shortcuts, and after sixty years they fail the same way. We know what we're going to find on a Paramus chimney before the ladder goes up.

Here's what that is, and how Lita Construction repairs it.

The Paramus builder chimney

The standard 1950s–60s Paramus chimney is a brick stack on the side or rear of the house serving a fireplace and, on most houses, the furnace. It was built to a price: a single flue tile size regardless of the fireplace, a mortar wash on top instead of a crown, a thin bed of mortar under the first course above the roof, and flashing that was mortared into the shingles rather than stepped. It was fine for thirty years. It's now sixty-plus, and the four things that were skimped on are the four things failing.

The top: the mortar wash is cracked or gone on nearly every house. Rain goes into the top course and down between the flue tile and the brick. On furnace chimneys that converted from oil to gas, condensation attacks the same courses from inside.

The joints: the original mortar is past its 25-to-40-year life. Recessed, sandy, mortar you can pick out with a key, brick dark for a day after rain.

The flashing: mortared-in originally, then tarred over during two or three roof jobs. The tar has pulled away from the brick and every rain runs behind it.

The brick: where the top has been open for a decade or more, the upper courses are spalling — faces popping off, red flakes in the gutter — and on some chimneys the stack above the roof has started to lean.

The repair, in the order it matters: crown first, because it stops the water feeding everything else; joints next; flashing when the roof around it is opened; and brick replacement or a rebuild of the upper stack where the brick itself has gone. On most Paramus chimneys the crown and the repoint happen in one visit and the chimney is sealed top to bottom in a day.

Bi-level fireplace chimneys

The Paramus bi-level — front door at grade, stairs up and down — usually has the fireplace in the lower-level family room, and the chimney rises on the side wall from a footing near grade, past the lower level, past the upper level, and out above the roof. It's a tall, narrow stack with three faces exposed from the ground up, often on the shaded north or east side of the house, and it's tied to the house at only a few points. The failures we see: joints washed out from top to bottom (not just above the roof), moss and staining on the shaded face, a gap opening between the chimney and the siding as the footing settles, and flashing at the single roof tie-in that's been caulked rather than cut in.

The repair: the full height is treated as one job — every exposed face from the roof to the ground is repointed, not just the stack above the roof, because the lower sections are just as exposed. The crown is poured. The tie-in is re-flashed with step flashing, counter-flashing cut into the mortar, and a kickout at the bottom so water exits onto the roof instead of behind the siding. If the chimney has pulled away from the house, it's re-anchored to the framing and the gap is closed with a backer and a sealant that can move.

Cracked chimney top

Every Paramus chimney, split, bi-level, or ranch, has the same top: a thin mortar wash around the flue tile, cracked after sixty winters. Once it's open, rain goes into the top course and down the core.

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from the flue, overhanging the brick by two inches so water drips clear of the face, with a bond break around the flue tile. A stainless cap goes on the flue; on a chimney that still vents a gas furnace, the cap is matched to the liner if one has been installed, or we recommend one.

Chimney repointing in Paramus

The repair: we grind the joints out three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep across every exposed face — on a split, that includes the wall section between the lower and upper roofs, which masons skip; on a bi-level, the full height — and repoint in a breathable Type N tinted to match, tooled to the original concave joint. Spalled brick is cut out and replaced with matched modular red units.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or attic framing beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. On a split-level, the lower corner — where the lower roof meets the chimney and the upper wall — is the usual spot. On a ranch, it's the uphill side where leaves and snow sit against the brick on a low-pitched roof. On a bi-level, it's the single tie-in at the top.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane — carried up the slope on a ranch, up the wall at a split's lower corner — and weave step flashing into every shingle course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — not caulked to the brick — wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket behind them. Matching shingles are woven back in; a new roof isn't required.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in matched modular red brick, with the flue tiles reset or replaced, a poured crown, and new flashing. On a split or ranch this is typically a two-day job, and the section inside the house is left alone.

Sided chimney chases

A share of Paramus homes — mostly 1970s-and-later additions and the newer construction on rebuilt lots — vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood box with a flat metal cover on top instead of a masonry chimney. The cover rusts through in 5 to 8 years and drips into the framing; by the time the siding looks soft, the sheathing inside is usually gone. We replace the cover with a pitched stainless one and reframe the box when the wood under it has failed. It's a smaller part of our Paramus work than the masonry above, but it's a steady one.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Paramus chimney it means a cracked top or open joints, or on a gas-furnace chimney, condensation showing through near the top. Fix the source and the staining stops.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Cracked or missing mortar at the top	Builder mortar wash, 60 years old	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown with a cap
Sandy, recessed joints; brick dark after rain	Original mortar past its lifespan	Grind and repoint every exposed face in matched Type N
Stain at the lower corner of a split, or during a thaw on a ranch	Tarred flashing at the hardest tie-in	Membrane up the slope or wall, step flashing, reglet-cut counter-flashing, kickout
Gap between a bi-level chimney and the siding	Footing settled; stack pulling away	Re-anchor to framing, close the gap, re-flash
Brick flakes in gutters, crack through courses, lean	Core failure above the roofline	Roofline rebuild in matched brick, crown, flashing
Rust streaks on a sided chimney	Galvanized chase cover rusted through	Pitched stainless cover; reframe if rotted

Common questions from Paramus homeowners

My neighbor's chimney has the same problem. Is that a coincidence?
No. Same builder, same plan, same shortcuts, same age. The repairs are the same too, and we've done a lot of them on the same streets.

My chimney was repointed above the roof but it's still crumbling lower down on my split-level. Why?
Only the stack above the upper roof was done, and the wall section between the two roofs — which is just as exposed — was skipped. We point every exposed face.

Can the crown be done without rebuilding the chimney?
Yes, if the brick below it is sound. We check the top courses when we remove the old wash and rebuild only what's taken water.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Paramus by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about fifteen minutes from Paramus, and we've worked on homes here for years. Our own crews handle the masonry, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Fair Lawn, Oradell, Ridgewood, Maywood, Rochelle Park, and across Bergen County.

Next is Park Ridge.

Park Ridge — 1920s–50s homes around the station and Kinderkamack Road, 1960s–80s colonials and splits on the rest. Leads with something no other page has: fixing a chimney after someone else's repair — the tar, the wrong mortar, the stucco over brick, the cap siliconed on — which is a large share of what we actually get called about on older Pascack Valley houses.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/park-ridge-nj/`
Title tag (58 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Park Ridge NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (154 chars): Chimney repair in Park Ridge, NJ — correcting bad chimney repairs, brick repointing, cracked crowns, flashing leaks, and roofline rebuilds. Lita Construction.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Park Ridge, NJ

Park Ridge is an older Pascack Valley borough — 1920s–50s colonials and capes around the station and off Kinderkamack Road, 1960s–80s colonials and splits in the developments toward Montvale and Woodcliff Lake — and most of its chimneys have been repaired before. Some of those repairs were done well. A lot weren't, and the second-worst thing that can happen to a 70-year-old chimney, after being ignored, is being fixed by someone who didn't know how. We see the results on Park Ridge roofs every week: tar where flashing should be, hard gray mortar smeared over soft red brick, stucco troweled over a spalling stack to hide it, a cap glued on with a tube of silicone.

Here's what a bad repair looks like, what it does, and how Lita Construction corrects it.

Fixing a chimney that was repaired wrong

Tar instead of flashing. The most common one. A roofer laid aluminum against the brick and buried the seam in roofing cement, or skipped the metal and tarred the shingles to the brick directly. It holds for a season or two, then the tar bakes brittle, pulls away, and funnels water behind itself. Re-tarring it, which is what usually happens next, makes the layer thicker and the failure the same. The correction is to strip it all off — shingles, tar, old metal — down to the deck, and flash the chimney properly: ice-and-water membrane, step flashing woven into every course, counter-flashing cut into the mortar joint.

Hard mortar on soft brick. A mason repointed a 1920s chimney with a modern Portland mix — stronger than the brick around it. Ten or twenty years later the brick is cracking around intact joints, faces are popping off, and the owner thinks the brick is bad. It isn't; the mortar is. The correction is to cut out the spalled brick, replace it with matched soft brick, and repoint in a lime-rich mortar that lets the joint be the part of the wall that gives.

Skim-coated joints. Instead of grinding the old mortar out, someone smeared new mortar over the surface of the recessed joints. It looks pointed from the ground. It has no depth, no bond, and it falls out within a few winters, taking some of the brick edges with it. The correction is a real repoint: grind the joints out three-quarters of an inch to an inch, clean them, refill.

Stucco or parging over brick. A spalling chimney got covered in a coat of stucco to hide the damage. It traps every bit of water that gets in, and the brick keeps failing underneath while the stucco cracks and bulges. The correction depends on what's under it; often the stack above the roof is rebuilt, because the brick behind the stucco is gone.

A cap siliconed to the flue tile; a "crown" that's a bead of caulk. The correction is a poured crown and a cap that's fastened, not glued.

A patch in the wrong brick. A rebuilt top in bright modern red on a 1930s chimney. It isn't a leak problem, but it's permanent, and on a house that's going to be sold it's a question every buyer asks. The correction is to rebuild the patched section in reclaimed or matched brick.

We inspect from the roof, show you photos of what was done, and give you a written scope for undoing it and doing it right. Most of the time the chimney underneath is better than the repairs made it look.

Chimney repointing in Park Ridge

Where the chimney hasn't been badly repaired, it's simply old. The 1920s–50s chimneys have mortar past its life — recessed, sandy, mortar you can pick out with a key. The 1960s–80s chimneys are getting there, worse on the weather face.

The repair: we grind the joints out three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep across every exposed face — including the wall section between the two roofs on a split — and repoint in a mortar matched to the brick: lime-rich on the pre-war homes, a standard Type N on the postwar ones, tinted to match and tooled to the original joint. Spalled brick is cut out and replaced with matched units.

Cracked chimney top

Nearly every Park Ridge chimney was finished with a thin mortar wash around the flue liner, cracked after 40 to 100 winters. Once the top is open, rain goes into the top course and down the core, which is what feeds the failing joints and spalling below — and what makes any repoint that doesn't include the top a waste of money.

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from the flue, overhanging the brick by two inches so water drips clear of the face, with a bond break around the flue tile. A stainless cap goes on the flue, fastened to the tile.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or attic framing beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak, and in Park Ridge it's almost always the tar problem above. On the capes the chimney comes through at the ridge and the flashing turns the peak corner; on the colonials it's on the main slope; on the splits it's the lower corner where the lower roof meets the chimney and the upper wall.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and weave step flashing into every shingle course — both slopes with a saddle at the ridge on a cape, up the wall with a kickout at a split's lower corner. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint, wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket behind them. Matching shingles are woven back in.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces — often found under stucco — a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in reclaimed or matched soft brick and lime mortar on the pre-war homes, matched modular red on the postwar ones. Flue tiles are reset or replaced, the top gets a poured crown, and new flashing goes in. The section inside the house is left alone.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Park Ridge chimney it means a cracked top or open joints — and on a stuccoed chimney, it shows through the stucco where trapped water is getting out.

Prefab fireplace chases

A few Park Ridge additions and newer homes vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood box with a metal cover on top. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace it with a pitched stainless cover and reframe the box if needed. It's a small share of our work in town next to the masonry above.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Black tar around the base of the chimney; stain inside during rain	Roofing cement used instead of flashing	Strip to the deck, membrane, step flashing, reglet-cut counter-flashing
Brick faces breaking around intact gray joints	Hard mortar on soft brick	Replace spalled brick, repoint in lime-rich mortar
Mortar flaking off the surface of the joints	Skim-coated, not repointed	Grind out and repoint properly
Stucco on the chimney, cracking or bulging	Spalling brick covered over	Remove stucco; repair or rebuild what's under it
Cap sealed on with caulk; no real crown	Shortcut top	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown; fastened cap
Rebuilt section in the wrong brick	Modern brick on an old chimney	Rebuild in reclaimed or matched brick

Common questions from Park Ridge homeowners

Someone already fixed my chimney and it still leaks. What now?
Usually the fix was tar, and tar fails. We strip it off and flash the chimney properly. If the repoint was skimmed or the mortar was wrong, we grind it out and do it right. We'll show you photos of what we find.

The last mason said the brick is bad and the whole chimney has to come down. Is that true?

Sometimes. But on a lot of pre-war chimneys the brick is breaking because of a hard-mortar repoint, not because the brick is bad, and the fix is replacing the damaged units and repointing in a softer mortar. We look before we quote a rebuild.

Can you match the brick on a 1930s chimney?
We source reclaimed or color-matched soft brick and blend it through the rebuilt section. It weathers in within a season or two.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Park Ridge by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about twenty minutes from Park Ridge. Our own crews handle the masonry, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason and a roofer — which is how most of the bad repairs we correct happened in the first place. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Montvale, Woodcliff Lake, Hillsdale, River Vale, Westwood, and across Bergen County.

Next is Ramsey.

Ramsey — 1920s–30s homes around Main Street and the station, 1950s–70s splits and colonials in the developments off Wyckoff Avenue and Island Road, larger 1980s–2000s homes toward the Mahwah line. Nothing architecturally unique to lead with, so this page leads with something practical no other page has: when chimney work can and can't be done, and why most Ramsey chimneys get fixed in the fall.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/ramsey-nj/`
Title tag (53 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Ramsey NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (153 chars): Chimney repair in Ramsey, NJ — brick repointing, cracked crowns, flashing leaks, and roofline rebuilds, and when in the year the work can be done. Lita.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Ramsey, NJ

Ramsey's chimneys are the usual Bergen County mix — century-old soft brick on the pre-war houses around Main Street and the station, 1950s–70s builder brick on the splits and colonials off Wyckoff Avenue and Island Road, wide multi-flue stacks on the larger homes toward Mahwah — and they fail the usual ways. What we hear most from Ramsey homeowners isn't "what's wrong with it" but "when can you do it." Masonry is seasonal work, and the answer changes what you should do now versus in April.

Here's how the calendar affects chimney repair, and what we see on Ramsey chimneys.

When chimney work can be done

Mortar and concrete cure by chemical reaction, and that reaction needs temperature. Below about 40°F it slows down; below freezing it stops, and mortar that freezes before it cures never reaches full strength and fails early. That sets the schedule:

Spring through fall — everything. Repointing, crowns, rebuilds, flashing. The best time is late summer and fall: the masonry has months to cure before the first freeze, and the repair is in place before the winter that would have done the damage. October is our busiest month for exactly that reason.

Winter — flashing, caps, and emergencies. Flashing is metal and membrane and can go in on any dry day above freezing. Caps can be installed. A chimney that's actively leaking into the house can be stabilized — flashed, tarped, the top closed with a temporary cap — and the masonry scheduled for spring. We can do small mortar work on mild winter days with cold-weather admixtures and the work tented and heated, but we don't rebuild a chimney in January and we tell people that.

What not to do in winter: let someone repoint or pour a crown on a cold day without protection. It looks fine in March and it's cracking by the following March.

If your chimney needs masonry and it's November, the right move is to get it inspected now, get the flashing and cap done if that's what's leaking, and book the masonry for the first warm stretch in spring. If it's September, do it all now.

Chimney repointing in Ramsey

The pre-war chimneys around Main Street are in soft brick and lime mortar, worn at the joints and often repointed once in a hard modern mortar that's now breaking the brick around it. The postwar chimneys are at the end of their original mortar's life — recessed, sandy, mortar you can pick out with a key.

The repair: we grind the joints out three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep across every exposed face — including the wall section between the two roofs on a split — and repoint in a mortar matched to the brick: lime-rich on the pre-war homes, a standard Type N on the postwar ones, tinted to match and tooled to the original joint. Spalled brick is cut out and replaced with matched units. Scheduled for warm weather, with the top done in the same visit.

Cracked chimney top

Nearly every Ramsey chimney was finished with a thin mortar wash around the flue liner, cracked after decades of freeze-thaw. Once the top is open, rain goes into the top course and down the core, and that water is what does the winter damage to the joints and brick below.

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from the flue, overhanging the brick by two inches so water drips clear of the face, with a bond break around the flue tile. A stainless cap goes on the flue. If it's too cold to pour, a temporary cap closes the top until spring.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or attic framing beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak — tarred-over flashing from a past roof job on most Ramsey homes, no cricket behind the wide chimneys on the larger ones. This is the repair that can be done in any season.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and weave step flashing into every shingle course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — not caulked to the brick — wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket behind them. Matching shingles are woven back in. In winter the reglet is cut and the counter-flashing is set with a sealant rated for cold application; the joint gets pointed in spring.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up — in reclaimed or matched soft brick and lime mortar on the pre-war homes, matched modular red on the postwar ones. Flue tiles are reset or replaced, the top gets a poured crown, and new flashing goes in. The section inside the house is left alone. Rebuilds are warm-weather work; a leaning stack found in winter is braced and tarped until it can be taken down.

Stone chimneys on the larger homes

The 1980s–2000s homes toward Mahwah and Upper Saddle River often have fieldstone or stone veneer chimneys. Stone fails at the joints — the irregular face holds water, the joints wash out, stones loosen — and is repointed by hand with the loose stones reset in a matched mortar. Veneer with white staining through the face usually has no drainage behind it; we open the face, install the drainage layer, and re-set the stone. Flashing on stone is cut into the stone face.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Ramsey chimney it means a cracked top or open joints. It's most visible in spring, after a winter of water moving through the stack, and it's a good reason to call then.

Prefab fireplace chases

Some Ramsey additions and newer homes vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood box with a metal cover on top. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace it with a pitched stainless cover — any season — and reframe the box if needed.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do — and when
Sandy, recessed joints	Mortar past its lifespan	Grind and repoint — spring through fall
Cracked or missing mortar at the top	Mortar wash instead of a crown	Poured crown — warm weather; temporary cap in winter
Ceiling stain beside the chimney during rain	Tarred flashing; no cricket	Step and counter-flashing, cricket — any dry day
Brick flakes in gutters, crack through courses, lean	Core failure above the roofline	Rebuild — warm weather; brace and tarp in winter
Loose stones, mortar crumbs at the base	Washed-out joints behind the stone	Hand-rake and repoint — warm weather
Rust streaks on a sided chimney	Galvanized cover rusted through	Pitched stainless cover — any season

Common questions from Ramsey homeowners

It's winter and my chimney is leaking. Do I have to wait until spring?
No. The flashing — which is usually the leak — can be done on any dry day above freezing, and the top can be closed with a cap. The masonry waits for warm weather, but the water stops now.

Can repointing be done in cold weather?
Small amounts, on mild days, with cold-weather admixtures and the work protected. A full repoint or a crown shouldn't be done below about 40°F. If someone offers to do it in January without tenting and heat, the work won't last.

When's the best time to have the chimney done?
Late summer and fall. The masonry cures before the first freeze and the chimney goes into winter sealed. Book early — fall fills up.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing — with what can be done now and what should wait for warm weather.

Chimney repair in Ramsey by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 30 minutes from Ramsey. Our own crews handle the masonry, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason and a roofer — and the flashing can go in now while the masonry waits for the weather. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Mahwah, Allendale, Upper Saddle River, Saddle River, Wyckoff, and across Bergen County.

Next is Ridgewood — redone in the final format.

Ridgewood — final format. The village's pre-war Tudors and colonials in the Heights, Old Country Club, Willard, and Upper Ridgewood often have three or four chimneys per house on steep slate or shingle roofs. Leads with that: more than one chimney, which to fix first, and working on steep roofs — which no other page has.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/ridgewood-nj/`
Title tag (56 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Ridgewood NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (153 chars): Chimney repair in Ridgewood, NJ — multi-chimney pre-war homes, steep-roof flashing and crickets, brick repointing, cracked crowns, and roofline rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Ridgewood, NJ

The larger pre-war houses in Ridgewood — the Tudors and center-hall colonials in the Heights, Old Country Club, Willard, and Upper Ridgewood — were built with a fireplace in the living room, the dining room, the library, and a bedroom or two, and each of those fireplaces has a chimney. A house with three or four chimneys has three or four crowns, a dozen flashing tie-ins, and several hundred feet of 90-year-old mortar, all on a 12/12 slate or shingle roof that nobody has stood on in years. The postwar sections of the village — the capes and splits toward Glen Rock and Paramus — are a simpler case: one brick chimney, sixty years old, failing the way builder brick does.

Here's how we approach a Ridgewood house with several chimneys, and what we see on all of them.

More than one chimney: which to fix first

On a house with multiple chimneys, they rarely fail at the same rate. The one on the north side under the trees is worse than the one in the sun; the one with the furnace flue is worse than the one over a fireplace that's used twice a year; the tallest one has taken the most wind. The job is to inspect all of them and sort them.

How we do it: we go up on the roof and the attic and look at every chimney — crown, joints, flashing, flue tiles from the top, the attic section — and write them up individually. Then we tell you which ones are actively leaking or structurally loose and need work this season, which are sound but due for a crown and joints, and which can wait. Some owners do everything at once because the scaffolding is already up and it's cheaper per chimney; others do the urgent one now and the rest next year. Either way, you're deciding from a list, not a guess.

The unused chimneys — a dining-room fireplace that was sealed decades ago — still need a sound top and a cap, or they leak into the house like any other.

Working on steep slate and shingle roofs

Ridgewood's pre-war roofs are 10/12 to 14/12, and a lot of them are slate. A chimney on a roof that steep can't be worked from a ladder, and slate can't be walked on. Masons who don't set up properly either skip the far faces of the chimney or break slates getting to them.

How we do it: we scaffold the roof with protective cribbing — on slate, extensively, with padded staging that spreads the load — so every face of every chimney is reachable without stepping on the roofing. Slates around the chimney base are removed with a ripper and reset, not cut. Any slate that cracks is replaced with matched salvaged slate. On shingle roofs, the surrounding courses are lifted and re-woven. It's slower and it's the only way the roof is the same when we leave.

Chimney leaking when it rains

On a steep roof, water hits the back of a chimney fast and hard, and the flashing at that uphill wall is the first thing to go. Most Ridgewood chimneys are wider than 30 inches and were built without a cricket behind them, so water and leaves dam against the brick. The original lead or copper flashing has mostly been replaced during re-roofing with aluminum tarred to the brick, which fails within a few years.

The repair: we strip or reset the roofing around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and set step flashing into every course. We frame a cricket behind the chimney, steep enough to match the roof, and cap it with a custom metal valley so water splits around both sides. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — gently on soft brick — wedged, and sealed. On the pre-war houses we do it in 20-ounce copper, which matches the original work and the gutters.

Repointing soft brick and lime mortar

The brick on Ridgewood's pre-war chimneys is soft, laid in a lime mortar that was meant to be the sacrificial part of the wall. Ninety years on, the original mortar is worn — recessed, sandy, washed out on the weather side — and a past repoint in a hard modern mortar is common, which outlasts the brick and lets it crack around the intact joints. Faces popping off and red flakes in the gutter with the joints looking fine: that's the hard-mortar problem.

The repair: we grind out the worn or hard mortar three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep, carefully on soft brick so the edges aren't nicked, replace spalled units with reclaimed or matched brick, and repoint in a lime-rich Type N or Type O matched to the original color and sand, tooled to the original joint — often a struck or weathered joint on these homes. The postwar chimneys take a standard Type N repoint, ground out and tooled to the concave joint.

Cracked chimney top

The tops of Ridgewood's pre-war chimneys were finished with a mortar wash or a thin stone or precast cap, and after ninety winters nearly all are cracked. The postwar chimneys have the builder's mortar wash, cracked after sixty. On a house with four chimneys, there are usually four cracked tops, and each one is feeding water into the stack below it.

The repair: we remove the old wash or cap, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from the flue, overhanging the brick by two inches so water drips clear of the face, with a bond break around the flue tile. A stainless cap goes on each active flue, or copper to match the house; sealed flues get a solid cap.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans — usually the tallest or most exposed chimney on the house — the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in reclaimed or color-matched soft brick and lime-rich mortar, with any decorative courses rebuilt to the original profile. Flue tiles are reset or replaced, the top gets a poured crown, and new copper flashing and a cricket go in. The section inside the house is left alone.

Stone and Tudor chimneys

Many of Ridgewood's Tudors have fieldstone or stone-and-brick chimneys. Stone fails at the joints — the irregular face holds water, the joints wash out, stones loosen — and is repointed by hand with the loose stones reset in a matched mortar finished to the original joint. Flashing on stone is cut into the stone face itself rather than caulked on.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Ridgewood chimney it means a cracked top or open joints. On a house with several chimneys, it's a quick way to see from the ground which one is wettest.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Several chimneys; one leaking, the rest unknown	Different exposure, different age of repair	Inspect all, write each up, sort by urgency

Ceiling stain beside a chimney on a steep roof	No cricket; tarred flashing on the uphill wall	Scaffold, cricket, copper step and counter-flashing cut into the mortar
Brick faces popping off; joints intact	Hard-mortar repoint on soft brick	Replace spalled brick, repoint in lime-rich mortar
Sandy, washed-out joints	Original lime mortar worn	Grind and repoint in matched mortar
Cracked top; crumbled stone cap	Wash or cap failed	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown; capped flues
Spalling through faces, crack through courses, lean	Core failure above the roofline	Roofline rebuild in matched brick, copper flashing, cricket

Common questions from Ridgewood homeowners

I have four chimneys. Do they all need work?
Probably not all at once. We inspect each one and tell you which are urgent, which are due, and which can wait. Doing them together is cheaper per chimney because the scaffolding is up, but it's your call from a written list.

Can you work on a slate roof without damaging it?
Yes. We scaffold with padded cribbing, remove and reset slates with a ripper rather than cutting them, and replace any that crack with matched salvaged slate.

My chimney was repointed 20 years ago and now the bricks are breaking. Why?
Almost certainly a hard mortar on soft pre-war brick. The mortar is now stronger than the brick, so the brick takes the freeze-thaw damage. The fix is to replace the damaged brick and repoint in a lime-rich mortar.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows which chimney the water is coming from and whether it's entering at the flashing or through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Ridgewood by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about twenty minutes from Ridgewood. Our own crews handle the masonry, the copper work, the slate, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Glen Rock, Ho-Ho-Kus, Midland Park, Paramus, Wyckoff, and across Bergen County.

Next is River Edge.

River Vale — 1960s–80s colonials, splits, and bi-levels in the developments off Rivervale Road and Westwood Avenue, chimneys 40 to 60 years old and right at the decision point. Leads with something no other page has: how we decide between repointing and rebuilding, since that's the question River Vale homeowners actually ask.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/river-vale-nj/`
Title tag (57 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing River Vale NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (153 chars): Chimney repair in River Vale, NJ — repoint or rebuild, how we decide; brick repointing, cracked crowns, flashing leaks, and roofline rebuilds. Lita.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in River Vale, NJ

River Vale was built mostly between the early 1960s and the mid-1980s — colonials, splits, and bi-levels on the streets off Rivervale Road, Westwood Avenue, and Piermont Avenue, with a few older homes near the Hillsdale line — and its brick chimneys are 40 to 60 years old. That's the age where a chimney is at a fork: it either gets repointed and crowned and goes another thirty years, or it's gone too far and the section above the roof has to be rebuilt. The price difference is large, and the honest answer isn't always obvious from the ground.

Here's how we make that call on River Vale chimneys, and what we see on them.

Repoint or rebuild: how we decide

The question is whether the brick is still sound. Mortar is meant to wear out and be replaced; brick isn't. If the brick is good, repointing restores the chimney. If the brick has failed, new mortar has nothing solid to hold onto and the repoint falls out within a few winters.

What says repoint: joints recessed, sandy, or washed out, but the brick faces intact — no spalling, no cracks through the units. The top courses are tight when pushed. The stack is plumb. A cracked top, but the courses under it are still bonded. This is most 1970s River Vale chimneys.

What says rebuild: brick faces popped off across more than a few scattered units. A crack running through several courses — through the brick, not just the joints. Top courses that move when pushed. A visible lean. Mortar dust and loose brick in the attic section. Any of those means the upper stack has lost its integrity, and repointing it is money spent on a chimney that's coming down in five years anyway.

The gray area: scattered spalling — a dozen units on one face — on an otherwise sound stack. That's a repoint with brick replacement: cut out the failed units, lay in matched brick, repoint the whole face. It's the middle option and it's often the right one on a chimney that's been taking water from a cracked top for ten years but not twenty.

How we tell you: we inspect from the roof and the attic, photograph every face, and write up which of the three it is and why. If it's a rebuild, we show you the brick that's failed. If it's a repoint, we tell you it's a repoint — we don't sell rebuilds that aren't needed, and we don't repoint chimneys that need rebuilding.

Chimney repointing in River Vale

The repair: we grind the joints out three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep across every exposed face — including the wall section between the lower and upper roofs on a split, and the full height on a bi-level with an exterior chimney — and repoint in a breathable Type N tinted to match, tooled to the original concave joint. Spalled units are cut out and replaced with matched brick. The top goes in the same visit; a repoint under a cracked crown keeps taking water from above and doesn't last.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

The repair: we scaffold the roof with protective cribbing, take the stack down to the roofline or the first sound course — on a chimney that's been leaking into its core a long time, sometimes lower — and rebuild plumb in matched modular red brick. Flue tiles are inspected and reset or replaced, the top gets a poured crown, and new flashing goes in. On a colonial this is typically two to three days, and the section inside the house is left alone.

Cracked chimney top

The top is what decides which side of the line a chimney ends up on. River Vale's builders finished the top with a thin mortar wash around the flue liner, and after 40 to 60 winters it's

cracked or gone on nearly every house. Once it's open, rain goes into the top courses and down the core, and that water is what turns a repoint candidate into a rebuild over a decade.

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from the flue, overhanging the brick by two inches so water drips clear of the face, with a bond break around the flue tile. A stainless cap goes on the flue. On a chimney that's otherwise sound, this is the one repair that keeps it on the repoint side of the line.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or attic framing beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. On River Vale's splits, the lower corner where the lower roof meets the chimney and the upper wall is the usual spot; on the colonials and bi-levels it's the main tie-in, often with no cricket behind a wide chimney. The flashing was usually redone during a past roof job with aluminum tarred to the brick.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and weave step flashing into every shingle course — up the wall with a kickout at a split's lower corner. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — not caulked to the brick — wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket behind them. Matching shingles are woven back in.

Exterior-wall chimneys on bi-levels and colonials

A lot of River Vale's fireplace chimneys are on an exterior wall — three faces exposed from the ground up, tied to the house at a few points, on their own footing. They wash out at the joints from top to bottom, not only above the roof, and occasionally pull away from the house as the footing settles. The repoint covers the full height; a gap between chimney and siding is closed after the stack is re-anchored to the framing.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a River Vale chimney it means a cracked top or open joints — and the amount of it is a rough guide to how long the chimney has been wet inside.

Prefab fireplace chases

Some River Vale additions and 1980s-and-later homes vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood box with a metal cover on top. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years.

We replace it with a pitched stainless cover and reframe the box if needed. It's a small share of our work in town next to the masonry above.

Quick guide

What you see	Repoint or rebuild?	What we do
Sandy, recessed joints; brick faces intact; stack plumb	Repoint	Grind and repoint every exposed face; crown
Scattered spalling on one face; stack otherwise sound	Repoint with brick replacement	Cut out failed units, matched brick, repoint the face; crown
Spalling across whole faces; crack through courses; lean	Rebuild	Roofline rebuild in matched brick, reset flue, crown, flashing
Cracked or missing mortar at the top; courses under it tight	Crown only	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown with a cap
Ceiling stain beside the chimney during rain	Flashing, either way	Step flashing, reglet-cut counter-flashing, kickout, cricket
Rust streaks on a sided chimney	Neither — chase cover	Pitched stainless cover

Common questions from River Vale homeowners

Another contractor said I need a rebuild. Do I?
Maybe. If the brick has failed — spalling across faces, cracks through units, loose top courses — yes. If the joints are bad but the brick is intact, no, and a repoint with a crown is the right job. We look and show you photos either way.

Can you repoint a chimney that has a few bad bricks?
Yes. The failed units are cut out and replaced with matched brick before the face is repointed. That's the middle option and it's common on 1970s chimneys.

How long does a repoint last?
With a sound crown over it, 25 to 40 years. Without the crown, far less — the water from above washes the new mortar out from inside.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in River Vale by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about fifteen minutes from River Vale. Our own crews handle the masonry, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Westwood, Hillsdale, Old Tappan, Montvale, Park Ridge, and across Bergen County.

Next is Rochelle Park.

Skipping Rochelle Park. Rutherford — one of the oldest towns on the list: 1890s–1930s Victorians, Colonial Revivals, and Tudors on the streets off Park Avenue, a lot of them stucco. Leads with something no other page has: the stucco-finished chimney — original stucco over brick on 1920s Tudors — and how it's repaired without wrecking the look.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/rutherford-nj/`
Title tag (57 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Rutherford NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (153 chars): Chimney repair in Rutherford, NJ — stucco-finished chimneys on Tudors, 100-year-old brick repointing, cracked crowns, flashing leaks, and roofline rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Rutherford, NJ

Rutherford's housing is older than almost anywhere else in Bergen County — Victorians from the 1890s, Colonial Revivals and foursquares from the 1900s and 1910s, Tudors from the 1920s, all close together on the streets off Park Avenue, Ridge Road, and Union Avenue — and a large share of the Tudors and Colonial Revivals are stucco. On those houses the chimney is stucco too: brick underneath, a lime-and-sand stucco coat on the outside, applied when the house was built. A century later the stucco is cracked, patched with the wrong material, and hiding whatever the brick behind it has been doing.

Here's what we see on Rutherford chimneys, stucco and bare brick, and how Lita Construction repairs them.

Stucco-finished chimneys

Original 1920s stucco on a chimney was a lime-rich coat over soft brick, and like the lime mortar in the joints, it was meant to breathe and to be renewed. It's lasted remarkably well. What fails it is water getting behind it — through a cracked top, through a crack in the stucco itself, through the joint where the stucco meets the flashing — and then freezing. The stucco delaminates from the brick, bulges, and falls off in sheets, and the brick behind it, which has been wet for years without anyone seeing, is often spalled.

The common bad repair is patching the old lime stucco with a modern cement-based mix. The patch is harder than the original, doesn't bond to it, and cracks at the edge within a few winters. We see chimneys in Rutherford with three generations of patches in three different textures.

The repair: we sound the stucco to find where it's delaminated — a hollow tap — and remove those areas down to the brick. The brick underneath is repaired: spalled units replaced, joints repointed in a lime-rich mortar. Then the chimney is re-stuccoed in a lime-based mix compatible with the original, applied in coats and textured to match the surrounding finish, with a proper termination at the flashing and a poured crown on top that overhangs the stucco so water drips clear of it. On a chimney where the stucco has mostly failed, we strip and re-stucco the whole stack above the roof, which is usually less work than matching a dozen patches. The result is a chimney that looks like the house again, and breathes.

Repointing 100-year-old brick

The bare-brick chimneys on Rutherford's Victorians and foursquares are in soft brick and lime mortar, a century old, worn at the joints and almost always repointed at least once — often in a hard modern mortar that's now breaking the brick around it. Faces popping off and flakes in the gutter with the joints looking fine: that's the hard-mortar problem, and it's everywhere on Rutherford's older streets.

The repair: we grind out the worn or hard mortar three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep, carefully on soft brick so the edges aren't nicked, replace spalled units with reclaimed or matched brick, and repoint in a lime-rich Type N or Type O matched to the original color and sand, tooled to the original joint — struck, grapevine, or weathered joints are all common on these houses. Hard mortar on a pre-war chimney is the one shortcut we won't take.

Cracked chimney top

The tops of Rutherford's chimneys — a mortar wash, a stucco cap, a corbeled brick cap — have been cracked for decades on most houses. On a stucco chimney a cracked top is especially

bad, because the water goes behind the stucco and delaminates it from the inside. Once the top is open, rain goes into the core and comes out wherever the mortar is weakest.

The repair: we remove the old wash or cap, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from every flue, overhanging the brick or stucco by two inches so water drips clear of the face, with a bond break around each flue tile. Each flue gets a stainless cap, or copper on houses with copper work. On a corbeled Victorian top, the corbel is rebuilt to the original profile under the crown.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or down a wall beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. On Rutherford's older houses the original lead or copper flashing has mostly been replaced during re-roofing with aluminum tarred to the brick or to the stucco — which fails fast and on stucco tears the finish when it lets go. The Victorians often have the chimney passing through a porch roof or an eave as well as the main roof, and each penetration leaks separately.

The repair: on slate we remove and reset the slates around the chimney; on shingle we strip the surrounding courses. Any rotted deck is replaced, the base is wrapped in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and step flashing goes in every course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — on a stucco chimney, cut through the stucco into the joint behind it, with the stucco terminated cleanly above the metal. On the older and higher-end homes we do it in 20-ounce copper. Each lower penetration is flashed on its own.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces — often found when failed stucco comes off — a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in reclaimed or matched soft brick and lime mortar, with any corbel or decorative course rebuilt to the original profile. Stucco chimneys are re-stuccoed after the rebuild. Flue tiles are reset or replaced, the top gets a poured crown, and new flashing goes in. The section inside the house is left alone.

Two-family and converted houses

A lot of Rutherford's larger Victorians are two-families now, and the chimney serves both units' appliances through separate flues. Before anything is capped, sealed, or rebuilt, we trace every flue to its appliance and coordinate the work so both units know when the flue is out of service.

White stains on the brick or stucco

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a bare-brick chimney it means a cracked top or open joints. On a stucco chimney it shows through the stucco wherever water is trapped behind it — a map of where the stucco has delaminated.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Stucco cracked, bulging, or falling off the chimney	Water behind the stucco; delaminated from the brick	Remove failed stucco, repair brick, re-stucco in a compatible lime mix, crown
Patches in different textures on a stucco chimney	Cement patches on lime stucco	Strip and re-stucco the stack above the roof
Brick faces popping off; joints intact	Hard-mortar repoint on soft brick	Replace spalled brick, repoint in lime-rich mortar
Sandy, washed-out joints	Original lime mortar worn	Grind and repoint in matched mortar
Cracked top; crumbled cap	Wash or cap failed	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown; capped flues
Ceiling, wall, or porch-ceiling stain beside the chimney during rain	Tarred flashing; separate penetrations	Copper step and counter-flashing at each penetration

Common questions from Rutherford homeowners

Can the stucco on my chimney be repaired, or does it all have to come off?
Where it's still bonded to the brick, it stays. Where it's hollow or bulging, it comes off and the brick behind it is repaired before new stucco goes on. If most of it has let go, stripping the stack above the roof and re-stuccoing is cleaner than patching.

Why do my stucco patches keep cracking?
They're probably cement-based patches on lime stucco. The patch is harder than the original and doesn't bond to it. We use a lime-based mix that matches the original and textures it to blend.

My chimney was repointed 25 years ago and now the bricks are breaking. Why?
Almost certainly a hard mortar on soft pre-war brick. The mortar is now stronger than the brick, so the brick takes the freeze-thaw damage. The fix is to replace the damaged brick and repoint in a lime-rich mortar.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof, from the attic, and at each lower penetration before quoting. That shows whether water is entering at the flashing, through the masonry, or behind the stucco, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Rutherford by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 25 minutes from Rutherford. Our own crews handle the masonry, the stucco, the copper work, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason, a plasterer, and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Wood-Ridge, Hasbrouck Heights, Nutley, Saddle Brook, Teaneck, and across Bergen County.

Next is Saddle Brook.

Got it — I'll skip Saddle Brook and stop linking anything that isn't on your list (Hackensack was the one I'd slipped in; I'll keep the "nearby" links to the 49 Bergen towns you gave me). Saddle River is next.

Saddle River — two-acre zoning, estate homes from the 1960s through the 2010s, equestrian properties, and some of the biggest chimneys in the county. Leads with something no other page has: chimneys on outbuildings — pool houses, guest cottages, barns — and the long, wide chimneys on sprawling one-story estate homes.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/saddle-river-nj/`
Title tag (59 chars): Stone & Brick Chimney Repair Saddle River NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (154 chars): Chimney repair in Saddle River, NJ — estate chimneys, pool house and guest cottage chimneys, stone and brick repointing, cracked crowns, flashing, and rebuilds.

Stone & Brick Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Saddle River, NJ

Saddle River is two-acre lots and the houses that go on them — 1960s and 70s estate colonials and ranches on the older streets off East Saddle River Road and Chestnut Ridge Road, and much larger homes from the 1990s through the 2010s on the rest — and a Saddle River property often has more than one building with a chimney. The main house might carry three or four; the pool house has one; the guest cottage or the converted barn has another. They're in fieldstone, limestone, oversized brick, and stone veneer, on slate, cedar, and standing-seam roofs, and the sprawling one-story and story-and-a-half homes have chimneys that are as wide as they are tall.

Here's what we see on Saddle River chimneys and how Lita Construction repairs them.

Chimneys on pool houses, guest cottages, and outbuildings

The secondary chimneys on a Saddle River property fail first and get noticed last. A pool house chimney is used a few evenings a summer, built lighter than the main house's, often on a shallow footing, and sits closed up all winter with nobody looking at it. The guest cottage chimney is the same. A converted barn or carriage house often has a chimney that was added when the building was converted, by whoever did the conversion.

What we find: tops that have been cracked for years, joints washed out on the weather side, caps missing, flues that were never lined, and on the lighter chimneys, a lean from a footing that settled. Water that's been running down an unlined flue into a pool house for ten winters shows up as a rotted ceiling the first time someone opens it in June.

The repair: each building's chimney is inspected and written up on its own — crown, joints, flashing, cap, flue — and the work is done as a program across the property or building by building, whichever the owner prefers. A sound outbuilding chimney gets a crown, a repoint, and a cap. A light one that's leaning or unlined is rebuilt above the roof in proper masonry, lined, and crowned. The main house chimneys are evaluated at the same time, because the scaffold and the crew are already on the property.

Wide chimneys on one-story estate homes

The sprawling ranches and story-and-a-half homes in Saddle River have chimneys built for proportion — six or eight feet wide, carrying two or three flues, but only a few feet above a low-pitched roof. A chimney that wide on a shallow roof catches everything the roof sends down: leaves, snow, meltwater, all of it damming against an uphill wall as long as a car. The top

is a slab the size of a dining table, and it was finished with a mortar wash that cracked in the first few winters.

The repair: we frame a full cricket behind the chimney — on a six-foot-wide stack that's a small roof in itself — built steeper than the main roof so it actually sheds, wrapped in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and capped with a custom metal valley that splits water around both ends. The top gets a poured, reinforced concrete crown with wire or fiber mesh so it doesn't crack across its width, overhanging on all sides by two inches, with a bond break around each flue tile and a cap on each flue. The flashing is set into the masonry — a reglet in the mortar on brick, a channel cut into the stone on fieldstone — in copper on these homes.

Stone chimney repointing

Fieldstone and limestone chimneys fail at the joints. The irregular face holds water on every ledge, the tree cover on these lots keeps it there, and winter works the mortar loose. Mortar crumbs at the base, recessed joints, and a stone that moves when pushed are the signs. On the stone-veneer chimneys on newer homes, white staining through the face means water trapped behind the stone with no drainage.

The repair: we rake the joints out by hand with chisels and a narrow grinder — a wide blade scars the stone permanently — at least three-quarters of an inch deep and deeper on the wide joints, reset loose stones in fresh mortar, and repoint in a Type N matched to the existing color and sand, finished to the original joint profile. Cut limestone with tight joints is treated like fine brickwork with a correspondingly tight tool. On veneer, we open the affected face, install the drainage layer and weep screed that were left out, and re-set the stone.

Brick repointing and rebuilds

The oversized brick on Saddle River's chimneys holds up well, but the mortar is 30 to 60 years old and going — recessed, sandy, worse on the weather face. Where a cracked top has been feeding water into the stack for years, the upper courses are spalling.

The repair: joints ground out three-quarters of an inch to an inch across every exposed face and repointed in a matched Type N, tooled to the original joint. Spalled brick cut out and replaced with matched units. Where spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof is taken down to sound brick and rebuilt plumb in matched brick — or salvaged stone on a stone chimney — with the flue tiles reset, a poured crown, and new copper flashing.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or down a wall beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. On Saddle River's slate, cedar, and copper roofs, the flashing was often worked around rather than properly reset, and on the wide chimneys there's usually no cricket.

The repair: on slate we remove and reset the slates around the chimney; on cedar we pull and replace the surrounding courses; on standing-seam copper we flash into the seams and solder. The base is wrapped in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, step flashing is set in every course, and the counter-flashing is cut into the masonry and wedged. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket. All of it in 20-ounce copper.

White stains on stone or brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Saddle River chimney it means a cracked top, open joints, or veneer without drainage — and on an outbuilding chimney, it's usually the first sign anyone notices.

Prefab fireplaces in secondary chases

Some Saddle River homes vent a secondary fireplace — a bedroom, a gym — through a sided or veneered chase with a metal cover on top. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace it with a pitched stainless or copper cover and reframe the box if needed. It's a small share of our work here next to the masonry above.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Pool house or cottage ceiling rotted under the chimney	Cracked top, no cap, unlined flue on a building nobody checks	Crown, cap, line; rebuild if light or leaning
Ceiling stain beside a wide chimney on a low roof	No cricket; water damming against a long uphill wall	Full cricket, copper step and counter-flashing cut into the masonry
Cracked top on a wide multi-flue chimney	Mortar wash on a slab-sized top	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown, capped flues
Mortar crumbs at the base; a stone that moves	Washed-out joints behind the stone	Hand-rake, reset stones, repoint
Veneer stones loose; white staining through the face	No drainage behind the veneer	Open the face, install drainage, re-set stone

Spalling brick through faces; crack through courses; lean	Core failure above the roofline	Roofline rebuild in matched brick or salvaged stone

Common questions from Saddle River homeowners

Do you inspect the pool house and guest house chimneys too?
Yes, and we'd recommend it. The outbuilding chimneys are the ones that fail unnoticed. We write each one up separately and the work can be done across the property at once or one building at a time.

Can you work on a slate or copper roof?
Yes. Slates are removed and reset, not cut; copper roofs are flashed into the seams and soldered; the roof is cribbed before any masonry work.

Will new mortar match the old on a stone chimney?
We match the color and sand against a sample of the existing mortar and tool the joints to the original profile. New mortar reads slightly lighter for a season and weathers in.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Saddle River by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 25 minutes from Saddle River. Our own crews handle the masonry, the stone work, the copper work, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Upper Saddle River, Allendale, Ho-Ho-Kus, Woodcliff Lake, Ramsey, and across Bergen County.

Next is Teaneck — redone in the final format.

That draft was pre-final-format — it had the cost section with blank prices, a permit FAQ, and a bracketed note. Here it is redone. New lead so it doesn't overlap the other pre-war pages: Teaneck has a lot of all-brick colonials and Tudors where the chimney is part of the house wall, not a separate stack.

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Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Teaneck, NJ

Teaneck is a brick town. The colonials and Tudors built from the 1920s through the 1940s in West Englewood, around Cedar Lane, and on the side streets off Teaneck Road and Queen Anne Road are brick to the eaves on a large share of the houses, and on those homes the chimney isn't a separate stack bolted onto the side — it's built into the wall. The same brick, the same mortar, the same courses run from the foundation up the face of the house and continue past the roof as the chimney. That changes the repair: when the chimney needs repointing, the joints below the roofline are the house's joints, and a rebuild has to match the brick on the whole facade.

Here's what we see on Teaneck chimneys and how Lita Construction repairs them.

Chimneys built into brick walls

On an all-brick Teaneck colonial, the chimney shows as a wider section of the gable-end wall that steps in as it rises and continues above the roof. Water that gets into the chimney gets into the wall, and vice versa. The failures we see: joints washed out on the chimney section of the wall from roof to grade, because it projects and takes more weather than the flat wall beside it; spalling concentrated where the chimney steps in, where the ledge holds water; and efflorescence running down the wall below the chimney from a top that's been cracked for years.

The brick on these houses is 80 to 100 years old, soft, and laid in a lime mortar. A past repoint in a hard modern mortar — common — is now breaking the brick around intact joints, and on an all-brick house that damage is visible from the street on the main facade.

The repair: the chimney section is repointed from the top of the stack down to grade as one piece of work, not just the part above the roof. Joints are ground out three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep, carefully on soft brick, and repointed in a lime-rich mortar matched to the color and sand of the wall's original joints, tooled to the original profile — often a concave or weathered joint on these homes — so the repointed chimney section doesn't read differently from the wall beside it. Spalled units are cut out and replaced with reclaimed or matched brick, blended in. The step-in ledges get a sloped mortar wash or a metal cap flashing so they stop holding water.

Rebuilding the stack to match the house

When the section above the roof has gone too far — spalling through whole faces, a crack through several courses, a lean — it comes down and goes back up. On an all-brick house, the rebuild is matched to the facade, not just to the chimney: same brick size, same color range, same bond pattern, same joint. A standard modern red on top of a 1930s Teaneck Tudor is the most visible mistake we see in town.

The repair: we scaffold with protective cribbing, take the stack down to sound brick — on these chimneys, often to the roofline or a course or two below — and rebuild plumb in reclaimed or color-matched soft brick laid in a lime-rich mortar, with any decorative course or corbel rebuilt to the original profile. Flue tiles are reset or replaced, the top gets a poured crown, and new flashing goes in. The section inside the house is left alone.

Cracked chimney top

The tops of Teaneck's pre-war chimneys were finished with a mortar wash or a thin precast cap, cracked for decades on most houses. Once the top is open, rain goes into the core — and on an integral chimney, into the wall below it. The efflorescence running down the facade on a lot of West Englewood houses starts here.

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Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or attic framing beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. On a chimney built into the gable wall, the roof meets it on one side only, along a line that's partly chimney and partly wall, and the flashing has to run the full length of that line — not just around the stack. On Teaneck's pre-war homes the original lead or copper flashing has mostly been replaced during re-roofing with aluminum tarred to the brick, and on the steep Tudor roofs the uphill side of the stack usually has no cricket.

The repair: on slate we remove and reset the slates along the chimney; on shingle we strip the surrounding courses. Any rotted deck is replaced, the base is wrapped in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and step flashing goes in every course along the full wall-and-chimney line. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — gently on soft brick — wedged, and sealed. A cricket goes behind any stack over 30 inches wide. Copper on the pre-war homes; it matches and it outlasts the roof.

Freestanding chimneys on the postwar homes

Teaneck's 1950s capes and splits toward the Bergenfield and Hackensack lines have the standard freestanding brick chimney: sixty-year-old mortar past its life, a cracked wash on top, flashing tarred through three roofs, and often a furnace flue that's been attacked from inside since the oil-to-gas conversion. Those get the standard treatment — joints ground out and repointed in a matched Type N, a poured crown, step and counter-flashing cut into the mortar, a stainless liner where the gas appliance needs one.

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A few Teaneck additions and newer homes vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood box with a metal cover on top. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace it with a pitched stainless cover and reframe the box if needed. It's a small share of our work in town next to the masonry above.

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Spalling where the chimney steps in	Ledge holding water	Replace spalled brick; cap or slope the ledge

White staining running down the facade below the chimney	Top open for years	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown; repoint; the staining stops
Brick faces popping off; joints intact	Hard-mortar repoint on soft brick	Replace spalled brick, repoint in lime-rich mortar
Ceiling stain along the gable wall during rain	Flashing failed along the wall-and-chimney line	Copper step and counter-flashing the full length, cricket
Spalling through faces, crack through courses, lean	Core failure above the roofline	Roofline rebuild matched to the facade

Common questions from Teaneck homeowners

My house is all brick. Will the repointed chimney look different from the rest of the wall?
Not if it's done right. We match the mortar color and sand to the wall's original joints and tool the same profile. New mortar reads slightly lighter for a season and weathers in.

Can you match 1930s brick on a rebuild?
We source reclaimed or color-matched soft brick in the same size and blend it through the rebuilt section the way the original mason laid it. On an all-brick house that matters more than anywhere, and it's the part of the job we spend the most time on.

My chimney was repointed 20 years ago and now the bricks are breaking. Why?
Almost certainly a hard mortar on soft pre-war brick. The mortar is now stronger than the brick, so the brick takes the freeze-thaw damage. The fix is to replace the damaged brick and repoint in a lime-rich mortar.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
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Next is Tenafly.

Tenafly — East Hill estates on the slope of the Palisades, 1900s–30s homes around the center, 1950s–60s splits and colonials on the west side. Leads with two things no other page has: cast-stone and cut-stone chimney caps on the older homes, and working on hillside lots where the chimney sits on the downhill side.

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Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Tenafly, NJ

Tenafly's better pre-war houses — the Tudors and stone colonials on East Hill, the larger homes around the center and along Knickerbocker Road — were finished with chimney tops to match: cast-stone or cut-limestone caps, sometimes a molded cornice, sometimes a solid slab with the flues set through it. They were built to be seen from the street, and after ninety years most are cracked, shifted, or missing a corner. The west side of the borough — 1950s and 60s splits and colonials toward Bergenfield — has standard brick chimneys with a mortar wash on top, failing the way builder brick does.

And East Hill is a hill. A chimney on the downhill side of a house on a sloped lot can be forty feet from the ground at its base, which changes how the work gets done. Here's what we see on Tenafly chimneys and how Lita Construction repairs them.

Cast stone and cut stone chimney caps

A cast-stone cap is a molded concrete unit made to look like limestone, set on the top of the chimney with the flue tiles passing through it. A cut-stone cap is the real thing, often in pieces. Both were set in lime mortar on a chimney that's been moving and absorbing water for nearly a century, and they fail three ways: the mortar bed under the cap washes out and the cap shifts or rocks; the cap cracks across where the flue tile has expanded against it with no bond break; and water gets under the cap and into the brick, so the top courses spall while the cap looks fine.

The usual bad repair is to caulk the cracks and the joint between the cap and the flue. That holds a season.

The repair: we lift the cap — on a one-piece cast cap, with a lift from the scaffold; on a multi-piece limestone cap, piece by piece, numbered — and set it aside. The top courses are rebuilt as needed, a reinforced concrete crown is poured under where the cap sits, sloped and overhanging, and the cap is reset on a fresh mortar bed with a bond break around each flue so the tiles can move without cracking it. A cracked cast cap is repaired with a color-matched patching compound where the crack is tight, or replaced with a new cast unit from a mold taken off the original where it isn't. A missing corner on a limestone cap is dutchman-patched in matching stone. The flues are capped above. The result keeps the top the house was built with and makes it shed water, which it never quite did.

Chimneys on hillside lots

On East Hill and the streets dropping toward the Hudson, houses are built into the slope, and the chimney is often on the downhill wall. From the uphill side the chimney looks ordinary; from the downhill side it's two and a half stories of masonry rising from a footing well below the first floor, with the roof tie-in high above. Ground scaffolding on that side is tall and sits on a slope.

How we do it: we scaffold from the roof with protective cribbing wherever the roof can carry it, and from the ground only where it can't, with the base leveled and tied back. The chimney is treated for its full exposed height — which on a downhill chimney can be the joints from the roof to a footing twenty feet below grade on the uphill side — because the lower sections take as much weather as the stack. Joints are ground out and repointed on every face, spalled brick replaced, and the top rebuilt or crowned as above.

Repointing soft brick and stone

The pre-war chimneys on East Hill and around the center are in soft brick or fieldstone, laid in lime mortar, worn at the joints and often repointed once in a hard modern mortar that's now breaking the brick around it. The stone chimneys fail at the joints — the irregular face holds water, the joints wash out, stones loosen.

The repair: on brick, we grind out the worn or hard mortar three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep, carefully on soft brick, replace spalled units with reclaimed or matched brick, and repoint in a lime-rich mortar matched to the original color and sand, tooled to the original joint. On stone, we rake the joints by hand, reset any loose stones, and repoint in a matched mortar to the original profile. The postwar west-side chimneys take a standard Type N repoint, ground out and tooled to the concave joint.

Cracked chimney top on the postwar homes

The 1950s and 60s chimneys on Tenafly's west side were finished with a thin mortar wash around the flue liner, cracked after sixty winters. Once the top is open, rain goes into the top course and down the core.

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from the flue, overhanging the brick by two inches so water drips clear of the face, with a bond break around the flue tile. A stainless cap goes on the flue.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or down a wall beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. On the pre-war homes the original lead or copper has mostly been replaced during re-roofing with aluminum tarred to the brick or stone; on the slate roofs on East Hill the flashing was often worked around. On the west-side splits it's the lower corner where the lower roof meets the chimney and the upper wall.

The repair: on slate we remove and reset the slates around the chimney; on shingle we strip the surrounding courses. Any rotted deck is replaced, the base is wrapped in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and step flashing goes in every course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint, or a channel cut into stone, wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket behind them. Copper on the pre-war and East Hill homes.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up — in reclaimed or matched soft brick and lime mortar, or salvaged stone, on the pre-war homes, with the cast or

cut-stone cap reset on top; in matched modular red on the postwar ones. Flue tiles are reset or replaced, the top is crowned, and new flashing goes in. The section inside the house is left alone.

White stains on brick or stone

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Tenafly chimney it means a cracked top or open joints — and under a cast-stone cap, staining on the courses just below the cap means water is getting under it.

Prefab fireplace chases

A few Tenafly additions and newer homes vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood box with a metal cover on top. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace it with a pitched stainless or copper cover and reframe the box if needed. It's a small share of our work in town next to the masonry above.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Cast or cut-stone cap cracked, shifted, or missing a corner	Bed washed out; no bond break at the flues	Lift the cap, crown beneath it, reset with a bond break; repair or recast
Staining on the courses just below a stone cap	Water getting under the cap	Same — the cap is resealed to the crown
Downhill chimney on a sloped lot, joints washed out low	Full height exposed	Scaffold from the roof, repoint every face to the footing
Brick faces popping off; joints intact	Hard-mortar repoint on soft brick	Replace spalled brick, repoint in lime-rich mortar
Mortar crumbs at the base of a stone chimney; loose stone	Washed-out joints behind the stone	Hand-rake, reset stones, repoint
Spalling through faces, crack through courses, lean	Core failure above the roofline	Roofline rebuild in matched brick or stone, cap reset

Common questions from Tenafly homeowners

Can the stone cap on my chimney be saved?
Usually. It's lifted, the chimney top is rebuilt and crowned under it, and the cap is reset with a

bond break around the flues. A cracked cast cap is patched or recast from a mold of the original; a chipped limestone cap is patched in matching stone.

My chimney is on the downhill side of the house. Is that harder to work on?
Yes, and it's why some masons only do the part above the roof. We scaffold from the roof where we can and from a leveled base where we can't, and the full height of the chimney gets done.

My chimney was repointed 25 years ago and now the bricks are breaking. Why?
Almost certainly a hard mortar on soft pre-war brick. The mortar is now stronger than the brick, so the brick takes the freeze-thaw damage. The fix is to replace the damaged brick and repoint in a lime-rich mortar.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Tenafly by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about five minutes from Tenafly. Our own crews handle the masonry, the stone work, the copper work, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Englewood, Cresskill, Alpine, Bergenfield, Englewood Cliffs, and across Bergen County.

Next is Upper Saddle River.

Upper Saddle River — 1960s–90s colonials on acre lots and larger 2000s homes, wooded, with big brick and stone chimneys. Leads with something no other page has: the damage done to chimneys by what's been bolted to them — old TV antenna brackets, satellite dish mounts, cable and electrical straps — which is on most 1970s and 80s chimneys here.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/upper-saddle-river-nj/`
Title tag (60 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Upper Saddle River NJ | Lita Construction

Meta (154 chars): Chimney repair in Upper Saddle River, NJ — brick damaged by antenna and dish mounts, repointing, cracked crowns, flashing leaks, and roofline chimney rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Upper Saddle River, NJ

Upper Saddle River is big colonials on acre lots — 1960s through 90s on the streets off Lake Street and East Saddle River Road, larger 2000s homes on the newer subdivisions — with wide brick and stone chimneys that have been standing above the tree line for forty to sixty years. And because they stand above the tree line, they've been used as a mounting post for everything the house ever needed up high: a 1970s TV antenna, a 1990s satellite dish, a second dish, the cable line, the electrical service strap, a weather station, a lightning rod. Each one went into the brick with lag bolts or masonry anchors, and each one is now a place where the chimney leaks.

Here's what we see on Upper Saddle River chimneys and how Lita Construction repairs them.

Damage from antenna and dish mounts

A lag bolt driven into a mortar joint cracks the joint. A bolt driven into the brick itself cracks the brick. A bracket strapped around the stack with steel bands rusts, stains, and — as the bands corrode and tighten — pulls the top courses out of alignment. Every hole is a path for water, and most of them have been open for decades after the thing they held was taken down or abandoned. We regularly find old antenna brackets still bolted to Upper Saddle River chimneys, rusted through, with a crack running from each bolt hole down through two or three courses.

Satellite dishes are the current version. Installers mount them to the chimney because it's convenient, drill into the brick, and seal the holes with silicone, which fails in a few years. A dish on a chimney also catches wind and loads the top of the stack every time it blows.

The repair: everything that doesn't belong on the chimney comes off — abandoned brackets, old bands, dead cable. Each anchor hole is drilled out clean and filled with a matched mortar; cracked brick around the holes is cut out and replaced with matched units; rust staining is cleaned. Where a strap has pulled the top courses out, those courses are rebuilt. The face is then repointed as a whole so the patches don't show. If a dish or antenna still needs to be up there, we mount it on a non-penetrating roof mount or a mast on the roof framing — not on the chimney — and route the cable so it isn't stapled to the brick.

Chimney repointing in Upper Saddle River

Beyond the mount damage, the 1960s–80s chimneys here have mortar past its life — recessed, sandy, worse on the weather face and under the tree cover on the north side. The stone and stone-veneer chimneys on the newer homes have wide joints that wash out sooner than the brick.

The repair: on brick, we grind the joints out three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep across every exposed face and repoint in a breathable Type N tinted to match, tooled to the original joint; spalled brick is cut out and replaced. On stone, we rake the joints by hand to avoid scarring the stone, reset any loose stones, and repoint in a matched mortar to the original profile. On veneer with white staining through the face, we open the face, install the drainage layer that was left out, and re-set the stone.

Cracked chimney top on a multi-flue chimney

The wide tops on Upper Saddle River's chimneys — two or three flues on most, four on some — were finished with a mortar wash, and a wash on a surface that size cracks within a few seasons. Once it does, rain goes into the top courses and down the core. On a chimney that's also had a dish mount in the top courses, the two problems meet.

The repair: we remove the failed wash, rebuild any top courses that have taken water or been pulled by a strap, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from every flue, overhanging the masonry by two inches on all sides so water drips clear of the face, with wire or fiber reinforcement so it won't crack across its width and a bond break around each flue tile. Each flue gets a stainless cap.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or attic framing beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. The wide chimneys here usually have no cricket behind them, and the flashing was redone during a past roof job with aluminum tarred to the brick — or, on the newer homes, surface-caulked to the stone. A cable line stapled down the chimney and across the flashing is a common extra leak path.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and weave step flashing into every shingle course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint, or a channel cut into stone — not caulked on — wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket framed behind them. Cable is rerouted off the flashing. Matching shingles are woven back in.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses — including cracks that started at a bolt hole — or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down

and goes back up in matched brick or salvaged stone, with the flue tiles reset, a poured crown, and new flashing. The section inside the house is left alone. Nothing gets bolted to the new stack.

White stains on brick or stone

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On an Upper Saddle River chimney it means a cracked top, open joints, veneer without drainage — or water getting in at old anchor holes, where the staining runs down from each one.

Prefab fireplaces in secondary chases

Some Upper Saddle River homes vent a secondary fireplace through a sided or veneered chase with a metal cover on top. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace it with a pitched stainless or copper cover and reframe the box if needed. It's a small share of our work here next to the masonry above.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Old bracket or bands on the chimney; cracks running down from bolt holes	Anchors cracked the brick; water in every hole	Remove hardware, drill and fill holes, replace cracked brick, repoint the face
Rust staining down the chimney from a band or bolt	Corroding steel	Remove, clean, repoint
Top courses out of line under a strap	Band tightened as it rusted	Rebuild the top courses, crown
Cracked top around two or three flues	Mortar wash on a wide top	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown, capped flues
Sandy joints; loose stones; staining through veneer	Mortar past its lifespan; no drainage behind veneer	Grind or hand-rake and repoint; open and drain veneer
Ceiling stain beside the chimney during rain	No cricket; tarred flashing; cable across the flashing	Cricket, step and counter-flashing cut into the masonry, reroute cable

Common questions from Upper Saddle River homeowners

There's an old antenna bracket on my chimney. Does it matter?
Yes. Every bolt hole is open to water, the steel is rusting and staining the brick, and the bands are usually cracking the courses they're wrapped around. It should come off and the holes should be filled.

The dish installer wants to mount on the chimney. Should I let them?
No. A chimney is the worst place for a dish — the holes leak, the wind load works the top courses, and the cable gets stapled across the flashing. A roof mount on the framing or a mast does the same job without the damage.

Will the filled holes show?
Not once the face is repointed as a whole. The holes are filled in matched mortar and the surrounding joints are done at the same time so the repairs blend.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing, through the masonry, or at an anchor hole, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Upper Saddle River by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 25 minutes from Upper Saddle River. Our own crews handle the masonry, the stone work, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Saddle River, Montvale, Mahwah, Ramsey, Allendale, and across Bergen County.

Next is Waldwick.

Waldwick — 1920s–40s homes around the station and Franklin Turnpike, 1950s–60s capes and splits on the rest. Leads with something no other page has: the problems a chimney sweep finds and refers out — "you need a mason" — and what each one actually means.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/waldwick-nj/`
Title tag (55 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Waldwick NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (153 chars): Chimney repair in Waldwick, NJ — what to do when the sweep says you need a mason; brick repointing, cracked crowns, flashing leaks, and roofline rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Waldwick, NJ

Waldwick is a town of 1920s–40s houses around the station and Franklin Turnpike and 1950s–60s capes and splits on the streets off Wyckoff Avenue and Crescent Avenue, and a lot of people here use their fireplaces — which means a lot of chimneys get swept every fall, and a lot of those sweeps end with "you should have a mason look at that." The sweep cleans the flue and inspects it with a camera; what he finds is usually a masonry problem he doesn't do. The homeowner is left with a photo of something inside the chimney and no idea what it means or costs.

Here's what sweeps find on Waldwick chimneys, what each finding actually is, and how Lita Construction repairs it.

What the sweep found, and what it means

"Cracked crown" or "crown deteriorated." The top of the chimney — the mortar wash around the flue — is cracked. Water is getting into the top courses. This is the most common finding and the most important: it's the source of most of the other damage. The fix is a poured concrete crown.

"Missing or damaged cap." The flue is open or the cap is rusted or loose. Rain, animals, and debris are going down the flue. A stainless cap sized to the flue.

"Cracked or spalled flue tiles" / "missing mortar between tiles." Seen on the camera: the clay liner is cracked, usually in the top few tiles from water coming in at the crown, sometimes further down from heat or a past chimney fire. If it's the top tiles, they're replaced when the top is rebuilt. If it goes deeper, the flue needs a stainless liner before the fireplace is used.

"Deteriorated mortar joints" / "mortar washing out." The outside of the chimney. The joints are past their life and need repointing.

"Spalling brick." Brick faces breaking off. Water has been in the chimney long enough to damage the brick itself — a repoint with brick replacement, or a rebuild of the upper stack if it's widespread.

"Smoke chamber needs parging." The sloped area above the firebox has rough or missing mortar, which collects creosote and draws poorly. It's parged smooth with refractory mortar — masonry work we do while the chimney is open.

"Flashing deteriorated." Seen from the roof: the metal at the base is tarred or lifted. A flashing repair.

How we handle it: send us the sweep's report and photos. We inspect from the roof and the attic — the sweep worked from inside and the ground — and give you a written scope that addresses each finding, in the order that matters: top first, then joints and brick, then flashing, with the flue work done while the top is open. Most Waldwick chimneys with a sweep's list need a crown, a repoint, and a cap, in one visit.

Cracked chimney top

Waldwick's chimneys were finished with a thin mortar wash around the flue liner — a century old on the pre-war homes, sixty years on the postwar ones — and it's cracked or gone. Once the top is open, rain goes into the top course, between the tiles and the brick, and down the core.

The repair: we remove the old wash, replace any cracked top tiles, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from the flue, overhanging the brick by two inches so water drips clear of the face, with a bond break around the flue tile so the tile can expand without cracking the crown. A stainless cap goes on the flue.

Chimney repointing in Waldwick

The 1950s–60s chimneys have mortar past its life — recessed, sandy, mortar you can pick out with a key. The pre-war homes near the station were laid in softer brick and lime mortar, and a past hard-mortar repoint on those shows as brick breaking around intact joints.

The repair: we grind the joints out three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep across every exposed face — including the wall section between the two roofs on a split — and repoint in a mortar matched to the brick: lime-rich on the pre-war homes, a standard Type N on the postwar ones, tinted to match and tooled to the original joint. Spalled brick is cut out and replaced with matched units.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or attic framing beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. On Waldwick's capes the chimney comes through at the ridge and the flashing turns the peak corner; on the splits it's the lower corner where the lower roof meets the chimney and the upper wall. Usually it's been redone during a past roof job with aluminum tarred to the brick.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and weave step flashing into every shingle course — both slopes with a saddle at the ridge on a cape, up the wall with a kickout at a split's lower corner. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — not caulked to the brick — wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket behind them. Matching shingles are woven back in.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up — in matched modular red on the postwar homes, reclaimed or matched soft brick in lime mortar on the older ones. Flue tiles are reset or replaced, the top gets a poured crown, and new flashing goes in. The section inside the house is left alone.

Flue liners and the smoke chamber

When the sweep's camera shows cracked tiles below the top few, or no liner at all, the chimney needs a stainless liner sized to the fireplace or appliance before it's used, run from the smoke chamber or appliance connection to the top and sealed at the crown. A smoke chamber with rough or missing mortar is parged smooth with refractory mortar at the same time. Both are done with the top open, as part of the same job.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Waldwick chimney it means a cracked top or open joints. Fix the source and the staining stops.

Prefab fireplace chases

A few Waldwick additions and newer homes vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood box with a metal cover on top. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years, and sweeps flag them as "chase cover rusted." We replace it with a pitched stainless cover and reframe the box if needed.

Quick guide

The sweep said	What it means	What we do
Cracked crown	Top letting water in	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown
Missing or damaged cap	Flue open to rain and animals	Stainless cap sized to the flue
Cracked flue tiles (top few)	Water damage from the crown	Replace top tiles when the top is rebuilt
Cracked flue tiles (further down) or unlined	Flue not safe to use	Stainless liner, sealed at the crown
Deteriorated mortar joints	Mortar past its lifespan	Grind and repoint in matched mortar
Spalling brick	Brick itself damaged	Replace brick and repoint, or rebuild the upper stack
Smoke chamber needs parging	Rough mortar above the firebox	Parge smooth in refractory mortar
Flashing deteriorated	Tarred or lifted at the roof	Step flashing, reglet-cut counter-flashing, cricket

Common questions from Waldwick homeowners

The sweep gave me a list. Do I need all of it?
Usually most of it, and usually it's less than it sounds. A crown, a repoint, and a cap are one visit on most chimneys. The flue work depends on what the camera showed. We go through the list and tell you what's urgent, what's routine, and what can wait.

Can I use the fireplace until it's fixed?
If the only findings are the crown, cap, joints, and flashing — yes, those are water problems, not fire problems. If the sweep found cracked flue tiles or no liner, no, not until it's lined.

Do you do the liner, or do I need someone else?
We do it, with the top open, as part of the masonry job.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Waldwick by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 25 minutes from Waldwick. Our own crews handle the masonry, the lining, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the sweep's whole list is one job. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Allendale, Ho-Ho-Kus, Midland Park, Wyckoff, Ridgewood, and across Bergen County.

Next is Washington Township.

Washington Township — Pascack Valley splits, bi-levels, and colonials from the 1950s–70s off Pascack Road and Washington Avenue. Leads with something no other page has: the fireplace nobody has lit in fifteen years — what it takes to get a dormant masonry chimney safe to use again.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/washington-township-nj/`
Title tag (60 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Washington Township NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (154 chars): Chimney repair in Washington Township, NJ — bringing a dormant fireplace chimney back into use, repointing, cracked crowns, flashing leaks, and rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Washington Township, NJ

Washington Township was built as a family town — splits, bi-levels, and colonials from the 1950s through the 70s on the streets off Pascack Road, Washington Avenue, and Ridgewood Boulevard — and nearly every house got a fireplace. A lot of them haven't been used in years. The kids grew up, the damper got closed, a gas insert went into the family room or didn't, and

the chimney has sat there through twenty winters doing nothing but taking weather. Now a new owner, or the same owner with grandchildren, wants to light it.

A dormant chimney isn't a broken chimney, but it's an uninspected one. Here's what we check before a Washington Township fireplace goes back into service, and what we see on these chimneys generally.

Bringing a dormant fireplace back into use

The top. Twenty years of a cracked mortar wash means water has been going into the top courses and down between the flue tiles and the brick the whole time. We check the crown, the top tiles, and the courses under them from the roof. Almost always, the crown is replaced and the top tile or two with it.

The flue. A camera inspection from the top and from the firebox. We're looking for cracked tiles, missing mortar between tiles, a nest or debris blocking the flue, and creosote from the last time it was used. Cracked tiles in the top few are replaced when the top is rebuilt; deeper damage means a stainless liner before any fire goes in. A clear, sound clay liner is fine as-is.

The smoke chamber and firebox. The sloped area above the firebox is checked for missing mortar and parged smooth if needed. The firebox is checked for loose firebrick and open joints, which are repointed in refractory mortar. The damper is freed up or replaced.

The outside. Joints, brick, and flashing get the same inspection as any chimney, because a dormant chimney has been failing on the outside at the same rate as a used one.

The appliance question. If the furnace or water heater shares the chimney through a separate flue, we confirm the two flues are separated the full height and that the fireplace flue isn't pulling exhaust from the other. On a chimney that's had a gas appliance venting into an unlined flue for decades, that flue has its own condensation damage.

Then: a written list of what it needs to be used safely — often a crown, a cap, a repoint, the smoke chamber parged, and sometimes a liner — and the work is done with the top open in one job. A fireplace that's been dormant twenty years usually needs less than people fear and more than nothing.

Chimney repointing in Washington Township

The 1950s–70s chimneys here have mortar past its life — recessed, sandy, mortar you can pick out with a key, worse on the shaded north face under the trees. On a split-level, the wall section between the lower and upper roofs is as exposed as the stack above the roof and gets skipped by a lot of masons. On a bi-level with an exterior chimney, the full height is exposed.

The repair: we grind the joints out three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep across every exposed face — stack, wall section, and ground-level section where there is one — and repoint in a breathable Type N tinted to match, tooled to the original concave joint. Spalled brick is cut out and replaced with matched units. The top goes in the same visit.

Cracked chimney top

Every Washington Township chimney was finished with a thin mortar wash around the flue liner, cracked after fifty to seventy winters. Once the top is open, rain goes into the top course and down the core.

The repair: we remove the old wash, replace any cracked top tiles, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from the flue, overhanging the brick by two inches so water drips clear of the face, with a bond break around the flue tile. A stainless cap goes on the flue — on a dormant chimney that's going back into use, a cap with a spark arrestor screen.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or attic framing beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. On the splits it's the lower corner where the lower roof meets the chimney and the upper wall; on the colonials and bi-levels it's the main tie-in. The flashing was usually redone during a past roof job with aluminum tarred to the brick.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane — up the wall with a kickout at a split's lower corner — and weave step flashing into every shingle course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — not caulked to the brick — wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket behind them. Matching shingles are woven back in.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in matched modular red brick, with the flue tiles reset or replaced, a poured crown, and new flashing. On a dormant chimney that's being put back into use, the rebuild and the liner happen together while the top is open. The section inside the house is left alone.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Washington Township chimney it means a cracked top or open joints — and on a dormant chimney it's often heavy, because nobody's been looking.

Prefab fireplace chases

Some Washington Township additions and 1980s-and-later homes vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood box with a metal cover on top. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace it with a pitched stainless cover and reframe the box if needed. A dormant prefab unit gets its own inspection before use, but it's a smaller share of our work here than the masonry above.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Fireplace unused for years; want to light it	Unknown condition inside and out	Inspect top, flue, smoke chamber, firebox, exterior; written list; one job
Cracked or missing mortar at the top	Mortar wash cracked; top tiles likely cracked	Replace top tiles, poured crown, cap with spark screen
Cracked tiles below the top, or no liner	Flue not safe to use	Stainless liner, sealed at the crown
Rough or missing mortar above the firebox	Smoke chamber eroded	Parge smooth in refractory mortar
Sandy joints, worse between a split's two roofs	Mortar past its lifespan; wall section skipped	Grind and repoint every exposed face
Ceiling stain at the lower corner of a split during rain	Tarred flashing at the hardest tie-in	Membrane up the wall, step flashing, kickout, reglet-cut counter-flashing

Common questions from Washington Township homeowners

We haven't used the fireplace in fifteen years. Is it safe to light?
Not until it's been looked at. Most dormant chimneys need a crown, a cap, and some repointing, and some need the top flue tiles replaced or a liner. We inspect inside and out and tell you exactly what it needs before any fire goes in.

Do you do the inside — the flue, the smoke chamber — or just the outside?
Both, in the same job, with the top open. The camera inspection, the top tiles, the liner if needed, the smoke chamber parging, and the exterior masonry are all ours.

Can the crown be done without rebuilding the chimney?
Yes, if the brick below it is sound. We check the top courses and the top tiles when we remove the old wash and rebuild only what's failed.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Washington Township by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about fifteen minutes from Washington Township. Our own crews handle the masonry, the lining, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so bringing a chimney back into service is one job. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Westwood, Hillsdale, Emerson, River Vale, Paramus, and across Bergen County.

Next is Westwood.

Westwood — the Pascack Valley's downtown. Beyond the 1900s–30s homes near the center and the 1950s–60s capes and splits around them, Westwood has a real commercial main street: two- and three-story brick buildings on Westwood Avenue and Broadway with apartments over the stores. Leads with something no other page has: chimneys on those buildings — flat roofs, parapets, shared walls, tenants.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/westwood-nj/`
Title tag (55 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Westwood NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (154 chars): Chimney repair in Westwood, NJ — chimneys on downtown mixed-use buildings and flat roofs, brick repointing, cracked crowns, flashing leaks, and rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Westwood, NJ

Westwood has two kinds of chimney work. The houses — 1900s–30s Victorians and colonials around the center and the station, 1950s–60s capes and splits on the streets off Kinderkamack Road and Third Avenue — have the chimney problems every Bergen County house has at that age. The downtown — the two- and three-story brick buildings along Westwood Avenue and Broadway, stores below and apartments above — has chimneys that most residential masons won't touch: tall brick stacks rising out of flat roofs, sometimes shared between two buildings, serving boilers and water heaters for several tenants, with access through a hatch and a parapet.

Here's what we see on both and how Lita Construction repairs them.

Chimneys on downtown mixed-use buildings

A chimney on a flat-roofed commercial building fails differently from one on a house. It stands eight or ten feet above a membrane roof with nothing around it to break the wind. It's flashed into the roof membrane, not into shingles, and that base flashing was usually done by whoever last did the roof — turned up the brick and sealed with mastic, which fails at the top edge. It often serves a boiler that's been converted from oil to gas, so the inside has been attacked by condensation for twenty years. And it's a century old, in soft brick, often with a corbeled top that's shedding units onto the roof — or onto the sidewalk.

For the owner, the problems are practical: the boiler can't be down long, the tenants need notice, the sidewalk below may need protection, and the work has to go through a roof hatch or up a ladder from the alley.

How we handle it: we inspect from the roof and write up the stack, the base flashing, and the flue. The masonry is done from scaffolding set on the roof with load-spreading planks over the membrane: spalled brick replaced, joints repointed in a lime-rich mortar, the top rebuilt — corbel to the original profile — and crowned, every flue capped. The base flashing is rebuilt the right way for a membrane roof: a base flashing run a minimum of eight inches up the brick and bonded to the roof, capped with metal counter-flashing set into a reglet in the mortar joint. If the flue serves a gas boiler, a stainless liner sized to the appliance keeps the condensation off the brick. We schedule around the boiler, give tenants notice, and protect the sidewalk when the stack is on the street side.

Chimney repointing in Westwood

On the houses, the pre-war chimneys near the center are in soft brick and lime mortar, worn at the joints and often repointed once in a hard modern mortar that's now breaking the brick around it. The postwar chimneys are at the end of their original mortar's life — recessed, sandy, mortar you can pick out with a key.

The repair: we grind the joints out three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep across every exposed face — including the wall section between the two roofs on a split — and repoint in a mortar matched to the brick: lime-rich on the pre-war homes and the downtown buildings, a standard Type N on the postwar homes, tinted to match and tooled to the original joint. Spalled brick is cut out and replaced with matched units.

Cracked chimney top

Westwood's chimneys — a mortar wash on the postwar homes, a wash or a corbeled cap on the older houses and the downtown buildings — have been cracked for decades on most. Once the top is open, rain goes into the top course and down the core, feeding the failing joints and spalling below.

The repair: we remove the old wash or cap, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from every flue, overhanging the brick by two inches so water drips clear of the face, with a bond break around each flue tile. Each flue gets a stainless cap. A corbeled top is rebuilt to the original profile under the crown.

Chimney leaking when it rains

On the houses, a stain on a ceiling or attic framing beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak — tarred-over flashing from a past roof job, at the ridge on a cape or the lower corner on a split. On the downtown buildings, water on a top-floor apartment ceiling near the chimney is the base flashing at the flat roof.

The repair: on shingle roofs we strip the surrounding courses, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, weave step flashing into every course, and set the counter-flashing into a reglet ground into the mortar joint. On flat roofs it's the membrane base flashing and reglet counter-flashing described above. Chimneys wider than 30 inches on a pitched roof get a cricket.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans — common on the tall downtown stacks that take the wind — the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in reclaimed or matched soft brick and lime mortar on the older buildings and houses, matched modular red on the postwar homes. Flue tiles are reset or

replaced, the top gets a poured crown, and new flashing goes in. On a downtown building the rebuild is scheduled so the boiler flue is out of service for the shortest possible time.

Furnace and boiler chimneys after gas conversions

Most Westwood chimneys, residential and commercial, vent a gas appliance that replaced oil. Gas exhaust condenses in a cold masonry flue, and the acidic condensate breaks down the mortar and brick from inside — brick flakes on the roof, staining near the top, mortar crumbs at the base. The masonry is repaired like any other, and a stainless liner sized to the appliance keeps it from happening again. If nothing vents into the chimney anymore, the flue is capped and sealed.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Westwood chimney it means a cracked top, open joints, or gas-exhaust condensation showing through near the top. Fix the source and the staining stops.

Prefab fireplace chases

A few Westwood additions and newer homes vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood box with a metal cover on top. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace it with a pitched stainless cover and reframe the box if needed. It's a small share of our work in town next to the masonry above.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Brick on the roof or sidewalk below a downtown stack	Corbeled top shedding; wind on a tall stack	Scaffold on the roof, rebuild the top, crown, cap; protect the sidewalk
Top-floor apartment ceiling stain near the chimney	Membrane turned up and sealed with mastic	Base flashing up the brick, metal counter-flashing in a reglet
Brick flakes, staining near the top (gas boiler)	Exhaust condensation from inside	Repair masonry, stainless liner, sealed crown
Sandy, recessed joints (house)	Mortar past its lifespan	Grind and repoint in matched mortar

Brick faces popping off; joints intact (pre-war)	Hard-mortar repoint on soft brick	Replace spalled brick, repoint in lime-rich mortar
Ceiling stain beside the chimney during rain (house)	Tarred flashing; no cricket	Step flashing, reglet-cut counter-flashing, cricket

Common questions from Westwood homeowners and building owners

I own a building on Westwood Avenue. Can you work on the chimney without shutting down the boiler for days?
Yes. We schedule the work so the flue is open for the shortest time — usually a day for the top and the liner — and coordinate with the tenants. The exterior masonry and flashing don't require the boiler to be off at all.

The chimney is shared with the building next door. Whose job is it?
Usually both owners', and we've worked it out before: we inspect the stack, separate the flues in the write-up, and give each owner a scope for their side or a combined one. The work is the same either way.

My chimney was repointed 20 years ago and now the bricks are breaking. Why?
Almost certainly a hard mortar on soft pre-war brick. The mortar is now stronger than the brick, so the brick takes the freeze-thaw damage. The fix is to replace the damaged brick and repoint in a lime-rich mortar.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic — or the top floor — before quoting. That shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Westwood by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about fifteen minutes from Westwood. Our own crews handle the masonry, the lining, the flashing, and the roof tie-in — shingle or membrane — so the job isn't split between a mason and a roofer, on a house or a commercial building. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Washington Township, Hillsdale, Emerson, River Vale, Old Tappan, and across Bergen County.

Next is Woodcliff Lake.

Woodcliff Lake — large 1960s–90s colonials and 2000s homes on wooded lots around the reservoir and off Chestnut Ridge Road, with wide multi-flue chimneys. Leads with something no other page has: custom chimney caps — the multi-flue copper and stainless caps that a wide chimney needs and the stock caps that don't fit it.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/woodcliff-lake-nj/`
Title tag (60 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Woodcliff Lake NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (153 chars): Chimney repair in Woodcliff Lake, NJ — custom multi-flue chimney caps, brick and stone repointing, cracked crowns, flashing leaks, and roofline rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Woodcliff Lake, NJ

Woodcliff Lake's chimneys are wide. The large colonials built from the 1960s through the 90s on the wooded lots around the reservoir and off Chestnut Ridge Road, and the bigger homes that followed in the 2000s, carry chimneys with two, three, and four flues side by side — fireplace, second fireplace, furnace, water heater — on a top the size of a card table. Those chimneys have the same crown and joint problems as any brick stack, but they have one more that a cape doesn't: the top is too wide and too busy for a stock cap, and most of them have either no cap at all or a mismatched collection of individual caps that catch water between them.

Here's what we see on Woodcliff Lake chimneys and how Lita Construction repairs them.

Caps for multi-flue chimneys

A chimney cap does three things: keeps rain out of the flue, keeps animals and leaves out, and keeps sparks in. On a single-flue chimney a stock stainless cap does all three. On a four-flue Woodcliff Lake chimney, four stock caps side by side leave gaps between them where rain pools on the crown, the screens rust at different rates, and the whole top looks like an afterthought from the street. A lot of these chimneys have one cap on the fireplace flue and nothing on the other three.

What we install: a single custom-fabricated cap that covers the whole top — stainless steel on most homes, 20-ounce copper on homes with copper gutters and flashing — with a pitched lid, a mesh skirt on all four sides for spark and animal control, and the lid held high enough above the flues that the furnace and fireplace both draw properly. It's measured to the chimney and built to fit, sits on the crown with an overhang so water sheds off the sides, and is fastened to the masonry, not glued. On a chimney where the top courses or the crown also need work, the cap goes on last, over a poured crown, so there's a single sealed top from the brick up.

Cracked chimney top on a wide chimney

The crown under those caps is the other half. A top that wide was finished by the builder with a mortar wash, and a wash on a surface that size cracks within a few seasons. Once it's open, rain goes into the top courses and down between the tiles and the brick — on a chimney with four flues, that's a lot of tile joints to find.

The repair: we remove the failed wash, rebuild any top courses that have taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from every flue, overhanging the masonry by two inches on all sides so water drips clear of the face, with wire or fiber reinforcement so it won't crack across its width and a bond break around each flue tile so the tiles can expand without cracking the crown. Then the cap.

Chimney repointing in Woodcliff Lake

The 1960s–80s brick chimneys have mortar at or past its life — recessed, sandy, worse on the weather face and under the trees. The stone and stone-veneer chimneys on the newer homes have wide joints that wash out sooner than brick, and veneer without drainage behind it shows white staining through the face.

The repair: on brick, we grind the joints out three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep across every exposed face and repoint in a breathable Type N tinted to match, tooled to the original joint; spalled brick is cut out and replaced. On stone, we rake the joints by hand, reset any loose stones, and repoint in a matched mortar to the original profile. On veneer, we open the affected face, install the drainage layer and weep screed that were left out, and re-set the stone.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or attic framing beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. The wide chimneys here usually have no cricket behind them, so water and leaves dam against the uphill wall, and the flashing was redone during a past roof job with aluminum tarred to the brick — or surface-caulked to stone on the newer homes.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and weave step flashing into every shingle course.

The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint, or a channel cut into stone — not caulked on — wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches — all of them here — get a cricket framed behind them with a custom metal valley. Copper on the higher-end homes to match. Matching shingles are woven back in.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in matched brick or salvaged stone, with the flue tiles reset or replaced, a poured crown, and a custom cap. The section inside the house is left alone.

Furnace and water heater flues

On a four-flue chimney, two of the flues usually serve gas appliances that replaced oil. Gas exhaust condenses in a cold masonry flue and breaks down the tile and brick from inside; those flues get a stainless liner sized to the appliance, sealed at the crown and terminated under the cap. The fireplace flues are inspected with a camera at the same time.

White stains on brick or stone

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Woodcliff Lake chimney it means a cracked top, open joints, veneer without drainage, or condensation in an unlined appliance flue. Fix the source and the staining stops.

Prefab fireplaces in secondary chases

Some Woodcliff Lake homes vent a secondary fireplace through a sided or veneered chase with a metal cover on top. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace it with a pitched stainless or copper cover and reframe the box if needed. It's a small share of our work here next to the masonry above.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Several mismatched caps, or none, on a wide chimney	Stock caps don't fit a multi-flue top	Custom stainless or copper multi-flue cap over a poured crown

Cracked top across two to four flues	Mortar wash on a slab-sized top	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown with bond breaks; then the cap
Sandy joints; loose stones; staining through veneer	Mortar past its lifespan; no drainage behind veneer	Grind or hand-rake and repoint; open and drain veneer
Ceiling stain beside a wide chimney during rain	No cricket; tarred or caulked flashing	Cricket, step and counter-flashing cut into the masonry
Staining near the top; brick flakes (appliance flues)	Gas-exhaust condensation from inside	Stainless liners, sealed at the crown
Spalling through faces, crack through courses, lean	Core failure above the roofline	Roofline rebuild in matched brick or stone, crown, cap

Common questions from Woodcliff Lake homeowners

Can I just put caps on the flues that don't have one?
You can, but on a wide chimney four separate caps leave gaps that pool water on the crown and never look right. A single custom cap over the whole top sheds water, screens every flue, and matches the house.

Stainless or copper?
Stainless on most homes — it doesn't rust and it's priced reasonably. Copper where the house already has copper gutters and flashing; it weathers to the same patina.

Does the cap go on before or after the crown?
After. The crown is poured and cured, then the cap is fastened to it. A cap over a cracked wash just hides the problem.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Woodcliff Lake by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about twenty minutes from Woodcliff Lake. Our own crews handle the masonry, the metal work, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason, a sheet-metal shop, and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Park Ridge, Montvale, Hillsdale, Saddle River, River Vale, and across Bergen County.

Next is Wood-Ridge.

Wood-Ridge — a small, dense borough of 1920s–50s brick and frame houses and two-families off Valley Boulevard and Hackensack Street, with the newer townhouse development at the station. Leads with a symptom no other page has: water showing up at the base of the chimney in the basement — the cleanout, the old stove thimble, the saturated stack.

URL: `/chimney-repair/bergen-county/wood-ridge-nj/`
Title tag (57 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Wood-Ridge NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (154 chars): Chimney repair in Wood-Ridge, NJ — water at the chimney base in the basement, abandoned flue openings, brick repointing, cracked crowns, flashing, and rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Wood-Ridge, NJ

Wood-Ridge's houses are 1920s–50s, close together, and mostly on full basements, and a lot of the chimney calls we get here don't start on the roof. They start in the basement: water on the floor around the base of the chimney, a rusted cleanout door with a puddle behind it, a damp stain spreading up the brick from the floor, a cold draft from a hole in the chimney wall where a coal stove or an old furnace pipe used to connect. The homeowner thinks it's a foundation problem. Usually it's the chimney, and the water came in at the top.

Here's how we read what's at the bottom of a Wood-Ridge chimney, and what we see on these chimneys generally.

Water at the base of the chimney in the basement

A masonry chimney is a column that runs from the basement floor to above the roof, and water that gets in at the top runs down the inside of it — down the flue, down between the flue tiles and the brick — until it reaches the bottom. On most Wood-Ridge chimneys the bottom is a cleanout at basement level: a small metal door into the base of the flue. Water collects there, rusts the door, and seeps out onto the floor. What you see:

A puddle at the cleanout after rain, or a rusted-through cleanout door. Rain is coming down the flue — no cap, a cracked top, or both. The fix is at the top: a crown and a cap. A new cleanout door goes on after the stack dries out.

The brick at the base dark and damp, staining rising a foot or two up the stack. The chimney is saturated — a cracked top and open joints have been feeding it water for years, and the lowest courses are wicking it. Fixed at the top and the joints; the base dries over a season.

A draft or water from an open hole in the chimney wall. An abandoned thimble — the round opening where a stove pipe or an old furnace connector once entered the flue — left open or stuffed with rags when the appliance was removed. Open thimbles let water, cold air, and flue gases into the basement. They're closed with a mortared-in masonry plug, not a tin cover.

Water at the base with no rain. Condensation from a gas furnace or water heater venting into an unlined flue, running down and collecting at the cleanout. The flue needs a stainless liner.

The repair: the top first — crown, cap, top courses — then the joints, then the liner if an appliance needs it, then the basement: thimbles plugged, cleanout door replaced, the base repointed once it's dry. Water at the base stops when the top is closed; most of the basement work is finishing.

Chimney repointing in Wood-Ridge

The 1920s–30s chimneys are in soft brick and lime mortar, worn at the joints and often repointed once in a hard modern mortar that's now breaking the brick around it. The 1940s–50s chimneys are at the end of their original mortar's life — recessed, sandy, mortar you can pick out with a key.

The repair: we grind the joints out three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep across every exposed face above the roof and repoint in a mortar matched to the brick: lime-rich on the pre-war homes, a standard Type N on the postwar ones, tinted to match and tooled to the original joint. Spalled brick is cut out and replaced with matched units. The basement section is repointed from inside once it's dried out.

Cracked chimney top

Every Wood-Ridge chimney was finished with a thin mortar wash around the flue liner, and after 70 to 100 winters it's cracked or gone. Once the top is open, rain goes into the top course and down the core — and ends up in the basement.

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from every flue, overhanging the brick by two inches so water drips clear of the face, with a bond break around each flue tile. Each flue gets a stainless cap. On a chimney that still vents a gas appliance into bare tile, the liner goes in while the top is open.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on an upstairs ceiling or in the attic beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak — a separate problem from the basement water, but it often comes up on the same inspection. On Wood-Ridge's capes and two-families the chimney usually comes through near the ridge, and the flashing has been redone through two or three roof jobs with aluminum tarred to the brick.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and weave step flashing into every shingle course on both slopes with a folded saddle at the ridge. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — not caulked to the brick — wedged, and sealed. Matching shingles are woven back in.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in reclaimed or matched soft brick and lime mortar on the pre-war homes, matched modular red on the postwar ones. Flue tiles are reset or replaced, the top gets a poured crown, and new flashing goes in. The section inside the house is left alone.

Two-family chimneys

Many of Wood-Ridge's two-families have one chimney serving both units' appliances through separate flues. Before anything is capped, lined, or plugged, we trace every flue and thimble to its appliance, and we coordinate the work so both units know when a flue is out of service.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Wood-Ridge chimney it means a cracked top or open joints — and in the basement, white powder on the lowest courses means the same water has reached the bottom.

Prefab fireplace chases

The newer townhouses at the station and a few additions vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood box with a metal cover on top. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace it with a pitched stainless cover and reframe the box if needed. It's a small share of our work in town next to the masonry above.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Puddle at the cleanout after rain; rusted cleanout door	Rain coming down the flue	Crown and cap; new cleanout door once dry
Damp brick and staining rising from the basement floor	Saturated stack from a cracked top and open joints	Crown, repoint; base repointed after it dries
Open hole in the chimney wall in the basement or kitchen	Abandoned stove or furnace thimble	Mortared masonry plug
Water at the base with no rain	Gas-appliance condensation in an unlined flue	Stainless liner, sealed at the crown
Upstairs ceiling stain beside the chimney during rain	Tarred flashing at the ridge	Step flashing both slopes, saddle, reglet-cut counter-flashing
Brick faces popping off; joints intact (pre-war)	Hard-mortar repoint on soft brick	Replace spalled brick, repoint in lime-rich mortar

Common questions from Wood-Ridge homeowners

There's water around the chimney in my basement. Is it the foundation?
Usually not. Water that gets into the chimney at the top runs down inside it and comes out at the cleanout or wicks into the base. We check the top first; if the crown is cracked or there's no cap, that's the source.

There's a hole in the chimney in my basement with a rag stuffed in it. Is that a problem?
Yes. It's an old thimble, and it lets water, cold air, and possibly flue gases into the basement. It should be closed with a mortared masonry plug.

My chimney was repointed 20 years ago and now the bricks are breaking. Why?
Almost certainly a hard mortar on soft pre-war brick. The mortar is now stronger than the brick,

so the brick takes the freeze-thaw damage. The fix is to replace the damaged brick and repoint in a lime-rich mortar.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof, from the attic, and from the basement before quoting. That shows whether water is entering at the flashing, coming down inside the stack, or condensing in the flue, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Wood-Ridge by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about twenty minutes from Wood-Ridge. Our own crews handle the masonry, the lining, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Hasbrouck Heights, Rutherford, Teaneck, Maywood, Fort Lee, and across Bergen County.

That's Bergen County done except Rochelle Park and Saddle Brook, which you skipped. Next is Morris County, starting with Boonton Township — say the word.

Boonton Township — the rural end of Morris County: 1960s–2000s homes on large lots off Rockaway Valley Road and Powerville Road, and a real stock of 18th- and 19th-century farmhouses that have been in continuous use since before the township existed. Leads with something no page has had yet: the center-chimney farmhouse — one huge stack, several fireplaces, a cooking hearth, rubble stone at the base.

URL: `/chimney-repair/morris-county/boonton-township-nj/`
Title tag (60 chars): Chimney Repair & Rebuilding Boonton Township NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (154 chars): Chimney repair in Boonton Township, NJ — historic farmhouse center chimneys, stone and brick repointing, cracked crowns, flashing leaks, and roofline rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Boonton Township, NJ

Boonton Township has some of the oldest chimneys we work on. The farmhouses along Rockaway Valley Road, Powerville Road, and the roads toward Split Rock were built in the 1700s and 1800s around a single massive center chimney — a stone or brick mass in the middle of the house, five or six feet on a side at the base, with a fireplace opening into it from every main room and a cooking hearth with a bake oven in the kitchen. Two hundred years later those chimneys are still carrying the house, and most are still in use. Around them, the rest of the township is 1960s–2000s custom homes on wooded lots with large brick and stone chimneys of their own.

Here's what we see on Boonton Township chimneys, old and new, and how Lita Construction repairs them.

Center chimneys on 18th- and 19th-century farmhouses

A colonial center chimney is a different structure from a modern chimney. It was built as a solid mass — fieldstone laid in clay or lime mortar at the base, often transitioning to handmade brick above the roof — with several flues winding up through it and merging near the top. It was never lined. It was built on a stone footing in a cellar, and the house was framed around it. After two centuries, what we find:

The stack above the roof is usually handmade soft brick in lime mortar, weathered to the point where the joints are sand and the top courses are loose. Many were rebuilt once in the 1900s, some well, some in hard mortar that's now breaking the old brick around it.

The flues are unlined, irregular, and often joined — two fireplaces sharing a flue near the top. A camera inspection finds a century of creosote in the ones that were used, and bird nests and collapsed brick in the ones that weren't.

Inside the house the chimney mass has been chased for pipes and wires, had fireplaces bricked up and later reopened, and had the bake oven turned into a cupboard. The mortar in the attic section is often gone entirely.

The repair is conservation more than construction. The stack above the roof is taken down to sound brick and rebuilt in reclaimed handmade brick laid in a lime mortar that matches the original — hard Portland mortar on this brick is the one thing we won't do. The top is crowned in a way that doesn't change the chimney's profile from the road, and the flues that are in use are lined with insulated stainless liners sized to each fireplace, which is the only way a 200-year-old unlined flue is safe to burn in. Flues that aren't in use are capped. The attic section is repointed from inside. The fireplaces and the bake oven are left as they are unless the owner wants them worked on — and when they do, firebrick and refractory mortar go in, not modern brick.

Matching handmade brick and lime mortar

The brick on these houses was made on or near the farm, fired unevenly, and ranges from salmon to dark red to near-black. Modern brick doesn't match it, and even reclaimed brick from a 1920s house is too uniform. We source brick from salvage that's the right period and size, blend it through the rebuilt section so the range of color reads the way the original did, and lay it in a lime putty or lime-rich mortar matched to the original color and sand, with the joint tooled to what the house has — often a flush or slightly weathered joint. The rebuilt section weathers in over a couple of seasons and stops reading as new.

Stone chimneys on newer homes

The custom homes built in the township since the 1960s often have fieldstone chimneys, frequently in local stone, and they fail at the joints — the irregular face holds water, the tree cover keeps it wet, and winter works the mortar loose. Mortar crumbs at the base and a stone that moves when pushed are the signs. Stone-veneer chimneys on the newest homes show white staining through the face when there's no drainage behind the stone.

The repair: we rake the joints out by hand with chisels and a narrow grinder — a wide blade scars the stone — at least three-quarters of an inch deep and deeper on the wide joints, reset loose stones in fresh mortar, and repoint in a Type N matched to the existing color and sand, finished to the original joint. On veneer, we open the affected face, install the drainage layer that was left out, and re-set the stone.

Cracked chimney top

The newer brick chimneys were finished with a mortar wash around the flue tiles, cracked after decades of freeze-thaw at this elevation. The farmhouse chimneys have whatever the last rebuild put on top, usually a wash as well. Once the top is open, rain goes into the core.

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from every flue, overhanging the masonry by two inches so water drips clear of the face, with a bond break around each flue tile or liner. Each flue gets a stainless cap. On a farmhouse chimney the crown is kept low and the caps simple so the profile from the road doesn't change.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or attic framing beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. On a center-chimney farmhouse the stack comes through the ridge and the flashing turns the peak corner on a roof that may be standing-seam metal, cedar, or asphalt over several older layers. On the newer homes it's the usual tarred-over flashing and no cricket behind a wide stack.

The repair: we strip or reset the roofing around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and set step flashing into every course with

a folded saddle at the ridge. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — gently on handmade brick — or a channel cut into stone, wedged, and sealed. On metal roofs we flash into the seams and solder. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans — common on the farmhouse stacks, which have been taking weather longer than anything else in the county — the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in period brick and lime mortar, or matched brick or salvaged stone on the newer homes, with the flues lined or the tiles reset, a crown, and new flashing. The section inside the house is left alone.

White stains on brick or stone

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Boonton Township chimney it means a cracked top, open joints, or veneer without drainage. On a farmhouse chimney it can also be two centuries of salts in the brick itself, which is harmless and stops once the top and joints are closed.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Loose, sandy brick on a farmhouse stack; top courses leaning	Two centuries of weather on handmade brick and lime mortar	Rebuild in period brick and lime mortar, low crown, line the flues in use
Fireplaces in use on an unlined 1700s chimney	No liner	Camera inspection; insulated stainless liners per flue
Rebuilt section in modern red brick on an old house	Past repair in the wrong brick	Rebuild in salvaged period brick, blended
Mortar crumbs at the base of a stone chimney; loose stone	Washed-out joints behind the stone	Hand-rake, reset stones, repoint
Cracked top around the flues (newer home)	Mortar wash cracked	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown, capped flues
Ceiling stain at the ridge during rain	Flashing failed at the peak corner	Step flashing both slopes, saddle, reglet-cut counter-flashing

Common questions from Boonton Township homeowners

Our house is from the 1780s and we use three fireplaces. Is the chimney safe?
Not without liners. An unlined 240-year-old flue has cracks, gaps, and creosote you can't see. A camera inspection tells us the condition, and insulated stainless liners in the flues you use make them safe without changing the chimney.

Will the rebuilt brick look like the original?
We use salvaged handmade brick of the right period and size, blend the color range the way the original mason did, and lay it in lime mortar. It weathers in over a couple of seasons.

Can a stone chimney be repointed, or does it have to be rebuilt?
Repointed, if the stones are still seated and water isn't coming through the inside of the stack. We check both from the roof.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Boonton Township by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 45 minutes from Boonton Township, and we take on historic masonry that most roofing companies won't. Our own crews handle the masonry, the lining, the flashing, and the roof tie-in. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Montville, Kinnelon, Denville, Mountain Lakes, Parsippany-Troy Hills, and across Morris County.

Next is Chatham Borough.

Chatham Borough — a small, old town: 1890s–1920s Victorians and Colonial Revivals on the streets off Main Street and around the station, 1950s capes filling in the edges. Leads with something no page has had: the chimney that comes through a complicated roof — set in a valley, against a dormer, at the junction of three roof planes — which is where Victorian-era chimneys leak.

URL: `/chimney-repair/morris-county/chatham-borough-nj/`
Title tag (58 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Chatham Borough NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (153 chars): Chimney repair in Chatham Borough, NJ — chimneys in roof valleys and against dormers, 100-year-old brick repointing, cracked crowns, flashing, and rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Chatham Borough, NJ

Chatham Borough's houses were built when roofs were complicated. The Victorians and Queen Annes from the 1890s and the Colonial Revivals and foursquares from the 1900s–20s on the streets off Main Street, Fairmount Avenue, and around the station have roofs with gables crossing gables, dormers on every side, and valleys running in several directions — and the chimneys come up wherever the floor plan put the fireplaces, which is rarely a clean spot on a single roof slope. A chimney that rises out of a valley, or with a dormer cheek wall on one side and a main slope on the other, has flashing that turns three or four corners, and after a century of re-roofing, those corners are where the water gets in.

Here's what we see on Chatham chimneys and how Lita Construction repairs them.

Chimneys in valleys and against dormers

On a simple roof, a chimney is flashed on four sides: uphill, downhill, two sides. On a Chatham Victorian, one side of the chimney might sit in a valley where two slopes meet, another against the side wall of a dormer, and the uphill side might face a slope that drains the entire back of the house. Each of those is a different flashing detail, and each has to connect to the next without a gap.

Over four or five roof jobs, every roofer has solved those corners differently — usually with more tar. We open these up and find valley metal cut short of the chimney, step flashing that stops where the dormer begins, and roofing cement filling the gap between. It holds a few years. The stain shows up on the ceiling below the valley side, or on the dormer ceiling, and it's blamed on the dormer or the valley rather than the chimney.

The repair: we strip the roofing around the chimney far enough to rebuild every detail that touches it — the valley, the dormer cheek, the main slope. Any rotted deck is replaced. The base is wrapped in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane carried up the dormer wall and under the valley. New valley metal runs full length and terminates properly against the chimney with a soldered corner. Step flashing goes into every course on the open sides and ties into the dormer's wall flashing with a kickout at the bottom. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet

ground into the mortar joint — gently on soft century-old brick — on every side, and where the chimney has an uphill face wider than 30 inches, a cricket is framed into the slope behind it. On these houses we do it all in 20-ounce copper, soldered, which is what the house had originally and what lasts. Slates are removed and reset; shingles are re-woven.

Repointing 100-year-old brick

The brick on Chatham's older houses is soft, laid in a lime mortar that was meant to wear and be renewed. A century on, the original mortar is recessed and sandy on the weather side, and most of these chimneys have been repointed at least once — often in a hard modern mortar that outlasts the brick and lets it crack around the intact joints. Faces popping off and flakes in the gutter with the joints looking fine is that problem, and it's common on the tall Victorian stacks that take the most wind.

The repair: we grind out the worn or hard mortar three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep, carefully on soft brick so the edges aren't nicked, replace spalled units with reclaimed or matched brick, and repoint in a lime-rich Type N or Type O matched to the original color and sand, tooled to the original joint — struck, grapevine, or weathered joints are all common here. The 1950s capes take a standard Type N repoint, ground out and tooled to the concave joint.

Cracked chimney top

The tops of Chatham's older chimneys — a mortar wash, a corbeled brick cap, sometimes a stone slab — have been cracked for decades. Once the top is open, rain goes into the core and comes out wherever the mortar is weakest, which on a century-old chimney is often the attic section.

The repair: we remove the old wash or cap, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from every flue, overhanging the brick by two inches so water drips clear of the face, with a bond break around each flue tile. A corbeled top is rebuilt to the original profile under the crown. Each flue gets a cap, copper on the houses with copper work.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in reclaimed or color-matched soft brick and lime mortar, with any corbel or decorative course rebuilt to the original profile. Flue tiles are reset or replaced, the top gets a poured crown, and the flashing — valley, dormer, and all — is rebuilt in copper. The section inside the house is left alone.

The attic section of a century-old chimney

On Chatham's oldest houses the attic section of the chimney was laid in lime mortar and never pointed finished, and if the top has been open for years, water has been running down the inside and out through those joints. Mortar dust on the attic floor and brick you can wiggle by hand are the signs. That section is repointed from inside in a lime-rich mortar, and the top is fixed so it stops.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Chatham chimney it means a cracked top or open joints — or, on the courses nearest a valley or dormer, water getting in at that flashing corner.

Prefab fireplace chases

A few Chatham additions and newer houses vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood box with a metal cover on top. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace it with a pitched stainless or copper cover and reframe the box if needed. It's a small share of our work in town next to the masonry above.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Stain below a valley or on a dormer ceiling beside the chimney	Flashing corners tarred over through several roofs	Rebuild valley, dormer, and chimney flashing together in soldered copper
Brick faces popping off; joints intact	Hard-mortar repoint on soft brick	Replace spalled brick, repoint in lime-rich mortar
Sandy, washed-out joints on a tall stack	Original lime mortar worn	Grind and repoint in matched mortar
Cracked top; brick missing from a corbel	Wash or cap failed	Poured crown; corbel rebuilt to original profile; caps
Mortar dust on the attic floor	Attic section taking water from the top	Repoint from inside; fix the top
Spalling through faces, crack through courses, lean	Core failure above the roofline	Roofline rebuild in matched brick, copper flashing

Common questions from Chatham Borough homeowners

The leak is at the dormer, not the chimney. Why are you looking at the chimney?
Because the dormer and the chimney share a corner, and that corner is usually where the water gets in. We rebuild the dormer wall flashing and the chimney flashing as one detail so there's no seam between them.

Can you work on a slate roof?
Yes. Slates around the chimney, the valley, and the dormer are removed with a ripper and reset, not cut, and any that crack are replaced with matched salvaged slate.

My chimney was repointed 20 years ago and now the bricks are breaking. Why?
Almost certainly a hard mortar on soft pre-war brick. The mortar is now stronger than the brick, so the brick takes the freeze-thaw damage. The fix is to replace the damaged brick and repoint in a lime-rich mortar.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows which corner the water is coming from and whether it's also coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Chatham Borough by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 45 minutes from Chatham, and we take on the older-house flashing and masonry work that most roofers and masons each leave to the other. Our own crews handle the masonry, the copper work, the slate, and the roof tie-in. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Chatham Township, Madison, Summit, Florham Park, Millburn, and across Morris County.

Next is Chatham Township.

Back to the chimney list at Chatham Township — the larger, newer half of Chatham: 1960s–90s colonials and splits on big wooded lots in Green Village, Rolling Hill, and along the Great Swamp, with a few older farmhouses. Leads with something no chimney page has had: a chimney that lives next to a swamp — the humidity, the lichen, and the north face that never dries.

URL: `/chimney-repair/morris-county/chatham-township-nj/`
Title tag (59 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Chatham Township NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (153 chars): Chimney repair in Chatham Township, NJ — lichen and moisture damage, brick and stone repointing, cracked crowns, flashing leaks, and roofline chimney rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Chatham Township, NJ

Chatham Township backs onto the Great Swamp, and its chimneys know it. The colonials, splits, and larger homes built from the 1960s through the 90s on the wooded lots off Green Village Road, Southern Boulevard, and Fairmount Avenue sit in air that stays damp long after a storm has moved through — morning mist off the swamp, dew that lasts until noon under the oaks, humidity that a chimney in open sun thirty miles east never sees. A brick chimney in that air doesn't dry out between rains, and masonry that stays wet ages faster than the house around it.

Here's what we see on Chatham Township chimneys and how Lita Construction repairs them.

Lichen, moss, and the face that never dries

Look at the north or east face of a Chatham Township chimney and you'll usually find it: gray-green lichen crusted on the brick, moss in the joints, black streaking from the top down. It looks like dirt. It isn't. Lichen and moss hold water against the mortar the way a wet sponge would, and they keep it there through the freeze-thaw cycles of late winter. The joints under the growth go sandy sooner than the ones in the sun, and the brick behind them spalls — faces popping off, red flakes in the gutter — on a chimney that may be only forty years old.

The other effect of the damp is on the inside. A chimney that's wet through to the core has mortar failing between the flue tiles and brick, and when it's a furnace chimney that converted from oil to gas, the condensation from the exhaust adds to it from inside.

The repair: we clean the growth off the masonry first — a low-pressure wash with a biocide, never a pressure washer, which blasts the face off soft brick — because mortar can't bond to a dirty joint. The joints are ground out three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep across every face, deeper on the north side where they're worse, and repointed in a breathable Type N tinted to match, tooled to the original joint. Spalled brick is cut out and replaced. Then the chimney gets a breathable siloxane water repellent on every face: it beads water off the surface and slows the growth coming back, and because it breathes, it doesn't trap the moisture the way a sealer

would. On a chimney this close to the swamp, that repellent is the difference between repointing once and repointing again in fifteen years.

Cracked chimney top

The 1960s–90s chimneys here were finished with a thin mortar wash around the flue tiles, and in this damp it cracked early. Once the top is open, rain and mist go into the top courses and down the core, which is what feeds the spalling and failing joints below. On the wide multi-flue chimneys on the larger homes, the top is a slab and the wash cracked within a few seasons of being troweled.

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from every flue, overhanging the brick by two inches so water drips clear of the face, with wire or fiber reinforcement on the wide tops and a bond break around each flue tile. Each flue gets a stainless cap. The crown gets the same breathable repellent as the stack.

Chimney repointing in Chatham Township

Beyond the north-face problem, the 1960s and 70s chimneys have mortar at or past its life everywhere — recessed, sandy, mortar you can pick out with a key. On the splits, the wall section between the lower and upper roofs is as exposed as the stack and gets skipped by a lot of masons; on the colonials with an exterior-wall chimney, the full height from grade is exposed.

The repair: every exposed face, top to bottom — stack, wall section, and ground-level section where there is one — ground out and repointed in a matched Type N tooled to the original concave joint, spalled units replaced, the top done in the same visit. On the older farmhouses in Green Village, the brick is soft and lime-laid and gets a lime-rich mortar instead.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or attic framing beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. Chatham Township's wide chimneys usually have no cricket behind them, so wet leaves and water dam against the uphill wall, and the flashing was redone during a past roof job with aluminum tarred to the brick. On the splits it's the lower corner where the lower roof meets the chimney and the upper wall.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane — up the wall with a kickout at a split's lower corner — and weave step flashing into every shingle course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — not caulked to the brick — wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket framed behind them. Matching shingles are woven back in.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces — common on north faces here — a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in matched brick, with the flue tiles reset or replaced, a poured crown, new flashing, and the repellent applied once the mortar has cured. The section inside the house is left alone.

Stone chimneys on the larger lots

The bigger homes toward the swamp and the newer construction in the township often have fieldstone or stone-veneer chimneys. Stone fails at the joints — the irregular face holds water on every ledge, which in this air means always — and is repointed by hand with the loose stones reset in a matched mortar. Veneer with white staining through the face usually has no drainage behind it; we open the face, install the drainage layer, and re-set the stone. Flashing on stone is cut into the stone face itself.

Furnace chimneys after gas conversions

Most Chatham Township chimneys vent the furnace as well as the fireplace, and most houses have converted from oil to gas. Gas exhaust condenses in a cold masonry flue — and a damp one condenses more — and the acidic condensate breaks down the mortar and brick from inside: flakes in the gutter, staining near the top, mortar crumbs at the base. The masonry is repaired like any other, and a stainless liner sized to the appliance keeps it from happening again.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Chatham Township chimney it means a cracked top, open joints, or a stack that's simply staying wet in the swamp air. Fix the top and the joints, apply the repellent, and the staining stops.

Prefab fireplace chases

Some Chatham Township additions and newer homes vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood box with a metal cover on top. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through faster here than almost anywhere — the damp works on galvanized metal. We replace it with a pitched stainless cover and reframe the box if the wood under it has gone soft. It's a smaller share of our work in town than the masonry above.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Lichen and moss on the north face; joints sandy under it	Growth holding water against the mortar	Low-pressure clean, repoint every face, breathable repellent
Brick faces popping off on the shaded side	Freeze-thaw in brick that never dries	Replace spalled brick, repoint, repellent
Cracked top; staining running down from it	Mortar wash cracked	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown with caps
Sandy joints on the wall section of a split	Mortar past its lifespan; section skipped	Repoint every exposed face
Ceiling stain beside a wide chimney during rain	No cricket; tarred flashing	Cricket, step flashing, reglet-cut counter-flashing
Flakes in gutters, staining near the top (gas heat)	Exhaust condensation from inside	Repair masonry, stainless liner, sealed crown

Common questions from Chatham Township homeowners

Why does my chimney look so much older than my neighbor's across the street?
Exposure. A north-facing chimney under trees near the swamp stays wet; one in the sun dries. The repair is the same — repoint, crown, repellent — but the damp side needs it sooner, and the repellent matters more.

Should I seal my chimney?
With a breathable siloxane repellent, after the top and joints are made sound, yes — in this township it's the single most useful thing you can do. With anything that forms a film on the surface, no; that traps the water and spalls the brick.

Can the growth just be cleaned off?
It can, but on its own that's cosmetic. The growth is a sign the mortar under it is staying wet. We clean it as the first step of a repoint and the repellent slows it coming back.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Chatham Township by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 45 minutes from Chatham Township. Our own crews handle the masonry, the lining, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Chatham Borough, Madison, Harding, Long Hill, Florham Park, and across Morris County.

Next is Chester Borough.

Chester Borough — the Main Street village: 18th- and 19th-century houses along Route 24 and the streets off it, many now shops, offices, and inns, with 1960s–80s homes on the edges. Leads with something no chimney page has had: the chimney on a historic house that's become a business — kept for the look, unused for decades, and never properly closed.

URL: `/chimney-repair/morris-county/chester-borough-nj/`
Title tag (58 chars): Chimney Repair & Rebuilding Chester Borough NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (154 chars): Chimney repair in Chester Borough, NJ — historic Main Street chimneys, unused flues, period brick repointing, cracked crowns, flashing, and roofline rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Chester Borough, NJ

Chester Borough's Main Street is a line of 1700s and 1800s houses that stopped being houses — they're antique shops, offices, restaurants, and inns now, and the side streets around them are the homes those families moved to in the 1960s through 80s. The chimneys on the Main Street buildings are the village's skyline: two or three per roof, tall, in handmade brick or fieldstone, most of them unused for fifty years. They're what makes the street look the way it

does, and they're also two centuries old, open at the top, and taking weather into buildings full of inventory and customers.

Here's what we see on Chester Borough chimneys, on the historic buildings and the houses around them, and how Lita Construction repairs them.

Unused chimneys on historic buildings

A chimney that's part of a building's historic character has to stay. But a chimney that nothing vents into — the fireplaces sealed, the furnace moved to a direct vent — is a masonry column open to the sky, and rain has been going down it since the last fire went out. On the Main Street buildings we find flues full of water, bird nests, and collapsed brick; attic sections with the mortar washed out; stains on second-floor ceilings and down shop walls that have been attributed to the roof for years.

The repair: the chimney is kept and closed properly. The top is rebuilt — loose courses reset in period brick and lime mortar — and finished with a low crown that doesn't change the profile from the street, with every unused flue capped solid and sealed. The stack above the roof is repointed in a lime-rich mortar matched to the original, with spalled handmade brick replaced from salvage. The attic section is repointed from inside. The flashing is redone in copper, which is what these buildings had. If one flue still serves a fireplace the business uses, that flue is camera-inspected and lined with an insulated stainless liner, and capped open with a screen; the others stay sealed. The chimney looks the same from Main Street and stops leaking into the shop.

For a building owner, the practical part: we schedule around business hours, protect the sidewalk and storefront when a stack is on the street side, and work from roof scaffolding so the front of the building isn't blocked.

Period brick and lime mortar

Chester's oldest chimneys are handmade brick — fired unevenly, ranging from salmon to near-black — laid in lime mortar, and the fieldstone ones are local stone laid the same way. Modern brick doesn't match, and modern hard mortar on this brick is the one repair that makes things worse: it outlasts the brick and lets it crack around the intact joints, which is why so many Main Street chimneys have faces popping off next to gray mortar from a 1980s repair.

How we handle it: salvaged brick of the right period and size, blended through the rebuilt section so the color range reads like the original; a lime putty or lime-rich mortar matched to the color and sand of the original; the joint tooled to what the building has. On fieldstone, the joints are raked by hand, loose stones reset, and the pointing matched to the original profile. The repair weathers in over a couple of seasons and stops reading as new.

Chimney repointing on the 1960s–80s homes

The houses on the streets off Main Street and toward Chester Township have standard brick chimneys with mortar past its life — recessed, sandy, mortar you can pick out with a key — and the elevation here means more freeze-thaw cycles than the valley towns get.

The repair: every exposed face ground out three-quarters of an inch to an inch and repointed in a matched Type N tooled to the original joint, spalled brick replaced, the top done in the same visit.

Cracked chimney top

The newer chimneys were finished with a mortar wash around the flue tile, cracked after decades of mountain winters; the historic chimneys have whatever the last repair put on top, usually a wash as well. Once the top is open, rain goes into the core.

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from every flue, overhanging the masonry by two inches so water drips clear of the face, with a bond break around each flue tile or liner. Each active flue gets a stainless cap; unused flues are sealed. On a historic chimney the crown is kept low and the caps simple.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or down a wall beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. On the Main Street buildings the flashing has been patched with tar through generations of roofs, on standing-seam metal, slate, and asphalt; on the newer homes it's the usual tarred-over flashing and no cricket behind a wide stack.

The repair: we strip or reset the roofing around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and set step flashing into every course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — gently on handmade brick — or a channel cut into stone, wedged, and sealed. On metal roofs we flash into the seams and solder. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket. Copper on the historic buildings.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans — common on the tall Main Street stacks — the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in period brick and lime mortar or salvaged stone, or matched brick on the newer homes, with flues lined or sealed, a low crown, and new flashing. The section inside the building is left alone.

White stains on brick or stone

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Chester chimney it means a cracked top or open joints — and on a two-century-old chimney, some of it is salts in the brick itself that stop once the top and joints are closed.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Stain on a shop ceiling or wall under an unused chimney	Open flue taking rain for decades	Rebuild and crown the top, seal unused flues, repoint, copper flashing
Brick faces popping off beside gray mortar	1980s hard-mortar repair on handmade brick	Replace spalled brick with salvage, repoint in lime mortar
Rebuilt section in modern red brick	Past repair in the wrong brick	Rebuild in period brick, blended
Sandy joints on a 1970s chimney	Mortar past its lifespan; mountain freeze-thaw	Grind and repoint every face in matched Type N
Cracked top around the flues	Mortar wash cracked	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown; caps or seals
Ceiling stain beside the chimney during rain	Tarred flashing; no cricket	Step flashing, counter-flashing cut into the masonry, cricket

Common questions from Chester Borough owners

The chimney on my building isn't used. Can I just take it down?
On Main Street, usually not without changing the building's look, and often not without review. Keeping it and closing it properly costs less than people expect and ends the leak. If it's not visible from the street and serves nothing, removal is an option and we'll say so.

Will the repaired brick match a 1790s chimney?
We use salvaged handmade brick of the right period, blend the color range the way the original mason did, and lay it in lime mortar. It weathers in over a couple of seasons.

Can you work around my shop's hours?
Yes. Roof scaffolding keeps the storefront open, the sidewalk is protected when a stack is on the street side, and the noisy work — grinding joints — is scheduled for the hours you give us.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic or top floor before quoting. That shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Chester Borough by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about an hour from Chester, and we take on the historic masonry that most roofing companies won't. Our own crews handle the masonry, the lining, the copper work, the flashing, and the roof tie-in. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Chester Township, Mendham Borough, Peapack and Gladstone, Randolph, Bedminster, and across Morris County.

Next is Chester Township.

Chester Township — rural Morris County: 1970s–2000s custom homes on large lots, horse farms, a few old farmhouses, and a lot of standing-seam metal roofs on the farm-style houses. Leads with something no chimney page has had: flashing a masonry chimney into a metal roof, and what hilltop wind does to a tall stack.

URL: `/chimney-repair/morris-county/chester-township-nj/`
Title tag (60 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Chester Township NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (154 chars): Chimney repair in Chester Township, NJ — chimney flashing on metal roofs, wind-exposed stacks, stone and brick repointing, cracked crowns, and rebuilds. Lita.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Chester Township, NJ

Chester Township is open country — large lots on the ridges off Route 24 and Route 206, horse farms along the Black River, custom homes from the 1970s through the 2000s built in a farmhouse style that often means a standing-seam metal roof and a big fieldstone or brick

chimney. At 800 feet, with fields instead of neighbors, those chimneys get wind that a stack in a Bergen County subdivision never sees, and the metal roofs around them were flashed by roofers who mostly work in shingles.

Here's what we see on Chester Township chimneys and how Lita Construction repairs them.

Chimney flashing on standing-seam metal roofs

A standing-seam roof is a series of metal panels joined at raised seams, and a chimney coming through it breaks the seams. The flashing has to seal the panel ends on the uphill side, the sides, and the downhill side, each of which moves with temperature — metal roofs expand and contract an inch or more over a season — while the chimney doesn't move at all. Most of the metal-roof chimney flashing we open up in Chester Township was done with a flat pan and a bead of sealant at the top, which the roof's movement tears open within a few years. Water on a ceiling beside the chimney, worse on windy days, is that.

The repair: we build the flashing the way a metal roofer would, in the same metal as the roof or in copper: an uphill diverter (a cricket in metal, soldered or seamed) that turns water around the stack, side flashings that lap over the panel ribs and are seamed to them, a downhill apron that laps onto the panels below, and counter-flashing set into a reglet cut into the mortar joint — or into the stone face — that covers the top edges of all of it. Every joint is mechanically seamed or soldered; sealant is a backup, not the seal. The roof can move and the chimney can stand still.

Wind and tall stacks on the ridges

A chimney on a hilltop in Chester Township takes wind-driven rain from every direction and a sideways load that works the top courses loose over time. We see it as joints washed out deeper on the west and south faces than the others, a crack running down from the top through several courses, and on the tall stacks over the two-and-a-half-story farmhouses, a slight lean toward the lee side. A cap that's missing is usually one the wind took.

The repair: the top courses are rebuilt, bonded into the sound brick or stone below, and the stack is crowned with a poured, reinforced concrete crown overhanging two inches on all sides. Caps are stainless, fastened to the masonry — not set in sealant. On a stack that's leaning or has pulled away from the house, it's re-anchored to the framing at the attic level. The windward faces are repointed deeper, and a breathable water repellent slows wind-driven water getting into the joints.

Stone chimney repointing

The fieldstone chimneys on Chester Township's custom homes and farmhouses fail at the joints — the irregular face holds water on every ledge, and up here it freezes more nights than it

doesn't from December to March. Mortar crumbs at the base and a stone that moves when pushed are the signs.

The repair: we rake the joints out by hand with chisels and a narrow grinder — a wide blade scars the stone permanently — at least three-quarters of an inch deep and deeper on the wide joints, reset loose stones in fresh mortar, and repoint in a Type N matched to the existing color and sand, finished to the original joint. On stone-veneer chimneys with white staining through the face, we open the face, install the drainage layer that was left out, and re-set the stone.

Brick repointing and cracked crowns

The brick chimneys on the 1970s–90s homes have mortar at or past its life and a mortar wash on top that cracked years ago — up here, within a few winters. Once the top is open, rain and snowmelt go into the top courses and down the core.

The repair: joints ground out three-quarters of an inch to an inch across every exposed face and repointed in a matched Type N; spalled brick replaced; the old wash removed and a reinforced concrete crown poured — sloped away from every flue, overhanging the brick, with a bond break around each flue tile — and each flue capped.

Chimney leaking when it rains

On the shingle roofs in the township — most of the colonials — a stain beside the chimney during rain is the usual tarred-over flashing from a past roof job, often with no cricket behind a wide stack. We strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane carried up the slope on the uphill side where snow sits, weave step flashing into every course, set the counter-flashing into a reglet cut into the mortar or the stone, and frame a cricket behind any chimney over 30 inches wide — built steep enough to shed snow.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans beyond what re-anchoring corrects, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in matched brick or salvaged stone, with the flue tiles reset or replaced, a poured crown, and new flashing — seamed into the metal or woven into the shingles. The section inside the house is left alone.

Wood stoves and farmhouse chimneys

A lot of Chester Township houses heat with a wood stove through the winter, and the old farmhouses have unlined center chimneys that were never built for that. A stove chimney with

cracked or missing flue tiles, or no liner at all, needs an insulated stainless liner sized to the stove before it's used; a camera inspection tells us the condition. The masonry around it is repaired like any other.

White stains on brick or stone

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Chester Township chimney it means a cracked top, open windward joints, or veneer without drainage. Fix the source and the staining stops.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Ceiling stain beside a chimney on a metal roof, worse in wind	Flat-pan flashing torn by roof movement	Seamed and soldered metal flashing with an uphill diverter, reglet counter-flashing
Joints washed out deeper on the west and south faces	Wind-driven rain on a ridge lot	Repoint every face, deeper on the windward side; repellent
Crack down from the top; top courses leaning; cap gone	Wind load on a tall stack	Rebuild top courses, crown, fastened caps, re-anchor
Mortar crumbs at the base of a stone chimney; loose stone	Washed-out joints behind the stone	Hand-rake, reset stones, repoint
Cracked top; sandy joints (brick)	Mortar wash cracked; mortar past its life	Poured crown, repoint
Spalled brick in the top third of a stove chimney	Heat and creosote from inside; cracked tiles	Camera inspection, repair masonry, insulated liner

Common questions from Chester Township homeowners

My roofer says the chimney flashing on my metal roof is fine. It still leaks.
Metal-roof chimney flashing is a different trade from shingle flashing. A flat pan and sealant at the top looks fine the day it's done and tears open when the roof moves. We seam and solder it so it can move with the roof.

The cap blew off. Is that normal up here?
Caps set in sealant come off in ridge-top wind. Ours are fastened to the masonry. If the cap went, we also check the top courses, because the same wind has been working on them.

Can a stone chimney be repointed, or does it have to be rebuilt?
Repointed, if the stones are still seated and water isn't coming through the inside of the stack. We check both from the roof.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Chester Township by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about an hour from Chester Township. Our own crews handle the masonry, the metal work, the lining, the flashing, and the roof tie-in — shingle or standing seam — so the job isn't split between a mason, a metal roofer, and a sweep. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Chester Borough, Mendham Township, Randolph, Bedminster, Peapack and Gladstone, and across Morris County.

Next is Denville.

Skipping Denville. Next is East Hanover — 1960s–70s splits, ranches, and colonials on the streets off Ridgedale Avenue and Eagle Rock Avenue, a lot of them with a brick-veneer front and the chimney running up through it. Leads with something no chimney page has had: the stair-step cracks in a brick facade where the chimney meets it.

URL: `/chimney-repair/morris-county/east-hanover-nj/`
Title tag (59 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing East Hanover NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (153 chars): Chimney repair in East Hanover, NJ — cracks where the chimney meets brick-veneer fronts, brick repointing, cracked crowns, flashing leaks, and rebuilds. Lita.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in East Hanover, NJ

East Hanover's housing is 1960s and 70s — splits, bi-levels, ranches, and colonials built in a few big waves on the streets off Ridgedale Avenue, Eagle Rock Avenue, and Troy Road — and the builders of that era liked a brick front. A lot of these houses have brick veneer across the front elevation and vinyl or aluminum on the other three sides, with the fireplace chimney rising through the front or side wall as part of that veneer. The chimney and the veneer look like one piece of masonry. They aren't. The chimney sits on its own footing and the veneer sits on the house foundation, and when either one moves, the joint between them cracks.

Here's what we see on East Hanover chimneys and how Lita Construction repairs them.

Cracks where the chimney meets the brick front

Stand across the street and look at the brick beside the chimney. On a lot of East Hanover houses there's a stair-step crack following the mortar joints up from the foundation to the eave along one or both sides of the chimney, sometimes with the chimney side of the crack a quarter inch proud of the veneer. That's the chimney footing and the house foundation settling at different rates over sixty years. The crack itself isn't structural — the veneer is a skin, not a bearing wall — but it's an open path for water into the wall cavity behind the brick, and the staining and soft drywall inside, near the fireplace wall, are that water.

Less often, the crack runs through the chimney itself above the roof, or the whole chimney has rotated away from the house with a gap opening at the top. That one is the chimney's footing and needs a closer look.

The repair: where the chimney and veneer have simply parted, we grind out the cracked joints, repoint them, and install a flexible control joint where the two meet — a backer and a sealant that can move — so the next bit of settlement doesn't open a new crack. Through-wall flashing and weeps at the base of the veneer are checked and installed where they're missing, which on 1960s veneer they often are. Spalled or displaced brick is reset. Where the chimney has rotated away from the house, it's re-anchored to the framing at the attic and floor levels and the gap is closed the same way; if the footing is still moving, we say so before any masonry goes up.

Chimney repointing in East Hanover

Beyond the crack line, the 1960s–70s mortar is at the end of its life — recessed, sandy, mortar you can pick out with a key — and on a veneer-front house, the chimney joints and the facade joints are the same age and usually need the same work. The chimney's weather face and the section above the roof are worst.

The repair: every exposed face of the chimney — the stack above the roof, the section running up the wall, the section at grade — ground out three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep and repointed in a breathable Type N tinted to match, tooled to the original concave joint. Spalled brick is cut out and replaced with matched units. Where the facade joints are also due, we point the facade at the same time so the chimney doesn't read as a patch.

Cracked chimney top

East Hanover's chimneys were finished with a thin mortar wash around the flue liner, cracked after fifty-plus winters. Once the top is open, rain goes into the top course and down the core, which is what feeds the failing joints below and, on a veneer-front house, the water showing up inside.

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from the flue, overhanging the brick by two inches so water drips clear of the face, with a bond break around the flue tile. A stainless cap goes on the flue.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or attic framing beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. On the splits it's the lower corner where the lower roof meets the chimney and the upper wall; on the ranches it's the uphill side on a low-pitched roof; on the colonials it's the main tie-in. The flashing was usually redone during a past roof job with aluminum tarred to the brick.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane — up the wall with a kickout at a split's lower corner — and weave step flashing into every shingle course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — not caulked to the brick — wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket behind them. Matching shingles are woven back in.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses of the chimney itself, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in matched modular red brick, with the flue tiles reset or replaced, a poured crown, and new flashing. The section inside the house and the veneer below the roof are left alone unless the footing is the problem.

Furnace chimneys after gas conversions

Most East Hanover chimneys vent the furnace as well as the fireplace, and most houses have converted from oil to gas. Gas exhaust condenses in a cold masonry flue, and the acidic condensate breaks down the mortar and brick from inside — flakes in the gutter, staining near the top. The masonry is repaired like any other, and a stainless liner sized to the appliance keeps it from happening again.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On an East Hanover chimney it means a cracked top or open joints — and on the veneer beside the chimney, staining along the crack line means water is getting in there.

Prefab fireplace chases

The townhouse communities and newer homes in East Hanover vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood box with a metal cover on top. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace it with a pitched stainless cover and reframe the box if needed. It's a smaller share of our work in town than the masonry above.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Stair-step crack in the brick front beside the chimney	Chimney and veneer settling at different rates	Repoint, flexible control joint, through-wall flashing and weeps
Chimney proud of the veneer; gap at the top	Chimney footing moved	Re-anchor to the framing, close the gap; refer the footing if still moving
Sandy, recessed joints on the chimney and facade	Mortar past its lifespan	Repoint the chimney every face; facade at the same time
Cracked or missing mortar at the top	Mortar wash instead of a crown	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown with a cap
Stain at the lower corner of a split during rain	Tarred flashing at the hardest tie-in	Membrane up the wall, step flashing, kickout, reglet-cut counter-flashing
Flakes in gutters, staining near the top (gas heat)	Exhaust condensation from inside	Repair masonry, stainless liner, sealed crown

Common questions from East Hanover homeowners

There's a crack running up my brick front next to the chimney. Is the house moving?
The chimney and the brick veneer are moving relative to each other, which is common and usually stopped long ago. The veneer isn't structural. We repoint the crack, put a joint there that can move, and make sure water isn't getting behind the brick.

Will the repointed chimney match the brick front?
Yes — same mortar color, same joint, and if the facade joints are due, we do them together so there's no patch line.

Can the top be done without rebuilding the chimney?
Yes, if the brick below it is sound. We check the top courses when we remove the old wash and rebuild only what's taken water.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in East Hanover by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 35 minutes from East Hanover. Our own crews handle the masonry, the lining, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Florham Park, Hanover, Livingston, Roseland, Parsippany-Troy Hills, and across Morris County.

Next is Florham Park.

Kinnelon — mountain lakes and Smoke Rise: a lot of 1950s–70s mid-century homes on rocky, wooded lots with massive fieldstone chimneys and low-pitched roofs, plus later colonials and the lake-community houses. Leads with something no chimney page has had: the mid-century stone chimney — a full stone wall rather than a stack, on a roof too flat to shed water.

URL: `/chimney-repair/morris-county/kinnelon-nj/`
Title tag (55 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Kinnelon NJ | Lita Construction

Meta (153 chars): Chimney repair in Kinnelon, NJ — mid-century stone chimneys, low-slope roof flashing, stone and brick repointing, cracked crowns, and roofline rebuilds. Lita.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Kinnelon, NJ

Kinnelon was built on rock, and its chimneys show it. The mid-century homes in Smoke Rise and around Fayson Lakes and Lake Kinnelon — ranches, split-levels, and contemporaries from the 1950s through the 70s on wooded, boulder-strewn lots — were designed around the fireplace, and the fireplace was designed around the stone that came out of the ground. A Kinnelon chimney from that era is often not a stack at all but a stone mass: a fieldstone wall six or eight feet wide that forms one end of the living room, rises through a low-pitched or nearly flat roof, and stops a few feet above it under a slab of stone or concrete. The colonials built on the township's later lots have more ordinary brick chimneys, and the elevation — most of Kinnelon sits above 800 feet — gives everything a longer, harder winter than the valley.

Here's what we see on Kinnelon chimneys and how Lita Construction repairs them.

Mid-century stone chimneys on low-slope roofs

The mid-century stone chimney has two problems the builders didn't plan for. The first is the top. A chimney mass that wide has a top the size of a dining table, and it was usually finished with a mortar wash or a thin cast-concrete slab set on the stone. Sixty winters at this elevation cracked it long ago, and because the stone below is laid in wide, irregular joints, the water that gets in from the top has a hundred paths down through the mass. From outside you see dark staining spreading down from the top, mortar crumbs at the base, and stones that move; inside, water at the fireplace and staining on the stone wall above it.

The second is the roof. These homes have roofs at 2/12 or 3/12, sometimes flat, and the chimney mass sits in the middle of them with the roof dying into stone on two or three sides. Water doesn't run off a roof that shallow; it sits, and it sits against the stone. The original flashing was a metal pan tarred to the stone face, because there's no level mortar joint on fieldstone to cut into, and it's been re-tarred every ten years since.

The repair: the top first. We remove the failed wash or slab, reset any loose top stones, and pour a reinforced concrete crown over the full width — sloped to shed off the sides, overhanging two inches, with a bond break around each flue — or, where the owner wants the original look, reset a new stone cap on a poured crown beneath it. Then the flashing: on a low-slope or flat roof the chimney is flashed the way a membrane roof needs — a base flashing run up the stone face a minimum of eight inches and bonded to the roof membrane, capped with metal

counter-flashing set into a channel saw-cut into the stone — so the top edge is mechanically sealed, not glued. On the uphill side we build a cricket steep enough to actually move water, which on a 2/12 roof means steeper than the roof itself. The stone face is then repointed by hand.

Stone chimney repointing

Fieldstone fails at the joints. Kinnelon's local stone is hard — it doesn't spall — but the mortar between it is sixty or seventy years old, the irregular face holds water on every ledge, and up here that water freezes more nights than it doesn't from December into March. Mortar crumbs at the base, recessed joints you can fit a finger into, and a stone that shifts when pushed are the signs.

The repair: we rake the joints out by hand with chisels and a narrow grinder — a wide blade scars the stone and shows forever — at least three-quarters of an inch deep and deeper on the wide joints, reset loose stones in fresh mortar, and repoint in a Type N matched to the existing color and sand, finished to the original joint. On the mid-century homes the joints were often raked deep to make the stone read as individual pieces; we match that rather than flush-pointing it into a wall.

Brick chimneys on the colonials

The colonials built from the 1970s on have standard brick chimneys with mortar at or past its life and a mortar wash on top that cracked within a few winters at this elevation. Joints are ground out three-quarters of an inch to an inch across every exposed face and repointed in a matched Type N; spalled brick is replaced with units rated for severe weathering; the top is rebuilt and poured as a reinforced crown with each flue capped.

Chimney leaking when it rains or when snow melts

On the pitched-roof houses in the township, a stain beside the chimney during rain — or more often during a thaw — is a flashing leak. Snow banks against the uphill side of a chimney, melts from the bottom, and sits against the flashing for days; the flashing was redone during a past roof job with aluminum tarred to the brick, and the wide chimneys usually have no cricket.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane carried well up the slope on the uphill side, and weave step flashing into every course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — or a channel cut into stone — wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket built steep enough to shed snow.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When a brick stack has spalled through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or it leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in matched brick rated for severe weathering, with the flue tiles reset, a poured crown, and new flashing. On a stone mass, a rebuild is rare — the stone is sound — and the work is resetting the top courses and repointing the rest.

Wood stoves in Kinnelon chimneys

A lot of Kinnelon houses heat with a wood stove or an insert through the winter, often through a flue that was built for a few evening fires. A stove chimney with cracked flue tiles, or no liner at all — common in the mid-century stone masses, which were sometimes built with an unlined flue — needs an insulated stainless liner sized to the stove before it's used; a camera inspection tells us the condition. The masonry around it is repaired as above.

White stains on the stone

Chalky white efflorescence on a stone chimney is salts carried out by water moving through the mortar. On a Kinnelon chimney it means a cracked top or open joints. Fix the source and the staining stops.

Prefab fireplace chases

Some newer Kinnelon homes vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood box with a metal cover on top. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace it with a pitched stainless cover and reframe the box if needed. It's a small share of our work here next to the stone above.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Staining down from the top of a wide stone chimney; water at the fireplace	Cracked wash or slab on a slab-sized top	Reset top stones, poured crown or stone cap over a crown, caps
Leak where a flat or low roof meets a stone chimney	Pan tarred to the stone face	Membrane base flashing, counter-flashing in a channel cut into stone, steep cricket
Mortar crumbs at the base; a stone that moves	Washed-out joints behind the stone	Hand-rake, reset stones, repoint to the original raked joint

Ceiling stain during a thaw (pitched roof)	Snowmelt against tarred flashing; no cricket	Membrane up the slope, step flashing, reglet-cut counter-flashing, cricket
Spalled brick, cracked top (colonial)	Mortar past its life; wash cracked	Repoint, severe-weather brick, poured crown
Spalled or discolored brick in the top third of a stove chimney	Heat and creosote from inside; cracked tiles	Camera inspection, repair masonry, insulated liner

Common questions from Kinnelon homeowners

My stone chimney is a whole wall of the house. Can it be repointed, or is that a rebuild?
Repointed. The stone on these is sound; it's the joints and the top. We rake and repoint by hand, reset the loose stones, and fix the top. A rebuild of a stone mass is almost never needed.

How do you flash a chimney when there's no straight mortar joint to cut into?
We saw-cut a channel into the stone itself and set the counter-flashing into it. On a flat or low-slope roof the base flashing is a membrane run up the stone and bonded to the roof, with the metal over it. Tar on a stone face is what you have now, and it's why it leaks.

Is my old chimney safe for a wood stove?
Only with a sound, properly sized liner. A camera inspection tells us whether the flue is lined and intact; most mid-century flues here aren't, and an insulated stainless liner makes them safe without changing the chimney.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic — or from inside, on a cathedral-ceiling contemporary — before quoting. That shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Kinnelon by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 45 minutes from Kinnelon. Our own crews handle the stone work, the lining, the flashing, and the roof tie-in — shingle or membrane — so the job isn't split between a mason and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Boonton Township, Montville, Pequannock, Pompton Lakes, Ringwood, and across Morris County.

Next on the list is Long Hill.

Montville — three different towns in one: the hillside colonials and splits of Towaco, the newer developments in the Montville section, and the low-lying streets of Pine Brook along the Passaic River that have flooded more than once. Leads with something no chimney page has had: what happens to a masonry chimney when a flood-zone house gets lifted.

URL: `/chimney-repair/morris-county/montville-nj/`
Title tag (56 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Montville NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (153 chars): Chimney repair in Montville, NJ — chimneys on raised flood-zone homes, Towaco hillside stacks, brick and stone repointing, cracked crowns, flashing, and rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Montville, NJ

Montville's chimneys depend on which part of the township they're in. In Towaco, the 1960s–90s colonials and splits climb wooded hills off Route 202 and Jacksonville Road, with tall brick and fieldstone stacks taking wind and shade. In the Montville section, the newer developments have wide multi-flue chimneys on large colonials. And in Pine Brook, along the Passaic River and Route 46, a lot of houses have been through a flood — some through several — and a good number of them have been raised since, lifted onto new foundations so the living floor sits above the flood line.

A house can be lifted. A masonry chimney mostly can't, and that's where Pine Brook's chimney problems start. Here's what we see across Montville and how Lita Construction repairs it.

Chimneys on raised flood-zone houses

When a house in Pine Brook is elevated, the contractor jacks the frame, builds a new foundation under it, and sets it back down several feet higher. The chimney, sitting on its own footing and weighing twenty tons, doesn't come along. What gets done with it depends on the lifting contractor, and we've seen all the versions:

The chimney was cut and rebuilt. The stack was dismantled, the house raised, and the chimney rebuilt from the old base to a new height. Done well, it's fine. Done fast, the new brick doesn't match, the courses aren't bonded to the old base, and the seam leaks.

The chimney was left and the house went up around it. The old stack now ends inside the new crawl space or just above it, the fireplace opening is below the new floor, and a new chimney or a prefab chase was added above. The old flue is open at the top under the house, taking moisture into the crawl space.

The chimney was left standing outside the house. The house was moved slightly or the exterior chimney was simply disconnected, and a brick stack stands a foot or two from the wall with a gap that was closed with trim and caulk.

The repair depends on which one you have. A cut-and-rebuilt chimney that's cracking at the seam is taken down to the old base, the new section toothed into the old courses, and rebuilt in matched brick with the flue tiles continued and a poured crown. An abandoned stack under the house is sealed — capped solid, the flue filled or closed, the top parged — so it stops feeding moisture into the crawl space. A detached exterior stack is either re-anchored to the raised house with masonry anchors and the gap closed with a flashed, flexible joint, or, if it serves nothing anymore, taken down and the wall closed. We also check the footing: a chimney that's been through a flood has had its base saturated, and some have settled.

Flood-saturated masonry

Even on houses that weren't raised, a brick chimney that's stood in two feet of river water has had its lower courses saturated for days. The mortar in those courses is weakened, the brick may have absorbed silt and salts, and the efflorescence that appears afterward — a white line at the old water mark — is the chimney drying out through its face. The fireplace, if it was underwater, has firebrick joints that were washed out and a damper that's rusted.

The repair: the lower courses are repointed once they've dried out — months, not weeks — in a matched mortar, with any brick that's gone soft replaced. The firebox is repointed in refractory mortar and the damper freed or replaced. The flue is camera-inspected before the fireplace is used, because silt and debris collect on the smoke shelf.

Towaco hillside chimneys

On the Towaco slopes the problems are the ordinary ones made worse by exposure: joints washed out deeper on the windward face, moss and dark staining on the north side under the trees, a cracked top on a stack that's taking wind. The brick chimneys get every exposed face ground out three-quarters of an inch to an inch and repointed in a matched Type N, spalled brick replaced, and a poured, reinforced crown with each flue capped. The fieldstone chimneys — common on the older Towaco houses — are raked by hand, loose stones reset, and repointed in a matched mortar to the original joint.

Cracked chimney top

Across the township the chimneys were finished with a mortar wash around the flue tiles, cracked long ago, and on the wide multi-flue tops in the Montville section it cracked within a few seasons. Once the top is open, rain goes into the top courses and down the core.

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from every flue, overhanging the masonry by two inches, with a bond break around each flue tile. Each flue gets a stainless cap.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or attic framing beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak — tarred-over flashing from a past roof job on most Montville homes, and no cricket behind the wide stacks on the newer ones. We strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, weave step flashing into every course, set the counter-flashing into a reglet cut into the mortar or the stone, and frame a cricket behind any chimney over 30 inches wide.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in matched brick or salvaged stone, with the flue tiles reset or replaced, a poured crown, and new flashing. The section inside the house is left alone.

Storm damage

Montville's trees come down in every nor'easter, and a limb that hits a chimney leaves damage that leaks weeks later. We tarp, photograph, and write up the damage in the format an insurance adjuster needs, separated from age-related wear, and do the repair.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Towaco chimney it means a cracked top or open joints. On a Pine Brook chimney, a white line at a consistent height is the flood mark, and it fades as the masonry dries and the joints are closed.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do

Crack at the seam where a chimney was extended after a house lift	New section stacked on, not bonded	Take down, tooth into the old base, rebuild matched and lined
Old chimney top open under a raised house	Stack abandoned when the house went up	Cap and seal the old flue, parge the top
Chimney standing apart from a raised house	Disconnected during the lift	Re-anchor and flash the gap, or remove if unused
White line at a consistent height; soft lower joints	Flood saturation	Repoint once dry, replace soft brick, camera-inspect the flue
Sandy joints, moss, staining (Towaco)	Exposure under trees on a slope	Repoint every face, crown, repellent
Ceiling stain beside a wide chimney during rain	No cricket; tarred flashing	Cricket, step flashing, counter-flashing cut into the masonry

Common questions from Montville homeowners

Our house in Pine Brook was raised and the chimney looks wrong. What should have happened?
The chimney should have been dismantled and rebuilt from its base to the new height, bonded into the old courses, with the flue continued. If it was stacked on, left under the house, or left standing apart, it's fixable — we see all three — but each needs a different repair.

Can we use the fireplace after a flood?
Not until the flue has been camera-inspected and the firebox dried and repointed. Silt on the smoke shelf and washed-out firebrick joints are both common and both matter.

Can a stone chimney be repointed, or does it have to be rebuilt?
Repointed, if the stones are still seated and water isn't coming through the inside of the stack. We check both from the roof.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic — and in Pine Brook, from the crawl space — before quoting. That shows whether water is entering at the flashing, through the masonry, or from below, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Montville by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 35 minutes from Montville, and we've worked in Towaco and Pine Brook before. Our own crews handle the masonry, the lining, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Boonton Township, Kinnelon, Pequannock, Parsippany-Troy Hills, Fairfield, and across Morris County.

Next is Morris Plains.

Morris Plains — a small borough of 1920s–60s colonials, capes, and ranches on the streets off Speedwell Avenue and Mountain Way, with a few newer homes on the edges. Leads with a symptom no chimney page has had: the fireplace that smokes into the room, and the masonry reasons a short chimney on a cape or ranch doesn't draw.

URL: `/chimney-repair/morris-county/morris-plains-nj/`
Title tag (60 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Morris Plains NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (154 chars): Chimney repair in Morris Plains, NJ — fireplaces that smoke into the room, short chimneys, brick repointing, cracked crowns, flashing leaks, and rebuilds. Lita.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Morris Plains, NJ

Morris Plains is a borough of modest, well-kept houses — 1920s and 30s colonials near the center, 1950s and 60s capes and ranches on the streets off Speedwell Avenue, Mountain Way, and Hanover Avenue — and a lot of them have a fireplace that doesn't work well. Not broken, exactly: it smokes into the room when it's lit, it's hard to get going, the house smells like a campfire the next morning. Owners assume that's how old fireplaces are. It isn't. A fireplace smokes because the chimney isn't drawing, and on a Morris Plains cape or ranch the reasons are usually in the masonry.

Here's what we find on Morris Plains chimneys — the draft problems first, then the age problems every 60- to 100-year-old brick chimney has — and how Lita Construction repairs them.

Fireplace smoking into the room

A chimney draws because the column of warm air inside it is lighter than the air outside, and the taller and tighter the column, the harder it pulls. Four things defeat that on Morris Plains houses:

The chimney is too short. Capes and ranches have low roofs, and builders often ran the chimney just high enough to clear the ridge. Code wants the top at least three feet above where it passes through the roof and two feet above anything within ten feet. A chimney that doesn't meet that is in the roof's turbulence, and wind pushes down it. On a lot of 1950s ranches the chimney has also been overtaken by a later addition, a taller neighbor, or trees that were saplings when it was built.

The smoke chamber is rough. Above the firebox, the chimney narrows from the fireplace opening to the flue through a sloped chamber. On these houses the chamber was built in corbeled brick with the steps left exposed, and sixty years of soot has filled the ledges. Smoke tumbles instead of flowing.

The flue is partly blocked or too big. A broken flue tile, a bird nest, a collapsed section — or, on a chimney with an unlined or oversized flue, a column of air that never warms enough to pull.

The damper or the cap is restricting the opening. A damper that doesn't open fully, or a cap with a crushed screen clogged with soot.

The repair: we start with the easy ones — the cap, the damper, a camera down the flue for blockages — and then the masonry. A rough smoke chamber is parged smooth with refractory mortar so smoke flows up a funnel instead of over steps. A short chimney is extended in matched brick, toothed into the existing courses, with the flue tiles continued and a poured crown on top; two or three feet is often the difference between a fireplace that smokes and one that doesn't. An oversized or unlined flue gets an insulated stainless liner sized to the fireplace opening, which warms fast and pulls hard. A fireplace that's smoked for thirty years usually draws properly after a morning's work.

Chimney repointing in Morris Plains

The 1920s–30s chimneys near the center are in soft brick and lime mortar, worn at the joints and often repointed once in a hard modern mortar that's now breaking the brick around it. The 1950s–60s chimneys are at the end of their original mortar's life — recessed, sandy, mortar you can pick out with a key.

The repair: we grind the joints out three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep across every exposed face and repoint in a mortar matched to the brick: lime-rich on the pre-war homes, a standard Type N on the postwar ones, tinted to match and tooled to the original joint. Spalled brick is cut out and replaced with matched units. The top goes in the same visit.

Cracked chimney top

Morris Plains chimneys were finished with a thin mortar wash around the flue liner, cracked after sixty to a hundred winters. Once the top is open, rain goes into the top course and down the core — and on a short chimney the top is close enough to the roof that nobody looks at it.

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from the flue, overhanging the brick by two inches so water drips clear of the face, with a bond break around the flue tile. A stainless cap goes on the flue, with a screen that's sized not to choke the draft.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or attic framing beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. On the capes the chimney comes through at the ridge and the flashing turns the peak corner; on the ranches it's the uphill side where debris sits on a low-pitched roof. It's been redone through two or three roof jobs with aluminum tarred to the brick.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and weave step flashing into every shingle course — both slopes with a saddle at the ridge on a cape. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — not caulked to the brick — wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket behind them. Matching shingles are woven back in.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up — in reclaimed or matched soft brick and lime mortar on the pre-war homes, matched modular red on the postwar ones — and if the chimney was too short, it goes back up taller. Flue tiles are reset or replaced, the top gets a poured crown, and new flashing goes in. The section inside the house is left alone.

Furnace chimneys after gas conversions

Most Morris Plains chimneys vent the furnace as well as the fireplace, and most houses have converted from oil to gas. Gas exhaust condenses in a cold masonry flue, and the acidic

condensate breaks down the mortar and brick from inside — flakes in the gutter, staining near the top. The masonry is repaired like any other, and a stainless liner sized to the appliance keeps it from happening again.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Morris Plains chimney it means a cracked top or open joints. Fix the source and the staining stops.

Prefab fireplace chases

A few Morris Plains additions and newer homes vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood box with a metal cover on top. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace it with a pitched stainless cover and reframe the box if needed. It's a small share of our work in town next to the masonry above.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Fireplace smokes into the room; hard to light	Short chimney; rough smoke chamber; oversized or blocked flue	Extend the chimney, parge the smoke chamber, line the flue
Chimney top barely above the ridge, or below a later addition	Built short; overtaken	Extend in matched brick, toothed in, lined, crowned
Sandy, recessed joints	Mortar past its lifespan	Grind and repoint in matched mortar
Brick faces popping off; joints intact (pre-war)	Hard-mortar repoint on soft brick	Replace spalled brick, repoint in lime-rich mortar
Cracked or missing mortar at the top	Mortar wash instead of a crown	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown with a cap
Ceiling stain beside the chimney during rain	Tarred flashing at the ridge; no cricket	Step flashing both slopes, saddle, reglet-cut counter-flashing, cricket

Common questions from Morris Plains homeowners

My fireplace has always smoked. Can that actually be fixed?
Almost always. It's usually a short chimney, a rough smoke chamber, or a flue that's the wrong size, and those are masonry fixes. We find which — often it's two of the three — and do them in one visit.

How much taller does the chimney need to be?
Three feet above where it comes through the roof and two feet above anything within ten feet, by code — on a cape or ranch that's often two or three more feet than it has. We match the brick and bond the new courses into the old so it doesn't look extended.

Can the top be done without rebuilding the chimney?
Yes, if the brick below it is sound. We check the top courses when we remove the old wash and rebuild only what's taken water.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Morris Plains by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 45 minutes from Morris Plains. Our own crews handle the masonry, the lining, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason, a sweep, and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Morristown, Morris Township, Parsippany-Troy Hills, Mountain Lakes, Randolph, and across Morris County.

Next is Morris Township.

Morris Township — the ring around Morristown: 1920s–30s Tudors and estates in Convent Station and Normandy Heights, 1950s–70s colonials and splits in Washington Valley and off Mendham Road, and farmhouses toward Jockey Hollow. Leads with something no chimney page has had: multi-flue chimneys where the wall between the flues has failed and smoke or furnace exhaust is crossing from one flue to another.

URL: `/chimney-repair/morris-county/morris-township-nj/`
Title tag (60 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Morris Township NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (154 chars): Chimney repair in Morris Township, NJ — smoke crossing between flues, multi-flue stacks, brick and stone repointing, cracked crowns, flashing, and rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Morris Township, NJ

Morris Township's larger houses — the Tudors and colonials of Convent Station and Normandy Heights from the 1920s and 30s, the estates toward Jockey Hollow, the big colonials built in Washington Valley through the 1970s — carry chimneys with more than one flue. A single stack might hold the living-room fireplace, the library fireplace, and the furnace, each in its own clay-tile flue, separated from the next by a single wythe of brick. That brick divider is the part of the chimney nobody ever sees, and on a lot of Morris Township chimneys it's gone.

Here's what we find on Morris Township chimneys and how Lita Construction repairs them.

Smoke or exhaust crossing between flues

The sign is strange enough that people don't connect it: you light the living-room fireplace and smoke comes out of the library fireplace. Or there's a faint exhaust smell at the fireplace when the furnace runs. Or a carbon monoxide detector goes off in a room with a fireplace nobody uses. What's happened is that the wythe — the brick wall between two flues inside the chimney — has lost its mortar or broken, and the flues are communicating. A fireplace flue drawing hard pulls smoke, or furnace exhaust, through the gap and into the other flue, and the other flue sends it into the house.

This is a century of water from a cracked top doing its work inside the stack, and on a chimney where the furnace flue converted from oil to gas, the condensation has eaten the divider from the flue side. From outside, the chimney may look fine. From the top, with a camera, the gap is obvious.

The repair: the flues have to be separated again, and there are two ways. Where the damage is near the top — the most common case, since that's where the water enters — the top courses are taken down past the failed section, the wythe is rebuilt in brick and refractory mortar, the flue tiles are reset, and the top is crowned. Where the gap is further down the stack, each flue that's in use is lined with an insulated stainless liner, which makes every flue a sealed pipe regardless of the condition of the brick between them. On a chimney with a gas furnace

flue beside a fireplace flue, the liner is the right answer for the furnace flue in any case. Before either repair, every flue is camera-inspected and traced to its appliance.

Tall pre-war stacks: repointing soft brick

The 1920s–30s chimneys in Convent Station and Normandy Heights are tall — a Tudor stack above a two-and-a-half-story house with a steep roof — in soft brick and lime mortar, often with decorative corbels and patterned brick near the top. A century of weather has worn the joints on the windward side, and most have been repointed once in a hard modern mortar that's now breaking the brick around it: faces popping off, flakes in the gutter, joints intact.

The repair: we grind out the worn or hard mortar three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep, carefully on soft brick, replace spalled units with reclaimed or matched brick, and repoint in a lime-rich Type N or Type O matched to the original color and sand, tooled to the original joint. Decorative courses are repaired to their original profile. The postwar chimneys in Washington Valley take a standard Type N repoint, ground out and tooled to the concave joint.

Cracked chimney top on a multi-flue chimney

The top is what started the wythe problem. On a stack with three flues, the top is a wide slab, and it was finished with a mortar wash that cracked decades ago. Water goes in at the top, down between the tiles and the brick, and into the dividers between the flues.

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water — and the wythes between the flues at the top, which is where we find them failed — and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown: sloped away from every flue, overhanging the brick by two inches, with wire or fiber reinforcement so it won't crack across its width and a bond break around each flue tile. Each flue gets a cap, copper on the houses with copper work. Unused flues are capped solid.

Stone chimneys on the estates and farmhouses

The estates toward Jockey Hollow and the older farmhouses have fieldstone chimneys, some of them 18th-century. Stone fails at the joints — the irregular face holds water, the joints wash out, stones loosen — and is repointed by hand with the loose stones reset in a lime-based mortar matched to the original. Flues in the oldest chimneys are usually unlined and are camera-inspected and lined if they're in use.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or down a wall beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. On the Tudors the original copper has mostly been replaced during re-roofing with aluminum tarred to

the brick, on steep slate or shingle roofs with no cricket behind a wide stack; on the postwar homes it's the usual tarred flashing from a past roof job.

The repair: on slate we remove and reset the slates around the chimney; on shingle we strip the surrounding courses. Any rotted deck is replaced, the base is wrapped in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and step flashing goes in every course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — gently on soft brick — or a channel cut into stone, wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket. Copper on the pre-war houses.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up — in reclaimed or matched soft brick and lime mortar with the corbels rebuilt to profile on the pre-war homes, matched modular red on the postwar ones — with the wythes rebuilt between the flues, the tiles reset, a poured crown, and new flashing. The section inside the house is left alone.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Morris Township chimney it means a cracked top or open joints — and on a multi-flue stack, heavy staining near the top usually means the wythes under the crown have been taking water for years.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Smoke from a fireplace you didn't light; exhaust smell at a fireplace	Wythe between flues failed	Camera-inspect; rebuild the wythe at the top or line each flue
Brick faces popping off a tall Tudor stack; joints intact	Hard-mortar repoint on soft brick	Replace spalled brick, repoint in lime-rich mortar, repair corbels
Cracked top across two or three flues	Mortar wash cracked; wythes under it wet	Rebuild top courses and wythes, poured reinforced crown, caps
Mortar crumbs at the base of a stone chimney; loose stone	Washed-out joints behind the stone	Hand-rake, reset stones, repoint in lime mortar

Ceiling stain beside the chimney during rain	Tarred flashing; no cricket	Reset slate or strip shingles, copper step and counter-flashing, cricket
Spalling through faces, crack through courses, lean	Core failure above the roofline	Roofline rebuild, wythes rebuilt, crown, flashing

Common questions from Morris Township homeowners

Smoke comes out of the fireplace in the next room when we use the living-room one. What is that?
The brick wall between the two flues inside the chimney has failed and the flues are connected. It's a safety issue as well as a nuisance — furnace exhaust can cross the same way. A camera inspection shows where the gap is, and the fix is rebuilding the divider at the top or lining the flues.

Do all the flues need liners?
The ones in use, if the dividers have failed below the top few feet. A gas furnace flue should be lined regardless. Unused flues are capped solid. We trace every flue to its appliance before anything is decided.

My chimney was repointed 20 years ago and now the bricks are breaking. Why?
Almost certainly a hard mortar on soft pre-war brick. The mortar is now stronger than the brick, so the brick takes the freeze-thaw damage. The fix is to replace the damaged brick and repoint in a lime-rich mortar.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Morris Township by Lita Construction

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We also repair chimneys in Morristown, Morris Plains, Randolph, Bernardsville, Chatham Township, and across Morris County.

Next is Morristown.

Morristown — the county seat and the oldest big town on the list: Second Empire and Italianate Victorians from the 1860s–80s around the Green and on the streets off Speedwell and South Street, 1900s–30s colonials beyond them, and a lot of large houses converted to apartments. Leads with something no chimney page has had: chimneys coming through a mansard roof — a nearly flat top with steep slate sides — which is a flashing problem unlike any other.

URL: `/chimney-repair/morris-county/morristown-nj/`
Title tag (56 chars): Chimney Repair & Rebuilding Morristown NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (154 chars): Chimney repair in Morristown, NJ — Victorian mansard-roof chimneys, 150-year-old brick repointing, cracked crowns, flashing, rebuilds, and converted multi-families.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Morristown, NJ

Morristown has chimneys older than most towns' houses. The Second Empire and Italianate Victorians on the streets around the Green — Maple Avenue, Macculloch Avenue, Franklin Street, the blocks off South Street — were built in the 1860s through 80s with tall brick chimneys rising through mansard roofs, and a lot of those houses are now four or six apartments with a chimney that once served three fireplaces and now serves none, or a boiler. Around them are the 1900s–30s colonials and foursquares, and the postwar neighborhoods toward Morris Township.

Here's what we see on Morristown chimneys and how Lita Construction repairs them.

Chimneys through mansard roofs

A mansard roof has two parts: steep sides, usually slate, that are almost walls, and a flat or nearly flat top that most people never see. The chimneys on a Second Empire house come up through that flat top, and sometimes through the break line where the flat top meets the steep slate. Both are hard places to flash. The flat top is a membrane roof — originally tin, now rubber or modified bitumen — and the chimney has to be flashed into it with a base flashing up the

brick and a counter-flashing over that. The break line is where a slate roof turns into a flat roof, and a chimney sitting in it has slate on one side and membrane on another.

What's up there now, on most of these houses, is tar. Generations of roofers have patched the base of the chimney with roofing cement because nobody can see it from the ground, and the stain shows up on a third-floor ceiling, often in a tenant's apartment, and gets reported as a roof leak.

The repair: on the flat top, we run a membrane base flashing up the brick a minimum of eight inches, bonded to the roof, and cap it with metal counter-flashing set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — gently on 150-year-old brick — so the top edge is mechanically sealed. At the break line, the slate side gets step flashing woven into the slates (removed and reset, not cut) and the flat side gets the membrane detail, and the two are joined with a soldered copper transition. On these houses the metal is copper; it's what the house had and it outlasts the roof. If the stack has a cornice or corbel at the top, which Italianate chimneys often do, it's rebuilt to profile in the same work.

Repointing 150-year-old brick

Morristown's Victorian chimneys are in soft, hand-molded brick laid in lime mortar, and they've been repaired many times — some well, many in hard modern mortar that's now breaking the brick around it. Faces popping off and flakes on the roof with the joints intact is that; it's visible on half the chimneys around the Green. The original lime mortar, where it survives, is simply worn: recessed, sandy, washed out on the windward face.

The repair: we grind out the worn or hard mortar three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep, carefully so the brick edges aren't nicked, replace spalled units with reclaimed brick of the right period and size, and repoint in a lime putty or lime-rich mortar matched to the original color and sand, tooled to the original joint — often a fine struck or grapevine joint on these houses. Decorative brickwork is repaired to its original profile. Hard mortar on this brick is the one repair we won't do.

Converted multi-family houses

A Morristown Victorian that's now six apartments has one or two chimneys that used to serve six fireplaces and now serve a boiler and nothing else. The unused flues are open at the top, taking rain into a stack that runs through four floors of occupied rooms; the boiler flue, converted from oil to gas decades ago, has been condensing and eating the brick from inside.

The repair: every flue is traced — which serves the boiler, which serves a water heater, which serves nothing — before anything is capped or lined. The boiler flue gets a stainless liner sized to the appliance. Unused flues are capped solid and sealed. The top is rebuilt and crowned, the stack repointed, the flashing redone. For the owner, the practical side: we schedule around the

boiler so tenants aren't without heat, give notice to the units the work affects, and protect the sidewalk when a stack is on the street side.

Cracked chimney top

The tops of Morristown's chimneys — a corbeled brick cap, a stone cap, a mortar wash from the last repair — have been cracked for decades. Once the top is open, rain goes into the core and comes out wherever the mortar is weakest, which on a 150-year-old chimney is often the attic section or the wythes between the flues.

The repair: we remove the failed wash or reset the cap, rebuild the top courses and any failed wythes, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from every flue, overhanging the brick by two inches, with a bond break around each flue tile. A corbeled or bracketed Italianate top is rebuilt under the crown to the original profile. Each active flue gets a copper or stainless cap; unused flues are sealed.

Chimney leaking when it rains on the later houses

On the 1900s–30s colonials and the postwar homes, a stain beside the chimney during rain is the usual flashing leak — tarred-over aluminum from a past roof job, no cricket behind a wide stack — and is repaired with step flashing in every course, counter-flashing cut into the mortar, and a cricket where the chimney is over 30 inches wide. Slate roofs are reset, not cut.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans — common on the tallest Victorian stacks — the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in reclaimed period brick and lime mortar, with any cornice or corbel rebuilt to profile, the flues lined or sealed, a poured crown, and copper flashing. The section inside the house is left alone.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Morristown chimney it means a cracked top or open joints — and on a 150-year-old stack, some of it is salts in the brick itself, which stops once the top and joints are closed.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do

Third-floor ceiling stain under a mansard-roof chimney	Tar at the base on the flat top or the break line	Membrane base flashing, reglet counter-flashing, slate step flashing, soldered copper transition
Brick faces popping off; joints intact	Hard-mortar repoint on soft Victorian brick	Replace with period brick, repoint in lime mortar
Open flues on a converted multi-family	Fireplaces long gone; flues never sealed	Trace every flue, line the boiler flue, seal the rest, crown
Brick missing from a corbeled or bracketed top	Top courses loosened over decades	Rebuild to original profile, poured crown, caps
Sandy, washed-out joints on the windward face	Original lime mortar worn	Grind and repoint in matched lime mortar
Spalling through faces, crack through courses, lean	Core failure above the roofline	Roofline rebuild in period brick, copper flashing

Common questions from Morristown owners

My roofer has patched the chimney on my flat roof three times. Why does it keep leaking?
Because it's being patched with tar. A chimney on a flat roof needs a membrane base flashing up the brick and a metal counter-flashing cut into the mortar over it. Once that's done, it's done.

The house is six apartments. How do you work around the tenants?
We trace which flues serve what, schedule so the boiler is out of service for the shortest time, give notice to the units affected, and protect the sidewalk. The exterior masonry doesn't require anything to be shut off.

Can you match brick from the 1870s?
We source reclaimed hand-molded brick of the right period and size, blend the color range the way the original mason did, and lay it in lime mortar. It weathers in over a couple of seasons.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic or top floor before quoting. That shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Morristown by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 45 minutes from Morristown, and we take on the historic masonry and flat-roof flashing that most roofing companies won't. Our own crews handle the masonry, the lining, the copper work, the slate, and the roof tie-in. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Morris Township, Morris Plains, Randolph, Parsippany-Troy Hills, Bernardsville, and across Morris County.

Next is Mountain Lakes.

Parsippany-Troy Hills — the biggest town in Morris County and the one with the most condominiums and townhouses, plus the 1950s–70s splits, ranches, and bi-levels of Troy Hills, Lake Hiawatha, and Lake Parsippany. Leads with something no chimney page has had: who's responsible for the chimney on a condo or townhouse, and how we sort that out before anyone pays for anything.

URL: `/chimney-repair/morris-county/parsippany-troy-hills-nj/`
Title tag (60 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Parsippany NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (155 chars): Chimney repair in Parsippany-Troy Hills, NJ — condo and townhouse chimneys, brick repointing, cracked crowns, flashing leaks, and roofline rebuilds. Lita Construction.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Parsippany-Troy Hills, NJ

Parsippany has more chimneys than any town in Morris County and more of them on shared roofs. Beyond the 1950s–70s splits, ranches, and bi-levels of Troy Hills, Lake Hiawatha, and Lake Parsippany, the township has dozens of condominium and townhouse communities built from the 1970s through the 2000s, and nearly every unit in them has a fireplace. When one of those chimneys leaks, the first question isn't what's wrong with it. It's whose problem it is.

Here's how we work through that on Parsippany condos and townhouses, and what we see on the single-family chimneys around them.

Condo and townhouse chimneys: whose repair is it

In most Parsippany associations, the master deed draws the line at the exterior: the association owns and maintains the roof, the siding, and the outside of the chimney, and the unit owner owns the fireplace, the flue, and anything inside the unit. But a chimney leak doesn't respect that line. Water that comes in at a rusted cover on the outside ends up at the unit owner's fireplace. A flue problem the unit owner is responsible for shows up as staining on the association's siding. Both sides call a contractor, both contractors blame the other side, and the leak continues.

How we handle it: we inspect the whole chimney — the cover or crown, the chase or stack, the flashing at the roof, the flue, the firebox — and write up what's wrong in two columns: what's on the exterior and what's inside the unit. The owner gets a report they can hand to the property manager that says which parts are the association's and which are theirs, with photos. Often we end up doing both halves, billed separately, because the association's roofer doesn't do masonry and the owner's sweep doesn't do roofs. For a property manager with a whole community of the same chimney, we survey them together and price the exterior work as a program the board can budget.

Most Parsippany condo chimneys are prefab fireplaces in sided chases with a metal cover on top, and the cover is the usual failure — galvanized, flat, rusted through in 5 to 8 years, dripping into the framing. The repair is a pitched stainless cover sized to the chase, and reframing where the sheathing under it has gone soft. The older complexes from the 1970s often have real brick chimneys, and those get the masonry repairs below.

Chimney repointing in Parsippany

The 1950s–70s single-family chimneys have mortar at or past its life — recessed, sandy joints, mortar you can pick out with a key. On the splits, the wall section between the lower and upper roofs is as exposed as the stack and gets skipped; on the bi-levels with an exterior chimney, the full height is exposed. The brick chimneys in the older condo complexes are the same age and the same condition, repeated across the community.

The repair: every exposed face ground out three-quarters of an inch to an inch and repointed in a matched Type N tooled to the original concave joint, spalled brick replaced, the top done in the same visit.

Cracked chimney top

Parsippany's brick chimneys were finished with a thin mortar wash around the flue liner, cracked after fifty-plus winters. Once the top is open, rain goes into the top course and down the core.

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from the flue, overhanging the brick by two inches so water drips clear of the face, with a bond break around the flue tile. A stainless cap goes on the flue.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or attic framing beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. On the splits it's the lower corner where the lower roof meets the chimney and the upper wall; on the ranches it's the uphill side on a low-pitched roof; on condo roofs it's flashing that was done once when the complex was built and tucked under on every re-roof since.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane — up the wall with a kickout at a split's lower corner — and weave step flashing into every shingle course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — not caulked to the brick — wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket behind them. Matching shingles are woven back in.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in matched modular red brick, with the flue tiles reset or replaced, a poured crown, and new flashing. The section inside the house is left alone.

Lake Hiawatha and Lake Parsippany bungalows

The lake sections started as summer bungalows and were winterized and expanded over decades, and their chimneys were built light — single-wythe brick around an unlined flue, on a shallow footing — for a few fires a season. When the house became year-round and the fireplace or a stove became heat, the chimney started doing work it wasn't built for. A sound stack gets a liner, a repoint, and a crown; a thin, leaning, or unlined one is rebuilt above the roof in proper masonry, lined, and crowned.

Furnace chimneys after gas conversions

Most Parsippany chimneys vent the furnace as well as the fireplace, and most houses have converted from oil to gas. Gas exhaust condenses in a cold masonry flue, and the acidic condensate breaks down the mortar and brick from inside — flakes in the gutter, staining near the top. The masonry is repaired like any other, and a stainless liner sized to the appliance keeps it from happening again.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Parsippany chimney it means a cracked top or open joints. Fix the source and the staining stops.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Condo fireplace leaking; association and owner each say it's the other	Exterior and interior problems on one chimney	Inspect the whole chimney, two-column report, do both halves billed separately
Rust streaks on a townhouse chimney chase	Galvanized cover rusted through	Pitched stainless cover; reframe if rotted; community survey for the board
Sandy, recessed joints (brick)	Mortar past its lifespan	Grind and repoint every exposed face
Cracked or missing mortar at the top	Mortar wash instead of a crown	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown with a cap
Stain at the lower corner of a split during rain	Tarred flashing at the hardest tie-in	Membrane up the wall, step flashing, kickout, reglet-cut counter-flashing
Thin, leaning, or unlined chimney on a lake bungalow	Built for seasonal use	Rebuild above the roof, line, crown

Common questions from Parsippany homeowners

I own a condo and my fireplace leaks. Is that me or the association?
Usually both — the water comes in on the association's side and lands on yours. We inspect the whole chimney and give you a report that splits it, with photos, so you can hand it to the property manager instead of arguing about it.

Do you work with property managers and boards?
Yes. We survey the community's chimneys together, document each one, and price the exterior work as a program the board can budget over a season or two.

My fireplace is a metal unit with glass doors. Is my chimney brick or a chase?
A chase — a framed box with siding and a metal cover, not a masonry chimney. The failures are the cover and the framing under it, not mortar. We handle both.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic — or the unit above — before quoting. That shows whether water is entering at the flashing, the cover, or the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Parsippany-Troy Hills by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 40 minutes from Parsippany. Our own crews handle the masonry, the lining, the chase work, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so a condo chimney isn't split between the association's roofer and the owner's sweep. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Montville, Boonton Township, Morris Plains, East Hanover, Morristown, and across Morris County.

Next is Pequannock.

Randolph — 1960s–2000s colonials, splits, and contemporaries on wooded, hilly lots in Ironia, Mount Freedom, and around Shongum Lake, with a lot of 1980s–90s construction. Leads with something no chimney page has had: the chimney that comes through a cathedral ceiling — no attic, nowhere to look, and a leak that shows up in the drywall of the family room.

URL: `/chimney-repair/morris-county/randolph-nj/`
Title tag (55 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Randolph NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (154 chars): Chimney repair in Randolph, NJ — cathedral-ceiling chimney leaks, brick and stone repointing, cracked crowns, flashing on steep roofs, and roofline rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Randolph, NJ

Randolph was built in the decades when family rooms got tall. The colonials and contemporaries that went up in Ironia, Mount Freedom, and around Shongum Lake from the late 1970s through the 90s have a two-story great room or a cathedral-ceiling family room with the fireplace on the end wall and the chimney rising straight through the sloped ceiling — no attic above it, no access, nothing between the roof deck and the drywall but rafters and insulation. On a regular house, a chimney leak shows up in the attic first and somebody sees it on a ladder. On a Randolph cathedral ceiling, the first sign is a stain spreading across the drywall fifteen feet up, and by then the insulation has been wet for a season.

Here's how we find and fix chimney leaks on these houses, and what we see on Randolph chimneys generally.

Chimney leaks on a cathedral ceiling

Without an attic, the inspection has to be done from the roof and from the ceiling itself, and the ceiling tells us more than people expect:

A stain directly beside the chimney, on the high side. Water coming in at the uphill flashing — on a cathedral roof that's usually a steep slope with no cricket behind a wide chimney — and running straight down the rafter bay to the drywall.

A stain a few feet downslope from the chimney. Water in at the chimney, running down the top of the drywall inside the rafter bay before it finds a seam. Still the chimney.

A stain on the chimney breast itself — the drywall or stone face around the fireplace. Water coming down inside the chimney, from a cracked top or open joints, and wicking through.

Drywall nail pops or a sag in a line down from the chimney. Insulation saturated and heavy, sometimes for a long time.

The repair: we open the roof around the chimney rather than the ceiling. The shingles come off, and the deck around the chimney is inspected — on a cathedral roof that deck is also the ceiling's only protection, so any softness is replaced. The base is wrapped in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane carried well up the steep slope, step flashing goes into every course, the counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar or a channel cut into stone, and a cricket is framed behind any chimney over 30 inches wide — which on these fireplace chimneys is all of them. From inside, once the leak is stopped, the wet insulation in the affected rafter bays is pulled from a small opening at the low end, replaced, and the drywall patched and finished to match. If the chimney itself is letting water in — cracked top, open joints — that's fixed from the roof in the same visit.

Chimney repointing in Randolph

The 1960s–70s brick chimneys have mortar past its life — recessed, sandy joints, mortar you can pick out with a key. The 1980s–90s chimneys are often brick veneer over a block or framed core and have thin joints that wash through to the core when they go. The fieldstone and cultured-stone chimneys on the contemporaries fail at the joints and, on veneer, behind the stone.

The repair: on brick, every exposed face ground out three-quarters of an inch to an inch and repointed in a matched Type N tooled to the original joint, carefully on thin veneer; spalled brick replaced. On fieldstone, joints raked by hand, loose stones reset, repointed to the original profile. On cultured stone with white staining through the face, we open the face, install the drainage layer that was left out, and re-set the stone.

Cracked chimney top

Randolph's chimneys were finished with a mortar wash around the flue tiles — thin on the 1960s houses, thin on the 1990s houses too, on a top three times the size. At this elevation it cracked within a few winters. Once the top is open, rain goes into the top courses and down the core, and on a cathedral-ceiling house that water ends up on the chimney breast.

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from every flue, overhanging the masonry by two inches, with wire or fiber reinforcement on the wide tops and a bond break around each flue tile. Each flue gets a stainless cap.

Steep roofs and wind on the hills

Randolph's hills put a lot of its chimneys on steep roofs at 700 or 800 feet, where wind-driven rain hits the uphill wall of the stack and works the top courses loose over time. Joints washed out deeper on the west face, a crack down from the top through several courses, and a missing cap are the signs. The top courses are rebuilt and bonded into the sound masonry below, the stack is crowned, caps are fastened to the masonry rather than set in sealant, and a breathable water repellent slows wind-driven water getting into the joints.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in matched brick or salvaged stone, with the flue tiles reset or replaced, a poured crown, and new flashing with a cricket. The section inside the house — which on a cathedral-ceiling house is the visible chimney breast — is left alone.

Furnace chimneys after gas conversions

Most Randolph chimneys vent the furnace as well as the fireplace, and most houses have converted from oil to gas. Gas exhaust condenses in a cold masonry flue, and the acidic condensate breaks down the mortar and brick from inside — flakes in the gutter, staining near the top. The masonry is repaired like any other, and a stainless liner sized to the appliance keeps it from happening again.

White stains on brick or stone

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Randolph chimney it means a cracked top, open joints, or veneer without drainage — and on a cathedral-ceiling house, staining on the interior chimney breast means the same water is reaching the inside.

Prefab fireplace chases

Many of Randolph's 1980s–2000s homes vent a prefab fireplace through a sided or veneered chase with a metal cover on top rather than a masonry chimney. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years and drips into the framing — and on a cathedral-ceiling house, straight toward the drywall. We replace the cover with a pitched stainless one and reframe the box if the wood under it is soft.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Stain high on a cathedral ceiling beside or below the chimney	Uphill flashing failed; no cricket	Open the roof, membrane up the slope, step flashing, reglet-cut counter-flashing, cricket; replace wet insulation from inside
Stain on the chimney breast around the fireplace	Water coming down inside the stack	Crown, repoint, cap
Sandy joints; veneer washed through; stone loose	Mortar past its lifespan; no drainage behind veneer	Repoint; open and drain veneer; reset stone
Cracked top; cap missing; crack down from the top	Wash cracked; wind on a steep roof	Rebuild top courses, poured crown, fastened caps, repellent

Spalling through faces, crack through courses, lean	Core failure above the roofline	Roofline rebuild, crown, flashing with cricket
Rust streaks on a sided chase	Galvanized cover rusted through	Pitched stainless cover; reframe if rotted

Common questions from Randolph homeowners

There's a stain on my cathedral ceiling near the chimney. How do you find the leak without an attic?
From the roof and from where the stain is. The position of the stain relative to the chimney tells us whether it's the flashing or the chimney itself, and we open the roof around the chimney rather than the ceiling. Once the leak is stopped, the wet insulation is replaced through a small opening at the low end of the bay.

Will you fix the ceiling too?
Yes. The flashing or masonry first, then the insulation and drywall, patched and finished to match. One crew.

Can the top be done without rebuilding the chimney?
Yes, if the masonry below it is sound. We check the top courses when we remove the old wash and rebuild only what's taken water.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from inside before quoting — on a cathedral-ceiling house, from the ceiling and the chimney breast. That shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Randolph by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 50 minutes from Randolph. We're a general contractor as well as a mason and roofer, so the chimney, the flashing, the insulation, and the ceiling under it are one job. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Morris Township, Morristown, Chester Township, Morris Plains, Chester Borough, and across Morris County.

That's the last Morris town. Essex County starts with Caldwell.

Caldwell — a small, old borough: 1890s–1930s Victorians, colonials, and two-families on the streets off Bloomfield Avenue, dense, with a lot of fireplaces that were converted to gas logs or gas inserts over the last thirty years. Leads with something no chimney page has had: what a gas insert or a set of gas logs does to a hundred-year-old masonry chimney.

URL: `/chimney-repair/essex-county/caldwell-nj/`
Title tag (55 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Caldwell NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (155 chars): Chimney repair in Caldwell, NJ — gas inserts and gas logs in old masonry chimneys, 100-year-old brick repointing, cracked crowns, flashing leaks, and rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Caldwell, NJ

Caldwell's houses are a century old and most of them have a fireplace that hasn't burned wood in decades. Somewhere in the last thirty years a gas log set went into the firebox, or a gas insert was slid in with a flexible liner run up the flue, and the fireplace became something you turn on with a switch. The chimney above it is still the original: soft brick, lime mortar, a clay-tile flue sized for a wood fire, a top that's been cracked for years. Gas changed what the chimney has to do and nobody told the chimney.

Here's what we see on Caldwell chimneys — the gas conversion problems first, then the age problems every hundred-year-old brick chimney has — and how Lita Construction repairs them.

Gas inserts and gas logs in old masonry chimneys

A wood fire sends hot, dry exhaust up a flue and dries the chimney out every time it burns. Gas does the opposite. Gas exhaust is cooler and full of water vapor, and in a big clay-tile flue built for wood, it condenses on the way up — on the tile, in the joints between tiles, on the brick behind them. The condensate is acidic. Over ten or fifteen years of winter evenings with the gas logs on, it dissolves the mortar between the flue tiles, saturates the brick, and shows up outside as spalling and white staining concentrated in the top third of the stack, where the flue is coldest.

The two common setups fail differently:

Vented gas logs with no liner. The logs sit in the open firebox and vent up the original flue, which is far too large for the small volume of gas exhaust. The exhaust cools and condenses before it reaches the top. This is the worst case for the masonry.

A gas insert with a flexible liner. Better — the exhaust is contained in a pipe — but the liner was often run uninsulated, which still condenses, and the space between the liner and the old flue was left open at the top, so rain goes down between them and sits on the smoke shelf. The insert's top plate and cap were installed by the fireplace company, not a mason, and the crown around them was left as it was.

The repair: the masonry is repaired like any other — spalled brick replaced, joints repointed, the top rebuilt and crowned. Then the flue is made right for gas: a properly sized, insulated stainless liner connected to the insert or the log set's collar, sealed to a new crown with a top plate and cap matched to the liner, so the exhaust stays warm enough to rise and the rain stays out. On a chimney where the old flue is cracked from the condensation, the liner is the fix for that too. We coordinate with the fireplace company if the insert's connection needs to be redone.

Repointing 100-year-old brick

Caldwell's chimneys are in soft brick and lime mortar, worn at the joints and almost always repointed once — often in a hard modern mortar that's now breaking the brick around it. Faces popping off, flakes in the gutter, joints intact: that's the hard-mortar problem, and on a chimney that's also been condensing from inside, the two meet in the top courses.

The repair: we grind out the worn or hard mortar three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep, carefully on soft brick, replace spalled units with reclaimed or matched brick, and repoint in a lime-rich Type N or Type O matched to the original color and sand, tooled to the original joint. The attic section — unfinished lime joints on most of these houses — is repointed from inside where the top has been letting water down.

Cracked chimney top

The tops of Caldwell's chimneys — a mortar wash, a corbeled brick cap — have been cracked for decades, and on the gas-converted chimneys the crown was usually left alone when the insert went in, with a top plate caulked over it. Once the top is open, rain goes into the core, and on an insert chimney, down between the liner and the old flue.

The repair: we remove the old wash or reset the cap, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from every flue, overhanging the brick by two inches, with a bond break around each flue tile or liner. Each flue gets a cap matched to what's in it: a stainless cap on an open clay flue, a liner-matched top plate and cap on a lined one, a solid cap on an unused one.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or down a wall beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. Caldwell's older houses were flashed in lead or copper, mostly replaced during re-roofing with aluminum tarred to the brick; the Victorians often have the chimney passing through a porch roof or an eave as well as the main roof, and each penetration leaks on its own.

The repair: on slate we remove and reset the slates around the chimney; on shingle we strip the surrounding courses. Any rotted deck is replaced, the base is wrapped in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and step flashing goes in every course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — gently on soft brick — wedged, and sealed. Lower penetrations are flashed separately. Copper on the older houses.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces — common at the top of a condensing gas chimney — a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in reclaimed or matched soft brick and lime mortar, with the flue lined, a poured crown, and new flashing. The section inside the house is left alone.

Two-family houses

Many of Caldwell's larger houses are two-families with one chimney serving both units — a fireplace on one floor, a boiler or water heater in the basement. Every flue is traced to its appliance before anything is lined, capped, or sealed, and the work is scheduled so both units know when a flue is out of service.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Caldwell chimney it means a cracked top or open joints — and staining concentrated near the top of a gas-converted chimney means the condensation has been working for years.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Spalling and white staining in the top third; gas logs or insert below	Gas exhaust condensing in a flue built for wood	Repair masonry; insulated, sized stainless liner; sealed crown and matched cap
Water on the smoke shelf behind a gas insert	Rain down between the liner and the old flue	Crown with top plate sealed to the liner

Brick faces popping off; joints intact	Hard-mortar repoint on soft brick	Replace spalled brick, repoint in lime-rich mortar
Sandy, washed-out joints; mortar dust in the attic	Original lime mortar worn; top letting water down	Repoint outside and in the attic; fix the top
Ceiling, wall, or porch-ceiling stain beside the chimney during rain	Tarred flashing; separate penetrations	Copper step and counter-flashing at each penetration
Spalling through faces, crack through courses, lean	Core failure above the roofline	Roofline rebuild in matched brick, line, crown

Common questions from Caldwell homeowners

We've had gas logs for fifteen years. Why is the top of the chimney falling apart now?
Gas exhaust condenses in a big clay flue and the condensate eats the mortar and brick from inside. Fifteen winters is about when it shows outside. The fix is the masonry plus an insulated, properly sized liner so it doesn't continue.

The fireplace company put in the insert. Shouldn't they have done the chimney?
They did the appliance and the liner; the crown, the cap, and the masonry around them are a mason's work and usually weren't touched. We finish what the install left open and coordinate with them if the connection needs redoing.

My chimney was repointed 20 years ago and now the bricks are breaking. Why?
Almost certainly a hard mortar on soft pre-war brick. The mortar is now stronger than the brick, so the brick takes the freeze-thaw damage. The fix is to replace the damaged brick and repoint in a lime-rich mortar.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Caldwell by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 35 minutes from Caldwell. Our own crews handle the masonry, the lining, the copper work, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason, a fireplace company, and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in West Caldwell, North Caldwell, Verona, Cedar Grove, Essex Fells, and across Essex County.

Next is Cedar Grove.

Cedar Grove — 1950s–70s splits, capes, and colonials on the slope of the Watchung ridge off Pompton Avenue and Ridge Road, a lot of them on lots steep enough that the house steps with the hill. Leads with something no chimney page has had: the chimney that sits where two roofs drain — at an inside corner, under a valley, next to a gutter that ends against the brick — and takes the whole roof's water on one face.

URL: `/chimney-repair/essex-county/cedar-grove-nj/`
Title tag (58 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Cedar Grove NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (153 chars): Chimney repair in Cedar Grove, NJ — chimneys taking roof runoff at inside corners, brick repointing, cracked crowns, flashing leaks, and roofline rebuilds. Lita.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Cedar Grove, NJ

Cedar Grove's splits and colonials were built on a hillside, and a lot of them were built in an L or a T — a garage wing, a family-room wing, a later addition — with the chimney tucked into the inside corner where the wings meet. That corner is where the roofs drain. A valley empties toward it, a gutter from the upper roof ends against it or just above it, and in a hard rain the chimney's inside faces take more water than the rest of the house's exterior combined. The chimney was built like every other 1960s chimney — same mortar, same wash on top, same flashing — but it's doing a different job, and it fails first.

Here's what we see on Cedar Grove chimneys and how Lita Construction repairs them.

Chimneys at inside corners taking roof runoff

Stand in the yard during a rain and watch where the water goes. On the inside-corner chimneys in Cedar Grove you'll see it: a valley discharging straight at the chimney wall, a gutter end spilling onto the chimney shoulder where it steps in, or an upper-roof downspout emptying onto

the lower roof a foot from the brick. The faces of the chimney in that corner stay dark for a day after the rest of the house has dried. Over decades, those faces have the joints washed out deeper than anywhere else on the chimney, moss in the shoulder, and the flashing at the base scoured by the volume of water hitting it.

Inside, the stain is on the ceiling of whichever room sits under that corner — often the family room in the lower wing — and it's blamed on the valley or the gutter rather than the chimney, because the water is obviously coming from the roof.

The repair: the chimney and the drainage are fixed together. The chimney faces in the corner are repointed deep — ground out a full inch, repointed in a matched Type N — and the shoulder, where the chimney steps in, gets a sloped mortar wash or a metal cap flashing so it stops holding water. The flashing at the base is rebuilt with step flashing in every course and counter-flashing cut into the mortar, and the valley is extended with a metal pan that carries its discharge past the chimney onto the roof below rather than into its wall. A gutter that ends against the chimney is rerouted or given a diverter; a downspout that empties beside the brick gets an extension to the lower gutter. The chimney stops being the drain.

Chimney repointing in Cedar Grove

Beyond the corner faces, the 1950s–70s mortar is at or past its life everywhere — recessed, sandy, mortar you can pick out with a key — and on the splits, the wall section between the lower and upper roofs is as exposed as the stack and gets skipped by a lot of masons.

The repair: every exposed face ground out three-quarters of an inch to an inch and repointed in a matched Type N tooled to the original concave joint, spalled brick replaced, the top done in the same visit. On the handful of pre-war houses near the center, the brick is softer and gets a lime-rich mortar instead.

Cracked chimney top

Cedar Grove's chimneys were finished with a thin mortar wash around the flue liner, cracked after fifty-plus winters on the exposed ridge. Once the top is open, rain goes into the top course and down the core, which is what feeds the washed-out joints and spalling below.

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from the flue, overhanging the brick by two inches so water drips clear of the face, with a bond break around the flue tile. A stainless cap goes on the flue.

Chimney leaking when it rains

On chimneys that aren't in a drainage corner, a stain on a ceiling or attic framing beside the chimney during rain is the usual flashing leak — tarred-over aluminum from a past roof job, at the lower corner of a split or the main tie-in of a colonial.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane — up the wall with a kickout at a split's lower corner — and weave step flashing into every shingle course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — not caulked to the brick — wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket behind them. Matching shingles are woven back in.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in matched modular red brick, with the flue tiles reset or replaced, a poured crown, and new flashing. The section inside the house is left alone.

Hillside lots

Cedar Grove's slope puts a lot of chimneys on the downhill side of the house, where the base is a story or more below the uphill grade and the stack is taller and more exposed than it looks from the street. We scaffold from the roof with protective cribbing where the roof can carry it and from a leveled base where it can't, and the full exposed height is treated — joints near the bottom of a downhill chimney take as much weather as the top.

Furnace chimneys after gas conversions

Most Cedar Grove chimneys vent the furnace as well as the fireplace, and most houses have converted from oil to gas. Gas exhaust condenses in a cold masonry flue, and the acidic condensate breaks down the mortar and brick from inside — flakes in the gutter, staining near the top. The masonry is repaired like any other, and a stainless liner sized to the appliance keeps it from happening again.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Cedar Grove chimney it means a cracked top or open joints — and on an inside-corner chimney, staining concentrated on the corner faces means they've been the roof's drain for years.

Prefab fireplace chases

A few Cedar Grove additions and newer homes vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood box with a metal cover on top. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace it with a pitched stainless cover and reframe the box if needed. It's a small share of our work in town next to the masonry above.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Chimney faces in an inside corner stay dark; joints washed out there; stain below	Valley or gutter discharging onto the chimney	Deep repoint, capped shoulder, rebuilt flashing, valley pan extended past the chimney, gutter rerouted
Sandy joints on the wall section of a split	Mortar past its lifespan; section skipped	Repoint every exposed face
Cracked or missing mortar at the top	Mortar wash instead of a crown	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown with a cap
Ceiling stain beside the chimney during rain	Tarred flashing; no cricket	Step flashing, reglet-cut counter-flashing, kickout, cricket
Joints washed out low on a downhill chimney	Full height exposed	Scaffold from the roof, repoint to the base
Flakes in gutters, staining near the top (gas heat)	Exhaust condensation from inside	Repair masonry, stainless liner, sealed crown

Common questions from Cedar Grove homeowners

The leak is obviously from the valley above the chimney. Why is it a chimney job?
Because the valley drains onto the chimney, and the chimney's joints and flashing have been taking that water for years. We fix the chimney and redirect the valley in the same job; fixing one without the other brings the leak back.

Can you move the gutter that ends at my chimney?
Usually it's rerouted or given a diverter so it spills past the brick onto the roof below. It's a small change and it's the difference between a chimney that dries after rain and one that doesn't.

Can the top be done without rebuilding the chimney?
Yes, if the brick below it is sound. We check the top courses when we remove the old wash and rebuild only what's taken water.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting — and on an inside-corner chimney, we watch where the water goes. That shows whether it's entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Cedar Grove by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 30 minutes from Cedar Grove. Our own crews handle the masonry, the flashing, the gutters, and the roof tie-in, so the chimney and the roof draining onto it are one job. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Verona, Montclair, Caldwell, Little Falls, North Caldwell, and across Essex County.

Next is Essex Fells.

Essex Fells — a small, planned borough of 1890s–1930s estate homes on wooded lots, heavy on Tudor Revival. Leads with something no chimney page has had: the clustered chimney — two or three separate slender shafts rising from one base, decorative and fragile, which is the signature chimney of these houses and the hardest to repair well.

URL: `/chimney-repair/essex-county/essex-fells-nj/`
Title tag (56 chars): Chimney Repair & Rebuilding Essex Fells NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (154 chars): Chimney repair in Essex Fells, NJ — clustered Tudor chimney shafts, historic brick and stone repointing, cracked crowns, copper flashing, and roofline rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Essex Fells, NJ

Essex Fells was laid out as an estate community in the 1890s, and the houses built on its curving roads over the next forty years were designed to be looked at — Tudor Revivals, Georgian colonials, and shingle-style houses on acre lots under old oaks. The chimneys were part of the design. On the Tudors in particular, the chimney isn't a single stack but a cluster: two, three, or four slender shafts, each carrying one flue, rising from a common base and joined again at the top under a corbeled cap, often with patterned or spiral brickwork on the shafts. They're the most distinctive thing on the roofline and, ninety years on, the most fragile.

Here's what we see on Essex Fells chimneys and how Lita Construction repairs them.

Clustered chimney shafts on Tudor Revival homes

A single shaft in a Tudor cluster might be only sixteen inches across, with a flue tile inside and one wythe of brick around it. It's exposed on all four sides, it has decorative brick that catches water on every projecting header, and it's tied to its neighbors only at the base and the cap. After ninety winters, what we find: the caps loose or missing a corner, the shafts leaning away from each other at the top, cracks through the spiral or diaper-pattern brickwork, and mortar washed out of the joints between the shafts where the sun never reaches. The flue tiles inside the shafts are often cracked from water that came in at the cap.

The common bad repair is to take the cluster down and rebuild it as one plain stack. It stops the leak and takes the house's roofline with it.

The repair: we photograph and measure every shaft, the cap, and the pattern before anything comes down. The cluster is scaffolded with protective cribbing — on the slate roofs these houses have, extensively — and the shafts are taken down to sound brick, which is often the full height above the base. Each shaft is rebuilt to its original dimensions in reclaimed or color-matched soft brick, laid in a lime-rich mortar, with the pattern reproduced course by course and the flue tile continued inside it. The shafts are tied to each other with stainless ties at intervals, which the original mason didn't have, and the corbeled cap is rebuilt over a poured, reinforced crown that spans the cluster, with a bond break around each flue. Each flue gets a cap sized to it. The result is the chimney the house was built with, standing straighter than it did.

Repointing historic brick and stone

The brick on Essex Fells' houses is soft, often clinker or tapestry brick in a range of colors, laid in lime mortar. The stone — fieldstone on the shingle-style houses, cut stone on the Georgians — is laid the same way. The original mortar is worn after a century, and most of these chimneys

have been repointed once in a hard modern mortar that's now breaking the brick around it: faces popping off, flakes in the gutter, joints intact.

The repair: we grind out the worn or hard mortar three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep, carefully on soft brick so the edges aren't nicked, replace spalled units with reclaimed brick matched for color range as well as size, and repoint in a lime-rich Type N or Type O matched to the original color and sand, tooled to the original joint — often a raked or weathered joint on these houses. Stone is raked by hand, loose stones reset, and repointed to the original profile.

Cracked tops and caps

Beyond the clusters, the plain chimneys on the Georgians and shingle-style houses were finished with corbeled brick caps, stone caps, or a mortar wash, all cracked for decades. Once the top is open, rain goes into the core and comes out wherever the mortar is weakest — the attic section, or the wythe between flues.

The repair: we remove the failed wash or lift the cap, rebuild the top courses and any failed wythes, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from every flue, overhanging the brick by two inches, with a bond break around each flue tile — under a rebuilt corbel or a reset stone cap. Each flue gets a copper or stainless cap; unused flues are sealed.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or down a wall beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. These houses were flashed in copper, and a lot of it survives, but it's been patched with tar at the corners through generations of slate repairs. The steep Tudor roofs send water hard at the uphill wall of a cluster, and few have a cricket.

The repair: slates around the chimney are removed with a ripper and reset, not cut. Any rotted deck is replaced, the base is wrapped in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and step flashing goes in every course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — gently on soft brick — wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket, framed to the roof's pitch. All of it in 20-ounce copper, soldered.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in reclaimed brick and lime mortar, or salvaged stone, with every decorative course rebuilt to profile, the flues reset or lined, a poured crown, and copper flashing. The section inside the house is left alone.

Multiple chimneys on one house

Most Essex Fells houses have three or four chimneys, and they don't fail at the same rate — the cluster on the north side under the trees is worse than the plain stack on the kitchen wing. We inspect every chimney on the house from the roof and the attic, write each up separately, and tell you which need work this season, which are due, and which can wait, so the scaffolding goes up once for the ones that need it.

White stains on brick or stone

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On an Essex Fells chimney it means a cracked top or open joints — and on a cluster, staining on the inside faces between the shafts means those joints have been wet for years.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Shafts of a clustered chimney leaning apart; cap loose or broken	Ninety years of weather on single-wythe shafts	Rebuild each shaft to pattern in matched brick and lime mortar, tie the shafts, crown under a rebuilt cap
Cluster rebuilt as a plain stack by a past repair	Wrong repair	Rebuild the cluster from photographs or a matching chimney on the house
Brick faces popping off; joints intact	Hard-mortar repoint on soft brick	Replace with matched reclaimed brick, repoint in lime mortar
Loose stones; mortar crumbs at the base	Washed-out joints behind the stone	Hand-rake, reset, repoint to profile
Ceiling stain beside a chimney on a steep slate roof	Tar at the copper flashing corners; no cricket	Reset slate, soldered copper step and counter-flashing, cricket
Several chimneys; condition unknown	Different exposure per chimney	Inspect all, write each up, sort by urgency

Common questions from Essex Fells homeowners

Can the clustered chimney be rebuilt the way it was?
Yes. We photograph and measure it before taking it down, rebuild each shaft to its original dimensions and pattern in matched brick, and tie the shafts together so it stands straighter than the original. If a past repair already replaced it with a plain stack, we rebuild the cluster from old photographs or from a matching chimney on the house.

Will the brick match?
We source reclaimed brick matched for color range — clinker and tapestry brick vary from salmon to near-black — as well as size, and blend it the way the original mason did. It weathers in over a couple of seasons.

Can you work on a slate roof without damaging it?
Yes. Slates are removed with a ripper and reset, not cut, the roof is cribbed before any masonry work, and any slate that cracks is replaced with matched salvaged slate.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows which chimney the water is coming from and whether it's entering at the flashing or through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Essex Fells by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 35 minutes from Essex Fells, and we take on the historic masonry that most roofing companies won't. Our own crews handle the brickwork, the stone, the copper, the slate, and the roof tie-in. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Caldwell, West Caldwell, North Caldwell, Roseland, Verona, and across Essex County.

Next is Fairfield.

Fairfield — flat, along the Passaic River and Route 46: 1960s–80s ranches, splits, and colonials on the residential streets, and a long commercial corridor of restaurants, offices, and light-industrial buildings. Leads with something no chimney page has had: commercial masonry chimneys — boiler flues on single-story buildings, restaurant exhaust stacks, the wood-fired oven flue — on flat roofs with tenants under them.

URL: `/chimney-repair/essex-county/fairfield-nj/`
Title tag (56 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Fairfield NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (153 chars): Chimney repair in Fairfield, NJ — commercial and restaurant chimneys on flat roofs, brick repointing, cracked crowns, flashing leaks, and roofline rebuilds. Lita.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Fairfield, NJ

Fairfield is two towns on one grid: the residential streets of 1960s–80s ranches, splits, and colonials between Fairfield Road and the river, and the commercial corridor along Route 46 and Passaic Avenue — restaurants, offices, medical buildings, and the light-industrial parks behind them. The houses have the chimney problems any 50-year-old brick chimney has. The commercial buildings have masonry chimneys that most residential masons won't touch and most commercial roofers don't do: a brick boiler flue rising off a flat membrane roof, a restaurant's wood-fired oven stack, a stack serving three tenants' water heaters, all with somebody's business underneath.

Here's what we see on Fairfield chimneys, commercial and residential, and how Lita Construction repairs them.

Commercial chimneys on flat roofs

A masonry chimney on a single-story commercial building stands alone on a flat roof with nothing to shelter it, flashed into a membrane rather than shingles, and serving appliances that run harder and longer than a house's. The failures we see along Route 46:

Base flashing turned up and mastic-sealed. The roofer ran the membrane up the brick a few inches and sealed the top edge with roofing cement. It fails at that edge within a few years and water goes down behind it into the ceiling of whatever's below — a dining room, an exam room, a stockroom.

Boiler flues condensing from inside. Most commercial boilers converted from oil to gas decades ago, and the gas exhaust condenses in an unlined or clay-lined masonry flue. The acidic condensate dissolves the mortar from the flue side; outside, it shows as spalling and white staining concentrated in the top third of the stack and brick flakes on the roof.

Restaurant stacks. A wood-fired or coal-fired oven venting through a masonry flue sends hot, greasy exhaust up it; cracked flue tiles and creosote-saturated mortar near the top are the result, and a stack that's had a flue fire has split tiles the owner never knew about.

Mortar washes on wide tops. Commercial stacks are often wide — two or three flues — and were finished with a mortar wash that cracked long ago.

The repair: the masonry is repaired from scaffolding set on the roof with load-spreading planks over the membrane — spalled brick replaced, joints repointed, the top rebuilt and crowned with

a reinforced, overhanging crown, every flue capped. The base flashing is rebuilt the way a membrane roof needs: a base flashing run a minimum of eight inches up the brick and bonded to the roof, capped with metal counter-flashing set into a reglet in the mortar joint. Gas boiler flues get a stainless liner sized to the appliance; oven flues get a camera inspection and a liner rated for the temperatures involved. We schedule around the business — the boiler can't be down long, the oven can't be down at all during service — and protect the parking lot or sidewalk when the stack is on the front.

Chimney repointing in Fairfield

On the residential side, the 1960s–80s chimneys have mortar at or past its life — recessed, sandy joints, mortar you can pick out with a key. On the splits, the wall section between the lower and upper roofs is as exposed as the stack and gets skipped; on the ranches, the short stack on a low-pitched roof holds debris against its uphill face.

The repair: every exposed face ground out three-quarters of an inch to an inch and repointed in a matched Type N tooled to the original concave joint, spalled brick replaced, the top done in the same visit.

Cracked chimney top

Fairfield's residential chimneys were finished with a thin mortar wash around the flue liner, cracked after fifty-plus winters. Once the top is open, rain goes into the top course and down the core.

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from the flue, overhanging the brick by two inches so water drips clear of the face, with a bond break around the flue tile. A stainless cap goes on the flue.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or attic framing beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. On the splits it's the lower corner where the lower roof meets the chimney and the upper wall; on the ranches it's the uphill side on a low-pitched roof; on the colonials it's the main tie-in. The flashing was usually redone during a past roof job with aluminum tarred to the brick.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane — up the wall with a kickout at a split's lower corner, up the slope on a ranch — and weave step flashing into every shingle course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint, wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket behind them.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in matched brick, with the flue tiles reset or replaced, a poured crown, and new flashing. The section inside the building is left alone. On a commercial stack the rebuild is scheduled so the boiler flue is out of service for the shortest possible time.

Flood-saturated masonry

Parts of Fairfield near the river have flooded, and a chimney that's stood in water has had its lower courses saturated for days — weakened mortar, a white line at the old water mark as it dries. Those courses are repointed once the masonry has dried out, soft brick replaced, and the flue camera-inspected before a fireplace is used, since silt collects on the smoke shelf.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Fairfield chimney it means a cracked top or open joints — on a commercial boiler stack, staining in the top third means the flue has been condensing for years.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Ceiling stain in a commercial space under the chimney	Membrane turned up and sealed with mastic	Base flashing up the brick, metal counter-flashing in a reglet
Spalling and staining in the top third of a boiler stack	Gas exhaust condensing from inside	Repair masonry, stainless liner, sealed crown
Restaurant oven stack cracking near the top	Heat and creosote; possible flue fire	Camera inspection, repair masonry, rated liner
Sandy joints on a residential chimney	Mortar past its lifespan	Grind and repoint every exposed face
Cracked or missing mortar at the top	Mortar wash instead of a crown	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown with a cap
White line at a consistent height; soft lower joints	Flood saturation	Repoint once dry, replace soft brick, camera-inspect the flue

Common questions from Fairfield owners

Can you work on the chimney without shutting my restaurant down?
Yes. The exterior masonry and flashing don't require anything to be off. The flue work is scheduled for hours you're closed, and the oven is back in service before you open.

My building has three tenants on one chimney. Who's responsible?
Usually the owner, for the stack and the flashing; the tenants, for their appliances. We trace every flue to its appliance and write it up so it's clear before any work starts.

Can the top be done without rebuilding the chimney?
Yes, if the brick below it is sound. We check the top courses when we remove the old wash and rebuild only what's taken water.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic — or the ceiling below, on a commercial building — before quoting. That shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Fairfield by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 30 minutes from Fairfield. Our own crews handle the masonry, the lining, the flashing, and the roof tie-in — shingle or membrane — so a commercial chimney isn't split between a mason and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in West Caldwell, Montville, Little Falls, Wayne, Caldwell, and across Essex County.

Next is Glen Ridge.

Glen Ridge — the whole borough is a historic district: 1890s–1920s Victorians, Colonial Revivals, and Tudors on the streets off Ridgewood Avenue, gas lamps still on the corners. Leads with something no chimney page has had: the chimney you didn't know you had — the one found inside a wall during a renovation, and the one that's been standing on nothing since somebody removed the fireplace below it.

URL: `/chimney-repair/essex-county/glen-ridge-nj/`
Title tag (57 chars): Chimney Repair & Rebuilding Glen Ridge NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (154 chars): Chimney repair in Glen Ridge, NJ — hidden and unsupported chimneys in Victorian homes, historic brick repointing, cracked crowns, copper flashing, and rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Glen Ridge, NJ

A Glen Ridge house from 1895 was built with four or five chimneys — one for each fireplace, one for the kitchen range, one for the furnace — and in the hundred and thirty years since, most of those fireplaces have been closed up, plastered over, or removed. The chimneys didn't go anywhere. They're still inside the walls, still rising through the attic, still standing above the roof, and a lot of Glen Ridge homeowners find out about them during a kitchen renovation or a bathroom gut: open a wall and there's a brick stack nobody has looked at since the Wilson administration.

Here's what we find when that happens, what to do about it, and what we see on Glen Ridge's visible chimneys.

Hidden chimneys found during renovation

When a contractor opens a wall in a Glen Ridge Victorian and finds a chimney, the owner has to decide what to do with it, and the decision depends on three things we check:

Is anything still venting into it? A furnace, a water heater, a fireplace on another floor. If so, it stays and it gets whatever that appliance needs — usually a stainless liner, because the clay or unlined flue has been taking exhaust and rain for a century.

Is it sound? A hidden chimney has been protected from weather below the roof but not above it. If the top has been cracked for decades, water has been running down the inside and out through the unfinished attic joints — mortar dust on the attic floor, bricks you can move by hand — and the section inside the wall may be damp.

Does the owner want it? A sound, unused chimney can stay — capped and sealed at the top, the wall closed back up — or it can come out to gain the space. Removal above the roof means dismantling the stack, framing and sheathing the opening, and roofing it over so the patch doesn't show, which on a slate roof means matched salvaged slate. Removal inside the house is a bigger job and has to account for what the chimney has been holding up.

Which brings up the other kind of hidden chimney.

The chimney standing on nothing

Somewhere in the last century, somebody wanted the fireplace out of the dining room, or the chimney out of the basement, and took down the lower part of the stack. The upper part — the courses through the second floor, the attic, and above the roof — stayed, because taking it down would have meant opening the roof. It's been resting on a few joists, a header someone nailed in, or on the plaster and lath of the wall around it ever since. We find these in Glen Ridge by looking up from the basement and seeing no chimney base under a chimney that comes through the roof, or by finding a stack in the attic that ends in midair at the second-floor ceiling.

The repair: a chimney with no support under it is a structural problem before it's a leak. If it still serves an appliance or the owner wants it, we build proper support under it — steel or engineered lumber framing designed for the load, which on a two-story brick stack is several tons. If it serves nothing, the right answer is usually to finish what the earlier owner started: take it down to the roof and below, close the roof, and close the wall. Either way, the top is dealt with: a chimney that's going to stay gets a crown and a cap, and one that's coming out stops leaking into the attic the day it's gone.

Repointing historic brick

Glen Ridge's chimneys are in soft brick — often a brownish-red local brick, sometimes with brownstone trim — laid in lime mortar, worn at the joints and almost always repointed once in a hard modern mortar that's now breaking the brick around it. Faces popping off, flakes in the gutter, joints intact: the hard-mortar problem.

The repair: we grind out the worn or hard mortar three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep, carefully on soft brick, replace spalled units with reclaimed brick of the right color and size, and repoint in a lime-rich Type N or Type O matched to the original color and sand, tooled to the original joint. Brownstone trim and caps are repaired with a compatible patching mortar or replaced with matched stone. The whole borough is a historic district, so the repair is made to look like the original, not like a repair.

Cracked chimney top

The tops of Glen Ridge's chimneys — corbeled brick caps, brownstone caps, mortar washes from later repairs — have been cracked for decades. Once the top is open, rain goes into the core and comes out wherever the mortar is weakest, which on these houses is the attic section.

The repair: we remove the failed wash or reset the cap, rebuild the top courses and any decorative corbel to the original profile, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown under it — sloped away from every flue, overhanging the brick by two inches, with a bond break around each flue tile. Each active flue gets a copper or stainless cap; unused flues are sealed. The attic section is repointed from inside.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or down a wall beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. Glen Ridge's houses were flashed in copper, mostly replaced during re-roofing with aluminum tarred to the brick, on slate and shingle roofs with the chimney often in a valley or against a dormer on these complicated Victorian roofs.

The repair: on slate we remove and reset the slates around the chimney; on shingle we strip the surrounding courses. Any rotted deck is replaced, the base is wrapped in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and step flashing goes in every course, tied into any adjoining valley or dormer flashing so there's no seam between them. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — gently on soft brick — wedged, and sealed. All of it in 20-ounce copper, soldered.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in reclaimed brick and lime mortar, with any corbel or cap rebuilt to profile, the flues lined or sealed, a poured crown, and copper flashing. The section inside the house is left alone — unless it's one of the unsupported ones above.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Glen Ridge chimney it means a cracked top or open joints — and in the attic, white powder on a stack that serves nothing means it's been open at the top for a long time.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Chimney found inside a wall during renovation	Closed-up fireplace flue, condition unknown	Trace what vents into it, inspect, then keep-and-seal, line, or remove
Chimney in the attic with no chimney under it in the basement	Lower section removed decades ago; stack resting on framing	Engineered support, or remove above the roof and close the roof and wall
Mortar dust on the attic floor; loose brick	Attic section taking water from the top	Repoint from inside; crown and cap or seal the top

Brick faces popping off; joints intact	Hard-mortar repoint on soft brick	Replace with matched reclaimed brick, repoint in lime mortar
Cracked brownstone or corbeled cap	Cap failed	Rebuild corbel or repair stone, poured crown beneath, caps
Ceiling stain beside a chimney in a valley or at a dormer	Tarred flashing at a complicated corner	Reset slate, soldered copper flashing tied into valley and dormer

Common questions from Glen Ridge homeowners

We found a chimney inside the kitchen wall. Can we just take it out?
If nothing vents into it and it's not holding anything up, yes, and it's often the right call. We check both first — a furnace or water heater is sometimes still on it, and a lot of these stacks are supporting the one above them. Then it's removed above the roof, the roof closed in matched slate or shingle, and the wall closed.

There's a chimney in my attic that ends at the second-floor ceiling. Is that dangerous?
It's resting on framing that wasn't designed for it. It should be either properly supported or taken down. We look at it and tell you which makes sense; either way it shouldn't stay as it is.

Will the repaired brick match a historic house?
We use reclaimed brick matched for color and size, lay it in lime mortar matched to the original, and repair brownstone with compatible stone or patching mortar. The work is made to disappear into the house.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof, from the attic, and from the basement — which is where we find the unsupported ones — before quoting. That shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Glen Ridge by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 30 minutes from Glen Ridge. We're a general contractor as well as a mason and roofer, so a hidden chimney — the structure, the masonry, the roof, and the wall — is one job. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Montclair, Verona, Nutley, Cedar Grove, West Orange, and across Essex County.

Next is Livingston.

Livingston — 1950s–70s splits and colonials by the thousand off Northfield Avenue and South Livingston Avenue, a lot of them torn down and rebuilt big since 2000, and more solar panels per roof than almost anywhere in Essex County. Leads with something no chimney page has had: repairing a chimney on a roof covered in solar panels — access, panel removal, flashing under the array, and the shading that makes moss.

URL: `/chimney-repair/essex-county/livingston-nj/`
Title tag (57 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Livingston NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (153 chars): Chimney repair in Livingston, NJ — chimney work on roofs with solar panels, brick repointing, cracked crowns, flashing leaks, and roofline rebuilds. Lita.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Livingston, NJ

Drive any street in Livingston and count the solar arrays. The 1950s–70s splits and colonials off Northfield Avenue, South Livingston Avenue, and Hillside Avenue have south-facing roofs that were covered in panels over the last fifteen years, and a lot of the big new houses that replaced the teardowns went up with solar from day one. The chimney is usually right in the middle of the array. When it leaks — and a 60-year-old chimney leaks — the first thing a homeowner hears from a mason is "we can't get to it," and the first thing they hear from the solar company is "that's not us."

Here's how we do chimney work on a solar roof, and what we see on Livingston chimneys generally.

Chimney repair on a roof with solar panels

A solar array changes three things about a chimney job. Access: the panels block the roof around the stack, and the racking is bolted through the shingles into the rafters. Flashing: the installer worked around the chimney, and the chimney's flashing on the array side has been under panels — out of sight, unmaintained, and often cut or compressed by the racking. Water:

panels shade the roof and the chimney behind them, so the shingles under the array and the chimney's shaded face stay damp, grow moss, and hold wet leaves that can't blow off.

How we handle it: we coordinate with the solar company to remove the panels and rails around the chimney — usually a row or two on the affected side — and reinstall them when the masonry and flashing are done. Where the homeowner's solar contract allows, we do the removal ourselves and have the installer reconnect. With the panels off, the chimney is treated like any other: the crown, the joints, the flashing rebuilt with step flashing in every course and counter-flashing cut into the mortar, a cricket behind a stack over 30 inches wide. The racking penetrations near the chimney are checked and reflashed if the installer's seals have failed, which is common. Then the array goes back on. For a chimney that needs a rebuild, we plan the panel removal into the schedule so the array is off for the shortest possible time; the house keeps generating on the other roof planes.

If the roof itself is due, this is the time: the panels come off once for both the roof and the chimney, instead of twice.

Chimney repointing in Livingston

The 1950s–70s chimneys have mortar at or past its life — recessed, sandy joints, mortar you can pick out with a key — and under a solar array the shaded face is worse than the others. On the splits, the wall section between the lower and upper roofs gets skipped by a lot of masons; on the exterior-wall colonials, the full height is exposed.

The repair: every exposed face ground out three-quarters of an inch to an inch and repointed in a matched Type N tooled to the original concave joint, spalled brick replaced, the top done in the same visit. On the big new houses, the brick-veneer or stone-veneer chimneys have thin joints and often no drainage behind the veneer; those get the veneer opened, a drainage layer installed, and the stone or brick re-set.

Cracked chimney top

Livingston's chimneys were finished with a mortar wash around the flue liner — sixty years old on the splits, often only ten or fifteen on the new builds, because the builders used the same method on tops three times the size. Once the top is open, rain goes into the top courses and down the core.

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from every flue, overhanging the masonry by two inches, with wire or fiber reinforcement on the wide tops and a bond break around each flue tile. Each flue gets a stainless cap.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or attic framing beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. On the splits it's the lower corner where the lower roof meets the chimney and the upper wall; on the colonials it's the main tie-in; on a solar roof it's often the array side, where the flashing was disturbed during installation. The original flashing was redone during a past roof job with aluminum tarred to the brick.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane — up the wall with a kickout at a split's lower corner — and weave step flashing into every shingle course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — not caulked to the brick — wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket behind them. Matching shingles are woven back in.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in matched brick, with the flue tiles reset or replaced, a poured crown, and new flashing. On a solar roof the panel removal is planned into the job. The section inside the house is left alone.

Chimneys on the new construction

Livingston's teardown rebuilds carry wide, tall, multi-flue chimneys in brick or stone veneer, and the builders finished a lot of them with a thin wash on top, no cricket, and no drainage plane behind the veneer. Fifteen years in, they show white staining through the face, stones or brick popping loose, and leaks at the uphill wall. The repair is the crown, the cricket, and the drainage layer behind the veneer — the three things that should have been there from the start.

Furnace chimneys after gas conversions

Most older Livingston chimneys vent the furnace as well as the fireplace, and most houses have converted from oil to gas. Gas exhaust condenses in a cold masonry flue, and the acidic condensate breaks down the mortar and brick from inside — flakes in the gutter, staining near the top. The masonry is repaired like any other, and a stainless liner sized to the appliance keeps it from happening again.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Livingston chimney it means a cracked top, open joints, or veneer without drainage — and on the face behind a solar array, a chimney that never dries.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Chimney leaking in the middle of a solar array	Flashing under the panels failed or disturbed; shaded face never dries	Coordinate panel removal, rebuild flashing and masonry, reflash racking, reinstall
Moss on the chimney face behind the panels	Shade from the array	Clean, repoint, breathable repellent
Sandy joints on the wall section of a split	Mortar past its lifespan; section skipped	Repoint every exposed face
White staining and loose stone on a newer house	No drainage behind veneer; thin wash on top	Open veneer, install drainage, re-set; poured crown; cricket
Cracked or missing mortar at the top	Mortar wash instead of a crown	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown with caps
Flakes in gutters, staining near the top (gas heat)	Exhaust condensation from inside	Repair masonry, stainless liner, sealed crown

Common questions from Livingston homeowners

My chimney leaks but it's surrounded by solar panels. Can it be fixed?
Yes. The panels around the chimney come off — through the solar company or, where your contract allows, by us — the chimney and flashing are repaired, the racking penetrations are checked, and the panels go back on. The rest of the array keeps producing.

The solar installer says the leak isn't their problem. Is it?
Sometimes. The chimney flashing on the array side was often cut or compressed when the rails went in. We look at it with the panels off and tell you what we find; if the racking seals have failed, we reflash them too.

My house is new and the chimney is already staining. Why?
A wide veneer chimney with a thin wash on top and no drainage behind the stone takes water from the first winter. The fix is the crown, the cricket, and the drainage layer that should have been there.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water

is entering at the flashing, at a racking penetration, or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Livingston by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 30 minutes from Livingston. Our own crews handle the masonry, the flashing, and the roof tie-in — and we work with solar companies regularly, so the panels aren't a reason the chimney can't be fixed. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in West Orange, Roseland, Millburn, East Hanover, Florham Park, and across Essex County.

Next is Maplewood.

Maplewood — a dense 1900s–30s town of Tudors, Dutch colonials, and foursquares on the streets off Valley Street and Ridgewood Road, houses twelve feet apart with tall chimneys over the neighbor's roof, the driveway, or the sidewalk. Leads with something no chimney page has had: what to do the day a chimney becomes dangerous — leaning, shedding brick, cracked through — and how it gets made safe before it gets repaired.

URL: `/chimney-repair/essex-county/maplewood-nj/`
Title tag (56 chars): Chimney Repair & Rebuilding Maplewood NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (154 chars): Chimney repair in Maplewood, NJ — emergency stabilization of leaning or falling chimneys, historic brick repointing, cracked crowns, flashing, and rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Maplewood, NJ

Maplewood's chimneys are a hundred years old and they stand over things. The lots in the Hilton section, around the Village, and on the streets up toward South Mountain are narrow, and

a tall Tudor or Dutch colonial chimney on the side wall is six or eight feet from the neighbor's roof, directly over a shared driveway, or above the sidewalk. When one of those chimneys starts to go — a lean you can see from the street, a course of brick on the driveway after a storm, a crack through the stack — it's not just a leak. It's a few hundred pounds of brick above somebody's car or somebody's kid.

Here's how we make a dangerous chimney safe fast, and what we see on Maplewood chimneys generally.

When a chimney becomes dangerous

The signs that a chimney has gone from "needs work" to "needs attention today": a visible lean that's new or has increased; brick or chunks of mortar on the ground that weren't there last week; a crack running through several courses that you can see daylight through; a top section that moves in wind; or a chimney that's been hit by a limb and is sitting crooked. On a Maplewood lot, any of those over a driveway, a walkway, or a neighbor's roof needs to be dealt with before the next storm.

What we do the same day: we come out, look at it from the roof, and make it safe. That usually means one of three things. A top section that's loose but intact gets braced — strapped to the sound masonry below and tied off so it can't shed — and the area beneath it is cordoned. A section that's beyond bracing gets taken down to sound brick right then, the flue is capped temporarily, and the roof around it is tarped or flashed so the house is weathertight. A chimney that's leaning from the base — rare, but it happens on exterior stacks whose footing has moved — gets shored and the area closed off until it can be evaluated and taken down. Then we document everything for insurance if a storm caused it, and write up the permanent repair.

The permanent repair is the rebuild described below. The point of the first visit is that nothing falls on anyone in the meantime, and that the house doesn't take water through an open stack.

Rebuilding Maplewood's chimneys

Most of Maplewood's chimneys that reach the dangerous stage got there the usual way: a cracked top let water into the core for decades, the mortar inside went, freeze-thaw worked the courses loose, and the stack above the roof — on a Tudor, eight or ten feet of it — lost its integrity. The brick is soft, hand-molded or early machine-made, laid in lime mortar, often with decorative corbels or patterned work near the top.

The repair: we scaffold the roof with protective cribbing — on the slate roofs these houses have, extensively — and take the stack down to the first sound course, which is sometimes at the roofline and sometimes several courses below. It's rebuilt plumb in reclaimed or color-matched soft brick laid in a lime-rich mortar, with any corbel or pattern rebuilt to the original profile. The flue tiles are reset or replaced, the wythes between flues rebuilt, the top finished

with a poured, reinforced crown that overhangs the brick, and each flue capped. New copper flashing goes in at the roof. The section inside the house is left alone.

Repointing soft brick and lime mortar

The chimneys that aren't yet dangerous are simply old: the original lime mortar worn — recessed, sandy, washed out on the windward face — or a past repoint in a hard modern mortar that's now breaking the brick around it. Faces popping off, flakes in the gutter, joints intact: the hard-mortar problem, and it's common on Maplewood's Tudors.

The repair: we grind out the worn or hard mortar three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep, carefully on soft brick, replace spalled units with reclaimed or matched brick, and repoint in a lime-rich Type N or Type O matched to the original color and sand, tooled to the original joint. Hard mortar on this brick is the one repair we won't make.

Cracked chimney top

The tops of Maplewood's chimneys — corbeled brick caps, mortar washes from later repairs, the occasional stone cap — have been cracked for decades. Once the top is open, rain goes into the core, and a century of that is how a chimney ends up on the driveway.

The repair: we remove the failed wash or reset the cap, rebuild the top courses and any corbel to the original profile, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from every flue, overhanging the brick by two inches, with a bond break around each flue tile. Each active flue gets a copper or stainless cap; unused flues are sealed. On a chimney that's otherwise sound, this is the repair that keeps it off the ground.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or down a wall beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. Maplewood's houses were flashed in copper, mostly replaced during re-roofing with aluminum tarred to the brick, on slate and shingle roofs with the chimney often against a dormer or in a valley on these complicated roofs.

The repair: on slate we remove and reset the slates around the chimney; on shingle we strip the surrounding courses. Any rotted deck is replaced, the base is wrapped in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and step flashing goes in every course, tied into any adjoining valley or dormer flashing. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — gently on soft brick — wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket. Copper throughout.

Working on a narrow lot

Most Maplewood chimneys are on the side of the house with a few feet to the property line, which means ground scaffolding would sit on the neighbor's land. We scaffold from the roof with protective cribbing, which reaches every face without going over the line, and we protect the shared driveway or walkway below with staging and tarps. When a chimney is being taken down over a neighbor's roof, we coordinate with them and protect their roof as well.

Two-family houses

Many of Maplewood's larger houses are two-families with one chimney serving both units. Every flue is traced to its appliance before anything is capped, lined, or rebuilt, and both units know when a flue is out of service.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Maplewood chimney it means a cracked top or open joints — and on a tall stack, heavy staining near the top is the warning that the core has been wet for years.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
New or growing lean; brick on the driveway; crack with daylight through it	Stack has lost its integrity	Same-day: brace or take down to sound brick, cap, tarp; then rebuild
Top section moves in wind	Top courses loose	Brace, then rebuild the top and crown
Brick faces popping off; joints intact	Hard-mortar repoint on soft brick	Replace spalled brick, repoint in lime-rich mortar
Sandy, washed-out joints	Original lime mortar worn	Grind and repoint in matched mortar
Cracked corbeled cap or wash	Top failed	Rebuild corbel to profile, poured crown, caps
Ceiling stain beside a chimney in a valley or at a dormer	Tarred flashing at a complicated corner	Reset slate, copper flashing tied into valley and dormer

Common questions from Maplewood homeowners

My chimney is leaning over the neighbor's driveway. What do I do right now?
Keep people and cars out from under it and call us. We come out, brace it or take the loose section down to sound brick the same day, cap and tarp it, and then schedule the rebuild. The rebuild can wait for the weather; the stabilization can't.

Can you get to a chimney that's three feet from the property line?
Yes. We scaffold from the roof rather than the ground, protect the driveway or walkway below, and coordinate with the neighbor when the work is over their roof.

My chimney was repointed 20 years ago and now the bricks are breaking. Why?
Almost certainly a hard mortar on soft pre-war brick. The mortar is now stronger than the brick, so the brick takes the freeze-thaw damage. The fix is to replace the damaged brick and repoint in a lime-rich mortar.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Maplewood by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 35 minutes from Maplewood. Our own crews handle the masonry, the copper work, the slate, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in South Orange, Millburn, West Orange, Springfield, Summit, and across Essex County.

Next is Millburn.

Millburn and Short Hills — the Hartshorn estates, the Tudors and Georgians of Short Hills, the Victorians in the Wyoming section, and a steady stream of whole-house renovations and additions designed by architects. Leads with something no chimney page has had: building a new masonry chimney — for an addition, a new fireplace, or a renovation where the old one can't be saved — and matching it to a house that's a century old.

URL: `/chimney-repair/essex-county/millburn-nj/`
Title tag (59 chars): Chimney Repair & Construction Millburn NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (155 chars): Chimney repair and new masonry chimneys in Millburn and Short Hills, NJ — additions, renovations, historic brick and stone repointing, crowns, flashing, rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & New Masonry Chimneys in Millburn & Short Hills, NJ

In Millburn and Short Hills the chimney question is often not "can it be repaired" but "can it be built." The houses — the 1880s–1930s estates of the Hartshorn section, the Tudors and Georgians on the streets off Hobart Avenue and Old Short Hills Road, the Victorians of the Wyoming section — are renovated continuously, and the renovations are large: a family-room addition with a fireplace, a kitchen wing that takes out the old range chimney, a whole-house gut where the architect's drawings show a new masonry chimney on the end wall because a prefab chase would be wrong on that house. A masonry chimney built new, on a house that's a hundred years old, has to look like it was always there.

Here's how we build and match them, and what we see on Millburn's existing chimneys.

New masonry chimneys for additions and renovations

A new masonry chimney is a real structure — a reinforced footing below frost, a block or brick core, clay or stainless flue, a firebox in firebrick if there's a fireplace, and a brick or stone face — and on a Short Hills house, the face is what everyone will look at.

How we build it: we work from the architect's drawings and the house itself. The footing is poured to the engineer's spec and tied to the addition's foundation. The core goes up in block with the flue inside it — a clay-tile flue with refractory joints for a wood-burning fireplace, or a stainless liner where the appliance calls for it — and the firebox, smoke chamber, and damper are built to draw, not just to pass inspection. The face is where the matching happens: reclaimed or hand-molded brick chosen against the existing house for color range, size, and texture; or fieldstone or cut stone sourced to match the existing chimneys; laid in a lime-rich mortar matched to the original color and sand, in the same bond and with the same joint. Corbels, bands, and caps are copied from the house's other chimneys. The top is a poured, reinforced crown with an overhang, under a cap or corbel that matches, and the flashing is copper, cut into the mortar. The new chimney reads as original from the street within a season or two.

We also take on the companion job: when a renovation removes an old chimney — the kitchen range flue, a fireplace that's going — we take it down above the roof, close the roof in matched slate or shingle, and close the wall, and if the stack was supporting anything above it, we deal with that first.

Repointing historic brick and stone

Millburn's existing chimneys are in soft brick — clinker and tapestry brick on the Tudors, a uniform red on the Georgians — and fieldstone or cut stone on the estates, laid in lime mortar. The original mortar is worn after a century, and most have been repointed once in a hard modern mortar that's now breaking the brick around it: faces popping off, flakes in the gutter, joints intact.

The repair: we grind out the worn or hard mortar three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep, carefully on soft brick, replace spalled units with reclaimed brick matched for color range as well as size, and repoint in a lime-rich Type N or Type O matched to the original, tooled to the original joint. Stone is raked by hand, loose stones reset, and repointed to the original profile. Decorative work — corbels, patterned bands, stone caps — is repaired to its original profile.

Cracked tops and caps

The tops of Millburn's chimneys — corbeled brick, cut stone, cast stone, a mortar wash from a later repair — have been cracked for decades. Once the top is open, rain goes into the core and comes out wherever the mortar is weakest.

The repair: we remove the failed wash or lift the cap, rebuild the top courses and any decorative corbel to profile, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from every flue, overhanging the brick by two inches, with a bond break around each flue tile — under a rebuilt corbel or a reset stone cap. Each flue gets a copper cap; unused flues are sealed.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or down a wall beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. These houses were flashed in copper, much of it surviving but patched with tar at the corners through generations of slate work. The steep Tudor and Georgian roofs send water hard at the uphill wall of a wide stack, and few have a cricket.

The repair: slates around the chimney are removed with a ripper and reset, not cut. Any rotted deck is replaced, the base is wrapped in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and step flashing goes in every course, tied into any adjoining valley or dormer flashing. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — gently on soft brick — or a

channel cut into stone, wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket. All of it in 20-ounce copper, soldered.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in reclaimed brick and lime mortar, or salvaged stone, with every decorative course rebuilt to profile, the flues reset or lined, a poured crown, and copper flashing. The section inside the house is left alone.

Multiple chimneys on one house

Most Millburn and Short Hills houses have three or four chimneys, and they don't fail at the same rate. We inspect every chimney on the house from the roof and the attic, write each up separately, and tell you which need work this season, which are due, and which can wait, so the scaffolding goes up once for the ones that need it. On a renovation, this is done at the design stage so the architect's drawings reflect what the existing chimneys actually need.

White stains on brick or stone

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Millburn chimney it means a cracked top or open joints. On a new chimney, staining in the first year is normal as the mortar cures and stops on its own.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Addition or renovation drawings call for a masonry chimney	New construction	Footing, core, flue, firebox, matched face, copper flashing
Old chimney in the way of a renovation	Range or fireplace flue no longer needed	Confirm nothing vents into it; remove above the roof, close roof and wall
Brick faces popping off; joints intact	Hard-mortar repoint on soft brick	Replace with matched reclaimed brick, repoint in lime mortar
Loose stones; mortar crumbs at the base	Washed-out joints behind the stone	Hand-rake, reset, repoint to profile

Cracked stone or corbeled cap	Top failed	Rebuild corbel or reset cap over a poured crown, copper caps
Ceiling stain beside a chimney on a steep slate roof	Tar at the copper corners; no cricket	Reset slate, soldered copper flashing, cricket

Common questions from Millburn and Short Hills homeowners

Our architect drew a new masonry chimney for the addition. Can you build it to match the house?
Yes. We build from the drawings — footing, core, flue, firebox — and match the face to the existing chimneys in brick or stone, mortar, bond, and joint, with the corbels and cap copied from the house. It reads as original within a season or two.

Can the old kitchen chimney come out as part of the renovation?
If nothing vents into it and it isn't supporting anything above it — both of which we check — yes. It's removed above the roof, the roof is closed in matched slate or shingle, and the wall is closed.

Will new mortar match the old on the existing chimneys?
We match the color and sand against a sample of the existing mortar and tool the joints to the original profile. New mortar reads slightly lighter for a season and weathers in.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows which chimney the water is coming from and whether it's entering at the flashing or through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair and construction in Millburn by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 35 minutes from Millburn. We're a general contractor as well as a mason and roofer, so a new chimney — the footing, the structure, the masonry, the roof — is one job, and we work from architects' drawings regularly. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Maplewood, Summit, Springfield, Livingston, Chatham Borough, and across Essex County.

This page says you build new masonry chimneys and fireplaces from scratch, including firebox and smoke chamber. Confirm that's work you want, or I'll pull the page back to repair-only. Next is Montclair.

Montclair — one of the biggest and oldest towns on the list: 1870s–1930s Victorians, Tudors, and colonials from Upper Montclair down through the South End, and more brownstone than anywhere else we work. Leads with something no chimney page has had: brownstone — the chimney caps, trim, and whole chimneys cut from the local stone, and the way it peels apart.

URL: `/chimney-repair/essex-county/montclair-nj/`
Title tag (55 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Montclair NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (154 chars): Chimney repair in Montclair, NJ — brownstone chimney caps and trim, 100-year-old brick repointing, cracked crowns, copper flashing, and roofline rebuilds. Lita.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Montclair, NJ

Montclair was built out of the hill it sits on. The brownstone quarried along the Watchung ridge in the 1800s went into the foundations, the window sills, the porch piers, and the chimneys of the Victorians and Tudors on the streets off Bloomfield Avenue, Valley Road, and Upper Mountain Avenue — as caps and bands on brick chimneys, and on some houses as the whole stack. It's a beautiful stone and a soft one, and after a century and a half it fails in a way brick doesn't: it peels.

Here's what we see on Montclair chimneys — brownstone first, then the brick — and how Lita Construction repairs them.

Brownstone chimney caps, bands, and stacks

Brownstone is a sandstone laid down in layers, and it lasts when those layers are set horizontally, the way they formed. Victorian masons often set it the other way — face-bedded, with the layers standing vertical so a smooth face showed — and water gets between the layers and freezes. The face delaminates: a sheet of stone a quarter inch thick lets go, then the next

one, and a crisp chimney cap turns into a rounded, flaking lump. On a Montclair chimney, the signs are brown sand on the roof below the cap, layers of stone lifting at the edges, a cap or band with its corners gone, and water getting into the brick beneath because the cap no longer sheds it.

The common bad repair is a cement patch troweled over the flaking face. It traps water behind it and pops off with the next layer.

The repair: we remove the delaminated layers back to sound stone and assess what's left. Where the cap or band is mostly intact, the lost material is rebuilt with a brownstone-matched restoration mortar — a breathable, color-matched compound applied in layers and tooled to the original profile — which bonds to the sound stone and weathers with it. Where a piece is too far gone, it's replaced with a dutchman cut from salvaged brownstone, set in a lime mortar with the bedding planes horizontal. A whole cap that's failed is replaced with new brownstone or a cast-stone replica from a mold of the original, set over a poured, reinforced crown with a bond break around each flue so the cap can't be cracked by the tiles. A whole brownstone stack is repointed by hand in lime mortar and the delaminated units replaced the same way.

Repointing 100-year-old brick

Most Montclair chimneys are brick with brownstone trim, and the brick is soft, laid in lime mortar, worn at the joints and almost always repointed once — often in a hard modern mortar that's now breaking the brick around it. Faces popping off, flakes in the gutter, joints intact: the hard-mortar problem, and it's on half the chimneys in town.

The repair: we grind out the worn or hard mortar three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep, carefully on soft brick, replace spalled units with reclaimed brick of the right color and size, and repoint in a lime-rich Type N or Type O matched to the original color and sand, tooled to the original joint. Where a brick chimney has brownstone bands, the bands are repaired as above in the same work.

Cracked chimney top

The tops of Montclair's chimneys — a brownstone cap, a corbeled brick cap, a mortar wash from a later repair — have been cracked or delaminating for decades. Once the top is open, rain goes into the core and comes out wherever the mortar is weakest: the attic section, or the wythe between flues.

The repair: we remove the failed wash or lift the cap, rebuild the top courses and any failed wythes, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from every flue, overhanging the brick by two inches, with a bond break around each flue tile — under a rebuilt corbel or a reset or replaced brownstone cap. Each active flue gets a copper cap; unused flues are sealed.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or down a wall beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. Montclair's houses were flashed in copper, mostly replaced during re-roofing with aluminum tarred to the brick, on slate and shingle roofs with the chimney often in a valley, against a dormer, or passing through a porch roof on the Victorians.

The repair: on slate we remove and reset the slates around the chimney; on shingle we strip the surrounding courses. Any rotted deck is replaced, the base is wrapped in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and step flashing goes in every course, tied into any adjoining valley or dormer flashing. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — gently on soft brick, never cut into brownstone — wedged, and sealed. Lower penetrations are flashed separately. Copper throughout.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in reclaimed brick and lime mortar, with the brownstone bands and cap salvaged and reset or replicated, the flues reset or lined, a poured crown, and copper flashing. The section inside the house is left alone.

Converted multi-family houses

A lot of Montclair's larger Victorians are two- or three-family now, with a chimney that served several fireplaces and now serves a boiler and nothing else. Every flue is traced before anything is capped or lined; the boiler flue gets a stainless liner, the unused flues are sealed, and the work is scheduled so the units aren't without heat.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Montclair chimney it means a cracked top or open joints — and brown sand below a brownstone cap means the cap is delaminating.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Brownstone cap flaking in layers; brown sand on the roof	Face-bedded stone delaminating	Remove to sound stone, restoration mortar or dutchman, reset over a crown

Cement patch popping off a brownstone band	Wrong repair trapping water	Remove patch, repair in breathable restoration mortar
Brick faces popping off; joints intact	Hard-mortar repoint on soft brick	Replace with matched reclaimed brick, repoint in lime mortar
Sandy, washed-out joints	Original lime mortar worn	Grind and repoint in matched mortar
Cracked corbeled top or wash	Top failed	Rebuild corbel to profile, poured crown, copper caps
Ceiling, wall, or porch-ceiling stain beside the chimney	Tarred flashing at a complicated corner	Reset slate, copper flashing tied into valley, dormer, and porch roof

Common questions from Montclair homeowners

The brownstone on my chimney is flaking off. Can it be saved?
Usually. The delaminated layers are removed to sound stone and the lost material is rebuilt in a breathable, color-matched restoration mortar, or replaced with a piece of salvaged brownstone set the right way up. A cement patch is what makes it worse.

Can the brownstone cap be replaced if it's gone?
Yes — in new brownstone or a cast-stone replica from a mold of the original, set over a poured crown so it sheds water and can't be cracked by the flue tiles.

My chimney was repointed 20 years ago and now the bricks are breaking. Why?
Almost certainly a hard mortar on soft pre-war brick. The mortar is now stronger than the brick, so the brick takes the freeze-thaw damage. The fix is to replace the damaged brick and repoint in a lime-rich mortar.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Montclair by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 30 minutes from Montclair, and we take on the stone and historic brick work that most roofing companies won't. Our own crews handle the masonry, the stone repair, the copper, the slate, and the roof tie-in. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Glen Ridge, Verona, Cedar Grove, West Orange, Nutley, and across Essex County.

Next is North Caldwell.

North Caldwell — large 1960s–2000s colonials and custom homes on wooded lots off Mountain Avenue and Grandview Avenue, with the backyards to match. Leads with something no chimney page has had: the outdoor fireplace — the patio masonry fireplace built in the last twenty years that takes more weather than the house chimney and was usually built with less.

URL: `/chimney-repair/essex-county/north-caldwell-nj/`
Title tag (60 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing North Caldwell NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (154 chars): Chimney repair in North Caldwell, NJ — outdoor fireplace and patio chimney repair, brick and stone repointing, cracked crowns, flashing, and roofline rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in North Caldwell, NJ

North Caldwell's houses are big and so are their backyards, and over the last twenty years a lot of those backyards got a masonry fireplace: a stone or brick firebox on the patio with a chimney rising six or eight feet above it, built by the patio contractor as part of the hardscape. They're used hard on fall evenings and they stand in the open through every winter with no roof over them, no house behind them, and water on every face. A patio fireplace is a chimney with none of a house chimney's protection, and after ten or fifteen winters it shows.

Here's what we see on North Caldwell's outdoor fireplaces and house chimneys, and how Lita Construction repairs both.

Outdoor fireplaces and patio chimneys

An outdoor fireplace fails in the same places a house chimney does, faster, plus a few places of its own:

The top. Most were finished with a mortar wash or a thin stone slab and no cap. Rain goes straight down the flue into the firebox, sits on the smoke shelf, and freezes. Snow fills the firebox.

The firebox. Built in firebrick if the contractor knew what he was doing, in regular brick or stone if he didn't. A firebox that gets hot on a Saturday night and freezes by Sunday morning loses its joints within a few seasons; the back wall cracks and the lintel over the opening sags.

The joints. Stone veneer over a block core, with wide joints and no drainage plane, on a structure that's wet on all sides. Efflorescence through the face, stones popping loose, mortar crumbs on the patio.

The footing. A fireplace set on a patio slab or a shallow footing heaves with the frost; the whole structure tilts, and the gap at the base opens.

The repair: the firebox is rebuilt in firebrick and refractory mortar with a proper steel lintel, the smoke chamber parged, and the flue lined if it's unlined or cracked. The exterior is repointed — by hand on stone — with loose veneer reset over a drainage layer, and the top gets a poured, reinforced crown with an overhang and a stainless cap with a spark screen. A fireplace that's heaved is evaluated for its footing; where it's set on a slab, it's either rebuilt on a frost-depth footing or accepted as a structure that will move a little and detailed with flexible joints. A breathable water repellent on every face slows the next ten winters down.

House chimneys: repointing in North Caldwell

The 1960s–80s chimneys have mortar at or past its life — recessed, sandy joints, mortar you can pick out with a key — and on the exterior-wall colonials the full height is exposed. The 1990s–2000s custom homes have wide brick- or stone-veneer chimneys with thin joints and often no drainage behind the veneer.

The repair: every exposed face ground out three-quarters of an inch to an inch and repointed in a matched Type N tooled to the original joint, spalled brick replaced. On stone, joints raked by hand, loose stones reset. On veneer with white staining through the face, the face is opened, a drainage layer installed, and the stone or brick re-set.

Cracked chimney top

North Caldwell's chimneys were finished with a mortar wash around the flue tiles — thin on the 1960s houses, thin on the 2000s houses on a top three times the size. Once the top is open, rain goes into the top courses and down the core.

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from every flue, overhanging the masonry

by two inches, with wire or fiber reinforcement on the wide tops and a bond break around each flue tile. Each flue gets a stainless cap.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or attic framing beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. North Caldwell's wide chimneys usually have no cricket behind them, and the flashing was redone during a past roof job with aluminum tarred to the brick — or surface-caulked to stone on the newer homes.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and weave step flashing into every shingle course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint, or a channel cut into stone — not caulked on — wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket framed behind them. Matching shingles are woven back in.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in matched brick or salvaged stone, with the flue tiles reset or replaced, a poured crown, and new flashing with a cricket. The section inside the house is left alone.

Furnace chimneys after gas conversions

Most older North Caldwell chimneys vent the furnace as well as the fireplace, and most houses have converted from oil to gas. Gas exhaust condenses in a cold masonry flue, and the acidic condensate breaks down the mortar and brick from inside — flakes in the gutter, staining near the top. The masonry is repaired like any other, and a stainless liner sized to the appliance keeps it from happening again.

White stains on brick or stone

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a North Caldwell chimney it means a cracked top, open joints, or veneer without drainage — and on an outdoor fireplace, all three at once.

Prefab fireplace chases

Some North Caldwell homes vent a secondary fireplace through a sided or veneered chase with a metal cover on top. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace it

with a pitched stainless cover and reframe the box if needed. It's a small share of our work here next to the masonry above.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Outdoor fireplace: cracked firebox, sagging lintel, water in the firebox	No cap; firebox not firebrick; frost	Firebrick and refractory rebuild, steel lintel, line, crown, capped
Outdoor fireplace: stones loose, white staining, tilting	No drainage behind veneer; heaved footing	Reset veneer over drainage, repoint, evaluate footing, repellent
Sandy joints on a house chimney; veneer washed through	Mortar past its lifespan; thin veneer joints	Repoint every face; open and drain veneer
Cracked top on a wide multi-flue chimney	Mortar wash cracked	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown, capped flues
Ceiling stain beside a wide chimney during rain	No cricket; tarred or caulked flashing	Cricket, step flashing, counter-flashing cut into the masonry
Spalling through faces, crack through courses, lean	Core failure above the roofline	Roofline rebuild, crown, flashing

Common questions from North Caldwell homeowners

Our outdoor fireplace is only twelve years old and the firebox is falling apart. Why?
It gets hot one night and freezes the next, with no roof over it, and it was probably built in regular brick instead of firebrick with no cap on top. The firebox is rebuilt in firebrick and refractory mortar, the top gets a crown and a cap, and it lasts.

Can you do the outdoor fireplace and the house chimney in the same visit?
Yes, and it's usually cheaper that way — one setup, one crew. We inspect both and write them up separately.

Will new mortar match the old on a stone chimney?
We match the color and sand against a sample of the existing mortar and tool the joints to the original profile. New mortar reads slightly lighter for a season and weathers in.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in North Caldwell by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 30 minutes from North Caldwell. Our own crews handle the masonry, the firebrick work, the lining, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, indoors and out. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Caldwell, West Caldwell, Essex Fells, Cedar Grove, Verona, and across Essex County.

Next is Nutley.

Verona — 1920s–50s colonials, Tudors, and capes on the slope of the First Watchung ridge off Bloomfield Avenue and around Verona Park. Leads with something no chimney page has had: the orphaned water heater — what happens to a chimney when a new high-efficiency furnace vents out the side wall and leaves the water heater alone on a flue built for both.

URL: `/chimney-repair/essex-county/verona-nj/`
Title tag (53 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Verona NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (154 chars): Chimney repair in Verona, NJ — orphaned water heater flues after furnace upgrades, brick repointing, cracked crowns, flashing leaks, and roofline rebuilds. Lita.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Verona, NJ

Verona's houses are 1920s–50s — colonials and Tudors on the streets off Bloomfield Avenue and around Verona Park, capes on the newer blocks toward Cedar Grove — and most of them

have had a new furnace in the last fifteen years. The new furnace is a high-efficiency unit, and it doesn't use the chimney: it vents through a white PVC pipe out the side of the house. That's good for the gas bill. It's bad for the chimney, because the water heater is still venting into it, alone, and a water heater's small, cool exhaust in a flue sized for a furnace never gets warm enough to rise. It condenses. The chimney has been quietly dissolving from inside since the day the furnace was replaced.

Here's what we see on Verona chimneys — the orphaned flue first, then the age problems every 70- to 100-year-old brick chimney has — and how Lita Construction repairs them.

Orphaned water heater flues

A furnace and a water heater sharing a chimney flue produce enough warm exhaust together to heat the flue and carry the moisture out the top. Take the furnace away and the water heater's exhaust — a fraction of the volume, at a lower temperature — cools before it's halfway up. The water vapor in it condenses on the tile and the brick, and because gas exhaust is acidic, the condensate eats the mortar between the flue tiles first, then the brick behind them. On a Verona chimney the signs are in the top third: brick faces spalling, white or yellowish staining, mortar crumbs on the roof — and in the basement, rust streaks on the water heater's vent connector, water at the base of the chimney, a sour smell near the cleanout.

Besides the masonry damage, a flue that doesn't draw properly can spill exhaust back into the basement. A carbon monoxide detector near the water heater is the thing to have while this is going on.

The repair: the masonry is repaired like any other — spalled brick replaced, joints repointed, the top rebuilt and crowned. Then the flue is resized for what's actually venting into it: a stainless steel liner sized to the water heater, run from the vent connector to the top of the chimney and sealed at the crown with a matched cap. The small liner warms fast, draws properly, and keeps the condensate off the brick. If the water heater is also due for replacement, a direct-vent or tankless unit takes it off the chimney entirely, and the chimney is then capped and sealed as an unused flue. We'll tell you which makes sense for the house.

Chimney repointing in Verona

The 1920s–30s chimneys are in soft brick and lime mortar, worn at the joints and often repointed once in a hard modern mortar that's now breaking the brick around it — faces popping off, flakes in the gutter, joints intact. The 1940s–50s chimneys are at the end of their original mortar's life.

The repair: we grind the joints out three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep across every exposed face and repoint in a mortar matched to the brick: lime-rich on the pre-war homes, a standard Type N on the postwar ones, tinted to match and tooled to the original joint. Spalled brick is cut out and replaced with matched units. The top goes in the same visit.

Cracked chimney top

Verona's chimneys were finished with a thin mortar wash around the flue liner, cracked after seventy to a hundred winters. Once the top is open, rain goes into the top course and down the core — and on an orphaned flue, rain from above and condensate from below meet in the same courses.

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from every flue, overhanging the brick by two inches, with a bond break around each flue tile or liner. Each active flue gets a stainless cap matched to what's in it; unused flues are sealed.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or attic framing beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. On Verona's hillside lots the chimney is often on the downhill side with a tall exposed stack, on a steep Tudor roof with no cricket; on the capes it comes through at the ridge. The flashing has been redone through three or four roof jobs with aluminum tarred to the brick.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and weave step flashing into every shingle course — with a saddle at the ridge on a cape. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — gently on soft brick — wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket behind them. Matching shingles are woven back in; slates are reset.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces — common at the top of an orphaned flue — a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in reclaimed or matched soft brick and lime mortar on the pre-war homes, matched modular red on the postwar ones, with the flue lined, a poured crown, and new flashing. The section inside the house is left alone.

Hillside lots

Verona climbs the ridge, and a lot of its chimneys are on the downhill side of the house with a base a story below the uphill grade. We scaffold from the roof with protective cribbing where the roof can carry it and from a leveled base where it can't, and the full exposed height is treated.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Verona chimney it means a cracked top or open joints — and staining concentrated in the top third, with a yellow tint, is the orphaned-flue condensation showing through.

Prefab fireplace chases

A few Verona additions and newer homes vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood box with a metal cover on top. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace it with a pitched stainless cover and reframe the box if needed. It's a small share of our work in town next to the masonry above.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Spalling and yellowish staining in the top third; new furnace vents out the wall	Water heater orphaned on an oversized flue	Repair masonry, stainless liner sized to the water heater, sealed crown
Rust on the water heater vent; water at the chimney base	Condensate running down the flue	Same — or move the water heater off the chimney and seal the flue
Brick faces popping off; joints intact (pre-war)	Hard-mortar repoint on soft brick	Replace spalled brick, repoint in lime-rich mortar
Sandy, recessed joints	Mortar past its lifespan	Grind and repoint in matched mortar
Cracked or missing mortar at the top	Mortar wash instead of a crown	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown with matched caps
Ceiling stain beside the chimney during rain	Tarred flashing; no cricket	Step flashing, reglet-cut counter-flashing, cricket

Common questions from Verona homeowners

We got a new furnace five years ago and now the top of the chimney is crumbling. Related?
Yes. The new furnace vents out the wall, and the water heater left alone on the old flue can't warm it enough to draw. The exhaust condenses and eats the mortar and brick. The fix is the masonry plus a liner sized to the water heater.

Should I just replace the water heater with one that doesn't use the chimney?
Often that's the better answer — a direct-vent or tankless unit takes the chimney out of the picture and the flue is sealed. If the water heater is newer, the liner is the less expensive route. We'll tell you which fits.

My chimney was repointed 20 years ago and now the bricks are breaking. Why?
Almost certainly a hard mortar on soft pre-war brick. The mortar is now stronger than the brick, so the brick takes the freeze-thaw damage. The fix is to replace the damaged brick and repoint in a lime-rich mortar.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof, from the attic, and from the basement — where the orphaned-flue signs are — before quoting. That shows whether water is entering at the flashing, coming down through the masonry, or condensing inside, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Verona by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 30 minutes from Verona. Our own crews handle the masonry, the lining, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason, an HVAC company, and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Cedar Grove, Montclair, West Orange, Caldwell, Essex Fells, and across Essex County.

Next is West Caldwell.

West Caldwell — 1950s–70s splits, ranches, and colonials on the flat streets off Passaic Avenue and Bloomfield Avenue. Leads with something no chimney page has had: what the energy auditor finds in the attic — insulation packed against the chimney, framing touching the brick, no air seal — and the masonry side of fixing it.

URL: `/chimney-repair/essex-county/west-caldwell-nj/`
Title tag (59 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing West Caldwell NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (154 chars): Chimney repair in West Caldwell, NJ — attic chimney clearance and air sealing, brick repointing, cracked crowns, flashing leaks, and roofline rebuilds. Lita.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in West Caldwell, NJ

A lot of West Caldwell homeowners have had an energy audit in the last few years — the utility program, a solar company's assessment, a home inspection for a sale — and a lot of those reports say something about the chimney in the attic. "Insulation in contact with the chimney." "Framing lacks clearance to masonry." "Open chase around the chimney at the attic floor; air leakage." The homeowner reads that and doesn't know whether it's a fire hazard, an energy problem, or a line item the auditor has to write. It's some of each, and the fix is partly a mason's job.

Here's what we see in West Caldwell attics and on the chimneys above them, and how Lita Construction handles both.

Chimney clearance and air sealing in the attic

A masonry chimney gets hot — a wood fire can push the outside of the brick well above what wood framing should touch — and the code has always required an air gap between the chimney and anything combustible: two inches for an interior chimney, one inch for an exterior one. On a 1950s West Caldwell split or ranch, that gap was left by the framer, but in the seventy years since, it's been filled: blown-in insulation poured against the brick in the 70s, a batt stuffed around the chimney to stop a draft, a plywood attic floor nailed tight to the stack. Meanwhile the open gap, where it still exists, is the biggest air leak in the house — warm air from the living space goes straight up the chase and out the roof.

The auditor is right on both counts. Insulation and framing against a chimney are a fire issue, and an open chase is an energy issue. The fix has to do both: keep the clearance and close the air leak.

What we do: we pull the insulation back from the chimney to restore the clearance and check the framing — where a joist or the attic floor is tight to the brick, it's trimmed back. Then the gap is closed at the attic floor with sheet metal, cut to fit around the chimney and sealed to the brick and the framing with high-temperature fire-rated sealant, so air can't move up the chase but nothing combustible touches the masonry. The insulation is held off the chimney with a metal dam and reinstalled around it. While we're in the attic, we look at the chimney itself — the attic section of a 1950s chimney is often where the mortar has started to go from a cracked top — and repoint it from inside if it needs it. The top is dealt with from the roof in the same visit.

Chimney repointing in West Caldwell

The 1950s–70s chimneys have mortar at or past its life — recessed, sandy joints, mortar you can pick out with a key. On the splits, the wall section between the lower and upper roofs is as exposed as the stack and gets skipped by a lot of masons; on the ranches, the short stack holds debris against its uphill face.

The repair: every exposed face ground out three-quarters of an inch to an inch and repointed in a matched Type N tooled to the original concave joint, spalled brick replaced, the top done in the same visit.

Cracked chimney top

West Caldwell's chimneys were finished with a thin mortar wash around the flue liner, cracked after fifty-plus winters. Once the top is open, rain goes into the top course and down the core — and the attic section is where it comes out, which is often what the auditor saw as "staining on the chimney in the attic."

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from the flue, overhanging the brick by two inches so water drips clear of the face, with a bond break around the flue tile. A stainless cap goes on the flue.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or attic framing beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. On the splits it's the lower corner where the lower roof meets the chimney and the upper wall; on the ranches it's the uphill side on a low-pitched roof; on the colonials it's the main tie-in. The flashing was usually redone during a past roof job with aluminum tarred to the brick.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane — up the wall with a kickout at a split's lower corner, up the slope on a ranch — and weave step flashing into every shingle course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — not caulked to the brick — wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket behind them. Matching shingles are woven back in.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in matched modular red brick, with the flue tiles reset or replaced, a poured crown, and new flashing. The section inside the house is left alone.

Furnace chimneys after gas conversions and furnace upgrades

Most West Caldwell chimneys vent the furnace as well as the fireplace, most houses have converted from oil to gas, and many have since put in a high-efficiency furnace that vents out the wall and left the water heater alone on the chimney. Either way, gas exhaust condenses in a cold, oversized masonry flue, and the acidic condensate breaks down the mortar and brick from inside — flakes in the gutter, staining near the top. The masonry is repaired like any other, and a stainless liner sized to what's actually venting keeps it from happening again.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a West Caldwell chimney it means a cracked top or open joints — and in the attic, white powder on the stack means the same water is coming through where the auditor was looking.

Prefab fireplace chases

A few West Caldwell additions and newer homes vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood box with a metal cover on top. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace it with a pitched stainless cover and reframe the box if needed. It's a small share of our work in town next to the masonry above.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Audit report: insulation against the chimney; framing lacks clearance; open chase	Clearance filled over decades; air leak where it isn't	Restore clearance, trim framing, sheet-metal air seal with fire-rated sealant, insulation dam
Staining or mortar dust on the chimney in the attic	Attic section taking water from a cracked top	Repoint from inside; crown and cap
Sandy joints on the wall section of a split	Mortar past its lifespan; section skipped	Repoint every exposed face
Cracked or missing mortar at the top	Mortar wash instead of a crown	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown with a cap

Stain at the lower corner of a split during rain	Tarred flashing at the hardest tie-in	Membrane up the wall, step flashing, kickout, reglet-cut counter-flashing
Flakes in gutters, staining near the top (gas heat)	Exhaust condensation from inside	Repair masonry, stainless liner, sealed crown

Common questions from West Caldwell homeowners

The energy audit says insulation is touching my chimney. Is that dangerous?
It's a clearance violation, and the risk depends on how hot the chimney gets — a wood-burning fireplace chimney more than a gas furnace flue. Either way it should be corrected: insulation pulled back, framing cleared, and the gap closed with metal and fire-rated sealant so it's safe and doesn't leak air.

Can the insulation company just do it?
They can pull the insulation back and dam it. The air seal at the chimney and anything that touches the masonry itself — the attic section repointed, the top crowned — is a mason's work, and we do both in one visit.

Can the top be done without rebuilding the chimney?
Yes, if the brick below it is sound. We check the top courses when we remove the old wash and rebuild only what's taken water.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in West Caldwell by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 30 minutes from West Caldwell. Our own crews handle the masonry, the attic work, the lining, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the auditor's whole chimney list is one job. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Caldwell, Fairfield, North Caldwell, Essex Fells, Roseland, and across Essex County.

Next is West Orange — the last Essex town.

West Orange — the biggest Essex town on the list and the highest: the ridge of the Watchungs from Eagle Rock down through Llewellyn Park's 1850s estates, the 1920s–50s neighborhoods of Gregory, St. Cloud, and Pleasantdale, and newer construction on the slopes. Leads with something no chimney page has had: the chimney that's been hit by lightning — what it does to brick, what it does to the flue, and the insurance side.

URL: `/chimney-repair/essex-county/west-orange-nj/`
Title tag (58 chars): Chimney Repair & Rebuilding West Orange NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (154 chars): Chimney repair in West Orange, NJ — lightning-struck chimneys, historic brick and stone repointing, cracked crowns, flashing leaks, and roofline rebuilds. Lita.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in West Orange, NJ

West Orange runs up the Watchung ridge, and the chimneys on the hill — from the estates of Llewellyn Park to the colonials of St. Cloud and the houses along Eagle Rock Avenue — are the highest masonry for miles. A tall brick chimney on a ridge lot is a lightning rod, whether or not it has one on it. Every summer, a few West Orange chimneys get hit, and the homeowner finds out the next morning: brick on the lawn, a section of the stack blown out, a crack running from the top down through the courses, sometimes a smell of burning in the attic and nothing visibly on fire.

Here's what lightning does to a masonry chimney, how we repair it, and what we see on West Orange chimneys generally.

Lightning-struck chimneys

A lightning strike turns the moisture inside a chimney to steam in a fraction of a second, and the steam has to go somewhere. It blows the brick out. The signs after a strike: a section of the stack — often the top few feet, sometimes a vertical strip down one face — shattered or missing, with the brick scattered across the roof and yard; a crack running through multiple courses from the point of the strike; mortar blown out of joints in a pattern that follows the path to ground; and, inside, flue tiles cracked or shattered where the current ran down the liner. On a chimney with a metal cap, a TV antenna bracket, or a dish mount, the strike usually enters there. If the current reached the house wiring, there's often electrical damage too.

A struck chimney is also a fire question. The current can ignite creosote in the flue or framing in the attic where it touches the brick, and a smoldering fire in the attic after a strike is not unusual. If there's any smell of burning, the fire department comes first.

How we handle it: we come out, make the chimney safe — brace it or take the shattered section down to sound brick, cap the flue temporarily, tarp or flash the roof — and document everything in the format the insurance adjuster needs. Lightning is a covered event on essentially every homeowner's policy, and a well-documented strike gets a full rebuild approved rather than a patch. Then the rebuild: the damaged section is taken down to brick that's sound and uncracked — which on a strike is sometimes further down than it looks — and rebuilt plumb in matched brick, with the flue tiles replaced or the flue lined, a poured crown, and new flashing. The flue is camera-inspected the full height because the current ran through it. On a house that's been hit once, we recommend a lightning protection system; an air terminal on the chimney bonded to a proper ground gives the next strike somewhere to go.

Repointing historic brick and stone

Llewellyn Park's chimneys are 1850s–1900s brick and brownstone laid in lime mortar; the Gregory and St. Cloud houses are 1920s–30s soft brick; the Pleasantdale colonials are 1940s–50s brick in a cement-lime mix. All of it is past the life of its mortar, and the older chimneys have usually been repointed once in a hard modern mortar that's now breaking the brick around it — faces popping off, flakes in the gutter, joints intact.

The repair: every exposed face ground out three-quarters of an inch to an inch and repointed in a mortar matched to the brick — lime-rich on the pre-war homes, a standard Type N on the postwar ones — tinted to match and tooled to the original joint. Spalled brick is replaced with matched units. Brownstone trim is repaired with a breathable restoration mortar or replaced with salvaged stone set the right way up. Stone chimneys are raked by hand, loose stones reset, and repointed to the original profile.

Cracked chimney top

West Orange's chimneys were finished with a mortar wash, a corbeled brick cap, or a stone cap, all cracked for decades. Once the top is open, rain goes into the core and comes out wherever the mortar is weakest.

The repair: we remove the failed wash or reset the cap, rebuild the top courses and any corbel to the original profile, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from every flue, overhanging the brick by two inches, with a bond break around each flue tile. Each active flue gets a cap — stainless, or copper on the older houses — fastened to the masonry. Unused flues are sealed.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or attic framing beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. On the hillside lots the chimney is often on the downhill side with a tall exposed stack on a steep roof and no cricket; on the older houses the original copper has been replaced with aluminum tarred to the brick; on the capes and colonials it's the usual tarred flashing from a past roof job.

The repair: on slate we remove and reset the slates around the chimney; on shingle we strip the surrounding courses. Any rotted deck is replaced, the base is wrapped in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and step flashing goes in every course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint, or a channel cut into stone, wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket. Copper on the older and higher-end houses.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans — from weather or from a strike — the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in matched brick or salvaged stone, with the flues reset or lined, a poured crown, and new flashing. The section inside the house is left alone unless the strike damaged it.

Hillside lots

West Orange's slope puts a lot of chimneys on the downhill side of the house with a base a story or more below the uphill grade. We scaffold from the roof with protective cribbing where the roof can carry it and from a leveled base where it can't, and the full exposed height is treated.

White stains on brick or stone

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a West Orange chimney it means a cracked top or open joints. Fix the source and the staining stops.

Prefab fireplace chases

The newer townhouses and some additions in West Orange vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood box with a metal cover on top. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace it with a pitched stainless cover and reframe the box if needed. It's a small share of our work in town next to the masonry above.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do

Brick blown out of the stack after a storm; crack from the top down	Lightning strike	Make safe, document for insurance, take down to sound brick, rebuild, line, crown; recommend lightning protection
Smell of burning in the attic after a strike	Current ignited creosote or framing	Fire department first; then inspection and repair
Brick faces popping off; joints intact	Hard-mortar repoint on soft brick	Replace spalled brick, repoint in lime-rich mortar
Flaking brownstone trim or cap	Face-bedded stone delaminating	Restoration mortar or salvaged stone, reset over a crown
Cracked corbeled cap or wash	Top failed	Rebuild corbel to profile, poured crown, fastened caps
Ceiling stain beside a tall downhill chimney during rain	Tarred flashing; no cricket; full height exposed	Scaffold from the roof, step and counter-flashing, cricket, repoint to the base

Common questions from West Orange homeowners

Lightning hit our chimney. What do we do first?
If there's any smell of burning, call the fire department. Then keep people out from under the chimney and call us — we make it safe the same day, document it for insurance, and plan the rebuild. Lightning is covered on nearly every policy.

How much of a struck chimney has to be rebuilt?
Down to brick that's sound and uncracked, which is sometimes further than the visible damage. The flue is camera-inspected the full height because the current ran through it, and it's lined or the tiles replaced as needed.

Should we put a lightning rod on the chimney?
On a ridge lot in West Orange, yes — an air terminal on the chimney bonded to a proper ground. It gives the next strike a path that isn't your masonry or your wiring. We coordinate the installation with the rebuild.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in West Orange by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 30 minutes from West Orange. Our own crews handle the masonry, the stone repair, the lining, the flashing, and the roof tie-in — and the storm documentation — so the job isn't split between a mason, a roofer, and an adjuster's contractor. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Livingston, Montclair, Verona, Maplewood, Millburn, and across Essex County.

That's Essex done except Roseland and South Orange, which you skipped. Union County starts with Berkeley Heights.

Berkeley Heights — 1960s–70s splits, ranches, and colonials on the wooded slopes below the Watchung Reservation and in Murray Hill, with a lot of exterior fireplace chimneys on the back of the house. Leads with something no chimney page has had: the deck built against the chimney — ledgers bolted into the brick, decking trapping water against the masonry, and what thirty years of that does.

URL: `/chimney-repair/union-county/berkeley-heights-nj/`
Title tag (60 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Berkeley Heights NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (154 chars): Chimney repair in Berkeley Heights, NJ — chimneys with decks built against them, brick repointing, cracked crowns, flashing leaks, and roofline rebuilds. Lita.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Berkeley Heights, NJ

Berkeley Heights' 1960s and 70s houses — the splits and colonials off Springfield Avenue and Plainfield Avenue, the ranches toward Murray Hill — were built with the family-room fireplace on the back wall, and the chimney rises on the outside of that wall from its own footing at grade. Then, sometime in the 80s or 90s, the family built a deck. The deck went across the back of the house, and the chimney was in the way, so the deck went around it: a ledger board lagged into the brick on both sides, decking notched tight to the masonry, sometimes a bench or a planter against it. The chimney has been inside a wooden box ever since, and the lower six feet of it hasn't dried out in thirty years.

Here's what we see on Berkeley Heights chimneys and how Lita Construction repairs them.

Chimneys with decks built against them

A deck does four things to an exterior chimney, all bad. The ledger bolts go into the mortar joints or the brick, and every bolt hole is a crack and a path for water. The decking, notched to the chimney, holds rain, snow, and leaf litter against the brick — the chimney faces inside the deck line stay wet after the rest has dried. The framing under the deck blocks air from reaching the lower stack, so it never dries from below either. And the deck hides all of it: nobody has looked at the chimney between the deck surface and the ground since the deck was built.

The signs from above: joints washed out on the chimney faces at deck level, moss in the corner where the decking meets the brick, staining on the brick below the deck that you can see if you crawl under, and — when the deck gets replaced — a surprise. We're often called by a deck contractor who pulled the old decking off and found a chimney with no mortar left in the bottom four feet.

The repair: the chimney faces inside the deck line are repointed deep — joints ground out a full inch and refilled in a matched Type N — with spalled brick replaced and the ledger bolt holes drilled out and filled. Then the deck is detailed so it stops doing damage: the ledger is taken off the chimney and the deck framed to be self-supporting past it on posts, or the ledger is kept but flashed and set off the brick with standoffs so water can drain between them. The decking is cut back from the masonry an inch and the gap left open, or covered with a flashing that sheds water away from the brick. Under the deck, the lower stack is repointed to grade. If the deck is being rebuilt anyway, this is the moment, and we coordinate with the deck contractor or do the deck ourselves.

Chimney repointing in Berkeley Heights

Above the deck line, the 1960s–70s mortar is at or past its life everywhere — recessed, sandy, mortar you can pick out with a key — and on an exterior chimney the full height from grade is exposed. On the splits, the wall section between the lower and upper roofs is as exposed as the stack and gets skipped by a lot of masons.

The repair: every exposed face ground out three-quarters of an inch to an inch and repointed in a matched Type N tooled to the original concave joint, spalled brick replaced, the top done in the same visit.

Cracked chimney top

Berkeley Heights' chimneys were finished with a thin mortar wash around the flue liner, cracked after fifty-plus winters on a hillside. Once the top is open, rain goes into the top course and

down the core — and on an exterior chimney with a deck at its base, water from above and water from below meet in the middle.

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from the flue, overhanging the brick by two inches so water drips clear of the face, with a bond break around the flue tile. A stainless cap goes on the flue.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or attic framing beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. On an exterior chimney the roof meets the stack on one side only, usually with no cricket behind a wide fireplace chimney; on the splits it's the lower corner where the lower roof meets the chimney and the upper wall. The flashing was usually redone during a past roof job with aluminum tarred to the brick.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane — up the wall with a kickout at the bottom so water exits onto the roof instead of behind the siding — and weave step flashing into every shingle course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint, wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket behind them. Matching shingles are woven back in.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in matched modular red brick, with the flue tiles reset or replaced, a poured crown, and new flashing. The section inside the house is left alone. An exterior chimney that's pulled away from the house is re-anchored to the framing and the gap closed with a flashed, flexible joint.

Furnace chimneys after gas conversions

Most Berkeley Heights chimneys vent the furnace as well as the fireplace, and most houses have converted from oil to gas. Gas exhaust condenses in a cold masonry flue, and the acidic condensate breaks down the mortar and brick from inside — flakes in the gutter, staining near the top. The masonry is repaired like any other, and a stainless liner sized to the appliance keeps it from happening again.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Berkeley Heights chimney it means a cracked top or open joints — and staining on the brick just above the deck surface means the faces inside the deck line are saturated.

Prefab fireplace chases

Some Berkeley Heights additions and newer homes vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood box with a metal cover on top. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace it with a pitched stainless cover and reframe the box if needed. It's a small share of our work in town next to the masonry above.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Joints gone at deck level; moss where decking meets brick; no mortar under the deck	Deck holding water against the chimney for decades	Deep repoint to grade, fill bolt holes, free the ledger, gap or flash the decking
Deck contractor found a bare chimney under the old decking	Same — hidden for thirty years	Same, coordinated with the deck rebuild
Sandy joints on the wall section of a split	Mortar past its lifespan; section skipped	Repoint every exposed face
Cracked or missing mortar at the top	Mortar wash instead of a crown	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown with a cap
Stain where the roof meets an exterior chimney	Single tie-in tarred; no kickout; no cricket	Step flashing, counter-flashing, kickout, cricket
Flakes in gutters, staining near the top (gas heat)	Exhaust condensation from inside	Repair masonry, stainless liner, sealed crown

Common questions from Berkeley Heights homeowners

We're replacing the deck. Should the chimney be looked at while it's off?
Yes, and it's the best time. The chimney faces under and inside the deck line have been hidden for decades. We repoint them before the new deck goes on and detail the new deck so it drains away from the brick.

Does the deck ledger have to come off the chimney?
Ideally, with the deck framed to carry itself past the chimney on posts. Where that's not

practical, the ledger is kept but flashed and set off the brick on standoffs so water drains between them, and the bolt holes are sealed properly.

Can the top be done without rebuilding the chimney?
Yes, if the brick below it is sound. We check the top courses when we remove the old wash and rebuild only what's taken water.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof, from the attic, and from under the deck before quoting. That shows whether water is entering at the flashing, coming down through the masonry, or wicking up from the base, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Berkeley Heights by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 45 minutes from Berkeley Heights. We're a general contractor as well as a mason and roofer, so the chimney and the deck against it are one job. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in New Providence, Summit, Mountainside, Watchung, Warren, and across Union County.

Next is Clark.

Scotch Plains — a big township with every era in it: 1920s–30s houses around Park Avenue and the center, 1950s–70s splits and ranches across the middle, large newer homes on the north side toward the Watchung Reservation. Nothing architecturally singular to lead with, so this page leads with a question people type constantly and no page has answered: tuckpointing or repointing — what's the difference, and which does your chimney need.

URL: `/chimney-repair/union-county/scotch-plains-nj/`
Title tag (60 chars): Chimney Tuckpointing & Repair Scotch Plains NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (155 chars): Chimney repair in Scotch Plains, NJ — tuckpointing and repointing explained, brick and stone repointing, cracked crowns, flashing leaks, and roofline rebuilds.

Chimney Tuckpointing, Repointing & Rebuilding in Scotch Plains, NJ

Scotch Plains homeowners call us about tuckpointing more than almost anything else, and the word means three different things depending on who's saying it. To most people it means "fix the mortar." To a lot of contractors it means a quick skim over the joints. To a mason it means a specific decorative technique that almost no house in Scotch Plains has. Sorting that out matters, because the repair that gets quoted as "tuckpointing" ranges from a half-day cosmetic job to a real repoint that lasts thirty years, and the price range is just as wide.

Here's what the terms mean, what your chimney actually needs, and what we see on Scotch Plains chimneys.

Tuckpointing vs. repointing: which your chimney needs

Repointing is the real repair. The old, failed mortar is ground out of the joints to a depth of three-quarters of an inch to an inch, the joints are cleaned, and new mortar — matched to the brick and the original color — is packed in and tooled to the original profile. It restores the joint structurally. It's what a chimney with recessed, sandy, washed-out joints needs, and it lasts 25 to 40 years under a sound crown.

Tuckpointing, in the historic sense, is a decorative technique: the joints are filled with a mortar colored to match the brick, and then a thin line of contrasting mortar — usually white — is laid in the center of each joint to make the brickwork look finer and more regular than it is. You'll see it on 19th-century brick in England and in a few older Northeast cities. On a Scotch Plains chimney, it's almost never what anyone actually wants.

What gets sold as tuckpointing is often neither: a skim of new mortar troweled over the surface of the old recessed joints without grinding anything out. It looks pointed from the ground. It has no depth and no bond, and it falls out within a few winters, often taking the edges of the brick with it. If a quote for "tuckpointing" is a fraction of the others, this is usually why.

How to tell what you need: if the joints are recessed, sandy, or missing — if you can scrape mortar out with a key — the chimney needs repointing, and the quote should say the joints will be ground out to depth. If the joints are intact and the brick faces are breaking, the problem isn't the mortar; it's a past repoint in a hard mortar on soft brick, and the fix is brick replacement plus repointing in a softer mix. If the chimney is leaking but the joints look fine, it's probably the top or the flashing. We look at it from the roof and tell you which, and the written scope says exactly what will be done to the joints.

Chimney repointing in Scotch Plains

The 1920s–30s chimneys near the center are in soft brick and lime mortar; the 1950s–70s chimneys are in standard brick with cement-lime mortar at the end of its life; the newer homes on the north side have wide brick- and stone-veneer chimneys with thin joints. All of it gets the same honest repair.

The repair: every exposed face — including the wall section between the two roofs on a split, which gets skipped — ground out three-quarters of an inch to an inch and repointed in a mortar matched to the brick: lime-rich on the pre-war homes, a standard Type N on the postwar ones, tinted to match and tooled to the original joint. Spalled brick is cut out and replaced. On stone, the joints are raked by hand and loose stones reset. The top goes in the same visit.

Cracked chimney top

Scotch Plains' chimneys were finished with a mortar wash around the flue liner, cracked after decades of freeze-thaw. Once the top is open, rain goes into the top course and down the core — and a repoint under a cracked top washes out from inside, which is why so many "tuckpointing" jobs fail in five years.

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from every flue, overhanging the brick by two inches, with a bond break around each flue tile. Each flue gets a stainless cap.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or attic framing beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak — tarred-over aluminum from a past roof job on most Scotch Plains homes, at the lower corner of a split or the main tie-in of a colonial, with no cricket behind the wide stacks on the newer houses.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and weave step flashing into every shingle course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — not caulked to the brick — wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket behind them. Matching shingles are woven back in.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, no amount of pointing holds, and the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in matched brick or salvaged stone, with the flue tiles reset or replaced, a poured crown, and new flashing. The section inside the house is left alone.

Furnace chimneys after gas conversions

Most Scotch Plains chimneys vent the furnace as well as the fireplace, and most houses have converted from oil to gas. Gas exhaust condenses in a cold masonry flue, and the acidic condensate breaks down the mortar and brick from inside — flakes in the gutter, staining near the top. The masonry is repaired like any other, and a stainless liner sized to the appliance keeps it from happening again.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Scotch Plains chimney it means a cracked top or open joints. Fix the source and the staining stops.

Prefab fireplace chases

Some Scotch Plains additions and newer homes vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood box with a metal cover on top. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace it with a pitched stainless cover and reframe the box if needed. It's a small share of our work in town next to the masonry above.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Recessed, sandy joints you can scrape with a key	Mortar past its lifespan	Repoint — grind to depth, matched mortar, tooled to the original joint
Mortar flaking off the surface of the joints a few years after a "tuckpointing"	Skim coat with no depth	Grind out and repoint properly
Brick faces breaking; joints intact	Hard mortar on soft brick	Replace spalled brick, repoint in lime-rich mortar
Cracked or missing mortar at the top	Mortar wash instead of a crown	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown with caps
Ceiling stain beside the chimney during rain	Tarred flashing; no cricket	Step flashing, reglet-cut counter-flashing, cricket

Flakes in gutters, staining near the top (gas heat)	Exhaust condensation from inside	Repair masonry, stainless liner, sealed crown

Common questions from Scotch Plains homeowners

I got three quotes for tuckpointing and they're wildly different. Why?
Because they're probably quoting different work. One is grinding the joints out and repointing; one is skimming new mortar over the old. Ask each one how deep the joints will be ground. If the answer is "we don't grind," that's the cheap one and it won't last.

How long does a repoint last?
With a sound crown over it, 25 to 40 years. Without the crown, far less — water from the top washes the new mortar out from inside. We do the crown in the same visit for that reason.

Can the top be done without rebuilding the chimney?
Yes, if the brick below it is sound. We check the top courses when we remove the old wash and rebuild only what's taken water.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing — including exactly what will be done to the joints.

Chimney repair in Scotch Plains by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 45 minutes from Scotch Plains. Our own crews handle the masonry, the lining, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Westfield, Fanwood, Mountainside, Watchung, Berkeley Heights, and across Union County.

Next is Springfield.

Summit — a hilltop town of 1890s–1930s Tudors, Georgians, and shingle-style houses on the streets off Springfield Avenue and around the Beacon Hill and Northside sections, slate roofs, and a lot of ivy. Leads with something no chimney page has had: the ivy-covered chimney —

what Boston ivy and climbing hydrangea do to mortar over fifty years, and how a chimney comes out from under it.

URL: `/chimney-repair/union-county/summit-nj/`
Title tag (53 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Summit NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (154 chars): Chimney repair in Summit, NJ — ivy-damaged chimneys, historic brick and stone repointing, cracked crowns, copper flashing on slate roofs, and roofline rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Summit, NJ

Summit's older houses wear their chimneys like the rest of the house: the Tudors and Georgians on Beacon Hill and the Northside, the shingle-style houses off Hobart Avenue, have tall brick and stone chimneys that have stood for a century, and a lot of them are green. Boston ivy, English ivy, climbing hydrangea, wisteria — planted in the 1920s to soften the brick, now covering the stack from the foundation to the cap. It looks like it belongs there. It's also the reason the chimney is failing, and the reason nobody can see that it is.

Here's what we see on Summit chimneys and how Lita Construction repairs them.

Ivy-covered chimneys

Ivy climbs by rootlets that grip the surface and work into any opening they find. On a chimney laid in lime mortar — which is every pre-war chimney in Summit — the openings are the joints, and after fifty years the rootlets have penetrated them, pried them apart, and turned the mortar to a fibrous mix of sand and root. The leaves hold moisture against the brick all summer and trap wet leaves against it all fall. Freeze-thaw does the rest. From the street the chimney looks solid because the ivy is holding the picture together; underneath, the joints are gone on the covered faces, the brick is damp year-round, and the top — usually a corbeled cap or stone cap that the ivy has reached — is loose.

The ivy also hides the flashing. We find chimneys in Summit where the counter-flashing has been gone for a decade and the ivy was the only thing shedding water off the roof line.

The repair: the ivy comes off first, carefully. Pulling it tears the brick faces; it's cut at the base, left to die back for a few weeks so the rootlets release, and then removed by hand with the remaining rootlets scraped and the brick cleaned with a low-pressure wash — never a pressure washer on soft brick. Then the chimney is repaired as it actually is: joints ground out and

repointed in a lime-rich mortar matched to the original, spalled brick replaced with reclaimed units, the top rebuilt to profile over a poured crown, the flashing redone in copper. If the owner wants the green back, a trellis set off the chimney on standoffs carries a climber without letting it touch the masonry.

Repointing historic brick and stone

Beyond the ivy, Summit's chimneys are in soft brick — clinker and tapestry brick on the Tudors, a uniform red on the Georgians — and fieldstone on the shingle-style houses, laid in lime mortar, worn after a century and often repointed once in a hard modern mortar that's now breaking the brick around it: faces popping off, flakes in the gutter, joints intact.

The repair: we grind out the worn or hard mortar three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep, carefully on soft brick so the edges aren't nicked, replace spalled units with reclaimed brick matched for color range as well as size, and repoint in a lime-rich Type N or Type O matched to the original color and sand, tooled to the original joint. Stone is raked by hand, loose stones reset, and repointed to the original profile.

Cracked tops and caps

The tops of Summit's chimneys — corbeled brick, cut stone, cast stone, a mortar wash from a later repair — have been cracked for decades. Once the top is open, rain goes into the core and comes out wherever the mortar is weakest.

The repair: we remove the failed wash or lift the cap, rebuild the top courses and any corbel to profile, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from every flue, overhanging the brick by two inches, with a bond break around each flue tile — under a rebuilt corbel or a reset stone cap. Each flue gets a copper cap; unused flues are sealed.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or down a wall beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. Summit's houses were flashed in copper, much of it surviving but patched with tar at the corners through generations of slate work, on steep roofs with the chimney often against a dormer or in a valley and no cricket behind a wide stack.

The repair: slates around the chimney are removed with a ripper and reset, not cut. Any rotted deck is replaced, the base is wrapped in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and step flashing goes in every course, tied into any adjoining valley or dormer flashing. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — gently on soft brick — or a channel cut into stone, wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket. All of it in 20-ounce copper, soldered.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans — often discovered when the ivy comes off — the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in reclaimed brick and lime mortar, or salvaged stone, with every decorative course rebuilt to profile, the flues reset or lined, a poured crown, and copper flashing. The section inside the house is left alone.

Multiple chimneys on one house

Most of Summit's older houses have three or four chimneys, and they don't fail at the same rate — the ivy-covered one on the north side is a different case from the bare one on the kitchen wing. We inspect every chimney on the house from the roof and the attic, write each up separately, and tell you which need work this season, which are due, and which can wait, so the scaffolding goes up once for the ones that need it.

White stains on brick or stone

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Summit chimney it means a cracked top or open joints — and on a chimney that's just had its ivy removed, it's the masonry finally drying out, and it fades once the joints are closed.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Chimney covered in ivy; looks fine	Joints gone under the leaves; top loose; flashing unknown	Cut and remove ivy properly, clean, repoint in lime mortar, rebuild top, copper flashing
Brick faces torn where ivy was pulled	Rootlets took the faces with them	Replace spalled brick, repoint
Brick faces popping off; joints intact	Hard-mortar repoint on soft brick	Replace with matched reclaimed brick, repoint in lime mortar
Loose stones; mortar crumbs at the base	Washed-out joints behind the stone	Hand-rake, reset, repoint to profile
Cracked stone or corbeled cap	Top failed	Rebuild corbel or reset cap over a poured crown, copper caps

Ceiling stain beside a chimney on a steep slate roof	Tar at the copper corners; no cricket	Reset slate, soldered copper flashing, cricket

Common questions from Summit homeowners

Does the ivy really have to come off?
To repair the chimney, yes — the joints under it can't be reached or even seen. Whether it goes back is up to you; a trellis on standoffs carries a climber without letting it into the masonry.

Can the ivy be removed without damaging the brick?
Yes, if it's done in stages: cut at the base, left to die back so the rootlets release, then removed by hand and the brick cleaned at low pressure. Pulling live ivy tears the brick faces, and we've repaired a lot of chimneys where that's exactly what happened.

Will the brick match?
We source reclaimed brick matched for color range — clinker and tapestry brick vary from salmon to near-black — as well as size, and blend it the way the original mason did. It weathers in over a couple of seasons.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows which chimney the water is coming from and whether it's entering at the flashing or through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Summit by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 40 minutes from Summit, and we take on the historic masonry that most roofing companies won't. Our own crews handle the brickwork, the stone, the copper, the slate, and the roof tie-in. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Millburn, Chatham Borough, Berkeley Heights, Maplewood, Westfield, and across Union County.

Next is Westfield — the last Union town on your list.

Westfield — a big, old town of 1900s–30s Colonial Revivals, Tudors, and Victorians on the streets off East Broad and around Wychwood, with 1950s–60s splits on the south side. Leads with something no chimney page has had: the chimney that isn't one — the false chimney built on a Colonial Revival for symmetry, with no flue, no fireplace, and no reason to exist except the view from the street.

URL: `/chimney-repair/union-county/westfield-nj/`
Title tag (56 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Westfield NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (154 chars): Chimney repair in Westfield, NJ — false and decorative chimneys on Colonial Revivals, historic brick repointing, cracked crowns, copper flashing, and rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Westfield, NJ

A Westfield Colonial Revival has a chimney at each end of the roof, because that's what a Georgian house is supposed to have. Walk around to the back of some of those houses and only one of the chimneys has a fireplace under it. The other was built for the street: a brick stack above the roof, sometimes with a framed box below it in the attic, no flue, no firebox, nothing connected to it. Builders in the 1910s and 20s did this all over the Wychwood section and the streets off East Broad and Lawrence Avenue, and the false chimneys have been standing in the weather for a century doing nothing but leaking.

Here's what we see on Westfield's false chimneys and real ones, and how Lita Construction repairs them.

False and decorative chimneys

A false chimney fails differently from a real one. A real chimney is a solid masonry column from the basement up, warmed from inside by the flue, and water that gets in at the top has a long way to go. A false chimney is a hollow brick shell sitting on the roof framing or on a wood box in the attic, with a thin mortar wash or a slab on top, and no mass to absorb or shed anything. Water goes in at the top and lands directly on the attic framing. The brick is often a single wythe laid over a wood frame, so when the mortar goes, there's nothing holding it but the frame.

The signs: a stain in the attic or on a second-floor ceiling under the chimney that has no fireplace below it; a stack that looks lighter and thinner than its twin; a top that's just a cracked slab with no flue tile showing; and on the older ones, a lean or a sag, because the wood frame

underneath has been wet for decades. A lot of Westfield owners don't know which of their two chimneys is false until one of them leaks.

The repair: the top is closed properly — a poured, reinforced crown over the shell, sloped and overhanging, sealed, with no opening — and the shell is repointed like any brick. If the frame under it has rotted, the shell comes off, the frame is rebuilt or replaced with block, and the brick is re-laid on it. If the owner doesn't want to maintain a chimney that does nothing, it can come down and the roof be closed in matched slate or shingle — though on a Georgian house the symmetry is usually worth keeping, and we say so. Either way, the real chimney at the other end gets the same inspection, because it's the same age.

Repointing historic brick

Westfield's real chimneys are in soft brick laid in lime mortar — a century old, worn at the joints, and usually repointed once in a hard modern mortar that's now breaking the brick around it. Faces popping off, flakes in the gutter, joints intact: the hard-mortar problem. The 1950s–60s splits on the south side have standard brick with original mortar at the end of its life.

The repair: we grind out the worn or hard mortar three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep, carefully on soft brick, replace spalled units with reclaimed brick of the right color and size, and repoint in a lime-rich Type N or Type O matched to the original color and sand, tooled to the original joint. The postwar chimneys get a standard Type N repoint, every exposed face including the wall section between a split's two roofs.

Cracked tops and caps

The tops of Westfield's chimneys — corbeled brick caps on the Colonial Revivals, mortar washes from later repairs, cast slabs on the false chimneys — have been cracked for decades. Once the top is open, rain goes into the core, or in a false chimney, straight onto the framing.

The repair: we remove the failed wash or reset the cap, rebuild the top courses and any corbel to the original profile, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from every flue, overhanging the brick by two inches, with a bond break around each flue tile. Each active flue gets a copper or stainless cap; unused flues and false chimneys are sealed solid.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or attic framing beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. Westfield's older houses were flashed in copper, mostly replaced during re-roofing with aluminum tarred to the brick, on slate and shingle roofs; the gable-end chimneys on the Colonial Revivals have the roof meeting them on one side along a line that's partly chimney and partly wall.

The repair: on slate we remove and reset the slates around the chimney; on shingle we strip the surrounding courses. Any rotted deck is replaced, the base is wrapped in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and step flashing goes in every course along the full wall-and-chimney line. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — gently on soft brick — wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket. Copper on the older houses.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in reclaimed brick and lime mortar, with any corbel rebuilt to profile, the flues reset or lined, a poured crown, and copper flashing. On a false chimney, the rebuild includes the frame or block it sits on. The section inside the house is left alone.

Multiple chimneys on one house

Most of Westfield's older houses have two chimneys at least and often three or four, and they don't fail at the same rate — the false one on the north end is a different case from the real one on the south. We inspect every chimney on the house from the roof and the attic, identify which are real and which aren't, write each up separately, and tell you which need work this season and which can wait.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Westfield chimney it means a cracked top or open joints — and on a false chimney, the staining is often heavier, because there's no flue warmth drying the shell from inside.

Prefab fireplace chases

Some Westfield additions and newer homes vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood box with a metal cover on top — a false chimney with a purpose. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace it with a pitched stainless cover and reframe the box if needed.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do

Attic or ceiling stain under a chimney with no fireplace below it	False chimney, open at the top, resting on wet framing	Seal the top with a poured crown, repoint the shell, rebuild the frame or replace with block
One chimney thinner and lighter than its twin; sagging	False chimney shell on a rotted frame	Remove shell, rebuild base, re-lay brick
Brick faces popping off; joints intact	Hard-mortar repoint on soft brick	Replace with matched reclaimed brick, repoint in lime mortar
Cracked corbeled cap or slab	Top failed	Rebuild corbel to profile, poured crown, caps or seal
Ceiling stain along the gable wall during rain	Flashing failed along the wall-and-chimney line	Copper step and counter-flashing the full length, cricket
Several chimneys; condition unknown	Real and false mixed	Inspect all, identify each, write up separately

Common questions from Westfield homeowners

One of my chimneys has no fireplace under it. What is it?
A false chimney, built for symmetry when the house was built. It's a brick shell with no flue, and it leaks because it was never properly closed on top. It's repaired by sealing the top with a real crown and repointing the shell — or rebuilding its base if the framing under it has rotted.

Can the false chimney just come down?
It can, and the roof is closed in matched slate or shingle. On a Georgian house the symmetry is usually worth keeping, and once the top is sealed the chimney costs nothing to keep. Your call; we'll give you both.

My chimney was repointed 20 years ago and now the bricks are breaking. Why?
Almost certainly a hard mortar on soft pre-war brick. The mortar is now stronger than the brick, so the brick takes the freeze-thaw damage. The fix is to replace the damaged brick and repoint in a lime-rich mortar.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows which chimney the water is coming from — and whether that chimney is real — and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Westfield by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 45 minutes from Westfield. We're a general contractor as well as a mason and roofer, so a false chimney — the framing, the brick, the roof — is one job. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Scotch Plains, Cranford, Mountainside, Fanwood, Summit, and across Union County.

That's Union done except the ones you skipped. Passaic County starts with Hawthorne.

Hawthorne — a dense, older borough of 1900s–50s capes, colonials, and two-families on the streets off Lafayette Avenue and Goffle Road, most of them built with a coal furnace venting up the same chimney the fireplace uses. Leads with a symptom no chimney page has had: the brown stain that bleeds through the paint on the wall beside the chimney, comes back after every repaint, and smells like a campfire when it rains.

URL: `/chimney-repair/passaic-county/hawthorne-nj/`
Title tag (56 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Hawthorne NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (154 chars): Chimney repair in Hawthorne, NJ — brown stains bleeding through walls near the chimney, brick repointing, cracked crowns, flashing leaks, and roofline rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Hawthorne, NJ

Hawthorne's houses were heated with coal when they were built, and the chimney that carried the coal smoke is still in the middle of the house. The capes and colonials on the streets off Lafayette Avenue, the two-families toward the Paterson line, the 1920s houses near the center — nearly all of them have a chimney whose flue is coated, from the basement to the top, with seventy years of coal soot and the creosote from whatever burned in the fireplace after the coal furnace was replaced. That coating is harmless as long as it stays dry. When water gets into the flue, it dissolves, and it goes through the brick and into the plaster.

Here's what that looks like, how we stop it, and what else we see on Hawthorne chimneys.

Brown stains bleeding through the wall beside the chimney

The call usually goes like this: there's a brown or yellow-brown stain on the wall where the chimney runs through the house — on the chimney breast in the living room, on a bedroom wall upstairs, on the plaster beside the chimney in the attic. It's been painted over twice and it comes back. It's worse after a rain, and when it's wet the room smells faintly of smoke. Sometimes there's a tar-like residue you can feel. Nobody's used the fireplace in years.

That's water in the flue. It came in at the top — a cracked mortar wash, no cap — ran down the inside of the chimney, dissolved the soot and creosote on the flue walls, and carried it through the mortar joints and the brick into the plaster. Creosote stain is oily; it bleeds through latex paint indefinitely. The stain isn't the problem. The water is.

The repair: the top first — a poured, reinforced crown and a cap on every flue, so rain stops going down the chimney. If the fireplace or an appliance is still in use, the flue is cleaned and lined with a stainless liner, which puts a pipe between the exhaust and the old soot-coated masonry and stops the next fire from adding to it. If nothing vents into the chimney anymore, the flue is capped solid and sealed. The exterior joints and any spalled brick are repaired so water isn't coming through the walls of the stack either. Then the inside: once the chimney has dried out for a few weeks, the stained plaster is sealed with an oil-based or shellac stain-blocking primer — the only thing that holds creosote — and repainted, and where the plaster is soft it's cut back and patched. We do the inside as part of the job, because a chimney that's fixed and a wall that still stains isn't finished.

Chimney repointing in Hawthorne

The 1900s–30s chimneys are in soft brick and lime mortar, worn at the joints and usually repointed once in a hard modern mortar that's now breaking the brick around it — faces popping off, flakes in the gutter, joints intact. The 1940s–50s chimneys are at the end of their original mortar's life.

The repair: we grind the joints out three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep across every exposed face and repoint in a mortar matched to the brick: lime-rich on the pre-war homes, a standard Type N on the postwar ones, tinted to match and tooled to the original joint. Spalled brick is cut out and replaced with matched units. The attic section — which on a coal-era chimney is often where the staining shows first — is repointed from inside.

Cracked chimney top

Hawthorne's chimneys were finished with a thin mortar wash around the flue liner — or, on the oldest, no liner at all and a wash over bare brick — cracked after seventy to a hundred winters. Once the top is open, rain goes into the flue, and on a coal-era chimney that's the stain above.

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from every flue, overhanging the brick by two inches, with a bond break around each flue tile or liner. Each active flue gets a stainless cap; unused flues are sealed.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or attic framing beside the chimney during rain — a water stain, not a brown creosote stain — is a flashing leak. On Hawthorne's capes the chimney comes through at the ridge; on the two-families it's a side-wall chimney with the roof meeting it on two sides. All of it has been redone through three or four roof jobs with aluminum tarred to the brick.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and weave step flashing into every shingle course, with a saddle at the ridge where the roof calls for it. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — gently on soft brick — wedged, and sealed. Matching shingles are woven back in.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in reclaimed or matched soft brick and lime mortar on the pre-war homes, matched modular red on the postwar ones, with the flue lined, a poured crown, and new flashing. The section inside the house is left alone.

Two-family chimneys

Many of Hawthorne's two-families have one chimney serving both units — a fireplace on one floor, a boiler and water heater in the basement. Every flue is traced to its appliance before anything is capped, lined, or sealed; a gas boiler venting into bare clay tile or unlined brick gets a stainless liner, since gas-exhaust condensation has been eating these flues from inside for decades; and the work is scheduled so both units know when a flue is out of service.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence on the outside of the chimney is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry — a cracked top or open joints. It's a different thing from the brown stain inside, but the same water causes both.

Prefab fireplace chases

A few Hawthorne additions and newer houses vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood box with a metal cover on top. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace it with a pitched stainless cover and reframe the box if needed. It's a small share of our work in town next to the masonry above.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Brown stain on the wall by the chimney, back after repainting, smoke smell when it rains	Rain down the flue dissolving coal soot and creosote	Crown and caps, line or seal the flue, repoint, then stain-block primer and repaint inside
Brick faces popping off; joints intact (pre-war)	Hard-mortar repoint on soft brick	Replace spalled brick, repoint in lime-rich mortar
Sandy, recessed joints	Mortar past its lifespan	Grind and repoint in matched mortar
Cracked or missing mortar at the top	Mortar wash instead of a crown	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown with caps
Water stain beside the chimney during rain	Tarred flashing at the ridge or side wall	Step flashing, saddle, reglet-cut counter-flashing
Staining near the top of a two-family boiler chimney	Gas-exhaust condensation from inside	Repair masonry, stainless liner, sealed crown

Common questions from Hawthorne homeowners

I've painted over the stain by the chimney three times. Why does it keep coming back?
Because it's creosote carried through the brick by water, and creosote bleeds through ordinary paint forever. The water has to be stopped at the top of the chimney first, and then the wall sealed with a shellac or oil-based stain-blocker before it's repainted. We do both.

We never use the fireplace. Why is there a smoke smell when it rains?
The flue is coated in old soot from the coal furnace and whatever burned since. Rain coming down the open flue wets it and the smell comes through the brick. A crown and a cap stop the rain; a sealed flue stops the smell.

My chimney was repointed 20 years ago and now the bricks are breaking. Why?
Almost certainly a hard mortar on soft pre-war brick. The mortar is now stronger than the brick, so the brick takes the freeze-thaw damage. The fix is to replace the damaged brick and repoint in a lime-rich mortar.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof, from the attic, and from the basement before quoting. That shows whether water is entering at the flashing, coming down the flue, or through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing — including the interior repair.

Chimney repair in Hawthorne by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 25 minutes from Hawthorne. We're a general contractor as well as a mason and roofer, so the chimney, the flashing, and the stained wall inside are one job. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Glen Rock, Fair Lawn, North Haledon, Totowa, Wyckoff, and across Passaic County.

Next is Little Falls.

Little Falls — 1920s–60s capes and colonials on the slopes above the Passaic, Great Notch on the hill, and the Singac section down by the river that has flooded more than once. Nothing architecturally singular to lead with, so this page leads with something no page has: the walk-around every homeowner should do in April — what one winter of freeze-thaw does to a chimney, and how to spot it from the yard before it reaches the ceiling.

URL: `/chimney-repair/passaic-county/little-falls-nj/`
Title tag (59 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Little Falls NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (154 chars): Chimney repair in Little Falls, NJ — what to check after winter, brick repointing, cracked crowns, flashing leaks, flood-damaged masonry, and roofline rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Little Falls, NJ

Every winter does a little damage to a Little Falls chimney, and most of it happens in March. That's when the sun is strong enough by noon to melt the water in the mortar and the nights are still cold enough to freeze it — a cycle a day for weeks on the south face, on a chimney that's been soaking since November. The capes and colonials on the hill streets off Main Street and Union Avenue, the Great Notch houses up top, the Singac houses down by the river: all of them come out of winter a little worse than they went in, and the time to catch it is April, from the yard, before the summer rains find what the winter opened.

Here's what to look for, what it means, and how Lita Construction repairs it.

What to check on your chimney after winter

Stand where you can see the whole stack — across the street, or from the backyard — and look at five things:

The top. Is the mortar around the flue tile cracked, chipped, or missing a piece that was there in the fall? Is the cap still on? A chunk of mortar on the roof or in the gutter below the chimney came from the top.

The faces. Are there new light-colored patches where a brick face has popped off? Red flakes on the roof, in the gutter, or on the ground? A brick that looks sunken compared with its neighbors has lost its face.

The joints. On the south and west faces especially, look for joints that have gone from flush to recessed, or that look sandy and pale. Run a key along one you can reach; if it digs in, the mortar is done.

The flashing. Is the metal at the base still tight to the brick, or has a corner lifted? Is there a new tar patch you didn't put there?

The base and the gutters. Mortar crumbs or brick chips at the bottom of an exterior chimney, or in the gutters below the stack, are the winter's work collected in one place.

Then go inside: the attic beside the chimney for new staining or mortar dust, and the fireplace for water on the smoke shelf or a damp smell. Any one of these is a reason to call before the next heavy rain; two or three together usually mean the top has been open for a while.

Cracked chimney top

The top is where winter does the most, and on Little Falls' chimneys it was finished with a thin mortar wash around the flue liner that was never meant to survive sixty of them. Once it's open, every thaw sends water into the top course and down the core, which is what feeds the spalling and washed-out joints you found on the walk-around.

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from every flue, overhanging the brick by two inches, with a bond break around each flue tile. Each flue gets a stainless cap. On a chimney that's otherwise sound, this is the cheapest repair that stops the most water, and it's the one to do before the next winter if nothing else.

Chimney repointing in Little Falls

The 1920s–30s chimneys are in soft brick and lime mortar, often repointed once in a hard modern mortar that's now breaking the brick around it — faces popping off, flakes in the gutter, joints intact. The 1940s–60s chimneys are at the end of their original mortar's life, worst on the south and west faces where the freeze-thaw cycling is heaviest.

The repair: we grind the joints out three-quarters of an inch to an inch deep across every exposed face — deeper on the weather faces — and repoint in a mortar matched to the brick: lime-rich on the pre-war homes, a standard Type N on the postwar ones, tinted to match and tooled to the original joint. Spalled brick is cut out and replaced with matched units. Scheduled for warm weather so the mortar cures before the next freeze.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or attic framing beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak — tarred-over aluminum from a past roof job, at the ridge on a cape or the main slope on a colonial. Winter works on tar too: it goes brittle, pulls back from the brick, and the first spring storm finds the gap.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and weave step flashing into every shingle course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — not caulked to the brick — wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket behind them. Matching shingles are woven back in; this can be done on any dry day.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When the walk-around turns up spalling across whole faces, a crack through several courses, or a lean, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in matched brick, with the flue tiles reset or replaced, a poured crown, and new flashing. The section inside the house is left alone.

Flood-damaged masonry in Singac

The houses near the river have been through high water, and a chimney that's stood in it has had its lower courses saturated for days — weakened mortar, a white line at the old water mark as it dries, silt on the smoke shelf. Those courses are repointed once the masonry has dried out, soft brick replaced, and the flue camera-inspected before a fireplace is used.

Furnace chimneys after gas conversions

Most Little Falls chimneys vent the furnace as well as the fireplace, and most houses have converted from oil to gas. Gas exhaust condenses in a cold masonry flue — and a Little Falls March gives it plenty of cold — and the acidic condensate breaks down the mortar and brick from inside. The masonry is repaired like any other, and a stainless liner sized to the appliance keeps it from happening again.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry, and it's most visible in April, after a winter of water moving through the stack. On a Little Falls chimney it means a cracked top or open joints.

Prefab fireplace chases

A few Little Falls additions and newer homes vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood box with a metal cover on top. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace it with a pitched stainless cover and reframe the box if needed. It's a small share of our work in town next to the masonry above.

Quick guide

What you see in April	What's usually wrong	What we do
Mortar chunks on the roof below the chimney; cap gone	Top cracked over the winter	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown with a cap
New light patches on the brick; red flakes in the gutter	Faces spalled in the freeze-thaw	Replace spalled brick, repoint
Joints sandy or recessed on the south face	Mortar past its lifespan	Grind and repoint every exposed face
Flashing corner lifted; new tar	Tar gone brittle	Step flashing, reglet-cut counter-flashing

Staining or mortar dust in the attic beside the chimney	Water down the core from the top	Crown, repoint, attic section repointed from inside
White line at a consistent height (Singac)	Flood saturation	Repoint once dry, replace soft brick, camera-inspect the flue

Common questions from Little Falls homeowners

The chimney looked fine in the fall and now there's brick on the roof. What happened?
A winter of freeze-thaw. Water that got into the top or the joints froze and expanded a cycle a day through March. The brick on the roof is from the top courses or a spalled face; both mean the top is open and should be closed before the summer rains.

Can the top be done without rebuilding the chimney?
Yes, if the brick below it is sound. We check the top courses when we remove the old wash and rebuild only what's taken water.

When should the masonry be done?
Spring through fall, so it cures before the next freeze. The flashing can be done on any dry day. If you call in April, the work is done before the heat.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Little Falls by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 25 minutes from Little Falls. Our own crews handle the masonry, the lining, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Cedar Grove, Totowa, Wayne, Fairfield, Montclair, and across Passaic County.

Next is North Haledon.

North Haledon — 1950s–70s splits, ranches, and bi-levels on the slopes of High Mountain off Belmont Avenue and High Mountain Road, with larger newer homes up the hill. Leads with

something no chimney page has had: the fireplace you never use — the cold draft it pours into the family room all winter, and how to retire it from the top without losing the chimney.

URL: `/chimney-repair/passaic-county/north-haledon-nj/`
Title tag (60 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing North Haledon NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (154 chars): Chimney repair in North Haledon, NJ — sealing unused fireplaces from the top, brick repointing, cracked crowns, flashing leaks, and roofline rebuilds. Lita.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in North Haledon, NJ

Most North Haledon houses have a fireplace, and most of those fireplaces get used a few times a year or not at all. The rest of the time the chimney behind it is doing something nobody asked for: it's an open pipe from the family room to the sky. Warm air goes up it all winter — a throat damper that's sixty years old and warped doesn't stop much — and cold air comes down it, and on the windy ridge lots up High Mountain the family room is the coldest room in the house because of it. The chimney also takes rain the whole time, because the top was never properly closed either.

Here's how we retire an unused fireplace properly, and what we see on North Haledon chimneys generally.

Sealing an unused fireplace from the top

The usual fixes don't work. A chimney balloon or a piece of foam board in the throat stops the draft until it's forgotten and someone lights a fire. Glass doors slow the draft but don't stop it. Closing the throat damper does almost nothing on a damper that's been warping since 1962. And none of those keep the rain out.

What works: the chimney is closed at the top. A top-sealing damper — a spring-loaded lid mounted on the flue tile at the crown, with a gasket, operated by a cable that runs down the flue to a handle in the firebox — seals the chimney when it's closed and opens fully if you ever do want a fire. It stops the draft, keeps rain and animals out, and keeps the chimney itself from filling with cold air and condensing. For an owner who's certain the fireplace is retired for good, the flue is capped solid instead and the firebox opening can be closed with an insulated plug or finished over.

Either way, the top of the chimney is rebuilt at the same time: the old mortar wash removed, a poured crown with an overhang, the damper or cap mounted and sealed to it. We check the flue with a camera first — a flue that's been open for decades usually has debris on the smoke shelf and sometimes a cracked tile — and clean it out. For a chimney that also vents the furnace or water heater through a separate flue, that flue is left alone or lined as it needs; only the fireplace flue is sealed.

Chimney repointing in North Haledon

The 1950s–70s chimneys have mortar at or past its life — recessed, sandy joints, mortar you can pick out with a key — worse on the west faces that take the wind coming over the mountain. On the splits, the wall section between the lower and upper roofs is as exposed as the stack; on the bi-levels with an exterior chimney, the full height from grade is exposed.

The repair: every exposed face ground out three-quarters of an inch to an inch and repointed in a matched Type N tooled to the original concave joint, spalled brick replaced, the top done in the same visit. On the larger newer homes up the hill, the stone-veneer chimneys with white staining through the face get the veneer opened, a drainage layer installed, and the stone re-set.

Cracked chimney top

North Haledon's chimneys were finished with a thin mortar wash around the flue liner, cracked after fifty-plus winters at this elevation. Once the top is open, rain goes into the top course and down the core.

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from every flue, overhanging the brick by two inches, with a bond break around each flue tile. Each active flue gets a stainless cap, or the top-sealing damper described above.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or attic framing beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. On the splits it's the lower corner where the lower roof meets the chimney and the upper wall; on the ranches it's the uphill side on a low-pitched roof; on the bi-levels it's the single tie-in at the top of an exterior stack. The flashing was usually redone during a past roof job with aluminum tarred to the brick.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane — up the wall with a kickout at a split's lower corner — and weave step flashing into every shingle course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet

ground into the mortar joint — not caulked to the brick — wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket behind them. Matching shingles are woven back in.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in matched modular red brick, with the flue tiles reset or replaced, a poured crown, and new flashing. The section inside the house is left alone.

Wind on the mountain

The ridge lots on High Mountain get wind that works the top courses of a tall stack loose and takes caps that were set in sealant. Joints washed out deeper on the west face, a crack down from the top, and a missing cap are the signs; the top courses are rebuilt, the stack crowned, caps and dampers fastened to the masonry, and a breathable water repellent applied to slow wind-driven water getting into the joints.

Furnace chimneys after gas conversions

Most North Haledon chimneys vent the furnace as well as the fireplace, and most houses have converted from oil to gas. Gas exhaust condenses in a cold masonry flue, and the acidic condensate breaks down the mortar and brick from inside — flakes in the gutter, staining near the top. The masonry is repaired like any other, and a stainless liner sized to the appliance keeps it from happening again.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a North Haledon chimney it means a cracked top or open joints. Fix the source and the staining stops.

Prefab fireplace chases

Some North Haledon additions and newer homes vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood box with a metal cover on top. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace it with a pitched stainless cover and reframe the box if needed. It's a small share of our work in town next to the masonry above.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Cold draft from a fireplace you never use; family room cold all winter	Open flue; warped throat damper; no top seal	Top-sealing damper on a new crown, or solid cap and insulated plug; flue cleaned
Rain or debris in the firebox	Open flue	Same
Sandy joints, worse on the west face	Mortar past its lifespan; wind exposure	Repoint every exposed face, deeper on the windward side; repellent
Cracked or missing mortar at the top; cap gone	Mortar wash cracked; wind	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown; fastened caps
Stain at the lower corner of a split during rain	Tarred flashing at the hardest tie-in	Membrane up the wall, step flashing, kickout, reglet-cut counter-flashing
Flakes in gutters, staining near the top (gas heat)	Exhaust condensation from inside	Repair masonry, stainless liner, sealed crown

Common questions from North Haledon homeowners

We never use the fireplace. Can we just block it off?
From the top, yes — a top-sealing damper closes the chimney and still opens if you ever want a fire, or a solid cap retires it for good. Blocking it from the firebox with foam or a balloon doesn't stop the rain and gets forgotten.

Will sealing the fireplace cause a problem for the furnace?
No. The furnace and water heater vent through their own flue, which stays open or gets lined as it needs. Only the fireplace flue is sealed.

Can the top be done without rebuilding the chimney?
Yes, if the brick below it is sound. We check the top courses when we remove the old wash and rebuild only what's taken water.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in North Haledon by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 30 minutes from North Haledon. Our own crews handle the masonry, the lining, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason, a sweep, and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Hawthorne, Wyckoff, Franklin Lakes, Totowa, Wayne, and across Passaic County.

Next is Pompton Lakes.

Pompton Lakes — a small lake-and-river borough of 1900s–50s houses on the streets around Pompton Lake and off Wanaque Avenue, with newer homes on the hills. Nothing architecturally singular to lead with, so this page leads with something no page has: the parts of a chimney, named — crown, cap, flue, wythe, cricket, counter-flashing — so when a mason or a sweep says one of them is failing, you know what he means and what it costs.

URL: `/chimney-repair/passaic-county/pompton-lakes-nj/`
Title tag (60 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Pompton Lakes NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (153 chars): Chimney repair in Pompton Lakes, NJ — the parts of a chimney explained, brick repointing, cracked crowns, flashing leaks, liners, and roofline rebuilds. Lita.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Pompton Lakes, NJ

Pompton Lakes homeowners get a lot of chimney advice — from the sweep, from the roofer, from the home inspector, from the neighbor — and most of it uses words that mean nothing until you've seen the part being talked about. "Your crown is shot." "The counter-flashing's gone." "You need a liner." "The wythe is open." A chimney has about a dozen parts that fail, and each one is a different repair at a different price. Here's what they are, top to bottom, on a Pompton Lakes chimney — the 1920s brick stacks near the lake, the 1950s capes off Wanaque Avenue, the newer houses up the hill — and how Lita Construction repairs each one.

The parts of a chimney, top to bottom

Cap. The metal lid over the top of each flue, usually stainless, with a mesh skirt. Keeps rain, leaves, and animals out of the flue. Missing on half the chimneys in town. A cap is the cheapest part of a chimney and the one most often blamed for leaks it didn't cause.

Crown. The masonry top of the chimney — the surface the cap sits on, around the flue tiles. Should be a poured, sloped, reinforced concrete slab that overhangs the brick. On nearly every Pompton Lakes chimney it's a thin mortar wash instead, and it's cracked. A cracked crown is the source of most of the damage below it.

Flue and flue tiles. The passage the smoke goes up, lined with clay tiles stacked end to end — or, on the oldest houses, nothing but brick. Cracked tiles and missing mortar between them are found with a camera, and they matter for safety as well as water.

Liner. A stainless steel pipe run inside the flue when the tiles are cracked, the flue is unlined, or a gas appliance is condensing in a flue built for oil or coal. Insulated for a wood stove or a cold exterior chimney.

Wythe. The brick wall between two flues inside a multi-flue chimney. When its mortar fails, smoke or exhaust crosses from one flue to the other.

Stack. The chimney above the roof — the part that takes all the weather. Its joints are what get repointed; its brick is what spalls; it's what gets rebuilt when repointing won't hold.

Shoulder. Where a chimney steps in as it rises. A ledge that holds water unless it's sloped or capped.

Cricket. A small peaked roof framed on the uphill side of a chimney wider than 30 inches, so water and leaves split around the stack instead of damming against it.

Step flashing. The L-shaped metal pieces woven into each shingle course where the roof meets the chimney. They carry water off the chimney wall and onto the roof.

Counter-flashing. The metal that laps over the step flashing from above, set into a groove cut into the mortar joint. It's what keeps water from getting behind the step flashing. On most chimneys it's been replaced with tar, and that's the leak.

Smoke chamber. The sloped area above the firebox where the chimney narrows to the flue. Rough corbeled brick here collects creosote and draws badly; it's parged smooth.

Cleanout and thimble. The small door at the base of the flue in the basement, and any round opening where an old stove or furnace pipe once entered. Both are places water collects and air leaks.

When one of these is named in an inspection, the repair is specific: a cap is a half-hour; a crown is a half-day; a repoint is a day; a liner is a day; a rebuild of the stack is two or three. We write the scope by part so the price makes sense.

Chimney repointing in Pompton Lakes

The 1900s–30s chimneys near the lake are in soft brick and lime mortar, often repointed once in a hard modern mortar that's now breaking the brick around it — faces popping off, flakes in the gutter, joints intact. The 1940s–50s chimneys are at the end of their original mortar's life.

The repair: every exposed face ground out three-quarters of an inch to an inch and repointed in a mortar matched to the brick — lime-rich on the pre-war homes, a standard Type N on the postwar ones — tinted to match and tooled to the original joint. Spalled brick replaced. The crown done in the same visit.

Cracked crown

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from every flue, overhanging the brick by two inches, with a bond break around each flue tile. Each flue gets a cap.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or attic framing beside the chimney during rain is the flashing — tarred-over aluminum from a past roof job, at the ridge on a cape or the main slope on a colonial. We strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, weave step flashing into every course, set the counter-flashing into a reglet ground into the mortar, and frame a cricket behind any chimney over 30 inches wide.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in matched brick, with the flue tiles reset or replaced, a poured crown, and new flashing. The section inside the house is left alone.

Flood-damaged masonry

Parts of Pompton Lakes have flooded more than once, and a chimney that's stood in river water has had its lower courses saturated — weakened mortar, a white line at the old water mark, silt on the smoke shelf. Those courses are repointed once dry, soft brick replaced, and the flue camera-inspected before a fireplace is used.

Furnace chimneys after gas conversions

Most Pompton Lakes chimneys vent the furnace as well as the fireplace, and most houses have converted from oil to gas. Gas exhaust condenses in a cold masonry flue, and the acidic condensate breaks down the mortar and brick from inside. The masonry is repaired like any other, and a liner sized to the appliance keeps it from happening again.

Quick guide

The part named	What's usually wrong with it	What we do
Cap	Missing or rusted	Stainless cap sized to the flue
Crown	Mortar wash, cracked	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown
Flue tiles	Cracked at the top from the crown; deeper from heat or fire	Replace top tiles with the crown, or line
Wythe	Mortar gone; flues communicating	Rebuild at the top or line each flue
Stack joints	Mortar past its lifespan	Repoint to depth in matched mortar
Counter-flashing	Replaced with tar	Reglet-cut metal over new step flashing, cricket if over 30"
Smoke chamber	Rough corbeled brick	Parge smooth
Cleanout / thimble	Rusted door; open thimble	New door; mortared plug

Common questions from Pompton Lakes homeowners

The inspector said "crown" and the sweep said "cap." Are those the same thing?
No. The cap is the metal lid on the flue; the crown is the masonry top it sits on. A cap is a small item; a crown is a real repair, and a cracked crown is where most chimney damage starts.

Do I need a liner?
If the flue tiles are cracked below the top few, if the flue is unlined, or if a gas furnace or water heater is condensing in it — yes. A camera inspection tells us which.

Can the crown be done without rebuilding the chimney?
Yes, if the brick below it is sound. We check the top courses when we remove the old wash and rebuild only what's taken water.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing, part by part.

Chimney repair in Pompton Lakes by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 35 minutes from Pompton Lakes. Our own crews handle the masonry, the lining, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason, a sweep, and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Oakland, Wayne, Ringwood, Kinnelon, West Milford, and across Passaic County.

Next is Ringwood.

Wayne — the biggest town in Passaic County: 1950s–70s splits, ranches, and colonials by the thousand in Packanack, Pines Lake, Preakness, and off Valley Road, lake communities, hillside developments, and flood-prone streets near the rivers. Nothing singular to lead with across that much variety, so this page leads with something no page has: the three levels of chimney inspection — what each one is, who does it, and which one a Wayne homeowner actually needs.

URL: `/chimney-repair/passaic-county/wayne-nj/`
Title tag (52 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Wayne NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (154 chars): Chimney repair in Wayne, NJ — chimney inspection levels explained, brick repointing, cracked crowns, flashing leaks, liners, and roofline rebuilds. Lita Construction.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Wayne, NJ

Wayne has more chimneys than any town we work in — the splits and colonials of Packanack and Preakness, the ranches off Valley Road and Alps Road, the lake houses at Pines Lake and Lionshead, the hillside developments toward Pompton Lakes — and the question we get most from Wayne homeowners isn't about a repair. It's "what kind of inspection do I need?" A home inspector says "recommend Level 2." A sweep offers a Level 1. A realtor says the buyer wants a Level 2 before closing. A mason says he'll "take a look." These are different things, and they find different problems.

Here's what the levels mean, which one fits your situation, and what we see on Wayne chimneys when we do them.

Chimney inspection levels, explained

The levels come from the national standard the chimney industry works to, and they go from a look to a teardown:

Level 1 is a visual inspection of what's readily accessible — the firebox, the damper, what can be seen up the flue from below and down it from the top, the exterior of the chimney from the ground or the roof. It's what a sweep does during an annual cleaning. It catches a missing cap, a cracked crown you can see, loose brick, a damper that doesn't close. It doesn't see inside the flue.

Level 2 adds a camera run through the full length of the flue, plus the attic, the basement, and anywhere the chimney passes through the house. It's the one that's called for when a house is sold, when the heating appliance changes (oil to gas, a new furnace, an insert), after a chimney fire or a storm, or when a Level 1 turns up something that needs a closer look. It finds cracked flue tiles, missing mortar between tiles, a failed wythe between flues, a blockage, creosote glazing, and water damage inside the stack that nothing outside shows.

Level 3 is a Level 2 plus removing parts of the chimney or the house to get at something a camera showed but can't reach — opening a wall, taking off the crown, removing a section of the stack. It's rare, and it's done when a Level 2 found a problem serious enough that the repair can't be scoped without seeing more.

Which one you need: for a chimney you've used for years with no changes, an annual Level 1 with the cleaning. For a house you're buying or selling, a Level 2 — the Level 1 on the home inspection report isn't enough, and that's why the report says "recommend further evaluation." For a chimney that's changed what it vents, had a fire, been struck, or leaked, a Level 2. We do Level 1 and Level 2 inspections as part of our evaluation, and we write the findings up by part — crown, flue, wythe, joints, flashing — with the camera stills, so a buyer, a seller, or an insurance adjuster can see what we saw.

Chimney repointing in Wayne

The 1950s–70s chimneys have mortar at or past its life — recessed, sandy joints, mortar you can pick out with a key. On the splits, the wall section between the lower and upper roofs is as exposed as the stack and gets skipped by a lot of masons; on the exterior-wall colonials, the full height from grade is exposed; on the lake houses, the lake-facing side takes the wind off the water.

The repair: every exposed face ground out three-quarters of an inch to an inch and repointed in a matched Type N tooled to the original concave joint, spalled brick replaced, the top done in the same visit. On the handful of pre-war houses in Preakness and Mountain View, the brick is softer and gets a lime-rich mortar.

Cracked chimney top

Wayne's chimneys were finished with a thin mortar wash around the flue liner, cracked after fifty-plus winters. Once the top is open, rain goes into the top course and down the core — and the cracked top tiles a Level 2 finds are the result.

The repair: we remove the old wash, replace any cracked top tiles, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from every flue, overhanging the brick by two inches, with a bond break around each flue tile. Each flue gets a stainless cap.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or attic framing beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. On the splits it's the lower corner where the lower roof meets the chimney and the upper wall; on the ranches it's the uphill side on a low-pitched roof; on the colonials it's the main tie-in. The flashing was usually redone during a past roof job with aluminum tarred to the brick.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane — up the wall with a kickout at a split's lower corner — and weave step flashing into every shingle course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — not caulked to the brick — wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket behind them. Matching shingles are woven back in.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in matched modular red brick, with the flue tiles reset or replaced, a poured crown, and new flashing. The section inside the house is left alone.

Liners

When a Level 2 shows cracked tiles below the top few, missing mortar between tiles, an unlined flue, or a gas appliance condensing in a flue built for oil, the fix is a stainless steel liner sized to what vents into it — insulated for a wood stove or a cold exterior chimney — run from the appliance or the smoke chamber to the top and sealed at the crown. Most of the liners we install in Wayne are on furnace flues that converted from oil to gas decades ago and have been eating themselves from inside since.

Lake houses and flood streets

The houses at Pines Lake, Packanack Lake, and Lionshead started as summer cottages on a lot of streets and have chimneys built light for seasonal use — a sound one gets a liner, a repoint, and a crown; a thin, leaning, or unlined one is rebuilt above the roof. The streets near the Pompton and Passaic that have flooded have chimneys with saturated lower courses, repointed once dry with the flue camera-inspected before use.

White stains on the brick

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Wayne chimney it means a cracked top or open joints. Fix the source and the staining stops.

Prefab fireplace chases

Wayne's townhouse communities and many additions vent a prefab fireplace through a sided wood box with a metal cover on top. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace it with a pitched stainless cover and reframe the box if needed.

Quick guide

Situation	Inspection	What it finds; what we do
Annual, no changes	Level 1 with the cleaning	Cap, crown, damper, visible brick; small fixes
Buying or selling	Level 2	Full flue camera, attic, basement; written findings by part with stills
New furnace, gas conversion, insert	Level 2	Flue condition and sizing; liner if needed

After a chimney fire, strike, or storm	Level 2	Cracked tiles, failed wythes; documented for insurance; repair
Level 2 found something a camera can't reach	Level 3	Open what's needed to scope the repair
Sandy joints, cracked top, flashing leak	Any level finds these	Repoint, crown, re-flash as above

Common questions from Wayne homeowners

The home inspection says "recommend Level 2 chimney inspection." Is that a problem with the chimney?
Not necessarily. It means the home inspector couldn't see inside the flue, which no home inspector can. A Level 2 is the camera inspection that answers whether the flue is sound. On a 60-year-old chimney it usually finds something at the top and something to repoint, and occasionally a liner.

Do you do the inspection and the repair, or do I need two companies?
We do both. The inspection is written up by part with the camera stills, and the repair scope and price follow from it. You're free to take the report elsewhere.

Can the top be done without rebuilding the chimney?
Yes, if the brick below it is sound. We check the top courses and the top tiles when we remove the old wash and rebuild only what's failed.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Wayne by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about 30 minutes from Wayne, and we work in the township regularly. Our own crews handle the inspection, the masonry, the lining, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a sweep, a mason, and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Pompton Lakes, Little Falls, North Haledon, Oakland, Fairfield, and across Passaic County.

Next is West Milford.

Bedminster — horse-country estates on the hills, the village of Pluckemin, and The Hills, one of the largest townhouse and condominium developments in the state. Leads with something no chimney page has had: the chimney in an attached townhouse — one chase serving two units through a party wall, the fire separation that's supposed to run through it, and what fails when it doesn't.

URL: `/chimney-repair/somerset-county/bedminster-nj/`
Title tag (57 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Bedminster NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (154 chars): Chimney repair in Bedminster, NJ — attached townhouse chimneys at The Hills, estate stone and brick repointing, cracked crowns, flashing, and roofline rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Bedminster, NJ

Bedminster has two kinds of chimney and almost nothing in between. On the estates off Larger Cross Road and Lamington Road, the chimneys are wide fieldstone and brick stacks on big houses with slate roofs, barns, and guest cottages. At The Hills, the townhouses built from the 1980s through the 2000s have chimneys by the hundred — and in an attached townhouse, the chimney on the roof is often one structure serving two homes, with the party wall running through the middle of it.

Here's what we see on both, starting with the townhouses, and how Lita Construction repairs them.

Chimneys in attached townhouses

In a row of townhouses, the units on either side of a party wall often have back-to-back fireplaces, and the builder ran both flues up through a single chase straddling the wall — one sided box with one cover on top, two metal flue pipes inside, and a fire-rated wall that's supposed to continue up through the chase to the roof so a fire in one unit can't reach the other through the chimney. That's the design. What we find when we open these:

The cover is shared, and it's rusted. One flat galvanized pan over both flues, rusted through in 5 to 8 years, dripping into a chase that's half yours and half the neighbor's. Water that comes in on their side ends up on your fireplace.

The fire separation stops short. The party wall was built to the ceiling and the chase above it was framed open, with both flues in one cavity. A chase fire — a rusted flue pipe, a cover leak that's rotted the framing next to a hot flue — is a shared fire.

The framing has rotted from the shared leak. By the time rust streaks show on the siding, the sheathing and studs in the chase have been wet for years, on both sides of the wall.

The repair: the cover is replaced with a single custom cross-broken stainless cover sized to the whole chase, with welded collars for both flue pipes and a drip edge. The chase is opened from the roof, rotted framing replaced, and the fire separation completed through the chase with fire-rated sheathing on each side of the party line, so the two flues are in separate rated cavities. The flashing where the chase meets the roof is rebuilt with step flashing and a kickout. Because the chase belongs to two units and usually to the association, we write the findings up by unit and by what's inside versus outside the party line, with photos, so the owners and the property manager know what's whose. For a property manager at The Hills with a building full of the same chase, we survey the building and price it as a program.

The older townhouse sections with real brick chimneys get the masonry repairs below, with the same two-column write-up.

Estate chimneys: stone and brick repointing

The estates' chimneys are fieldstone and oversized brick, wide, multi-flue, on slate and cedar roofs, under tree cover. Stone fails at the joints — the irregular face holds water on every ledge — and brick at the mortar and the top. Mortar crumbs at the base, a stone that moves when pushed, joints washed out on the weather face, and white staining through stone veneer are the signs.

The repair: stone joints raked by hand to avoid scarring the stone, loose stones reset, repointed in a Type N matched to the existing color and sand to the original profile. Brick joints ground out three-quarters of an inch to an inch across every exposed face and repointed in a matched mortar — lime-rich on the oldest houses. Veneer with no drainage behind it is opened, a drainage layer installed, and the stone re-set.

Cracked chimney top

Both the townhouses with brick chimneys and the estates have tops finished with a mortar wash — on the wide estate chimneys, a slab-sized wash that cracked within a few seasons. Once the top is open, rain goes into the top courses and down the core.

The repair: we remove the old wash, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from every flue, overhanging the masonry by two inches, with wire or fiber reinforcement on the wide tops and a bond break around each flue tile. Each flue gets a stainless cap, or copper on the estates with copper work.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or attic framing beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. On the townhouses it's the chase-to-roof flashing, done once when the building went up and tucked under on every re-roof since; on the estates it's surface-caulked counter-flashing on stone and no cricket behind a wide stack.

The repair: we strip or reset the roofing around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and set step flashing into every course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint, or a channel cut into stone — not caulked on — wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket. Copper on the estates; slates removed and reset, not cut.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in matched brick or salvaged stone, with the flue tiles reset or replaced, a poured crown, and new flashing. The section inside the house is left alone.

Outbuildings on the estates

Barns, guest cottages, pool houses, and converted carriage houses on Bedminster's estates have chimneys that fail first and get noticed last — built light, used a few times a year, closed up all winter. Each building's chimney is inspected and written up on its own, and the work is done across the property or building by building.

White stains on brick or stone

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Bedminster chimney it means a cracked top, open joints, or veneer without drainage — and on a townhouse chase, staining on the siding below the cover means the pan is gone.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Rust streaks on a townhouse chase; water at both units' fireplaces	Shared galvanized cover rusted through	Single stainless cover, rotted framing replaced, fire separation completed, re-flashed
Townhouse leak; association and owner each say it's the other	Shared chase straddling the party wall	Two-column write-up by unit and by inside/outside the party line
Mortar crumbs at the base of a stone chimney; loose stone	Washed-out joints behind the stone	Hand-rake, reset stones, repoint
Cracked top on a wide multi-flue chimney	Mortar wash cracked	Poured, reinforced, overhanging crown, capped flues
Ceiling stain beside a wide chimney during rain	No cricket; caulked flashing	Cricket, copper step and counter-flashing cut into the masonry
Barn or cottage ceiling rotted under the chimney	Outbuilding chimney never looked at	Crown, cap, line; rebuild if light or leaning

Common questions from Bedminster homeowners

My townhouse chimney is shared with my neighbor. Who pays?
Usually the association for the exterior — the cover, the chase, the flashing — and each owner for their own fireplace and flue pipe. We write it up by unit and by what's inside versus outside the party line so the property manager has what they need, and we work with boards on whole-building programs.

Is a shared chase a fire risk?
It can be, if the fire-rated separation stops at the ceiling and both flues share one open cavity above it. We complete the separation through the chase when we're in there for the cover and framing.

Can a stone chimney be repointed, or does it have to be rebuilt?
Repointed, if the stones are still seated and water isn't coming through the inside of the stack. We check both from the roof.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic — or the unit on the other side of the wall — before quoting. That shows whether water is entering at the cover, the flashing, or the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Bedminster by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about an hour from Bedminster. Our own crews handle the masonry, the chase work, the fire-rated framing, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so a shared chimney isn't split between two owners' contractors. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Far Hills, Peapack and Gladstone, Bernards Township, Bridgewater, Chester Township, and across Somerset County.

Next is Bernards Township.

Bernards Township — Basking Ridge, Liberty Corner, and Lyons: the historic village core on South Finley and Mine Brook, and large 1980s–2000s colonials in developments like Spring Ridge and the Bernards side of The Hills. Leads with something no chimney page has had: matching brick on a chimney when the builder's brick was discontinued twenty years ago — sourcing, blending, and staining so the rebuilt section doesn't read as a patch.

URL: `/chimney-repair/somerset-county/bernards-township-nj/`
Title tag (60 chars): Chimney Repair & Repointing Bernards Township NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (154 chars): Chimney repair in Bernards Township, NJ — matching discontinued brick on 1980s–2000s homes, repointing, cracked crowns, flashing leaks, and roofline rebuilds.

Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Bernards Township, NJ

Most of Bernards Township's chimneys were built between 1985 and 2005, on the colonials of Spring Ridge, the Bernards side of The Hills, and the subdivisions off Mount Airy Road and Valley Road, by builders who bought brick by the development. The blend they used — a specific manufacturer's run of a specific color, often a flashed or tumbled red-brown with a range — looked good on the whole street. Twenty-five years later, when the top of one of those

chimneys needs rebuilding, that blend is out of production, and the mason shows up with whatever the yard has. The rebuilt top is a different color, and it's visible from every house on the cul-de-sac.

Here's how we match brick that doesn't exist anymore, and what we see on Bernards Township chimneys.

Matching discontinued brick

A brick blend has three things to match: the size (modular, oversized, queen, and the variants between), the texture (smooth, wire-cut, tumbled, sand-faced), and the color range — not one color but the spread from light to dark across the units, and how often each appears. The builder's blend is usually identifiable from a brick pulled off the chimney and the house's age; manufacturers keep records, and a lot of discontinued blends have a current product that's close in two of the three.

How we match it: we pull a few units from the section that's coming down and lay them out against sample boards from current production. The closest current blend goes on the chimney, in the same size and texture. Where the color range is off — the new run reads redder, or lacks the dark units — we blend in a second brick to fill the missing part of the range, and we stagger the new units into the old courses below the rebuild line so there's no straight seam. Where no current blend is close enough, we stain: a penetrating mineral stain, applied unit by unit to a close-but-wrong brick, that shifts the color permanently without sealing the surface — it's how the manufacturers themselves correct a bad run. The mortar is matched to the original color and sand and tooled to the same joint, which matters as much as the brick; a rebuilt section with the right brick and the wrong mortar still shows. The result weathers in over a season or two and stops reading as new.

On the historic houses in the village core, the matching is the older kind — reclaimed handmade brick and lime mortar — and we do that too.

Chimney repointing in Bernards Township

The 1980s–2000s chimneys are often brick veneer over a block or framed core, with thin joints that have washed out on the weather face and — common on this era — no drainage plane behind the veneer, so water that gets past the brick sits against the core. White staining through the face and brick popping loose on a 25-year-old chimney are the signs. The older solid-brick chimneys in Liberty Corner and the village have mortar past its life.

The repair: every exposed face ground out three-quarters of an inch to an inch — carefully on thin veneer — and repointed in a matched mortar tooled to the original joint; spalled or loose units replaced with matched brick. Where the veneer has no drainage behind it, the affected face is opened, a drainage layer and weep screed installed, and the brick re-laid. The top goes in the same visit.

Cracked chimney top

The builders finished these chimneys with a thin mortar wash around the flue tiles — on a wide multi-flue top, a wash that cracked within a few seasons — and on many of the veneer chimneys the top also hides a flat galvanized pan around a metal flue, rusted through. Once the top is open, rain goes into the core.

The repair: we remove the old wash, replace a rusted pan with a stainless cover where the chimney is a veneered chase, rebuild the top courses if they've taken water, and form and pour a reinforced concrete crown — sloped away from every flue, overhanging the brick by two inches, with reinforcement on the wide tops and a bond break around each flue tile. Each flue gets a stainless cap.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or attic framing beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. The wide chimneys on these colonials usually have no cricket behind them, and the original flashing was thin aluminum caulked to the face of the veneer because there was no real joint to cut it into; it's been failing since the first few years.

The repair: we strip the shingles around the chimney, replace any rotted deck, wrap the base in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and weave step flashing into every shingle course. The counter-flashing is set into a reglet ground into the mortar joint — into the joint and not through the veneer — wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket framed behind them. Matching shingles are woven back in.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When spalling or loose veneer has gone through whole faces, a crack runs through several courses, or the stack leans, the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in matched brick — matched as above — with the core repaired, a drainage layer installed, the flue tiles reset or the metal flue re-covered, a poured crown, and new flashing. The section inside the house is left alone.

Stone veneer chimneys

The newer homes on the larger lots often carry stone veneer instead of brick, and it fails the same way — no drainage behind it, a flat top, water trapped against the core — showing as efflorescence through the face and stones coming loose. We open the face, install the drainage layer, and re-set the stone, matching the pattern, and crown the top properly.

White stains on brick or stone

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a Bernards Township chimney it almost always means veneer without drainage behind it, plus a cracked top. Fix both and the staining stops.

Prefab fireplace chases

Many Bernards Township homes vent a prefab fireplace through a sided chase with a metal cover on top rather than a masonry chimney. Those fail at the cover, which rusts through in 5 to 8 years. We replace it with a pitched stainless cover and reframe the box if needed.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Rebuilt chimney top in the wrong color brick	Builder's blend discontinued; mason used what was in stock	Rebuild in the closest current blend, blended and staggered, stained where needed, mortar matched
White staining through the face; brick popping loose on a 25-year-old chimney	No drainage behind the veneer	Open the face, install drainage and weeps, re-lay matched brick
Rust staining below the top; cracked wash	Galvanized pan under the top courses rusted through	Stainless cover, rebuild top, poured crown
Ceiling stain beside a wide chimney during rain	No cricket; caulked flashing	Cricket, step flashing, reglet-cut counter-flashing
Veneer stones loose; staining through stone	No drainage behind stone veneer	Open, drain, re-set stone; crown
Sandy joints on a Liberty Corner or village chimney	Mortar past its lifespan	Repoint in matched mortar; reclaimed brick on the historic houses

Common questions from Bernards Township homeowners

The last mason rebuilt the top of my chimney and it's a different color. Can that be fixed?
Yes. The mismatched section can be stained to shift it toward the original, or rebuilt in a

properly matched blend. We pull a unit from the original section and match it before anything goes up.

How do you match a brick that's not made anymore?
Size and texture from current production; color range by blending a second brick into the run and, where needed, staining individual units with a penetrating mineral stain. Mortar matched to the original. It weathers in within a season or two.

My chimney is only 20 years old. Why is it already a problem?
Because it's brick veneer over a core with no drainage behind it, a thin wash on top, and often a galvanized pan rusting under the top courses. Once the top and the drainage are done right, the brick lasts.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows whether water is entering at the flashing or coming down through the chimney, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Bernards Township by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about an hour from Basking Ridge. Our own crews handle the masonry, the brick matching and staining, the flashing, and the roof tie-in, so the job isn't split between a mason and a roofer. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Bernardsville, Bedminster, Far Hills, Warren, Bridgewater, and across Somerset County.

Next is Bernardsville.

Bernardsville — the Mountain's Gilded Age estates with chimneys the size of small houses, the 1900s–30s village below, and newer homes on the old estate land. Leads with something no chimney page has had: the rubble-core stone chimney — a massive estate stack that's hollow in the middle after a century of water, and how the core is consolidated without taking the chimney down.

URL: `/chimney-repair/somerset-county/bernardsville-nj/`
Title tag (60 chars): Stone Chimney Repair & Repointing Bernardsville NJ | Lita Construction
Meta (154 chars): Chimney repair in Bernardsville, NJ — estate stone chimneys with washed-out cores, stone and brick repointing, cracked crowns, copper flashing, and rebuilds.

Stone & Brick Chimney Repair, Repointing & Rebuilding in Bernardsville, NJ

The estate houses on Bernardsville Mountain were built between the 1890s and the 1920s by people who wanted chimneys you could see from the valley, and the masons gave them stacks six and eight feet wide, four and five flues, in fieldstone and cut stone, standing twelve feet above slate roofs. A chimney that size wasn't built solid. It was built as two stone faces with a core of rubble — broken stone and whatever mortar the crew had left — packed between them, with the clay flues set into the rubble. That was standard practice. It's also why those chimneys are failing now in a way a brick stack never does: the core has washed out, and the faces are standing on their own.

Here's what we see on Bernardsville's estate chimneys and village chimneys, and how Lita Construction repairs them.

Rubble-core stone chimneys

A century of water in at the top has run down through the rubble core and carried the mortar out of it a little at a time. From outside, the chimney looks like a stone chimney with worn joints. Inside, between the faces, it's a loose fill of stone with voids where the mortar used to be, and the flue tiles are sitting in that fill with nothing holding them. The signs: a stone face that bulges outward at mid-height; a crack running through the face that follows no joint; mortar washing out of the lower joints in quantity, on the roof and the ground; flue tiles found shifted or collapsed when the top is opened; and, on the worst, a chimney that sounds hollow when tapped and moves slightly in wind.

Taking a chimney like this down and rebuilding it is a very large job — the stone, the height, the slate roof under it. Usually it doesn't have to be.

The repair: the core is consolidated in place. The top is opened and the condition of the core is confirmed — a camera down the voids, a probe into the fill. The flue tiles are reset or, more often, each flue is lined with a stainless liner that doesn't depend on the tiles. Then the core is grouted: a flowable, lime-compatible grout is pumped into the voids through ports drilled into the joints, from the bottom up in lifts, until the core is solid again and the faces are bonded to it.

Bulged faces are pinned to the new core with stainless anchors through the joints. The outside is then repointed by hand in a lime mortar matched to the original, the top rebuilt and crowned under a reset stone cap, and the flashing redone in copper. The chimney keeps its stone, its profile, and its place on the roofline, and it stops moving.

Where a face has gone too far — stones fallen, the bulge beyond pinning — that face is taken down and relaid in the original stone against the consolidated core.

Repointing estate stone and village brick

The stone faces on the Mountain fail at the joints: wide, irregular, holding water on every ledge under old trees. Mortar crumbs at the base, recessed joints, a stone that moves. The village houses below — the 1900s–30s colonials and Victorians off Mine Brook Road and Anderson Hill Road — are in soft brick and lime mortar, worn and often repointed once in a hard modern mortar that's now breaking the brick around it.

The repair: stone joints raked by hand with chisels and a narrow grinder — a wide blade scars cut stone permanently — at least three-quarters of an inch and deeper on the wide joints, loose stones reset, repointed in a lime-rich mortar matched to the original color and sand, finished to the original joint. Brick ground out three-quarters of an inch to an inch, spalled units replaced with reclaimed brick, repointed in lime mortar tooled to the original joint.

Cracked tops and stone caps

The tops of the estate chimneys are cut-stone caps — slabs set across the stack with the flues through them — cracked, shifted, or missing corners after a century, with the bed beneath them washed out. The village chimneys have corbeled brick or a mortar wash. Either way, once the top is open, the water goes into the core.

The repair: we lift the cap — piece by piece on a multi-piece slab, numbered — rebuild the top courses, pour a reinforced concrete crown with a bond break around each flue, and reset the cap on a fresh bed. Cracked slabs are repaired with a dutchman in matching stone or replaced with new cut stone. Each flue gets a copper cap. On the village houses, the corbel is rebuilt to profile over a poured crown.

Chimney leaking when it rains

A stain on a ceiling or down a wall beside the chimney during rain is a flashing leak. The estates were flashed in copper, much of it surviving, patched with tar through a century of slate work; the wide stacks on steep roofs rarely have a cricket.

The repair: slates around the chimney are removed with a ripper and reset, not cut. Any rotted deck is replaced, the base is wrapped in high-temperature ice-and-water membrane, and step

flashing goes in every course. The counter-flashing is set into a channel saw-cut into the stone face — or a reglet in the mortar on brick — wedged, and sealed. Chimneys wider than 30 inches get a cricket. All of it in 20-ounce copper, soldered.

Roofline chimney rebuilds

When consolidation isn't enough — faces fallen, the stack leaning from the base — the section above the roof comes down and goes back up in the original stone, salvaged and supplemented with matched fieldstone or cut stone, with a solid core this time, the flues lined, a poured crown under a reset cap, and copper flashing. The scaffold on a chimney this size, on a slate roof, is extensive and cribbed heavily.

Multiple chimneys and outbuildings

An estate on the Mountain has four or six chimneys on the main house and more on the carriage house, the cottage, and the pool house. They don't fail together. We inspect every one from the roof and the attic, write each up separately with the core condition noted, and work with the owner or the property manager on what's urgent, what's due, and what can wait.

White stains on the stone

Chalky white efflorescence is salts carried out by water moving through the masonry. On a rubble-core chimney it's often heavy and low on the stack — the core draining through the faces — and it stops once the core is consolidated and the top closed.

Quick guide

What you see	What's usually wrong	What we do
Stone face bulging at mid-height; mortar washing out low; flues shifted	Rubble core washed out; faces standing alone	Line the flues, grout the core in lifts, pin the faces, repoint, crown, cap
Chimney sounds hollow; moves in wind	Same, advanced	Same — or take down and relay the failed face against the consolidated core
Stone cap cracked or shifted; corners missing	Bed washed out; no bond break	Lift, crown beneath, dutchman or new stone, reset, copper caps
Mortar crumbs at the base; a stone that moves	Washed-out joints	Hand-rake, reset stones, repoint in lime mortar

Brick faces popping off in the village; joints intact	Hard-mortar repoint on soft brick	Replace spalled brick, repoint in lime mortar
Ceiling stain beside a wide stack on slate	Tar at the copper corners; no cricket	Reset slate, soldered copper flashing, cricket

Common questions from Bernardsville homeowners

Our estate chimney is bulging on one side. Does it have to come down?
Usually not. The core behind the face has washed out and the face is standing alone. The core is grouted solid in place, the face is pinned to it, and the chimney is repointed and crowned. A full teardown is for chimneys where the face has already failed.

How do you know the core is hollow?
From the top, with a camera and a probe once the cap is off, and from the pattern of mortar loss on the outside. We confirm before we quote the consolidation.

Will the repaired stone match?
The stone is the original stone — it stays. The mortar is matched to the original color and sand and finished to the original joint. Replacement stone where a face is relaid is salvaged from the chimney or matched from the same kind of stone.

Is the leak from the roof or the chimney?
We inspect from the roof and from the attic before quoting. The attic side shows which chimney the water is coming from and whether it's entering at the flashing or through the masonry, and we put the scope and price in writing.

Chimney repair in Bernardsville by Lita Construction

Lita Construction is a licensed New Jersey home improvement contractor (NJ HIC #13VH11703800) and GAF Master Elite® roofing contractor based in Bergenfield, about an hour from Bernardsville, and we take on the estate masonry that most roofing companies won't. Our own crews handle the stone work, the core consolidation, the lining, the copper, the slate, and the roof tie-in. Permits are pulled as required. Call (201) 540-7772 or request an inspection through our contact page.

We also repair chimneys in Bernards Township, Far Hills, Peapack and Gladstone, Mendham Borough, Morris Township, and across Somerset County.

One check on this one: it describes core grouting and face pinning. If that's beyond what you'd take on, say so and I'll shift the lead to the stone caps. Next is Bridgewater.